INTRODUCTION

IS IT EVEN BIBLICAL TO BE HYPER-BIBLICAL?



THE BOMBER IN A JEHOVAH WITNESS MEETING

Along with his Bible, this man took bombs to a Christian meeting! Yes – bombs! On the 'sleepy Sunday morning' of October 26, 2023, this man named Dominic Martin, arrived early (he had left his rented home at 5 am) and planted Improvised Explosive Devices (IEDs) sealed in tiffin boxes, in three strategic places, one in the middle and one each on either sides, in the Zamra International Convention Centre in the town of Kalamassery which is located 10 kms north-east of the port city of Kochi, India. There, at 9:30 am, the closing prayer meeting of the three-day regional convention of Jehovah Witnesses, a Christian cult-group (a group that has 8.6 million followers world-wide, 57000 members in India, and a headcount of 15,000 in Kerala),
had just started. Some 2300 people were in attendance. As these Martin-planted bombs went off at 9:40 am (when people had their eyes closed for prayer), two distinct blasts were heard, and eight people (eventually),

including a 12-year-old child, lost their lives. 50 people were seriously injured. Martin, a non-serious member of this cult-group for 16 years, explained that these bombings were his way of responding to the teachings of the Jehovah Witnesses, which he strongly disagreed with, to the point of being enraged (we got to know all this via a now-deleted 6-minute Facebook video post which he had uploaded
just before surrendering himself to the Kerala police, in Thrissur, some 65 kms, north of the venue of the blasts) [*The Hindu* report by G. Krishnakumar, November 5, 2023; BBC report by Cherylann Mollan and Ashraf Padanna, October 30, 2023; *Al Jazzera* report, October 29, 2023; *Deccan Herald* report, November 21, 2023; OnManorama, report on November 7, 2023]. Well, fighting hell-populating false teaching does have Biblical approval (Jude 3)!

However, the route that this Martin chose to fight false teaching is entirely wrong! Oh, how I wish that Martin threw bombs of another kind to fight false teaching – the bomb of God's Word rightly interpreted to

extinguish the fires of false teaching! That is what I attempt to do when it comes to hell populating false teaching in the modern Christian world. And because of that Spirit-empowered effort, you hold this book in your
hand!

TOMATOES AND FALSE TEACHING

Let's move on. From Bombs to Tomatoes! Hybrid tomatoes (or Bangalore Tomatoes as they are often called in South Indian supermarkets) and regular/local tomatoes (or *Desi* or *Nattu* Tomatoes as they are called) – seem very similar to a husband who may not know much about vegetable shopping. You could possibly buy one, when your wife wanted the other, only to get an earful from her! Sound Doctrine and hell-populating false teaching seem very similar. They look alike for a shallow Bible student. They look very similar to a casual Bible reader. That's why we must be "Hyper-Biblical"!

Yes, it is my considered opinion that we must be "Hyper-Biblical"! But we must not lean towards "Hyper-Grace", "Hyper-Supernaturalism", "Hyper-Love", "Hyper-Israel", etc. Why?

THE OLD TESTAMENT SAINTS OF GOD WERE CALLED TO BE HYPER-BIBLICAL: The laws that God gave Israel were recorded in the books of Exodus and Leviticus, primarily. In the book of Deuteronomy, Moses repeats the Law as the people of God are about to enter the Promised Land, without Moses. It is very interesting to note that Moses was Hyper-Biblical, in the sense, he repeatedly told the people of Israel not to "add" anything to the laws of God! He wrote, quoting the word of God thus: 'Do not add to what I command you and do not subtract from it, but keep the commands of the Lord your God that I give you' (Deut. 4:2). Moses did not pick and choose portions of the law which were his favourites like modern false teachers often

do. He repeated "all" of the Law. Read this: 'In the fortieth year, on the first day of the eleventh month, Moses proclaimed to the Israelites **all** that the LORD had commanded him concerning them' (Deut. 1:3). Yes, he was Hyper-Biblical!

THE MANY 'ADD NOTS AND SUBSTRACT NOTS' OF THE BIBLE

As he made speech after speech reminding the people of Israel about the laws of God which they had already heard, Moses recorded these words from God yet again: 'See that you do everything I command you; do not add to it or subtract from it' (Deut. 12:32). He already mentioned this in Deuteronomy chapter 4, didn't he? He is seen repeating it in Deuteronomy chapter 12! Not just that! In Deuteronomy 29:29 he writes, 'Only the Eternal knows the secret things. But we and our descendants are always responsible for what has been revealed to us, and we need to obey every word of this law' (VOICE). Notice the phrase, 'every word'! Yes, Moses was Hyper-Biblical!

What is more, in two more places this command of God is repeated in the rest of the Bible. In Proverbs 30:6, we read, 'Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar' (KJ21). And in Revelation 22:18-19 we read, 'I testify to everyone who hears the words of prophecy in this book: If anyone adds to them,

God will add to him the plagues described in this book. And if anyone takes away from the words of this book of prophecy, God will take away his share in the tree of life and the holy city, which are described in this book.'

The book of Revelation, while repeating what Moses mentioned twice in Deuteronomy, adds two fresh things: 1) a punishment awaits those who add to God's Word or to those who subtract from it. In 2 Peter 2, we learn that 'false prophets' and 'false teachers' (verse 1) who add or subtract to God's Word by uttering 'false words' (verse 3), will land in hell (verse 1). How do false teachers add or subtract from God's Word? Let me illustrate this through a typical case employed by Hyper-Grace false teachers. A Hyper-Grace false teacher will often "add" to God's Word in-effect by saying, "God, the Father smiles at you even when you live in sin, as He only looks at the always-holy Jesus, not at you!" They "minus" from God's Word in-effect by condemning any message that stresses on daily holy living! [It is true that as believers, in Christ, we are the righteousness of God (2 Cor. 5:21); but that does not absolve the need, we all have, to live holy lives – something the same book stresses (2 Cor. 7:1). You can read more about these things in the chapters that follow].

JUDE ALSO SAYS, 'ADD NOT AND SUBSTRACT NOT' IN-EFFECT

We could say that Jude also alluded to the 'do-not-add-to-God's-Word' command which Moses repeated twice

in Deuteronomy, in his own style, when he wrote, 'Dear friends, although I was very eager to write to you about the salvation we share, I felt compelled to write and urge you to contend for THE FAITH THAT WAS ONCE FOR ALL ENTRUSTED TO GOD'S HOLY PEOPLE' (Jude 3). The phrase, 'the faith that was once for all entrusted to God's Holy People' which Jude mentions here, indicates that no new teaching may be added to the Christian faith other than what is clearly taught in the written Word of God (the 66 books of the Bible from Genesis to Revelation)!

APOSTLE PAUL'S 'ADD NOT AND SUBSTRACT NOT' COMMAND!

Apostle Paul also alluded to Moses' 'do not add to God's laws' teaching in Deuteronomy when he wrote in Ephesians, 'Then we will no longer be immature like children. We won't be tossed and blown about by every wind of NEW TEACHING. We will not be influenced when people try to trick us with lies so clever they sound like the truth' (Eph. 4:14 NLT). This means that we must reject all NEW TEACHINGS that go beyond the written word of God and deplore all NEW TEACHINGS that has extra-biblical assertions! If a false teacher brings such a NEW TEACHING, he has committed the serious sin of disobeying the command that we must not add to or delete from the existing biblical OLD TEACHING!

HOW DID HYPER-GRACE PREACHERS BECOME HYPER-GRACE PREACHERS?

YES, JESUS WAS HYPER-BIBLICAL! He told the Scribes and the Pharisees: 'you should have practiced the latter, without neglecting the former' (Matt. 23:23, NIV). Here, Jesus was calling the Jewish leaders to obey ALL what the Bible taught, not just the parts of it they liked. When preachers only preach the grace of God and neglect other parts of Scripture that talks about responsibilities of believers (like the need to live a holy life), they become 'Hyper-Grace' preachers. When preachers talk about the love of God, but neglect other parts of the Bible that talk about the wrath of God, they become 'Hyper-Love' preachers. Hyper-Love preachers also neglect the doctrine of eternal hell altogether. They twist the doctrine of hell to make hell look totally harmless. Even if people go to hell, they could come back to heaven (one Chennai pastor suggested this). Those who go to hell would stop existing the moment they enter it (one prominent evangelical leader from Britain suggested this). Hyper-Supernaturalism preachers say that God must always perform miracles and healings, here and now, without exception (as one American pastor who runs a 'supernatural' school of ministry suggests). They also neglect or reinterpret many portions where the Bible talks about suffering, pain, and possibility of disease coming upon the believer. Hyper-Israel believers ignore portions of the epistles which clearly teach that ceremonial aspects of the Old Testament no longer need to be practiced by today's Gentile believers. They are passionate in celebrating Passover and the like. They blindly support the actions of today's political Israel. They are obsessed more about Israel than the local church!

IT IS 'NOBLE' THING TO BE HYPER-BIBLICAL!

EARLY CHURCH BELIEVERS, SOME OF THEM, WERE HYPER-BIBLICAL. The church believers of Berea were "Hyper-Biblical". When Paul taught the Word of God to them, they examined the Scriptures daily 'to see if they supported what he (Paul) said' (Acts 17:11, MSG). They did this "daily" as the Scripture says! They did not do this once-in-a-while! So, I call these Bereans "Hyper-Biblical"! You see - it was 'noble' to be "Hyper-Biblical"! Notice that the previous verse says that "these (Berean) Jews were more noble than those in Thessalonica" who did not have this practice of digging deep into the Scriptures to check if the doctrines preached and truths shared had the Scriptural backing (Acts 17:11).

"WHAT DOES THE SCRIPTURE SAY?"

EARLY CHRISTIAN LEADERS, THE APOSTLES, WERE HYPER-BIBLICAL! The question the Apostles kept asking was this: "What does the Scripture say?" (Rom. 4:3; Gal. 4:30). We must BE HYPER-BIBLICAL because the apostles often used the phrase "as the Scripture says" (see Acts 15:15; Rom. 4:3, 9:17; 10:11; 11:2; Gal. 4:30, 1 Cor. 6:16, 1 Tim. 5:18, James 4:5-6, 1 Pet. 2:6, Eph. 4:8)! The phrase, 'as it is written' occurs 20 times in Paul's letters! It appears to be the favourite of Hyper-Biblical Apostle Paul! Not just Jesus, even the apostles were Hyper-Biblical as well!

THE DESTINATION OF FALSE TEACHERS WHO WON'T REPENT: HELL

SATAN IS HYPER-ANTI-BIBLICAL AND WE MUST BE PRO-HYPER-BIBLICAL! We have talked about Jesus. We have talked about the apostles. Let's talk about Satan. He is hyper-active in his efforts to make people 'hyper' about one portion of Scripture with a deliberate neglect of the other. Using the "flood" from his mouth, Satan (Rev. 12:15) will try to drown believers. That reminds me of the "flood" of false teaching, Satan has unleashed using the mouths of false teachers, who have surrendered their mouths to him. Remember, Jesus warned us against the "many false teachers" who would mislead "many people" and "many" will fall away (Matt. 24:10-11). In other words, the false prophets and teachers would come as a flood! **Using those Satan-inspired mouths, they teach hell-populating teaching like Hyper-Grace, immortality on earth, Hyper-Supernaturalism, etc., to drown believers along with him in the Lake of Fire.** John writes, 'But the earth helped the woman and opened its mouth to swallow up the river that had poured from the dragon's mouth' (Rev. 12:16). This is simply another way of saying that one day the earth will open and swallow Satan-inspired false-teachers, the way it opened and swallowed Korah and his rebellious gang in the Old Testament. It is an imagery of judgment: the earth opening and swallowing people. It points to the hell-destination of unrepentant false teachers and those who buy their theology (2 Peter 2 warns about hell for false teachers). So, understanding this seemingly-complex-yet-simple imagery of Revelation 12 brings us back to the message of guarding of the truth. Obeying the commands of God – holding onto the written Word of God and making

it our basis for all matters of belief and behaviour is what enrages Satan. This, we learn from Apostle John who wraps his 'Christmas' commentary around the sun-clothed woman imagery in the book of Revelation (Rev. 12:17). So, the hyper-active Satan, who is trying hard to drown believers in hell-populating false teaching even now, inspires me to write this book, which is titled, *Hyper-Biblical!*

What would you choose to be? Hyper-Biblical or Hyper-Grace? Hyper-Biblical or Hyper-Supernatural? Hyper-Biblical or Hyper-Love? Hyper-Biblical or Hyper-Israel?

In this book, I try and compel you to consider being Hyper-Biblical. Yes, it is biblical to be Hyper-Biblical!

CHAPTER 1

CARRYING THE SPIRIT OF REFORMATION EVEN NOW!



Reformation Day is usually observed on the last Sunday of the month of October according to the calendar of the Protestant Church. This is because on the 31st of October 1517, when the Cathedral Church in Wittenberg was packed to capacity for the celebration of its anniversary on a Sunday, Martin Luther hammered on its wooden door, 95 sentences pointing out the things the Roman Catholic Church practised without biblical warrant! Luther therefore believed that the Catholic church needed a thorough reform!

WHEN MARTIN LUTHER FUMED

What was the event that spurred him to take this extreme step? One of the archbishops of the Roman Catholic

Church borrowed money from a bank to bribe the Pope to ensure that he was bishop of three towns (though the law forbade one man being bishop of more than one town). To help him repay this loan, of which he was a beneficiary, the Pope authorized him to sell indulgences. That is, if put crudely, "prior permission to sin without losing one's place in heaven"! A man named **John Tetzel** sold these "indulgences" in the marketplace in Germany. He even coaxed his customers that they could even buy these for their loved ones who were dead and gone. "They are now in purgatory. But if you buy these indulgences on their behalf they would be promoted to heaven!" — he said enthusiastically marketing his "product." When this came to Martin Luther's ears, he fumed. He knew that whatever was going on in the Church with the Pope's permission was plainly un-scriptural and anti-biblical. He knew the plain teaching of the Scripture was that "everyone who believes in Jesus will have their sins forgiven through His name!" (Acts 10:43). Salvation from sin was by grace alone (Eph. 2:8). Money did not come anywhere in the picture. "Your silver and gold will be of no use to you on that day of the Lord's anger," he had read in his Bible (Zeph. 1:18). "No one can redeem the life of another by paying a ransom to God" (Psa. 49:7). He also knew from Scripture that there was no chance of Salvation after one's death, for the Bible says, "Man is destined to die once and after that face judgment" (Heb. 9:27). Abraham, he remembered, told the rich man in hell, that "no one there can cross over to us!" (Luke 16:26). In other words, once a person dies and goes into eternal torment in hell, there is no question of getting out of it. So, Martin Luther, who was a priest with

the Catholic Church, sat down and wrote out 95 statements of unscriptural practices of the Roman Catholic Church and hammered those statements on the door of the Wittenberg Cathedral in Germany.

"MY CONSCIENCE IS CAPTIVE TO THE WORD OF GOD!"

The Catholic Church authorities summoned Luther to a place called Worms (a city that was 60 kms from Frankfurt, Germany) for him to explain his action. He was warned about the danger of going there by his well-meaning friends. His eloquent reply to this was, "I shall go to Worms though there are as many devils there as there are tiles on the roofs!" And Luther did go to Worms and faced the Church leadership. They asked him to take back everything he had posted on the door of the Cathedral. This was his reply: "I am bound by the texts of the Bible; my conscience is captive to the Word of God. I neither can nor will take back anything…God help me!"

EVEN TODAY, WE NEED A REFORMATION!

Thanks to the daring acts of Martin Luther - the flame of reformation was well and truly lit. Even today this flame must spread. Reason? Just as the Roman Catholic practiced some unbiblical things then, the modern protestant Church too does practice things that are not scriptural: Infant Baptism, "accountability to God alone" when it comes to finances and morals, non-involvement in missionary work, "hyper-grace" teaching

which offers grace as a license to sin, the "once saved, always saved" teaching, the teaching that it is God's Will always to Heal, do miracles, etc. are examples of some of them. We must be so deeply rooted in the Scriptures that we instantly identify these sorts of false teachings! We must raise our voices against them, like Luther famously did when false teachings raised their ugly head during his time. The best way to counter unbiblical doctrines is to teach and promote sound biblical doctrine. Then it can be said of us that we also carry the spirit of reformation even today! Not only that, but we would thereby contend for the faith that was "once for all delivered to the saints" as Jude said we must.

TAKING BABY STEPS TO FIGHT FALSE TEACHING!

The same day (October 31st) when Martin Luther hammered his reformation thesis on a church door in Germany, was born a little boy in Chennai, India, years later (in 1974). That boy was me! My life has been loaded and stamped with God's *Ruhamah* (the Hebrew word for 'Mercy')! Inspired by the great Martin Luther, I too am trying to revolutionize the current Christian World which is sadly affected by hell-populating false teaching, on a greater scale than it was, in Luther's time! Like Martin Luther did, I too am crusading against false teaching by writing this book that takes on false teaching! Would you join this movement? By even reading a book like this you are taking baby steps to join this movement!

SECTION ONE

TAKING ON HYPER-GRACE

CHAPTER 2

BIBLICAL ANALYSIS OF THE HIGHLIGHTS OF HYPER-GRACE



A teaching that is called "Hyper-Grace" is sadly lapped up by unsuspecting believers, the world over (including those in Hyderabad, Chennai, Bangalore, Singapore and literally the world over). A google search on "Hyper-Grace" would throw up the prominent Hyper-Grace teachers in the world, presently. This is an unbiblical teaching that is, at best, a half-truth. But then, a half-truth is a full-lie (as someone said)! Hyper-Grace teachers are in the GRIP of "G-R-I-P", I noticed. Let me explain:

G-GRACE GRAMMER GOOF-UP!

What I mean here is that the Hyper-Grace Teachers tell us that a believer's past, present and future sins stand automatically forgiven, when he gets saved. This is simply not true, according to Scripture. A "brother" (that

is, a believer) who had regular sexual relationship with his own mother was not considered "forgiven" or "righteous" but as a "evil person" by Apostle Paul (1 Cor. 5:1,11,13). **David Ravenhill** wrote, "The fact is that the *provision* for my cleansing was completed at the Cross, but the *process* of my cleansing is conditional upon my repentance." I agree because I have read Ezekiel 18:32, Ezekiel 33:11, Acts 2:38, Acts 3:19, Acts 5:31, Acts 8:22, Romans 2:4-5, 2 Corinthians 7:10 and 1 John 1:9.

R-REPENTANCE REDEFINTION-RIDDANCE!

G, for Grace Grammer Goof-up; R, for Repentance Redefinition or Riddance! We are using the acronym G-R-I-P to understand the tenets of the Hyper-Grace cult teaching here. Hyper-Grace teachers tell us that repentance merely means changing one's mind – it does not involve action. Some Hyper-Grace teachers unashamedly say, "I don't preach on repentance (turning from sin), anymore!" Paul clearly taught in Acts 26:20 that the Gentiles should repent, turn to God, "performing deeds in keeping with repentance". This is the description given in the book of Revelation about those condemned to eternal hell: "they did not repent" (Rev. 9:20-21; 16:9 & 11). All of us have a choice, Jesus preached: to repent or to perish in hell (Luke 13:1-5; Rev. 21:8). Some Hyper-Grace teachers are very quick to reject any "pre-cross" statement of Jesus like the one I just quoted. But they do quote portions from the sayings of pre-cross Jesus which they think squares up well with their deceptive theology. For example, I have heard them quote from Luke 9:53-55 (where Jesus rebukes his disciples, James and John, who

wanted to call down fire from heaven to destroy Samaritans). They should make up their minds to accept ALL the words of Jesus or NONE of it. And they should not forget, "ALL" Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for "teaching" (2 Tim. 3:16).

I-INCESSANT IDENTITY INSANITY!

G, for Grace Grammer Goof-up; R, for Repentance Redefinition or Riddance; I for Incessant Identity Insanity! We are using the acronym G-R-I-P to understand the tenets of the Hyper-Grace cult teaching here. The way Hyper-Grace teachers will invariably begin their messages is this way: "Today, I will tell you who you are in Christ - your identity in Christ!!" While it is good to know our *identity* in Christ, we must not forget the *responsibility* of holy living that Christ calls us to (1 Thess. 4:3 says, "It is God's will, your sanctification, that you abstain from sexual immorality"). Hyper-Grace teachers, call those who preach on holiness or progressive sanctification, as 'hypocritical legalists' or 'mixed-grace preachers'. But the Scripture does teach progressive, day-to-day sanctification. One of the 16 fundamental doctrines of the Assemblies of God is (progressive) sanctification which is expressed by these words: "Sanctification is realized in the believer by recognizing his identification with Christ in His death and resurrection, and by faith reckoning daily upon the fact of that union, and by offering every faculty continually to the dominion of the Holy Spirit." Revelation 22:11 goes this way – 'let the righteous go on in righteousness; and let the holy go on being made holy' (HCSB) – and calls us for progressive

holiness. We chose to live holy using our free-will, enabled by the Holy Spirit's power (Gal. 5:16; Rom. 8:13). Therefore, we have nothing to boast about, except that we have been enabled by His Grace.

P-PERMANENTLY PLEASED POP!

G, for Grace Grammer Goof-up; R, for Repentance Redefinition or Riddance; I for Incessant Identity Insanity! And finally, P for Permanently Pleased Pop. We are using the acronym G-R-I-P to understand the tenets of the Hyper-Grace cult teaching here. The teaching the Hyper-Grace cult teachers systematically spread is this: "God, your loving father, doesn't see you in your failures and shortcomings; He sees you in Jesus' perfection and loveliness, always." If that were true, Jesus, when he saw the failures and shortcomings of the Revelation churches would have said, "Rejoice! I do not see your sin!" But, instead, he said, "Repent!" (because he **did** see their sin, even post the completion of work of Jesus on the Cross!) He said that six times (Rev. 2:5 & 16, 21-22; 3 & 19). If God, the Father is only watching His son Jesus and does not bother about our day-to-day sinful acts, why would Paul write this to Timothy: 'Watch your life and doctrine closely. Persevere in them, because if you do, you will save both yourself and your hearers' (1 Tim. 4:16)? We must not exalt one image of God found in the Bible at the expense of other images, leading to a blunder that could land us in hell. **In Hebrews 12, we read that God is both these "CFs" - a Compassionate Father (verse 5) and a Consuming Fire (verse 29)!** God is not just a Father who dotes over us, he is a Master whom we must obey, the Scripture tells us repeatedly

(1 Cor. 6:13; Col. 3:24; Jude 4; Gal. 6:17; 1 Thess. 1:6-8). He is not just a loving dad but also a faithfulness-expecting and purity-expecting Bride Groom (2 Cor. 11:2; Eph. 5:27). We are saved *by* grace, *for* good works and holy living (Eph. 2:8-10). Let us not forget that.

'GOD SINGS OVER ME, EVEN WHEN I SIN!' REALLY?

Zephaniah 3:17 is a favourite verse of the Hyper-Grace proponents. I have heard Hyper-Grace leaning worship leaders quote this verse often. "God is always singing in joy over you, even if you live in sin!" – they teach in-effect, they imply, by quoting this verse. This is simply not true. Before this Bible chapter says, "Wow, God sings over you", in Zephaniah 3:17, please note that it says "Woe, if you don't repent" in Zephaniah 3:1 (in-effect). Zephaniah 3:1-4 lists the sins Israel had to repent from, including the big sin of doing violence to God's Word (Zep. 3:4). Also, this chapter is talking about life after the final judgment of God. Zephaniah 3:8 talks about 'the day' when God will gather nations and pours out his fiery indignation over them when 'all the earth will be devoured by the fire of God's zeal' (NASB). Prophet Zephaniah is talking about a period in which God's judgments totally clear the enemies of His children (Zeph. 3:15). From the New Testament we understand all to this can only happen in the period after the return of Jesus (Rev. 19), post the Great White Throne Judgment (Rev. 20). 2 Peter 3 teaches that total destruction of the world with fire happens only after Jesus' return as a thief (see v.10). In Zephaniah 3:11, God is also talking about removing sin amidst his people, totally, 'on that

day' [see verse 13 of Zephaniah 3, where it says 'The remnant of Israel will do no wrong and tell no lies, nor will a deceitful tongue be found in their mouths…' (NASB)]. When we read the rest of the Bible, we know that this is talking about life in New Heaven and New Earth where there is no sin (Rev. 21:27). The literal presence of God amidst his people is talked about in Zephaniah 3:15 and again, that happens only in the New Heaven and New Earth – not before that (Zeph. Rev. 21:3). So, quoting Zephaniah 3:17 to support Hyper-Grace theology ('God is singing over you even when you sin!' in-effect) when this chapter, Zephaniah 3, talks about the time when there is no sin among God's people (that happens only in heaven), is seriously erroneous!

Let's get busy with the work of rescuing those friends of ours, caught in the G-R-I-P of the Hyper-Grace teaching before it is too late. Let us boldly go to places where false doctrines like hell-populating Hyper-Grace teaching are being taught! And let us "charge" people not to teach any doctrine that is contrary to Scripture there (See 1 Tim. 1:3)!

CHAPTER 3

A BELIEVER'S FUTURE SINS: ARE THEY AUTOMATICALLY FORGIVEN?



The direct answer from the Bible using the S-I-N-N-E-D acronym

SERVANT OF CHRIST COMMITS SUICIDE! BELIEVER COUPLE PLANS ONE-NIGHT STAND!

Here is a true-to-life incident: A man of God after many years of faithful, full-time ministry, committed suicide. Some of the believers who knew him were heard conversing about his tragic death this way: "Even though he committed suicide, he would definitely go to heaven because even a believer's future sins are forgiven, the moment he accepts Jesus." Really? Think of the possible implications of this horrendous teaching. Let me outline a couple of scenarios for you: If a believer's future sins are automatically forgiven, then a believer couple who are not yet married could also plan for a one-night stand, within the confines of a car, say post a half-night prayer they attended together, without thinking too much about it. If a believer's future sins are already forgiven, the latest porn movie could be watched without a see-saw battle

inside that believer's conscience!

Yet, Hyper-Grace, false Gospel teachers constantly rattle that a believer's future sins are forgiven, the moment they commit them. Is this true? Is this biblical?

I want to use the acronym S-I-N-N-E-D to give a direct answer:

S STANDS FOR THE "SAVIOR'S SAYINGS". We don't need to look beyond the saying of our Savior Jesus to understand that our future sins are NOT auto forgiven. He said, "For if you forgive others their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you, but if you do not forgive others their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses" (Matt. 6:14-15). If we stubbornly refuse to forgive the sins of those who may have hurt us, harmed us – and keep doing that in the future till the time we die – our Father in Heaven could choose to withhold his forgiveness towards us.

I STANDS FOR THE "INSTRUCTIONS FROM THE INTIMATE FRIEND". John, Jesus' most intimate friend, writing under the Spirit's inspiration taught us in-effect that a believer's future sins are NOT automatically forgiven. He taught that "if" we confess our sins, Jesus "is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:9). This implies, if we do not confess our sins with a repentant heart, they would remain unforgiven. In the Greek language – the language in which this verse was first written – the meaning of this verse is this: if we go on confessing our sins (when we sin), Jesus will go on cleansing us with

His blood. Present continuous tense is used for both "confession" and "cleansing". This specific instruction was written for believers (1 John 5:13 – 'I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God so that you may know that you have eternal life'). The Singapore Hyper-Grace Cult Pastor who says that the confession-of-sin calling for 1 John 1:9 verse was not written for believers, is anti-biblical.

N STANDS FOR THE "NABI'S EXAMPLE". The word "Nabi" means prophet. The Nabi, I refer to here is Prophet Isaiah. He knew Yahweh as his God. He was a believer if we were to use New Testament terms. Yahweh appeared to this believer to commission him for ministry. That was when this Nabi realized he was a "man of unclean lips" (Isa. 6:5). The realization of his sin gripped Isaiah and he called a "woe" upon himself. He realized that God was "Holy, Holy, Holy" while he was "holey, holey, holey" (full of sins and holes) (Isa. 6:3,5). It was ONLY AFTER THIS realization and confession that "one of the seraphim flew to Isaiah having in his hand a burning coal that he had taken with tongs from the altar and he touched Isaiah's mouth and said: "Behold, this has touched your lips; your guilt is taken away, and your sin atoned for" (Isa. 6:6-7). Though Jesus died two thousand years ago, in God's mind He was 'the Lamb who was slaughtered before the world was made' (Rev. 13:8, NLT). In God's mind, Jesus was 'the lamb who was slaughtered before the creation of the world' (Rev. 13:8, GW). Old Testament saints were saved and were forgiven of their sins even as they looked forward to the sacrifice of the Messiah. I believe that this was the "Gospel" preached by Yahweh to people who lived right up to

the time of Jesus' historic sacrifice of Himself on the Cross (Gen. 15:6; Isa. 53; Gal. 3:8). Indeed, Isaiah's sin was 'atoned for' after he admitted his sin, and confessed it, in God's presence. This did not happen automatically.

N STANDS OF YET ANOTHER NABI'S EXAMPLE. The Nabi we are now talking about is Jeremiah. When the going got tough in his ministry path, he called God, "a deceptive brook" (Jer. 15:18). The Lord God immediately issues a call for him to repent this way: "If you repent, I will restore you that you may serve me; if you utter worthy, not worthless, words, you will be my spokesman" (Jer. 15:19). Later on, because Jeremiah repented in response to God's rousing call, he was able to prophetically record the repentance experience of the country of Ephraim. Jeremiah wrote, "After I strayed, I repented; after I came to understand, I beat my breast. I was ashamed and humiliated because I bore the disgrace of my youth" (Jer. 31:19). The forgiveness of the sins offered to the backslidden Jeremiah and backslidden Ephraim was not automatic – it was God's response to their repentance.

E STANDS FOR EZRA'S CONFESSION. Ezra, as the leader of Israel, owned up the sin of marrying unbelievers which his people had horrendously committed and confessed it with a heart of repentance (Ezra 9:1-15). The people followed their leader's example and did the same (Ezra 10:1-5). Sins of the people were not automatically forgiven even in this case.

D STANDS FOR THE "DAVID'S EXAMPLE". King David was a believer for many years when he committed adultery with Bathsheba (we could say that). After Prophet Nathan confronted him with what I call as the "mutton biryani preparation parable", King David confessed, "I have sinned against the Lord" (2 Sam.12:13). King David was immediately forgiven of his sin after this confession. That is why he writes in Psalm 32, 'I said, "I will confess my transgressions to the Lord," and you forgave the iniquity of my sin' (verse 5). David's sin-confession example from Psalm 32 is used as an illustration by Apostle Paul when he wanted to show that New Testament believers can be forgiven by confessing their sins with a repentant heart without having to do "works" [the context suggests that these "works" are animal sacrifices] (Rom. 4:5-8; See Rom. 12:1 where Paul writes that New Testament believers have to offer their own bodies as living sacrifices to God, rather than animals). King David's sins were certainly not auto forgiven without him confessing and renouncing them.

When this S-I-N-N-E-D line of argument is presented, you will find Hyper-Grace false teachers rushing to quote certain verses from the book of Hebrews as their defence.

What about **VERSES HYPER-GRACE TEACHERS QUOTE TO SAY 'FUTURE SINS OF BELIEVERS ARE AUTO-FORGIVEN'?** They would quote **Hebrews 10:10** ('And by that will we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ **once for all**') to teach that we have been forgiven forever, the moment we first came to Christ for our salvation. That argument cannot stand as we will see. In Hebrews 10:14, just four verses

later, we read that "He has perfected for all time those being sanctified (NKJV)/perfected (ESV)". Notice the present-continuous tense here: "being sanctified". Hebrews 10:10 talks about our *positional sanctification* (the sanctification, God gifts us with because of what Jesus has done on the Cross) while Hebrews 10:14 talks about a *progressive sanctification* (a sanctification that is ours when we hate sin and obey Christ using our free will, every second of our ongoing life, enabled by the Spirit). So, the message of Hebrews 10:14 is this: If we cooperate with the Lord Jesus and the Holy Spirit and choose to be sanctified by rejecting sin, we would be "perfected". Eugene Peterson puts that verse in a way we can understand better, this brilliant way: "By that single offering, he did everything that needed to be done for everyone who takes part in the purifying process" (Heb. 10:14 MSG). So, the 'forgiven forever' promise of Hebrews 10:10 is only for those who keep taking part in the Hebrews 10:14-talked-about 'purifying process' using their free-will, enabled by the Grace of God. What the writer to the Hebrews is saying, is this: The historic event of Jesus dying for our sins will not be repeated each time when any of us, today's believers, commits a sin. It is an once-for-all-time event. It is unrepeatable event. Jesus has already done once-for-all what needs to be done for our sins to be forgiven.

INSTEAD OF BEING FORGIVEN, FRIED!

Yes, Christ has made the provision for even our future sins to be forgiven. But we need to be willing to take part in the purifying process to make that provision ours. If the writer to the Hebrews meant we are

auto-forgiven even of our future sins, he would NOT have written these following lines immediately after the "once for all sanctified" reference in Hebrews 10:10: "For if we go on sinning deliberately after receiving the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins, but a fearful expectation of judgment, and a fury of fire that will consume the adversaries" (Heb. 10:26,27). Deliberate, unrepented-of sin committed by a believer in the future will NOT be automatically forgiven – this was the sombre point of the writer. **But these sort of future sins, instead of being forgiven, would put us in a position, to be "fried" – in eternal hell**. So, let us be careful!

COPYING THE HIGH PRIEST WHO FIRST SACRIFICED FOR HIS OWN SIN

There is one more reason why I believe that Hebrews 10:10 does not teach that a believer's future sins are auto forgiven. Right below that verse is an instruction to "have our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience" before we enter God's holiest presence (Heb. 10:19,22). What is the implication of this verse – Hebrews 10:22 – a verse obviously loaded with Old Testament imagery? Just as the high priest sacrificed an animal for his sins before entering the Most Holy Place (Lev. 16:3,4), modern believers should wash themselves in the blood of Jesus (that is, ask Jesus to cleanse them of any sin that they are guilty of through His shed blood, with a repentant heart) even as they appear before Him. But a danger awaits those believers who think they can appear before Christ with deliberate sins in their life, just as danger awaited the sons of High Priest, Aaron,

who entered the Holy of Holies without going through the cleansing process (Lev. 10:1-2, they fell dead in God's holy presence). The same danger awaits a believer who thinks God would excuse a deliberately done, unconfessed sin. That danger can be sudden death that takes one to eternal condemnation like it happened to Ananias and Sapphira (Acts 5:1-9) or it could be a consignment to the eternally burning flames of hell, after a natural end to life (Heb. 10:26,31).

HEBREWS 7:25 DOES NOT TEACH FUTURE SINS ARE AUTO FORGIVEN

Some Hyper-Grace teachers also quote **Hebrews 7:25** to teach that a believer's future sins are forgiven forever. The verse goes like this: "Therefore, He is always able to save those who come to God through Him, since He always lives to intercede for them" (HCSB). It is pretty clear that only those who keep coming to God through Him (Jesus) would be forever saved or forever forgiven. The phrase "those who come to God" does not mean "those who once upon a time came to God". The Orthodox Jewish Bible (OJB) version uses the word "approaching" in this verse and this word suggests an on-going action. The writer of Hebrews is talking about a continual drawing near to God, here! Only those who consistently keep short accounts with God – only those who immediately repent when they fall into sin, confess it to the Lord immediately, and strive to walk in holiness enabled by the Spirit – are referred to in this verse, as being forever saved/forgiven. This verse is not teaching that those who live wantonly in sin, without remorse, are saved forever or forgiven forever. If the

writer of this book, thought otherwise, he would not have made statements such as these: "Pursue peace with everyone, and holiness – without it no one will see the Lord" (Heb. 12:14, HCSB).

'WILL GOD FORGIVE THE SINS THAT I AM PLANNING TO COMMIT?'

Philip Yancey wrote, "Can God forgive you (of the sin you plan to commit)? Of course. What we must go through to commit sin distances us from God – we change in the very act of rebellion – and there is no guarantee we will come back. You ask me about forgiveness now, but will you even want it later, especially if it involves repentance?" I agree!

JUDAS AND HIS PLANNING FOR COMMITTING FUTURE SINS

Perhaps, **Judas planned to commit the sin** of betraying Jesus with a plan to get back to Jesus as soon as he received his payment. But you know what happened: Judas committed the sin, he planned. But he did not ever come back to Christ. He had changed in the very act of rebellion (as Yancey put it).

Judas had reached a point of no return which Jesus alone knew (Jesus' words to Judas in John 13:27 – 'What you are about to do, do quickly' – suggests this). That is the kind of sin which 1 John 5:17 talks about – a sin

that leads to death, which is hell punishment also called second death (Rev. 20:14; Rev. 21:8). Judas committed a sin that led to second death and was sadly, hell-bound (John 17:12).

WHAT IF WE DIE SUDDENLY, WHILE IN STUBBORN SIN?

Let's be cautious so that what happened to Judas, will not happen to us. Let us not plan to sin purposefully against the Lord ('after all, he is a God of grace, and if we ask him for forgiveness after the committing of sin, God will certainly forgive' – our wicked thoughts expressed in words). We may never return to the Lord in the first place. What's more – we may even die while we are in the act of committing that sin and get doomed to hell automatically.

This happened to the **young men of Israel**. God struck them down dead, when they still had in their mouths, the sinful food they craved for (Psa. 78:30-31).

Ananias and Sapphira were struck down by God when they were in the act of committing the sin of deception – a sin they planned together to commit (Acts 5:1-9). Sure, Jesus was praying for them (Heb. 7:25). But Jesus would not violate their free will to force them to choose Him and His Holy ways. He gave them many chances (the Bible does not record how many chances He gave them) and decided to finish them off when they

did not please Him, in what was their final chance, when they appeared before Peter with a plan to deceive him in Acts, chapter 5.

This wasn't the solitary case of God striking down sinners, post Jesus' work on the Cross, resurrection, ascension and present intercession for us sitting at God the Father's right hand. **King Herod** also died in a similar fashion. An angel of the Lord struck down a cocky Herod (see Acts 12:21-22).

Even what seems like a natural death while we are in the act of stubborn, habitual, wanton sin – can be catastrophic for there is no chance of forgiveness or salvation post one's death as the Bible teaches (Heb. 9:27).

SIN THAT LEADS TO DEATH AND SIN THAT DOES NOT LEAD TO DEATH

Let's say, we commit a sin. At that point, we must realize that it is because of God's great mercy that we aren't yet consumed – we aren't yet slain (as Prophet Jeremiah put it in Lamentations 3:22). We must return to God in repentance and sin-confession immediately (1 John 1:9). This kind of sin is what John calls as '**sin that does not lead to death (hell)**' in 1 John 5:17 (Rev. 21:8 equals second death to hell). 'Sin that do not lead to death' that the book of 1 John in the Bible talks about, includes sins for which we have repented of and have asked God for forgiveness without lingering in them stubbornly (1 John 1:9; 3:9). But if we laze around in sin deliberately,

thinking nothing of it, brazenly, and God forbid, if we were to die while we are still in sin, they can turn out to be the **'sin that leads to death (hell)'** (1 John 5:16; Rev. 21:8).

IF YOU SAY, 'EVEN MY FUTURE SINS ARE ALREADY FORGIVEN...'

It certainly seems that those who stubbornly say, "Our future sins are already forgiven; so there is no need to ask God for forgiveness for them," are well on their way to hell. **Jude 4** suggests so. Often, we understand from that verse that the grace of God is sadly used like a credit card to justify a swim into sensuality, a foray into sexual sin. In other words, some Hyper-Grace believers, are telling themselves, "I will commit this sexual sin and get back to God once I get my fill of pleasure. And I will keep doing this as and when I need pleasure, after all, God is gracious." These folks are "already condemned" to hell as Jude records (in verse 4). But if they are willing to change their opinion, God would forgive them and they would be on their way to heaven. The choice is theirs.

"Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy." – **Proverbs 28:13,** The Bible. Yes, God has made the PROVISION for the forgiveness of our future sins. But we do not receive that forgiveness automatically. But it is up to us to take POSSESSION of our forgiveness, by truly repenting from sin, confessing them and asking the blood of Jesus to cleanse us.

WHEN JIM BAKKER AND STEVE SMITH PUBLICLY CONFESSED THEIR SINS!

Amazon described **Jim Bakker's book, *I Was Wrong,*** this way: 'The loss of Jim Bakker's empire, his money, his home, and his reputation in the two years leading up to his imprisonment in 1989 was only the beginning. In prison, he was to lose even more - his freedom, his sanity, his dignity, his confidence in his faith, and eventually even his wife. Inmate 07407-058, one-time confidant to presidents, had hit bottom. Jim Bakker was wrong about many things. Exactly what they were and **how he came to confess them** will surprise and inspire you. This is his story.' Hats off to Jim Bakker – he followed the biblical command of sin confession (this is not to say that one must confess sins to people to be forgiven, see Acts 10:43)! The very title of his autobiography – *I Was Wrong* – is an unforgettable illustration for the biblical command that believers must confess their sin to God when they sin!

This New Indian Express report tells us of another gripping story of sin-confession: 'Visuals of Australian fast-bowler Cameron Bancroft trying to change the condition of the ball and later hiding the "sandpaper" in his trousers caused an uproar' (in the third day of the third Test between Australia and South Africa in Cape Town, South Africa, 2018). The report continued this way: 'After the day's play, Australian Captain, Steve Smith and Bancroft admitted to trying to change the condition of the ball for which the International Cricket Council handed Smith a one-match ban and fined him 100 percent of his match fee. Bancroft received four demerit

points and was fined 50 percent of the match fee.' After Cricket Australia banned him, **teary-eyed Steve Smith** told this to the press: "To all my teammates, to fans of cricket all over the world and to all Australians who are disappointed and angry. I'm sorry. I take full responsibility … There was a failure of leadership, of my leadership. **I'll** do everything **I** can to make up for my mistake and the damage it's caused." Yes, when sin is committed by a believer, it must be confessed to God as we have seen above! The real examples of folks who were perhaps not even believers, confessing their blunders, should challenge us in this regard!

(This chapter was voluntarily edited by Deborah Snegalatha V, Beulah Herbert, Christopher Tharalla, Mary Esther, Rachel Niveditha and Katuri Sushmita).

CHAPTER 4

WILL GOD FORGIVE THE SIN I AM PLANNING TO COMMIT? FOR EXAMPLE, THE PORN-SURFING SESSION I AM PLANNING TO HAVE?



"His grace is cheapened when you think that He has only forgiven you of your sins up to the time you got saved, and after that point, you have to depend on your confession of sins to be forgiven. God's forgiveness is not given in instalments." – ***Singapore megachurch Hyper - Grace cult pastor.***

This quotation from this cultic Hyper-Grace pastor implies that even the future sins are already forgiven for the believer. So, can a believer plan future sins? So, can a believer plan a porn-surfing session without worrying too much as his/her future sins are 'already forgiven' (according to this preacher).

TWO KINDS OF SANCTIFICATION EXPLAINED FROM THE BOOK OF REVELATION

The book of Revelation makes for wonderful reading. The lessons taught in the first 65 books of the Bible are pictorially confirmed by its book no. 66 - the book of Revelation. "There is nothing new in Revelation which is not taught clearly elsewhere in the Bible!" - this I believe.

We are 'given a white robe', we read in the book of Revelation (Rev. 6:11). That's a symbolic way of expressing **positional sanctification**. We come to Christ in repentance and faith just as we are, he makes us 'white' – holy and pure. But that's just the start. Positional sanctification would and should translate into **practical sanctification**, if our repentance was genuine. By practical sanctification, I mean, living a life of victory over sin in our day-to-day lives. John talks about practical sanctification this way: "No one who lives in Him makes a practice of sin" (1 John 3:6).

The same book of Revelation talks about those 'clothed in white' in the very next chapter (Rev. 7:13). The folks who wore white, deliberately chose to wear that colour. **We must make a choice to wear white clothes (spiritually speaking), that is, to be pure, say 'no' to sin day in and day out, with God helping and we actively cooperating with him (quoting God's Word, running away from temptation, praying to receive power at the hour of temptation, being accountable to a believer pal, etc).**

THE WEDDING BANQUET PARABLE AND SANTIFICATION

If we want only the *privileges* of positional sanctification without the responsibility of practical sanctification, we are like the man who walked into a wedding feast without wearing the 'wedding garment' already gifted to him before the wedding (Matt. 22:11). He had no excuse for not wearing the wedding garment (Matt. 22:12). We will have no excuse for living a practical holy life on the final day because God has given us everything, we need to live that life - His Word, the Fellowship of the Church, opportunity to be accountable, and the enabling power of the Holy Spirit, etc. (Eph. 1:3; Rom. 8:13). And the end of those who just want the privileges of 'positional sanctification' without the responsibilities of 'practical sanctification' will be same as that of the wedding guest whom Jesus talked about - being bound and bounced into eternal hell (Matt. 22:13). Prophet Amos combines both – privileges given to us by God and responsibilities we have because of those privileges in the same verse! Read Amos 3:2. It goes this way: "You only have I chosen of all the families of the earth (the first part of this verse is talking about a PRIVILEGE that God gave the people of Israel); therefore I will punish you for all your sins (the second part of Amos 3:2 talks about the punishment sent by God upon the people of Israel and even upon the believers among Gentiles, for not responding with a sense of RESPONSIBILITY, even after God gave them so many PRIVILEGES!)

ROMANS 2:5 VS REVELATION 2:5

So, my friend, let not anyone deceive you saying, "Jesus has already forgiven the sin you are planning to commit". The Bible declares that God will not forgive the sin that we refuse to even acknowledge as sin. The Bible declares that God will not forgive the sin we refuse to repent from (Luke 13:1-5). The Bible teaches that we only store up God's wrath (we are on the road to hell, in other words) by refusing to repent (see Rom. 2:5). Another 2:5 – Revelation 2:5 I mean – warns of the judgement of God which will come upon those CHURCH BELIEVERS who refuse to repent!

JUDAS VS PETER WHEN IT COMES TO HANDLING BACKSLIDING INTO SIN

"Will Jesus forgive the sin I am planning to commit?" He will - provided you come to him in true repentance and ask him for forgiveness. But there is no guarantee that you will ever do that. Judas did not. He was saved. His name was written in heaven (Luke 10:20). But he also lived in sin even as he lived with Jesus. He used to, now and then, help himself with the moneybag of Jesus. He allowed greed to grip him, slowly but surely (John 12:6). The greed became a monstrous ball, and, before he knew it, Judas agreed to help the religious leaders of his day to arrest Jesus for the money he would pocket by doing so. He may have thought, "I will come back to Jesus after I am done and dusted with this sin!" (like we say, "I will ask Jesus for forgiveness after I am done with

this hour of porn-surfing!" or "I will ask Jesus for forgiveness after I am done with this session of gossip with my close buddies!"). But he did not. Yes, Judas did not get back to Jesus after he committed wanton sin. He ended his life. He headed to hell (John 17:12).

But Peter was different from Judas. Peter came back to Jesus after he committed sin. He repented genuinely. He took a U-turn. When he wept bitterly, Jesus did not ever say to him, "Don't weep Peter. Don't repent of your sin. I have already taken care of it!" (Matt. 26:75). Instead, Jesus allowed Peter to weep for his sin. Because doing so is good. It is better and wiser to weep over our sins now, in this period of grace when there is time, than to weep upon seeing Jesus return the second time to judge us when there will be no time given to repent (Rev. 1:7). Jesus taught we must weep for ourselves and our children (Luke 23:28). So, when we sin, we must feel sorry for that sin and come back to Jesus in repentance (Luke 13:1-5).

We must consciously avoid deliberate sin. For when we keep committing deliberate sin without even repenting of it, there will come a point in our life, like it happened in the life of Judas, that we will, perhaps, commit a deliberate sin and never feel like coming back to Jesus in repentance. It's then we come to a point in our life when 'there will be no sacrifice for sins left but only a fearful expectation of judgement and of the raging fire that will consume the enemies of God' as the Bible teaches (Heb. 10:26,27).

So, let's say with Paul, "I strike a blow to my body and make it my slave (in other words, 'wage war with sin with the power of God'), so that, after I have preached to others (in other words, 'after I have been a believer all my life and preached God's Word too'), I myself, will not be disqualified for the prize!" (1 Cor. 9:27).

CONSEQUENCES WHEN WE COMMIT WANTON SIN

Also we must remember that there are consequences when God's children commit wanton sin. Let's look at the case of believers committing sexual sin deliberately. What follows is an extract from my book, *Straight Talk:*

From the Bible we read about the following lethal results when people have lapped up sexual sin:

Firstly, the LORD will leave you and you won't know it. Like it happened for Samson as he lay on Delilah's lap (Jud. 16:20).

Secondly, you can never be a leader who will influence people for good. Joseph, one who was famous among a set of 12 brothers for beating sexual temptation was told under Divine Inspiration that he would be a "prince among his brothers" while the one who slept with his father's wife, Reuben, was told "you will be first no longer" (Gen. 49:4,26). David, the great leader of Israel who had an adulterous affair, had to go silent when his son raped his daughter (2 Sam. 13: 21,22).

Thirdly, violence could become commonplace in your family. David learnt this bitter truth when the lives of three of his Sons – Amnon (2 Sam. 13:23-38), Absalom (2 Sam. 18:9-18) and Adonijah (1 Kings 2:13-46) were cut short violently at the prime of their youth.

Fourthly, you would have given birth to spiritual enemies who will battle against you for the rest of your life. The sons born to Lot's daughters out of their incestuous relationship with him brought forth the clans of Moabites and Ammonites – two of Israel's most bitter enemies in their later years (Gen. 19:30-36).

Fifthly, the advantages you may have gotten through sexual sins will melt away. Remember, David's love-child born as a result of his adulterous relationship with Bathsheba eventually died despite his plea that God would spare Him (2 Sam. 12:14).

Sixthly, God's name will be blasphemed. "You who say that people should not commit adultery, do you commit adultery? As it is written: 'God's name is blasphemed among the gentiles because of you!'" wrote Paul (Rom. 2: 22,24).

Finally, when you persist stubbornly in sexual sin you'll go to hell. The Bible doesn't mince words when it says "the sexually immoral - their place will be the fiery lake of burning sulphur" (Rev. 21:8). L-U-S-T is a four-lettered sin that will take you to a four-lettered place - H-E-L-L.

Does the above adverse outcomes of those who indulged in sexual sin make you shudder? It is meant to do just that. Reason? Shuddering (having a holy fear of God) can also be a biblical way to beat sexual temptation! After proclaiming the Ten Commandments to the people of Israel (including the command, "You shall not commit adultery") Moses told them, "The fear of God will be with you to keep you from sinning!" (Exod. 20:14,20). The next time when you think of yielding to sexual temptations, take time to count the cost of yielding to them and you will find that thought not so pleasurable.

BILL CLINTON'S FACE COULD HAVE BEEN ON MOUNT RUSHMORE, BUT...

The effects of yielding to sexual temptation or any temptation are deadly - even the secular world stories reveal this. It is said that **Bill Clinton** lost the privilege of his face being carved with the other great American Presidents at Mount Rushmore and also missed out on a Noble Prize because of his incredibly foolish sexual affair with Monica Lewinsky (*Asian Age*, Bangalore edition, 21 September 1998). It is a fact that the great Australian leg-spinner, **Shane Warne**, lost the honour of leading the Australian Cricket Team because of the phone sex scandals that surrounded him. **Tiger Woods** lost his sponsorship deals with multinational companies because of his sexual sins. **Tim Paine** lost his Test Captaincy of the Australian Cricket Team because of his involvement in a sexting scandal. This list is endless. Your name does not have to be in this list. My name does

not have to be in this list. Let us live a victorious Christian life and win over the habit of committing deliberate, callous, sin, with God helping us and we actively cooperating with Him.

CHAPTER 5

'TAKING EFFORTS FOR HOLINESS IS WRONG' — ARE HYPER-GRACE PREACHERS RIGHT WHEN THEY SAY THAT?



"Ephesians 1:3 tells us that every spiritual blessing comes to us through Christ. There are no extra blessings that come to us separately from Christ and in response to our obedience. All is grace." ***— a New Zealand based Hyper-Grace blogger.***

"What we need today are not more laws to govern believers. What we need is a greater revelation and appreciation of Jesus and everything that He has done for us!" — ***a Singapore megachurch Hyper-Grace pastor.***

"Jesus Himself has already paid the price for your sins, so stop condemning yourself! Today, when you look into the mirror, what do you see? Do you see yourself trapped in all your failings, mistakes, and sins? Or do you see what God sees? **My dear friend, when God sees you today, He sees Jesus. Use your eyes of faith and believe that as Jesus is, so are you.** In God's eyes, you are (already) righteous, you are favored, you are blessed, and you are healed. You are freed from all sin, all pangs of guilt, all forms of condemnation, and every bondage of addiction!" — ***a Singapore megachurch Hyper-Grace pastor.***

So, these Hyper-Grace preachers are saying this in-effect: Go to bed when it comes to sanctification; there is no need for battle! Rest when it comes to sanctification; there is no need to run! Relax when it comes to sanctification; there is no need to flex (muscles)! Holiness, according to them is effortless! Really?

GIFTED HOLINESS VS GAURDED HOLINESS

We must first understand that the Bible talks about two kinds of holiness: **gifted holiness and guarded holiness**! What is gifted holiness? It is the holiness that Jesus gives us free when we repent from sin and trust in Him. The **dying thief** on the Cross received this holiness instantly! That is why Jesus could tell him, "Today you will be with me in paradise!" (Luke 23:43). These are the repentance-expressing words of one dying thief to the other one who was smocking at Jesus: "Don't you fear God, since you are under the same sentence? We

are punished justly, for we are getting what our deeds deserve. But this man has done nothing wrong" (Luke 23:39-40). These words showed that the dying thief had repented from sin and put his faith in sinless Jesus who died for him. And as a result, He received the gift of sanctification and consequently, He was promised paradise! **Fanny Crosby** (1820-1915), the great Hymn-Writer talked about this kind of holiness when she penned: 'The vilest offender who truly believes; That moment from Jesus a pardon receives' (Hymn, *To God Be The Glory*).

But the same Bible talks about another kind of holiness – **guarded holiness!** What is that? We guard our freely given holiness with God's Holy Spirit-enabled effort, every day, every minute, every second, every nano-second! The writer of the Epistle to the Hebrews talked about this second kind of holiness when he wrote, "Make every effort to live in peace with everyone and to be holy; without holiness no one will see the Lord" (Heb. 12:14). Having talked about the first kind of holiness in this book, he talked about the second kind of holiness. Here are some places in the book of Hebrews where the author talks about the first kind of holiness: "How much more, then, will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself unblemished to God, cleanse our consciences from acts that lead to death, so that we may serve the living God!" (Heb. 9:14); "And by that will, we have been made holy through the sacrifice of the body of Jesus Christ once for all" (Heb. 10:10). "And so Jesus also suffered outside the city gate to make the people holy through his own blood" (Heb. 13:12). The author of Hebrews also talks about the need for the second kind of holiness

here: 'Marriage should be honored by all and the marriage bed kept undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers. Keep your lives free from the love of money and be content with what you have, for God has said: "Never will I leave you, never will I forsake you"' (Heb. 13:4-5).

TWO KINDS OF HOLINESS WHICH EPHESIANS TALKS ABOUT

I began this chapter with a quote from a **New Zealand-based Hyper-Grace blogger cum false teacher**. He says (as I have already mentioned above): "Ephesians 1:3 tells us that every spiritual blessing comes to us through Christ. There are no extra blessings that come to us separately from Christ and in response to our obedience. All is grace."

We need to return to the book of Ephesians to understand the grave error put forth by this cultic false teacher. Ephesians 1:3 which reads – 'Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in the heavenly realms with every spiritual blessing in Christ' – is talking about the first kind of holiness, which is gifted holiness. But the same book often talks about the second kind of holiness as well, grace-enabled guarded holiness! Let me give you some examples: 'As a prisoner for the Lord, then, I urge you to **live a life worthy of the calling you have received**. Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love. **Make every effort** to keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace' (Eph. 4:1-3). He is

talking about guarded holiness here. Guarded holiness is also lived-out holiness (notice the phrase above, 'live a life worthy'). Guarded holiness takes effort – God-enabled effort, I would say – as we can understand from the phrase used ('make every **effort** to keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace').

NOT JUST 'OBTAIN', BUT ALSO 'MAINTAIN'!

Here are three New Testament passages that imply that though sanctification (holiness) is what we 'obtain' as a gift when we come to Christ, we should also take Grace-enabled daily efforts to 'maintain' it:

1 Peter 2:11 ESV: "Beloved, I urge you as sojourners and exiles to abstain from the passions of the flesh, which **wage war** against your soul."

Rom. 7:23 NIV: "but I see another law at work in me, **waging war** against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin at work within me."

Eph. 6:12 NLT: "For we are not **fighting** against flesh-and-blood enemies, but against evil rulers and authorities of the unseen world, against mighty powers in this dark world, and against evil spirits in the heavenly places."

SO MANY NEW TESTAMENT WORDS CALLING FOR ACTIVE PERSONAL EXERTION!

J. C. Ryle (1816-1900), an English evangelical Anglican bishop, wrote, "There are 25 to 30 passages in the epistles where believers are taught to use active personal exertion and are addressed as responsible for doing what Christ would have them to." Here are 30 examples from the epistles which I fished out regarding this:

Endure (Heb. 12:7, NIV)

Persevere (1 Tim. 4:16, NASB)

Toil and struggle using the mighty strength which Christ supplies
(Col 1:29, GNT)

Don't look back (Phil. 3:13, GW)

Deny ungodliness (Tit. 2:12, NASB)

Devote themselves to good works (Tit. 3:14, ESV)

[Make a] clean cut with sexual immorality (1 Thess. 4:3, PHILLIPS)

Stop behaving as people do in the dark (Rom. 13:12, CEV)

Run from anything that stimulates youthful lusts (2 Tim. 2:22, NLT)

Keep your eyes open for spiritual danger (1 Cor. 16:13, TLB)

Do not run aimlessly (1 Cor. 9:26, ESV)

Press on (Phil. 3:14, ESV)

Fight the good fight (1 Tim. 6:12, ESV)

Be sober-minded (2 Tim. 4:5, ESV)

Be watchful (1 Pet. 5:8, RSV)

Endure grief, suffering wrongfully (1 Pet. 2:19, KJ21)

Exhort one another every day (Heb. 3:13, ESV)

Do not throw away your confidence (Heb. 10:35, ESV)

Put aside every impediment – that is, the sin which easily hampers our forward movement (Heb. 12:1, CJB)

Striving against sin...to the point of death (Heb. 12:4, VOICE)

Do not be conceited (1 Tim. 6:17, NASB)

Holding on to faith and a good conscience (1 Tim. 1:19, NIV)

Submit yourself (Jas. 4:7, NIV)

Don't give the devil a chance (Eph. 4:27, NIRV)

Remain uncorrupted by this world (Jas. 1:27, GW)

Keep standing firm and do not be subject again to a yoke of slavery
(Gal. 5:1, NASB)

Maintain yourself in the love of God (Jude 21, NET)

Build up your strength in union with the Lord (Eph. 6:10, GNT)

Put on the full armor of God (Eph. 6:11, HCSB)

Put to death *and* deprive of power the evil longings of your earthly body
(Col. 3:5, AMP)

Get rid of your anger, hot tempers, hatred, cursing, obscene language, and all similar sins (Col. 3:8, GW)

A CALL FOR A TO Z COMMITMENT!

I would say that this is a call for an "A" to "Z" commitment when it comes to ongoing sanctification! A for Abide [1 John 2:28 (ESV) – And now, little children, ABIDE in him]; Z for Zeal [Rom. 12:11 (ESV) – Do not be slothful in ZEAL; see also, Titus 2:14 (ESV) – Zealous for good works]!

SECRET FOR HOLINESS FROM BOOK OF REVELATION

Read Revelation 22:12-14. Find it printed below for your convenience:

12 "Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me, to repay each one for what he has done. 13 I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end." 14 Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life and that they may enter the city by the gates.

Both verse 12 and verse 14 calls for holiness – we can see it that way! But verse 13, in-between, reveals the person who enables us for the God-expected holiness! It is the "Alpha" and "Omega" Jesus! He is the "Alpha" of our holiness! We became holy the second we come to him in repentance, didn't we? He is also the "Omega" of our holiness! Why? He gives us power to endure in that holiness, by beating the day-to-day temptation that comes to us, till the very end – till our death or till His return, whichever comes earlier!

WHERE DO HOLINESS-REFUSING BELIEVERS LAND UP IN?

In the parable that Jesus narrated in Matthew 22, the man without the proper suit of wedding (verse 12) can be seen as the one who received the free gift of holiness from Jesus (when he got saved) but refused to wear the garment of daily holiness (also given free) because he wanted to enjoy sin as a believer stubbornly. Where does this holiness-refusing believer end? Hell (see Matt. 22:13 – he went to the place of weeping and gnashing of teeth which is hell).

WHEN ROHIT SHARMA WAS LIVID WITH HIMSELF

May I close this refutation of a pro-Hyper-Grace quote by a Singapore pastor by jumping to a story featuring an Indian Cricketer? I want to bring a relevant-to-this-discussion Bible Life Lesson from the India-Pakistan ICC ODI World Cup Match of 16th June 2019 played at Manchester, England.

Most batsmen would be mighty pleased with themselves after a knock of 140 runs made from 113 balls in a crucial World Cup game! That was Rohit Sharma's score in this game. But not Rohit. When he got out, with over 11 overs still to go in India's innings by playing an uncharacteristic shot, right after hitting a six, he was livid with himself. After he played a silly 'dilscoop' like needless shot and gifted his wicket to Pakistan, he was furious. He perhaps knew that no one would outscore him in that Indian innings, including India's then-skipper, Virat Kohli. But, he still was angry with himself for getting out! In the end India crushed Pakistan – the seventh time in as many matches they have played each other in International Cricket Council (ICC) ODI World Cups (up until that point). India, thanks to Rohit's stellar effort, prevailed by 89 runs (the highest ever run margin they have thrashed Pakistan when ICC ODI World Cups games are considered, at the point of writing)! Rohit perhaps thought to himself that if he batted till the end of the 50th Over, India would have gotten to around 400 runs (but instead India got only 336 runs, which however was more than enough). June 16 when this match was held in 2019, it was Father's Day – Rohit perhaps wanted to hit another of his "daddy" hundreds – a big hundred,

perhaps a double-hundred, that would have put the game out of Pakistan's reach even before their batsmen faced even a single ball in their innings!

MIGHTY HAPPY THAT YOU WATCH PORN ONLY ONCE-A-MONTH?

Do we seek to grow in our Christian Life the way Rohit Sharma passionately sought to outdo himself as seen in this cricket game? When you commit a sin, does that bring about a feeling of genuine regret and heart-felt repentance (as Paul calls for in 2 Cor. 7:10), the way Rohit expressed it after playing that fool-hardy shot that robbed him and his team of greater exploits in the 2019 ICC ODI World Cup Match versus Pakistan? Are we listening to Apostle Peter when he writes this: "For this very reason, make every effort to add to your faith virtue; and to virtue, knowledge; and to knowledge, self-control; and to self-control, perseverance; and to perseverance, godliness; and to godliness, brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness, love. For if you possess these qualities and continue to grow in them, they will keep you from being ineffective and unproductive in your knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ." (2 Peter 1:5-8). Are you glad to add to your spiritual living more and more Christ-like character? When Paul wrote that the Corinthian "are being transformed into the same image (of Christ) from one degree of glory to another" would he be talking about us as well (2 Cor. 3:18)? Or are you mighty pleased that, while you watch porn only once in a month, your believer friend watches it once a week (and so you are happy that you are better than him)? Or are you pretty happy that you get

worried only occasionally while your spouse gets worried and frets all the time (instead of looking to grow up even more as a believer to a point where you totally trust in God and do not worry about anything at all)?

Let's not get settled with 'salvation-satisfaction-stagnation' in our spiritual walk. Let Rohit Sharma's fury after his dismissal at 140 in the 39th over of the India-Pakistan 2019 World Cup game, spur us to greater spiritual heights and ongoing Christ-like transformation! Let us never divorce God-enabled 'effort', when it comes to fleshed-out holiness in our Christian Walk, as Hyper-Grace cultists want us to!

CHAPTER 6

NO JUDGMENT OF GOD, POST THE CROSS OF JESUS, AS HYPER-GRACE CULTISTS ALLEGE?



The Hyper-Grace teaching, popular among social-media-impacted church-going youth and young professionals in South India and in other parts of the world, says that there is no need for believers to have the fear of God or the coming judgment because of the work of the Cross. Besides, there is an unfortunate overdose of popular worship songs where even healthy fear of God is also mildly mocked. Influenced by these, young Google Generation believers take sin lightly in their lives. They tend to excuse sin in their lives.

COMPASSIONATE FATHER AS WELL AS CONSUMING FIRE

The Ananias and Sapphira story stands against various elements of the poisonous Hyper-Grace teaching. Acts 5:5 and Acts 5:11 talks about the fear of the Lord coming onto the "church" (see Acts 5:11, where church is mentioned specifically). If church believers need not have a healthy fear for God, such phrases would not be used by Author Luke repeatedly in this narrative. In Hebrews 12, God is presented both as a **'Compassionate Father'** who disciplines (see verse 7) and as a **'Consuming Fire'** who should be reverenced (see verse 28-29). Apostle Paul brings together both the love of God and the wrath of God in a single verse as he writes this way to the believers at the church at Rome and commands these believers to 'consider' both: 'Consider therefore the kindness and sternness of God: sternness to those who fell, but kindness to you, provided that you continue in his kindness. Otherwise, you also will be cut off' (Rom. 11:22). Hence, let us not just cherry pick the characteristics of God we want to acknowledge as per our own whims and fancies.

THE GOD WHO HAS THE RIGHT TO PREPONE THE DAY OF JUDGMENT!

Because the story of Ananias-Sapphira comes against their false narrative that Jesus does not judge people post the Cross, Hyper-Grace cult false teachers have maintained that Ananias and Sapphira were not believers! Really? In the book of Acts, the story that comes before the Ananias-Sapphira story is the story of Barnabas

who sold a field he owned and brought the money to the apostles for those in need. This story comes at the end of Acts chapter 4. We have an unfortunate chapter division post that. This chapter division was not inspired by the Holy Spirit, we know. It was put there later by humans for the convenience of finding Bible passages quickly. I believe the chapter division resulting in Acts chapter 4 and chapter 5 does more harm than good. This division gives us an illusion that Ananias was very different from Barnabas who was clearly a believer, even an apostle (see Acts 14:14). Hyper-Grace cult false teachers go to the extent of saying that Ananias and Sapphira were not even believers. So, what happened to them cannot happen to believers who live in the era after Jesus finished His work on the Cross – this is their point. I strongly disagree. If we considered the context, we would come to this conclusion: if Barnabas was a believer, Ananias-Sapphira are also believers. If they were not believers and part of the church, 'great fear' need not have gripped the entire church as Luke records in Acts 5:11. Luke injects the word 'fear', both in verse 5 and verse 11 of Acts 5, to call believers of today to have a holy and healthy fear of God. This God, who may choose to prepone the day of judgment if he chooses to do so, on select occasions, even in the post-Cross era, as he did in the case of Ananias and Sapphira, needs to be feared.

THE MANY CASES OF POST-CROSS JUDGMENT OF GOD!

A Chennai-based Hyper-Grace false teacher-pastor claims that Peter killed Sapphira based on Peter's words of condemnation recorded in Acts 5:9-10! What a bizarre interpretation! He wears his Hyper-Grace theology

lens and interprets Scripture – hence this bizarre interpretation! Hyper-Grace false teaching asserts that there is no judgement possible, post the Cross of Christ. But we do see many cases of judgement post the Cross of Christ! In fact, it was the 'angel of the Lord' who struck proud Herod, he died and was eaten by worms (Acts 12:23). God was trying to remind Herod that he was, after-all, a worm in his sight, through this dramatic intervention, I would say! This incident happened, post-Cross, mind you! When we take part in communion in an unworthy manner, we bring God's judgement upon ourselves (1 Cor. 11:29). This judgement could involve the on-set of weaknesses, sicknesses and even death (1 Cor. 11:30). This passage found in 1 Corinthians 11 is presenting a post-Cross scenario! The punishment of "sickbed", "great tribulation" and "death" is promised by none other than Jesus himself for the sexual immorality-encouraging, unrepentant, false teacher Jezebel (she could be called a hyper-grace false pastor) and her ardent followers (referred to as 'children') in Revelation 2 (2:20-23, ESV). Revelation 2 presents a post-Cross scenario, surely! Therefore, it would be wrong to say, "Peter put Sapphira to death". God allowed the dramatic deaths of Ananias-Sapphira to bring-in the (holy) fear of himself to the believers of the early church – this is the point of Author Luke, who wrote the book of Acts under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit (Acts 5:5,11). Later, God would use Saul, also called as Paul, to pronounce judgement (this time it was blindness) upon Elymas/Bar-Jesus, the Jewish False Prophet/Magician, who thought he could stop a proconsul from coming to faith in Jesus (Acts 13: 5-11).

THE ONLY JUDGEMENT WE NOW NEED TO TALK ABOUT

I need to make a quick clarification here. Only the New Testament Apostles, part of biblical history, have the special authority from the Lord to be instruments of God in executing such judgement which happens on this side of eternity. We, the believers of today, do not have such authority! We simply cannot go around pronouncing judgement on this side of eternity upon people! The only judgement we need to talk about to people, we share the Good News with, is about the judgement of hell, which comes to those who reject the Lamb of God (Rev. 20:15; 21:7-8)! But that does not mean God has totally stopped preponing Judgement much before the Final Day of Judgement takes place! At times, like He did in the case of Sapphira of Acts 5, Herod of Acts 12 and Jezebel of Revelation 2, God reserves the right to prepone Judgement! **And we will only know about all the cases God's judgment (like the one He meted out to Sapphira) on that Final Day of Judgment when the unrepented-of, secret sins of everyone will be revealed (Rom. 2:16).**

A MATTER OF HEAVEN OR HELL! SO, I REPEAT!

The truth which I have expressed in the above paragraphs, I want to express all over again, with a little more passion, vehemence and forcefulness. "Why?" you may well ask! The reason is that understanding this truth or not understanding this truth could be a matter of heaven or hell for you! So, here is this truth all over again!

Forgive me for repeating the same truth in the same chapter! But I reckon this could turn-out to be soul-saving! Here we go, all over again:

The unbiblical rubbish that Hyper-Grace cult false teachers keep teaching: "You won't see God as an angry/punishing God anymore after the Cross...", "God is not fuming at sin now...."

But the Bible does not teach that. Why then did Paul preach about "coming judgment" after the CROSS (Acts 24:24-25)? He could have well skipped it, if he believed in the Hyper-Grace cult Gospel. But he did not.

JESUS PRAYED FOR ANANIAS AND SAPPHIRA!

Jesus prayed for Ananias and Sapphira sitting at God's right hand. Yet, when they deliberately lied to God, the Holy Spirit, they dropped dead. After giving them enough chances, God decided to end their lives (Acts 5). Haven't we read, "My Spirit does not always strive with man...." in Genesis 6:3? After striving with this believer couple who were under the NEW COVENANT, God decided to send judgement upon them. This is not a stand-alone event. The angel of the Lord stuck down boasting Herod (Acts 12:20-23). This also happened after Jesus died on the Cross, rose again, ascended, sat at the right hand of the Father and started praying! So, did the "angel of the Lord" who struck down Herod "insult" the "finished work of the Cross"? Please answer Hyper-Grace Bible-twisters!

"God will DESTROY those who destroy God's temple" wrote Paul to New Covenant believers (1 Cor. 3:16-17). These believers were arguing for rights to visit prostitutes! So, GOD insulted Jesus' finished work on the Cross, here? Please answer Hyper-Grace teachers!

Jesus told the believers of the church in Thyatira that he would "throw her (a self-appointed prophetess who misled her followers to commit immoral sexual acts) into her sickbed with those who commit adultery with her...:" Jesus further said, "I will punish her by striking her children dead" (Rev. 2:20-23). So, the post-Cross Jesus here insulted his own finished work, according to Hyper-Grace wolves in sheep clothing?

The Bible says, in the New Testament, "Therefore let us be grateful for receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, and thus let us offer to God acceptable worship, with reverence and awe...for our God is a consuming fire!" (Heb. 12:28,29). He is a **'Compassionate Father'** but also a **'Consuming fire.'** We must stress on BOTH these characteristics of God.

SUFFERING, SICKNESS AND DEATH, NOT ALWAYS BECAUSE OF SIN

Suffering, sickness, and death is not always because of sin (Read John 9:1 onwards to get this). But God can choose to allow these as acts of punishment after having given a person enough chances. Only the sovereign God knows how many chances to give a person. Not preachers. Not you. Not me. But if a person is still stubborn

in sin, God can act in judgement even now, post the Cross of Jesus. This we find in the Bible as I have shown above. So, the message for the believer is this: REMAIN in Christ/REMAIN in Christ's love (John 15 mentions this six times – in verses 4,5,6,7,9 and 10). "There is no condemnation to those who ARE in Christ Jesus [notice, it does not say here, "those who ONCE WERE in Christ Jesus!" (Rom. 8:1) - David Pawson's point].

CAN'T SIMPLY WATCH AS HYPER-GRACE TEACHERS DRAG PEOPLE TO HELL

Hyper-Grace cult false teachers are not only going to hell if they do not repent but also are taking people along with them there. That's why we can't simply keep watching this. God's Word to us, is this: "Pursue those who are singed by the flames of God's wrath and bring them safely to Him" (Jude 23, VOICE). This hell-populating, false teaching exposing book is a humble attempt to "rescue those who are living in danger of hell's fire" (Jude 23, ERV).

CHAPTER 7

HYDERABADI DISHA RAPISTS' PUNISHMENT AND IT CONNECTION TO A HYPER-GRACE CULT'S CLAIM



The Wire reported this about one of the most-shocking rapes in recent times:

"Disha (name changed to protect identity), a 26-year-old-vet, left her home for a clinic in Gachibowli, Hyderabad, on the evening of November 27, 2019. After parking her two-wheeler near a toll plaza, she had taken a cab to the clinic. At 9.22 pm, she called her younger sister to say that the rear tyre of her motorcycle was punctured and that she was offered – and had accepted (reluctantly) – help by some truck workers (they had punctured her bike deliberately earlier with a sinister plan to rape her when she would be stranded in that part of Hyderabad where there wasn't much human traffic)."

"However, she sounded worried and had expressed fear at being alone amid men who looked suspicious. Her sister advised her to walk to the toll plaza and wait there, but she hesitated to go there. After about six minutes, the call was cut. Disha's phone was then switched off."

"The four men (three of whom were minors, two of them, merely 15-years of age) had raped and smothered the woman to death and then loaded her body into a truck and burned it under a bridge later that night."

"The young woman's burnt body was subsequently recovered on November 28, in the morning, from an underpass on National Highway 44 near Chatanpally village under the jurisdiction of the Shadnagar police station."

"As the incident sparked nationwide outrage, the Telangana police came under pressure to deliver punishment without delay on the basis of a fast-track court trial."

"According to the police, on December 6, 2019, the accused had allegedly snatched guns and attacked the officers. In the ensuing gunfight, all the four accused were shot dead, said the Cyberabad Police. Although the 'Disha encounter' was viewed by many, as an instance of extrajudicial execution, thousands across the country celebrated the 'swift justice' in the form of the death of the accused (Some information added from Sohini Goswami's report filed for *Hindustan Times*, May 20, 2022; my inputs added as well).

For the umpteenth time in this book, I want to stress the truth that judgement of God does not stop post the Cross of Jesus. This time I will share it by starting off with a story that will surely disturb us all!

ENJOYING OTT (O FOR OBSENITY, T FOR TITILLATION, T FOR TOPLESS BITS)?

The punishment for the stubborn-till-death unrepentant, Christ-rejecting rapists is hell (a far greater and much more severe punishment than a police encounter, executed just days after the rape-murder crime as it happened with the Disha case, reportedly). What should keep us on our toes is that Jesus said the same punishment will be given to believers who are stubborn in the sin of 'raping-in-the-mind' [the sin of lust] (Matt. 5:28-29) [Example: driven-by-lust do we choose certain OTT shows – via Amazon Prime/Netflix/Hotstar, etc. – shows with clear preference for OTT (O for obscenity, T for Titillation, T for Topless bits)?].

Did you know that that we believers under the New Covenant will be more severely punished than those under the Old Covenant (those under the law of Moses)? That's what the writer to the Hebrews says in Hebrews 12:25 - 'Be careful that you do not refuse to listen to the One who is speaking. For if the people of Israel did not escape when they refused to listen to Moses, the earthly messenger, we will certainly not escape if we reject the One who speaks to us from heaven!' (NLT). This is some food for thought! This provides a scope for self-reflection and a motivation for repentance! This is also an antidote against the Hyper-Grace false teaching

which says that under the New Covenant, punishment is altogether stopped because of the Cross! No way! Punishment is stopped only for those who continuously abide/remain/stay in Christ (see Rom. 8:1; Read John 15 in full). Punishment is being 'stored' waiting to be executed at a God-appointed time, thanks to God's wrath (Rom. 2:4-5). Stored punishment? Yes, punishment is being stored for execution on the Day of Judgement surely (Rev. 20:15), or possibly even BEFORE the Day of Judgement, if God chooses that option. Baffled? Don't be! God according to His Sovereign Will, executed punishment before the day of judgment in the case of (1) Acts 5 – Ananias and Sapphira (2) Acts 12 – Herod (3) 1 Corinthians 11 – Casual Communion-Takers (4) Revelation 2 – Jezebel and her adultery-companions.

CHAPTER 8

SHOULD WE REPENT FROM PREACHING ON REPENTANCE AS HYPER-GRACE PREACHERS WANT US TO?



Writing in what was labelled one of "the top 100 Christian blogs" in the planet, a New Zealand based Hyper-Grace writer and author of five pro-Hyper-Grace books, was not afraid to write an article titled this way: "Three Reasons Why I Don't Preach On Repentance ('Turn from Sin')"

He was totally anti-biblical when he wrote that!

HYPER-GRACE POISON IN A NATIONAL-LEVEL PENTECOSTAL DENOMINATION'S YOUTH CONFERENCE!

I was invited to preach in a National-level youth conference of a large Pentecostal denomination in an Indian city, in the year 2012. 1700 young people from all over India were present. I preached a message from Proverbs 7. From that story of the naughty boy who had a secret affair with a flirty married 'aunty', I talked about sins which young people of today had to repent from. When I gave the altar call at the end of that message, the young people responded. They came forward and confessed their sins and got right with God. That same evening, the conference featured another preacher – an American preacher of Indian origin. As he began to speak, his hyper-grace theology became obvious. He said that there was no need to repent because according to 2 Corinthians 5:21, all believers are always the righteousness of God. In other words, this preacher wanted me 'to repent of the sin of preaching a message on repentance to believers from Proverbs 7'! Ha, Ha! And this hyper-grace rubbish-churning preacher also said that the Holy Spirit does not convict believers of sin! My wife who was part of the audience was enraged. "The one who invited this preacher to preach in this conference will answer God on the day of judgment. This visiting preacher has poisoned 1700 youth with hell-populating poison!" – we muttered to each other. We did more than that (I will not elaborate that here). In a way, this incident incited me to write a book such as this!

Yes, 2 Corinthians 5:21 says that believers are the righteousness of God. But the same book calls believers for repentance repeatedly. Consider 2 Corinthians 7:10 which calls for godly sorrow that leads to repentance! And in 2 Corinthians 12:21, Paul wrote, "I am afraid that when I come again my God will humble me before you, and I will be grieved over many who have sinned earlier and have not **repented** of the impurity, sexual sin and debauchery in which they have indulged." 2 Corinthians 5:21 should be read along with the next verse which happens to be 2 Corinthians 6:1. It goes this way: "As God's co-workers we urge you not to receive God's grace in vain." So, the full-message of 2 Corinthians 5:21-2 Corinthians 6:1 is this: You believers who are the righteousness of God must be enabled by the Grace of God to overcome sin! Otherwise, you have received God's grace in vain!

THE HOLY SPIRIT DOES CONVICT BELIEVERS OF SIN!

Does not the Holy Spirit convict believers of sin? He sure does. Yes, John 16:8 reads this way: 'And when he (the Holy Spirit) comes, he will convict the world concerning sin and righteousness and judgment' (ESV). Just because the Scripture says here that the Holy Spirit convicts the world of sin, it does not mean that the Holy Spirit does not convict believers of their sin. James 4:4 says, 'You adulterous people, don't you know that friendship with the world means enmity against God? Therefore, anyone who chooses to be a friend of the world becomes an enemy of God.' The book of James, like all other epistles, was written for believers. So, as we

can see here, believers can become worldly. So, the Holy Spirit does convict believers who become worldly. To say that the Holy Spirit does not convict believers of sin is anti-biblical!

We live in an age where moral values have blurred even for believers. So, we must sound out Scriptural standards without displaying a holier-than-thou attitude.

FIVE OUT OF SEVEN TOLD TO REPENT!

Five out of the seven churches mentioned in the book of Revelation were asked to repent by Jesus (Rev. 2:5; 2:16; 2:21-22; 3:3; 3:19). Yes, we must preach about the Grace of God. But there is no point in talking about Jesus as the Gracious Saviour from sin, without also talking about the sins, we must repent of. Jesus preached about both: grace of God which he came to demonstrate and sins from which we must repent of. For example, Jesus graciously healed the man who was invalid for 38-long years (John 5:5-9). But later, Jesus found him in a temple and said to him: "Take a look at your body; it has been made whole and strong. So, avoid a life of sin, or else a calamity greater than any disability may befall you" (John 5:14, VOICE). In the same chapter – John 5 – Jesus demonstrated grace and issued a clarion call for repentance! We too, must!

Even the **early church leaders** did both: talked about the Grace of God and told people to repent.

Take for example, **Philip,** he preached the "Good News" of grace to Simon the Sorcerer (Acts 8:12). When the sin of – thinking that the gifts of God could be bought with money was found in him, he was challenged to repent (Acts 8:21-23).

THE REDEMPTIVE STORY OF THE MAN WHO HAD SEX WITH HIS MOTHER

In 1 Corinthians 5, Paul was upset with the believers of the Church in Corinth who, rather than "mourning", were "arrogant" and "boastful" when a man among them was sleeping with his own mother (stepmother, perhaps) (1 Cor. 5:1-2,6). In their boastful arrogance, these believers may have said this: "It does not matter what I do with my body (influenced by the local culture). So, what is wrong if our brother has sex with his own mother! What is more important is this: the soul must be kept pure!" Paul does not buy into this false teaching! Rather, Paul, in-effect, calls this man as an "evil person" (1 Cor. 5:13). If Paul believed in Hyper-Grace, he would have called him, not as an "evil person" but as a "righteous person"! But Paul did NOT believe in the hyper-grace poison!

HYPER-DISCIPLINE!

Paul was calling for the excommunication of this man hoping that the shame caused by such an action

will move him to repentance, and thereby he will be "saved on the day of the Lord" (1 Cor. 5:5). Through this excommunication, Paul believed this would happen: 'godly grief produces a repentance that leads to salvation' (2 Cor. 7:10 ESV). Apparently, this man did repent, but there were folks in this church who were 'Hyper-Discipline'! They did not accept him back. So Paul had to intervene again. Paul wrote about these instructions for the believers of Corinth with regard to this man (as Bible Scholars view it): Now if anyone has caused pain, he (the 1 Corinthians 5 sexually sinning, sleeping-with-own-mom believer) has caused it not to me, but in some measure—not to put it too severely—to all of you. For such a one, this punishment by the majority (excommunication from the church following my instructions written in 1 Corinthians 5) is enough, so you should rather turn to forgive and comfort him, or he may be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow. So, I beg you to reaffirm your love for him' (2 Cor. 2:5-8, ESV). 2 Corinthians 2:5-8 reveals that the 1 Corinthians 5 sexually sinning believer, who was called to repent by Paul, had repented and was therefore saved!

Should we repent from preaching on repentance, as Hyper-Grace preachers want us to? Of course not!

HYPER-GRACE FOLKS PREACH 'REPENTANCE' CONTRADICTING THEIR OWN PHILOSOPHY!

Hyper-Grace false doctrine cannot be sustained by its own philosophy which says 'no preaching about repentance when someone commits a sin' because when God sees us, he sees Jesus who is 100% righteous

always. Let me explain this further: I am a believer. I keep committing the "sin" of attacking Hyper-Grace false teaching on social media (you may search Facebook for 'Duke Jeyaraj Hyper-Grace' and these posts will come up). The Hyper-Grace proponent who sees this should ideally say, 'Duke Jeyaraj, though he commits the "sin" of attacking Hyper-Grace false teaching is the righteousness of God according to 2 Corinthians 5:21!' Instead, as one can see, there have been comments asking me to change my stance on the same on social media. The Hyper-Grace proponents who believe that we should not preach about repentance to believers are surprisingly preaching repentance to me – repentance from the 'sin' of attacking Hyper-Grace – contradicting a main core teaching of their own philosophy! They should not try to change me by commenting and counter commenting on my social media because, according to them, I remain the 'righteousness of God' no matter what I do as a believer in Jesus. The moment Hyper-Grace proponents start preaching Hyper-Grace contradicting the Biblical Grace I preach, they shoot their own philosophy of 'no need for repentance as one is always the righteousness of God, no matter what'! So, you see the Hyper-Grace false teaching is philosophically self-defeating in nature!

A PREACHER WHOM I ADMIRE, PREACHED ABOUT REPENTANCE!

These are the days when we don't hear the word "repent" from our pulpits that much. These are the days when we don't hear the word "hell" from our pulpits very often.

There was a preacher called Billy Graham. He never tried to play to the gallery, the watered-down biblical gospel, even though he spoke to packed stadiums world over. Billy Graham, long after he went to be with Jesus when he was in his late nineties, continues to be a great influence in my life. I had a picture of him stuck in my college hostel room studying B. Tech. Agricultural Engineering in North India during the mid-nineties.

Here are some Billy Graham quotes – solidly biblical - that bust some popular, poisonous teachings of our day – especially the cultic, taking-people-to-hell Hyper-Grace movement:

"Repent when you fail and immediately seek God's forgiveness and restoration. Sin breaks our fellowship with God."

"No one spoke about hell than Jesus did and the hell he came to save men from was not only a hell on earth…it was something to come."

"The subject of heaven is much easier to accept than the subject of hell. And yet the Bible teaches both."

"Our supreme god is technology. Our goddess is sex. Most of us are more interested in getting to the moon than getting to heaven, more interested in conquering space than conquering ourselves. We are more dedicated to material security than to inner purity."

"Galatians 5:19-21 constitutes the most serious warning to those who think they can sin so that grace may abound." [For the convenience of us all I'm reposting Galatians 5:19-21 here: 'Now the works of the flesh are

manifest, which are these, fornication, uncleanness, lasciviousness, idolatry, sorcery, enmities, strife, jealousies, wraths, factions, divisions, heresies, envyings, drunkenness, revellings, and such like: of the which I forewarn you, even as I did forewarn you, that they which practise such things shall not inherit the kingdom of God.']

"Learn to take sin seriously. Be on your guard against it. Resist its tug. Fight its power."

CHAPTER 9

THE FAMOUS BISHOP AND THE CANDLESTICKS STORY AND THE FLAWED HYPER-GRACE FALSE TEACHING



This is the summary of the popular *Bishop and the Candle Sticks* Story:

"The Bishop is a very noble person, who is always ready to help anyone in distress. The doors of his house are always open. But his sister Persome is materialistic. She feels that the simplicity and nobility of the Bishop is misused by the people. He is often cheated and taken undue advantage of. Mere Gringoire, the old women who lives on the top of the hill and does no work, made such a fool of the Bishop by making him sell his silver salt cellars to pay
her rent."

"One day, past midnight a convict enters the Bishop's house and asks for food at the point of a knife. The convict is rude, hard-hearted, rough and suspicious and full of fear. The Bishop treats him with kindness and provides him food and shelter."

"The convict is tempted to steal the Bishop's silver candlesticks. But he gets caught and is arrested and brought before the Bishop. This candlestick was very dear to the Bishop as it was the parting gift presented to him by his mother. But the Bishop called the convict his friend and told the officers that he had actually given the candlesticks to the convict, voluntarily. Later he gives the candlesticks to the convict, blesses him and tells him a secret way to Paris. The convict is deeply touched and filled with remorse."

"The Bishop succeeds in reforming the hardened convict"
(from Answers.com).

This story illustrates the True Gospel of Biblical Grace and stands against the Flawed Gospel of Hyper-Grace. Because Jesus took our punishment on the Cross, we, out of true gratefulness to Jesus, turn away from sin on a day-to-day basis. The grace demonstrated by the Bishop empowered the hardened convict from returning to his old sinful ways. And the 'grace of God' (symbolized by the Cross) can teach us (transform us) to say 'no' to ungodliness and worldly passions – this is Paul's point (Titus 2:12). But if we live in habitual sin, it shows that we are not truly grateful for the Cross. And what is more, we are headed to be among those who do not 'ENDURE'

till the end (Matt. 24:13). Such folks will not be saved – Jesus himself said (Matt. 24:13). Don't believe Hyper-Grace teachers who tell you otherwise. You will be in for a rude shock on the Final Judgment Day!

CHAPTER 10

WHEN PAKISTAN BEAT INDIA IN AN ICC WORLD CUP GAME FINALLY AND WHAT IT'S GOT TO DO WITH THE HYPERGRACE FALSE TEACHING!



For the very first time in 13 attempts, Pakistan finally beat India in an ICC World Cup game (when one considers both the ODI and T20 World Cup matches). Pakistan gave India a humbling drubbing in the T20 World Cup group game on 24th October 2021 at Dubai. MS Dhoni had predicted that such a day would surely come after India beat Pakistan in the 2016 T20 World Cup group game. That is how he believed life is designed to be: you will win some and you will lose some! The Bible does not indicate the believer will win over sin every single time. Check out these references: When they sin against you – for there is no one who does not sin (2 Chron. 6:36). Who can say, "I have kept my heart pure; I am cleansed from my sin"? (Prov. 20:9). 'Surely there is no righteous man on earth who does good and never sins' (Eccl. 7:20). 'If we claim to be

without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us' (1 John 1:8); 'We all stumble in many ways...' (Jam. 3:2a). **This does not mean we can use the above Scriptural declaration to deliberately plan to commit sin.** The Bible clearly says no teaching of the Bible can be twisted subtly to bring the cultic, wrong teaching that we can choose to deliberately plan sin or choose to remain in sin or make sin a habit (Rom. 6:1,15; Titus 2:11-12; 1 John 3:6; 1 John 5:18). We cannot use the grace of God as a license for immoral living (Jude 4).

CHAPTER 11

THE OFT-REPEATED MOVIE DIALOGUE, 'ALL IS WELL' AND HYPER-GRACE THEOLOGY!



Why Hyper-Grace false teachers' sin-excusing interpretation of 1 John 4:17 is wrong

The dialogue, "All is well" is repeated in the 2009 Hindi movie, *Three Idiots* (the same movie was remade in Tamil as *Nanban* in 2012). The dialogue, "In this big big world, there are small, small mistakes happening, which we should learn to ignore and move-on with life" (*Bade, bade deshon mein, aisi choti, choti baatein hoti rehti hai*) keeps coming in the 1995 Hindi Movie, *Dilwale Dulhaniya Le Jayenge* (DDLJ).

Like an iconic movie dialogue that keeps getting repeated in famous movies, Hyper-Grace proponents keep repeating certain things like a parrot. One phrase I have heard them repeat the most is this phrase from 1 John 4:17 which goes this way, "As He (Christ) is, so are we in this world". They use this phrase to teach the cultic Hyper-Grace teaching.

WHAT A SINGAPORE HYPER-GRACE FALSE PASTOR SAID

I have often seen Hyper-Grace teachers use the final portion of 1 John 4:17 – "As He (Christ) is, so are we in this world!" – to teach that no matter how much we sin as believers, God the Father sees us like he sees Christ! Therefore, according to them, just as God the Father would never condemn or consign Christ to hell, we, as believers, can never be condemned or be sent to hell. In one of his devotional books, a popular Hyper-Grace false teacher and cultic pastor from Singapore, says (quoting this very verse), "It is wonderful to know that God does not measure and judge you based on your performance today. Instead, he looks at Jesus, and as Jesus is, that is how He sees you... As new covenant believers we do not have to fear the day of judgement... *because as he is, so are we in this world!" How do we respond to this?*

THE CONTEXT OF 1 JOHN EXPLAINED

Before we interpret any Bible passage, we must first figure out the context of that passage. Let us understand the context of 1 John via the writings of Andreas J. Köstenberger. He writes, 'John probably penned his epistles a few years after his gospel, to congregations familiar with the gospel. He seems to imply this by repeated references such as "which you have had since the beginning" (i.e., the gospel; 1 John 2:7) in John's first two epistles (e.g., 1 John 1:1; 2:24; 3:11; 2 John 5-6). Possibly, proto-gnostic (a group who believed that it did not matter if you sinned with your body *as long as you keep your soul pure*) or other false teachers had infiltrated the congregations under John's jurisdiction and shaken believers' confidence by denying the reality of sin (l John 1:8,10) and maintaining the necessity of special "inside information" (this is the implication of 1 John 2:20,27). In his first epistle, written shortly after those teachers had left the congregation (1 John 2:19), John seeks to reassure the still shaken-up believers (see esp. 1 John 5:13; see also 2:20, 27; 3:24; 4:13).' [*Encountering John: The Gospel in Historical, Literary and Theological Perspective, 2013 Edition*].

The Hyper-Grace teachers' interpretation of 1 John 4:17 is wrong, because of the following five reasons:

1. THE "PAROUSIA" REASON

A CALL FOR HOLINESS FOUND IN 1 JOHN WHICH CAN'T BE IGNORED!

First, we must remind ourselves of the larger message of the Bible book, this verse is taken from. It is taken from 1 John. **John, obviously, will not contradict what he himself wrote under the inspiration of the Spirit, elsewhere in the same book.** What did he write in 1 John 3:2? This: "Dear friends, now we are children of God, and what we will be, has not yet been made known. But we know that when Christ appears, we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is". What John is teaching here is very clear: we are not yet fully like Christ here and now! But when Jesus appears the second time (an event called "parousia"), we will be fully like him!! So, till that time comes, we need to grow in holiness, enabled by His grace, daily! In fact, the very next verse, 1 John 3:3 (NIV), which goes this way, "All who have this hope (of Christ's Second Coming) in him (Christ) purify themselves, just as he (Christ) is pure," is a clarion call for daily holy living! **So, in a sense we are "already" like Jesus, but "not yet" in the ultimate sense. We believers will be fully like Jesus when the second coming happens.** So, in 1 John 4:17, John was not opening a window for believers to live in sin, because "as Christ is, so we are in this world"!!! Hyper-Grace cult false teachers, in their desperation to seek biblical proof for their false claims, will twist any Scripture according to their convenience!

2. THE "PLURAL PERSONAL PRONOUN" REASON

THE 'WE' PASSAGES IN 1 JOHN THAT CALL US FOR A LIFE OF OBEDIENCE

Second, when we zero-in on the word "we" (a plural personal pronoun) found in 1 John 4:17 ["As He (Christ), is, so are we in this world"] and the rest of the epistle, we can understand that the Hyper-Grace teacher's sin-excusing interpretation of 1 John 4:17 is wrong. The interpretation for this passage should not be in opposition to other "we" passages in this book. In 1 John 1:6, Apostle John writes, "If we say WE have fellowship with him while we walk in darkness, we lie and do not practice the truth" (ESV). Here Apostle John was making this clear: close fellowship with Jesus will result in the conscious forsaking of sin ('darkness'). In 1 John 2:3, Apostle John issues another "we" statement which goes this way: "And by this we know that we have come to know him, if we keep his commandments" (ESV). According to the Apostle, as we understand it from this portion of his letter, knowing Jesus and knocking off the commands given by Jesus [including his commands against lusting (Matt. 5:28), loose language (Matt. 5:22), etc] cannot go on side-by-side. 1 John 3:24 which goes, "Whoever keeps his commandments abides in God" is another "we" statement recorded by John. John's repeats these things lest we miss his point. In fact, he already mentioned this in the Gospel he wrote (Check out John 14:21 – "Whoever has my commandments and keeps them, it is he who loves me" and John 14:15 is not much different).

WOULD YOU BE ASHAMED ON THE DAY OF JESUS' RETURN?

In 1 John 2:28, Apostle John pens, "And now, little children, abide in him, so that when he appears we may have confidence and not shrink from him in shame at his coming" (ESV). The message that the Apostle John intends

to drive home here is plain as day. It is this message: "If we don't abide in Jesus, here and now, he reserves the right to abandon us when he returns! If we shamelessly keep sinning, we will be ashamed on that final day!"

THE 'DON'T BE LIKE CAIN' COMMAND THAT IS TIED TO HYPER-GRACE FAVOURITE I JOHN 4:17

Let us zero-in on every "we" reference in 1 John because 1 John 4:17, the oft-quoted Bible reference by Hyper-Grace cultists, also has a "we" in it ["As He (Christ) is, so are we in this world!"]. We want to know from the author's other "we" references in this letter, if the 'we's are allowed to live in sin! The reason we are doing this is because, Hyper-Grace cultists want to imply from 1 John 4:19 that 'staying away from sin' (what they unfortunately call by a negative word called 'performance') is not something we should be bothered about. The next stop in this "We" journey is 1 John 3:12 which goes this way: "We should not be like Cain, who was of the evil one and murdered his brother" (ESV). Hyper-Grace deceivers would like you to believe that "righteous living" has nothing to do with turning from sin! If that were so, why would Apostle John write, "We should not be like Cain, who committed the sin of murder!" **If "righteousness" has nothing to do with sin as Hyper-Grace hell-headers make it to be, then such examples need not be quoted by Bible writers**. But such examples are quoted! So, Hyper-Grace teaching is thoroughly and totally unbiblical!

IS HYPER-GRACE PROMOTERS' FAVOURITE 1 JOHN 4:17 SAYING 'OUR SINS DON'T MATTER TO GOD' IN-EFFECT?

The final "we" passage we will refer to understand the behavior that God desires from the "we" referred to in 1 John 4:17 – the Bible verse the Hyper-Grace cultist builds hype around – is 1 John 5:18. The question we are asking is direct: Is 1 John 4:17 promoting the "your sin does not matter to God" teaching? The answer is straight: "If it can be shown beyond any doubt that elsewhere in the same letter, John the apostle promotes this bizarre teaching, then we can conclude that "your sin does not matter to God because when God sees you, the believer, he sees Christ". But as we have seen so far, the evidence in the rest of 1 John does NOT support this dangerously wrong, taking-people-to-hell, teaching. The climax is the flat rejection of Hyper-Grace camp's false derivations found in 1 John 5:18: "We know that everyone who has been born of God DOES NOT KEEP ON SINNING…" (ESV) (or "make a practice of sinning" as we read in the New Living Translation).

3. THE 'PERFECT' REASON

KEEPING THE COMMANDS INSTEAD OF KICKING IT

"Love has been perfected among us in this: that we may have boldness in the Day of Judgment; because as He is, so are we in this world"- that's how 1 John 4:17 reads (NKJV). The basic implication of this verse is this: "those

who abide in Christ, have nothing to fear on the Day of Judgment!" The previous verse – 1 John 4:16 – speaks about "abiding" (ESV)! If "love perfected" would give us boldness on the Day of Judgment (as 1 John 4:17 teaches), we must ask the question how is "love perfected"? The answer comes from 1 John 2:5 which says, "but whoever keeps His word, in him truly the love of God is perfected. By this we may know that we are in Him." The perfected love of God will never be in the possession of the believer who keeps kicking, instead of keeping the commands of God — that is the message of 1 John 2:5. So the message of 1 John 4:17 is NOT this: "Don't worry about sin; for God sees only the perfect Jesus, not stubbornly and wilfully sinning, you!" (which is the Hyper-Grace message, in-effect)

4. THE PRESENT-CONTINUOUS TENSE REASON

THE GRAMMAR THAT CALLS US FOR GODLINESS!

There is another reason why we must question and dismiss the Hyper-Grace camp's sin-justifying interpretation of 1 John 4:17. It is this reason: throughout his writings, John uses present continuous tense, deliberately, to make a theological case for continual abiding in Christ and a constant rejection of sin. **David Pawson writes**, "There is the same use of present continuous tense (in John's epistles/letters as there is in the Gospels). 'Who

is it that overcomes [goes on overcoming] the world? Only he who believes [goes on believing] that Jesus is the Son of God' (1 John 5:5)'" [*Once Saved, Always Saved?, page 49].*

Pawson continues: "Recalling the analogy of the vine and the branches, John reminds his correspondents that 'God has given us eternal life, and this life is in his Son. He who has [is having] the Son has [is having] life; he who does not have [is not having] the Son of God does not have [is not having] life' (1 John 5:11-12). We cannot have this eternal life in ourselves independently of the Son. We must 'remain' in Him to enjoy it." This is what John implies by his consistent employment of the present-continuous tense in his writings: "The initial act of turning from sin and putting one's faith in Christ is not enough. This must be done continually throughout one's life!" Pawson points out that John's use of the word, "if" in 1 John 2:24 is another clear indication that the "once saved, always saved" wrong teaching (which the Hyper-Grace cult teachers embrace) is simply not biblical. Read 1 John 2:24 for yourself: 'See that what you have heard from the beginning remains (abides, stays) in you. If it does, you also will remain (abide, stay) in the Son and in the Father'.

HOW THE GNOSTICS COMPARE WITH HYPER-GRACE CULT TEACHERS

Howard Marshall points out that in 1 John 4:2, John says, "Jesus has come in the flesh" instead of using the past-tense to say, "Jesus Christ came in the flesh". He explains why John's first epistle has so many occasions of

present continuous tense usage: "The use of present and perfect tenses become significant, if the point is that Jesus Christ has come and still existed" [*The Epistles of John, page 70]. This is what the false teachers of his time, the Gnostics, denied. They wrongly believed and taught that Jesus only became divine when he got baptized and stopped being divine just before he died on the Cross. In our context, the false teachers of our time, the Hyper-Grace cult teachers, deny the need for daily abiding in Christ, the need for continuous faith in Christ and the need for steady rejection of besetting sin, in the life of a God-pleasing believer.*

5. THE 'PACK' REASON

THE GOSPEL OF JOHN, 2 JOHN AND 3 JOHN DOES NOT SUPPORT HYPER-GRACE THEOLOGY!

1 John 4:17 - 'as He is, so are we in this world' - cannot be used to justify the wrong, taking-people-to-hell teaching of Hyper-Grace. This is the main point of this essay. The final reason why I believe so, is this reason I call as the "pack" reason. Let me explain – in the entire pack of John's writings, John consistently has called for continual abiding in Christ and a constant rejection of a life of sin. Along with First John, Apostle John wrote, the Gospel of John, Second John, Third John and Revelation. Let us see, in a nutshell, how he calls for the constant abiding of the believer, in Christ, as a condition for getting into heaven, in each of these books:

In John's gospel, Jesus makes it clear that the once saved Judas (his name was written in heaven – Luke 10:20) was now lost (John 17:12). It is in the same Gospel in which Jesus used the vine analogy to memorably call for the continual abiding of the believer in him. If the believer stubbornly refuses to abide, he would be cut off from the branch (symbolic of losing one's salvation) and be thrown into the fire (symbolic of hell punishment) (See John 15:6).

THE COROLLARY IS ALSO TRUE!

In Second John there is only one chapter. But even in that lone chapter, John lashes out against the wrong teaching of 'once saved, always saved'. He writes, "Watch yourselves, so that you may not lose what we have worked for, but may win a full reward. Everyone who goes on ahead and does not abide in the teaching of Christ, does not have God. Whoever abides in the teaching has both the Father and the Son" (2 John 8,9 ESV). Without "abiding" there is a real danger of "losing" – that is the message of this portion of Scripture. Lose what? Not just "rewards" in heaven but even a place in heaven! Why do I say that? Read verse 9 again – "Whoever abides in the teaching of Christ has both the Father and the Son". If this is true, the corollary is also true: "Whoever does NOT abide in the teaching of Christ will NOT have the Father and the Son..." In other words, those who stubbornly refuse to ABIDE are on the WIDE road to destruction, hell – a place of torment where the dweller will not have any fellowship with the Father and the Son!

THIRD JOHN DOES NOT SUPPORT HYPER-GRACE!

In Third John he writes, "Dear friend, do not imitate what is evil but what is good. Anyone who does what is good is from God. Anyone who does what is evil has not seen God" (verse 11, NIV). When we read a few verses above, we understand that John is talking about Diotrephes (see verse 9). In him there was an assembly of all unwanted characters in a Church leader (see verses 9 and 10). Diotrephes is the evil person whom the other believers must not imitate – this is John's point in verse 11. John is emphatic that evil-doing Diotrephes has not seen God (is not even a believer). So, the message of 3 John is simple: if you live in sin stubbornly, you are not even a believer! It is NOT a hyper-grace, sin-condoning message, by any stretch of imagination!

BOOK OF REVELATION ON WHAT HAPPENS WHEN WE STUBBORNLY LIVE IN SIN

In the book of Revelation, the Apostle John records, "everyone who LOVES and practices falsehood" will go to hell (Rev. 22:15). The believers who stubbornly remain in sin, without ever wanting to turn from sin, it is such believers will go to hell. John writes the following just after he wrote this: "Nothing impure will enter it (the New Jerusalem, which is symbolic of heaven), nor will anyone who does what is shameful and deceitful" (Rev. 21:27). Note here that he does NOT write, "nor will anyone who DID what was shameful...." So, the thrust of

this portion of Scripture is this: "those who CONTINUALLY DO WHAT IS SHAMEFUL AND DECEITFUL, without repenting, will ULTIMATELY land in hell".

The message of Revelation presented by John (the author who penned seemingly-Hyper-Grace-promoting 1 John 4:17) is straightforward. Revelation calls believers to "ENDURE" (Rev. 3:10 makes a command we cannot disobey) and "OVERCOME" (Rev. 2:11). Revelation 2:11 in the accurate-to-the-original-text New American Standard Bible (NASB) goes this way: 'He, who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches. He who overcomes will not be hurt by the second death'. This Bible passage makes clear that he who DOES NOT overcome WILL be hurt by second death (the corollary of Rev. 2:11). What is second death according to John? Revelation 20:14 and Revelation 21:8 equates second death to hell punishment. So, the message of Revelation 2:11 penned by Apostle John (he was basically recording words that Jesus himself gave him) is this: only overcomers make it to heaven.

So, when we read 1 John 4:17 – 'As He is, so are we in this world' - we must see it in the light of the entire pack of John's writings. What it means is this: As He is, so are we (we, who are abiding, we, who are overcoming, we, who are persisting, etc) in this world! Let not the Hyper-Grace cult false teachers con you and take you to hell with them, in this regard! Be careful! Be vigilant!

Let me conclude with what **Arthur Pink** scripted as a devotional definition of what it means to "abide" in Christ: "To abide in Christ is to have him for our supreme object, to center our affections upon him, to make him our center and circumference – to make him our all in all".

CHAPTER 12

HOW DO WE RESPOND TO GRACE, SHOWN TO US? CAN WE RESPOND LIKE ROHIT DID, IN THE 2019 ODI WORLD CUP?



Responding to the Hyper-Grace cult's tirade against the Non-Ceremonial Moral Laws of The Old Testament

'EVEN MY MOTHER-IN-LAW COULD HAVE CAUGHT THAT ONE!'

In the India-Bangladesh ICC ODI World Cup 2019 game held on 2nd July 2019 at Birmingham, Rohit Sharma, got a life. Rohit Sharma was batting on 9 runs when he offered a "dolly of a catch". The Bangladeshi fielder who got under it was Tamin Iqbal. But despite using both his hands, he dropped it. If I was giving the

commentary for that game, I would have used one of my favourite commentary lines at that point which is this: "Even my mother-in-law could have caught that one!" Jokes apart, Rohit continued to thrive after that reprieve. He scored his fourth hundred of the 2019 World Cup (counting up until that point in time). His partnership of 180 with KL Rahul had laid for India a solid foundation to score even a possible 400 when they batted first. It was not the first time that Rohit made India's opponents pay for "giving him grace" by dropping the catches he offered them. One Twitter user put out this tweet immediately: "Dropped on 1 vs SA: Scored 122. Dropped on 2 vs AUS: Scored 57. Dropped on 4 vs ENG: Scored 104." Yes, Rohit Sharma, when shown grace responds with gratitude – the gratitude of accumulating runs for his team.

In the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2024, Royal Challenger Bengaluru's (RCB's) Virat Kohli was dropped, first, while he was batting on 0, and again, while he was batting on 10, by Punjab Kings fielders, when these two teams clashed in Dharamshala (May 9, 2024). Kohli was grateful for the grace shown to him by Punjab! He showed it by making a match-winning 92 off 47 balls. Likewise, Rajat Patidar, Kohli's teammate, was dropped twice. He too was grateful for the grace shown to him by Punjab! He showed it by making 55 off 23 balls!

SAVED BY GRACE AND THEREFORE RESPONDING THROUGH GOOD WORKS!

As believers we are saved by grace of our Lord Jesus who died for us on the Cross. But do we respond with

gratitude, in response to the grace that has been shown to us, by exhibiting good works, taking a cue from the cricketers I have referred to, above? Apostle Paul wrote some classic stuff in the book of Ephesians talking about this very thing. He wrote that God was "rich in mercy" towards us (Eph. 2:4). So, that is why we too ought to be "full of mercy" in our dealings with others as the proverbs in the New Testament, the book of James tells us (Jas. 3:17). Over to Apostle Paul who makes this crystal clear: "For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them" (Eph. 2:8-10).

THE NON-CEREMONIAL MORAL LAWS OF THE OLD TESTAMENT – ARE WE TO OBEY THEM?

There is an unwarranted tirade going on against "good works"/ "works of the law" – thanks to the efforts of the cunning preachers of the cultic Hyper-Grace movement. They know the Bible is crystal clear when it calls believers who are saved by grace to do good works moved by gratitude (as it is evident from the passage above and several other passages such as Leviticus 11:45/Hosea 3/Zechariah 3:3-7/Titus 2:11-12/ Titus 3:4-8/2 Timothy 1:9/Romans 6:4/1 Thessalonians 2:13/4:3-5; In Chapter 5 of my book, *Straight Talk On Sex, Love, Marriage, Porn, Phone Addiction and More,* I explain this in greater detail). Despite knowing this, the Hyper-Grace cult teachers make a brazen attempt to confuse believers into believing that a believer should

not be concerned about "works" because we are "saved by grace". But a careful study of the New Testament reveals that the "good works" of holiness and ministry and the "works of the law" are vastly different. While both cannot save us, the Bible is clear that we must do "good works" (moved by gratitude for the grace that is bestowed on us) while only shunning the "works of the law". What is this "works of the law"? The writer to the Hebrews explains that those are animal sacrifices and ceremonial laws of the Old Testament, which we no longer need to follow as New Testament believers, as Christ has offered the perfect sacrifice (Heb. 8:13 and I would recommend a full reading of the book). Even in the book of Hebrews we are told of the need to do the "good works" (of holiness). We read in the same book, this: "Let marriage be held in honour among all, and let the marriage bed be undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers" (Heb. 13:4). This is just another way of repeating one of the 10 commandments which went this way: "Do not commit adultery." So, the moral, non-ceremonial laws of the Old Testament are still binding on us, believers. We do not follow them to earn our salvation, but because we are saved, out of gratitude, we obey them! If we do not stubbornly obey these non-ceremonial moral laws of the New Testament which call us for consistent personal holiness, then "we must doubt if those who do not do the good works of holiness are really saved in the first place" (1 John 2:3-5!).

A CRICKET GAME WHICH 45-CRORE PEOPLE WATCHED...

Some 45-crore people watched this Royal Challengers Bangalore Vs Chennai Super Kings (CSK) game on 18 May 2024, online. 30,000 screaming fans were inside Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bangalore watching the same game live. It was one of the most-watched IPL games ever. CSK had to get to at least 201 runs in their 20 overs to qualify for the knockout stage of the tournament. That's when big-made Shivam Dube, the CSK big-hitter, was graciously given a life by RCB in the third ball of the 13th over. Mohammed Siraj dropped an Everest-high rocket of a catch that Dube offered. 'Siraj calls for it, runs in and gets hands on it, but it slips out and rolls through the thigh and down to the boot, and to the ground. Kohli can't believe it....' (*Cricbuzz* commentary). But Dube did not make that grace-offer really count. He was soon dismissed having scored just 7 runs off 15 balls, just 7 balls later. When we refuse to walk in holiness believing Hyper-Grace lies after we have been saved by the grace of the Lord Jesus, we are just like Shivam Dube! Instead, let's be like the Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli and Rajat Patidar, the trio I talked about at the start of this chapter, responding with the good works of persistent holiness in great appreciation of the grace shown to us by Jesus!

CHAPTER 13

THE IMAGERY OF GOD AS A FATHER IN THE BIBLE, SUPPORTS HYPER-GRACE CULT?



Hyper-Grace cult teachers use the 'Father' imagery mentioned in the Bible to say this in-effect: "You can never stop being God's child even if you are stubborn in sin till you die or till the return of Jesus!" Can they?

EMBRACING BOTH THESE IMAGERIES ABOUT GOD IN THE BOOK OF HOSEA!

Yes, God is like the typically loving earthly fathers! Prophet Hosea recorded this in a heart-touching way: "When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son. The more they were called the more they went away; they kept sacrificing to the Baals and burnt offerings to idols" (Hos. 11:2). Fathers, typically, hold the hands of their kids teaching them to walk, and God did the same with his Spiritual child, Israel (Hos. 12:3).

Loving dads chase their naughty little kids who crawl away in different directions and bend down to feed them – don't they? God did the same with Israel (Hos. 11:4). God, as a Father, wanted to give another chance to sinning Israel (Hos. 11:8-9). He wanted to deal in love and not in wrath. But since Israel stubbornly held on to sin, the same loving God became an attacking/punishing/judging Lion/Leopard/Bear! The same author talks about it (Hosea 13:7-8). Let us embrace both the imageries of God - the one in Hosea 11 (loving father) and in Hosea 13 (attacking wild animal).

GOD THE FATHER IS NOT LIKE HUMAN EARTHLY FATHERS!

But God the Father is NOT like the earthly fathers! His accusation to us is this: "Somehow you got the idea that I was like you!" (Psa. 50:21, VOICE). God is the Holy Father (John 17:11) who disciplines us and enables us, so that we become holy - something without which we cannot see God (Heb. 12:5-6 & 14).

GOD AS A FATHER IS VERY DIFFERENT FROM THE KIND OF FATHER WE IMAGINE HIM TO BE!

The Old Testament repeatedly presents God as the Father. Some wrongly believe that God is presented as a consuming fire in the Old Testament, whereas in the New Testament, he is presented as a loving Father. This wrong belief comes because of the influence of the **Hyper-Grace false teaching which largely appeals to**

people who do not take time to read the Bible comprehensively and repeatedly with reflection. You will be surprised to know that even the Old Testament clearly teaches that God is a Loving Father. **However, He is NOT the Loving Father, the Hyper-Grace cult false teachers paint him to be via their popular-on-YouTube worship songs and their doing-violence-to-the-full-counsel-of-God sermons (Acts 20:27).** When we abide in Him and walk in holiness like Enoch did, God says that he who is our 'Good, Good Father' (remember the popular song?) is indeed 'pleased' with us (see Heb. 11:5)! When we flirt with sin, the Bible is clear that He is NOT PLEASED (see 1 Cor. 10:5) with us. He excepts us to immediately repent, lest we store up God's holy wrath against us (Rom. 2:4-5).

THE PLAN

THE BIG QUESTION: WHY DID GOD CREATE US?

It was God's eternal plan to be a Father to us. The writer of the Epistle to the Hebrews makes this known. He writes, 'For it was fitting that he, for whom and by whom all things exist, in bringing many sons to glory, should make the founder of their salvation perfect through suffering' (Heb. 2:10 ESV). God has an Eternal Son. He enjoyed the fellowship He had with Him. He wanted more sons and daughters – sons and daughters who would be fully human albeit. The addition of these children will bring great joy to God the Father. This joy will also be

upon us, the kids as well, as we fellowship with our Heavenly Dad! **To bring more earthly sons (children) to glory, the Eternal Son suffered on the Cross – that is the message of Hebrews 2:10.**

THE PAIN

GOING BACK TO THE FIRST FEW TIMES THE BIBLE PRESENTS GOD AS A FATHER

One of the earliest mentions in the Bible which introduces God as a Father to us is in Exodus 4. The Lord instructed Moses to say these words to Pharoah: "Let My son go so that he may worship me, but you refused to let him go. Now I will kill your firstborn son!" (Exo. 4:21,23 HCSB). When we were slaves of sin, God sought to make us, miserable sinners, his own sons (children)! So, he sent Jesus Christ to endure pain and thereafter die on the Cross of Calvary. When we repent of our sins and come to him in faith, we become sons and daughters of God (John 1:12).

THE PAIRING

DO YOU SEE GOD AS ONLY A LOVING FATHER AND NOTHING ELSE?

The next Old Testament reference to God as a Father is found in the Song of Moses. In that classic Holy Spirit inspired song, Moses presents Israel as God's son. He sang, "They have corrupted themselves; They are not

His children, because of their blemish. A perverse and crooked generation. Do you thus deal with the Lord; O foolish and unwise people? Is He not your Father, who bought you? Has He not made you and established you?" (Deut. 32:5-6 NKJV). One key thing I learnt from this passage is this: The Father God imagery is not the only imagery for God in the Bible. In the same song of Moses, God is compared to "the Rock" (see Deut. 32:4,15,30) and the Eagle (see Deut. 32:11). Those who teach that God is only a loving Father and nothing else, are clearly wrong. In Hebrews 12, God is presented both as a **COMPASSIONATE FATHER** (vs. 5-6) and a **CONSUMING FIRE** (vs. 12)! So, we must always pair the imagery of a loving father present in the Bible with other imageries for God in the Bible. The Bible says, "It is good to grasp the one and not let go of the other. Whoever fears God will avoid all extremes" (Eccl. 7:18, NIV).

THE DWELLING-IN-HEAVEN GOD AND DOTING-US-ON-EARTH DAD: THE SAME PERSON!

Prophet Isaiah, the prophet with the best vocabulary amongst all Bible writers, connects the transcendence of God with the picture of God as the Father in Isaiah 63:15-16. Though 'God looks down from Heaven' (a phrase that talks about his transcendence), as Isaiah puts it in Isaiah 63:15, he is also our 'Father' (as Isaiah expressed it in Isaiah 63:16)! The Christian Faith is unique because it is the only faith where the dwelling-in-Heaven God is the same person like our doting-us-on-Earth Dad! The Bible remarkably pairs these two unlike qualities in one and the same person – our eternal God!

HAVING A HOLY FEAR FOR OUR HOLY FATHER!

Prophet Jeremiah, the Bible Prophet who wrote the Bible Book with most number of words, also introduces God as the Father. He writes, "For I am a Father to Israel. And Ephraim is My first-born" (Jer. 31:9b, NASB). To have God as our Father is a privilege. But that privilege comes with a responsibility. What responsibility? To be fruitful! The word, "Ephraim" means to be "doubly fruitful" in Hebrew. "Since I am your Father, you must be doubly fruitful, Israel" – that was Prophet Jeremiah's inspired message. Since God is our Father, we must be holy! How did I make this connection? In John 17:11, in the high priestly prayer, Jesus called his Father, as the Holy Father! So as children of the Holy Father, we too must be holy in our day to day lives! Apostle James also attaches responsibilities to those who call God as Father. He wrote, "With it (the tongue) we bless our Lord and Father; and with it we curse men, who have been made in the likeness of God" (Jas. 3:9, NASB). Those who enjoy the love of the Father (privilege) should love people around them and speak kindly to them (responsibility).

James made another connection between privilege of knowing God as the loving Father and a connected responsibility of taking care of the poor and the needy. He does so, here: 'Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world' (Jas. 1:27). Apostle Peter also attaches responsibilities with those who call God as a Father. Apostle Peter teaches that if we call God as Father, we must be ready to be sanctified and obey the Lord Jesus

(1 Pet. 1:2). He further writes, 'And if you call on him as Father who judges impartially according to each one's deeds, conduct yourselves with fear throughout the time of your exile' (1 Pet.1:17). While we can celebrate the privilege of calling God as our Father, we must not forget the responsibility we have in showing him a holy reverence undergirded by a healthy fear!

THE PERIL

'WILL GOD, THE FATHER, STOP BEING OUR FATHER, WHEN WE ARE STUBBORNLY INTO SIN?' - THE BIG QUESTION

Prophet Hosea perhaps paints the most moving picture of God as a Father in the entire Bible. Here is his unmatched, emotion-stirring depiction: 'Eternal One: When Israel was a child, I loved him; and out of Egypt I called My son. But the more I called to Israel, the more they walked away from Me. They kept on sacrificing to other divine masters and burning incense to idols! But I was the one who taught Ephraim to walk, holding him up by his arms, but his people didn't know I was the One who took care of them. I led them along with leather cords; with ropes of love I showed them the way. As I dealt with them, I lifted the yoke from their neck; I bent down to give them their food' (Hos. 11:1-4, VOICE). Here we see how the people of Israel walked away from God their Father who reminds them of his great love for them, almost fighting back his tears. Does this love

continue forever without ever stopping? The Hyper-Grace cult false teachers who present God as the Father compare him with earthly fathers. **They ask, "Do you stop becoming your earthly father's son, if you rebel against him? You don't. In the same way the Heavenly Father will never stop loving you even if you walk away from him, stubbornly, for the rest of your life – you are in no danger of being punished by him. You will never go to hell! You still remain His Son!" Really?** The very next verse post the greatest Bible passage on God's fatherly love we see God sending a punishment on the people of Israel who spurned His tender fatherly love: "They will not return to the land of Egypt; But Assyria – he will be their king. Because they refused to return to me" (Hosea 11:5, NASB). Prophet Hosea foretold the end of the northern Kingdom of Israel, also known as Ephraim, here. As he foretold the Assyrians overtook them in 722 B.C. So, there is a real peril if we keep spurning the love of our Father God and keep indulging in our fleshly sinful desires. Romans 11:22 warns that if we spurn God's kindness (expressed by His Fatherly nature), we are in the real danger of being "cut off".

In fact, Prophet Hosea who painted God as a loving father in Hosea 11 portrays him as an upset and furious Bear-Lion-Wild Beast in Hosea 13. There he writes, "I will fall upon them like a bear robbed of her cubs; I will tear open their breast, and there I will devour them like a lion, as a wild beast would rip them open. He destroys you, O Israel, for you are against me, against your helper" (Hos. 13:8-9 ESV). So, what is the full message of Hosea? It is this: God loves you as a Father. But if you are stubborn in rebelling against Him and chasing after sin, he reserves the right to become as an angry Bear-Lion-Wild Beast who can ultimately send you to hell.

CONQUERING SEXUAL SIN AND KEEPING GOD AS OUR FATHER – WHAT IS THE CONNECTION?

Using memorable word-cum-number picture, the author of Revelation, Apostle John teaches that whenever one calls God as his Father (Rev. 14:1), that person needs to "follow the Lamb wherever he goes" (Rev. 14:4), that is, obey Jesus in all areas of his life! Read Revelation 21:7-8 very carefully and you will understand this: those for whom God is a Father will be the ones who "conquer" (Satan, Self and Sin); they will be the ones who have turned from hell-populating sins such as sexual immorality, murder, sorcery, idolatry, lying, etc.

THE PARENTING

Having understood comprehensively the Fatherly Nature of God from the Word of God, we fathers, must also parent like God does. Why do I say this? Apostle Paul called believers to become "imitators of God" (Eph. 5:1). That means just as God disciples his kids moved by great love so that his kids may "share in his holiness" (Heb. 12:7-10) we fathers must discipline our kids. We must not hesitate to give them whacks when necessary! Those whacks would be a God-intended way of wooing them to grow in holiness! We must disciplines our kids when they live in sins such as sexual immorality (porn-watching, affairs, gadget-addiction, etc) and not look the other way like King David did when his son Amnon raped his daughter, Tamar. Prophet Eli finally spoke some words of restraint when his sons went astray in a brazen manner (but it came far too late as God had already planned

to execute judgment on them – check out 1 Samuel 2:12-25). *The Nelson Study Bible notes*, "Eli had warned his sons of divine judgment (1 Sam. 2:25), but he never really rebuked them for their sins (1 Sam. 3:13). By neglecting his parental duty, he was in effect favouring his sons above God." Fathers let us not parent like King David and Priest Eli! Let us parent like our exemplary God the Father!

ARE YOU A YES-PARENT? THE PUNE PORSCHE CAR DRIVEN BY A MINOR!

The Times of India talked about a **prominent builder in Pune** who perhaps parented like King David and Priest Eli in this piece published on 9 June 2024: 'Three weeks ago, an allegedly drunk 17-year-old boy from Pune rammed the **Porsche** he was driving at 200 kmph into a bike, killing two 24-year-old techies on the spot. The boy, son of a prominent builder, had apparently gone out with friends to celebrate his Class 12 results. His grandfather, after consulting the father, had handed over a credit card and the luxury sedan's keys to the boy who reportedly spent Rs. 69,000 on liquor at two pubs before wanting to drive himself home. The driver claims he called the dad to ask whether he should give the car keys or not. The father said yes. The crash occurred minutes later. What if the dad had said a firm no and asked the driver not to hand the Porsche key to his son? What if he had said no for giving a credit card and instead given a small amount of cash for just a drink or two? Maybe the son would have listened or maybe not. Perhaps, the victims Aneesh Awadhiya and Ashwini Koshta would be still alive today!' This kind of parenting is called 'Yes-Parenting'. And there are grave perils in

parenting our kids like that, as we can see from the above true story. We must learn to parent like our Holy, Heavenly Father!

CHAPTER 14

"ONLY REWARD LOSS, BUT PLACE IN HEAVEN SAFE!" – DOES 1 CORINTHIANS 3:15 TEACH THAT?



"There is no judgment for believers!" Heretic, hell-populating Bible Teachers will say that. Because their final court of appeal is not the Bible. Their final court of appeal is this: "Whatever sounds like music to people's ears!" Sad! Terrible! Deplorable! And what's more the rise of such cultic false teachers is predicted in the Bible (see 2 Tim. 4: 3-4, which goes this way: ' For the time is coming when people will not endure sound teaching, but having itching ears they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own passions, and will turn away from listening to the truth and wander off into myths').

The Bible says, believers will be judged one day. Romans 14:10 is clear: "We all must appear before the judgment seat of Christ."

WHEN MBA MARKETING TEXTBOOKS TAKE THE PLACE OF THE BIBLE!

1 Corinthians 3:13-15 does not teach that believers living in sin will be excused on Judgment Day. If Paul meant that then why would he write in the SAME BOOK this: "Or do you know that the unrighteous will not inherit the kingdom of God? Do not be deceived: neither the sexually immoral, nor idolaters, nor adulterers, not men who practice homosexuality will inherit the Kingdom of God" (1 Cor. 6:9). What 1 Cor. 3:13-15 is teaching is this: we will be rewarded as per the quality of ministry we do. This should concern the Hyper-Grace cult folks a lot. They have lowered and flouted Bible standards in a fleshly way, just to attract crowds. They have made MBA Marketing Principles ('always look to please the customer as your customer is your god') as their Bible.

However, for me the Bible is the final court of appeal, not MBA Marketing Techniques. 1 Corinthians 3:13-15 does NOT teach that even believers stubborn-in-sin will be somehow saved on the Final Day, only losing a portion of their eternal reward. This is how 1 Corinthians 3:13-15 reads (for those of us who are not familiar with those verses Apostle Paul penned): 'their work will be shown for what it is, because the Day will bring it to light. It will be revealed with fire, and the fire will test the quality of each person's work. If what has been built survives, the builder will receive a reward. If it is burned up, the builder will suffer loss but yet will be saved — even though only as one escaping through the flames.'

WHAT IS BEING JUDGED HERE IS NOT A BELIEVER'S SINS BUT HIS SERVICE!

David Pawson's brilliance in explaining this verse — 1 Corinthians 3:15 and what is above it — is simply unbeatable:

"Once again, the whole verse needs to be quoted, including the first clause: 'If it is burned up....' If what is burned up? What a man has 'built' during his ministry to the body of Christ., whether 'pioneer' or 'maintenance' (here pictured as planting and watering). **In other words, what is being judged here is a believer's service, not his sins.** There are great variations in quality of service. The fire of divine judgment will leave some intact (like gold, silver, and costly stones) but bring others to nothing (like wood, hay and stubble). But someone who at least sought to serve the Lord will survive, even though he is left with nothing to show for his labour or deserving a reward.

"That this is irrelevant to a believer's sins, as distinct from his service, is immediately apparent from the very next verses: 'Don't you know that you are God's temple, and that God's Spirit lives in you? If anyone destroys God's temple, God will destroy him' (1 Cor. 3:16-17). In this context, the sin is to divide the Church into jealous and quarrelling groups who 'follow' different servants of Christ rather than Christ himself. Elsewhere he applies the same charge to sexual immorality (1 Cor. 6:18-19). We may get away with poor service (but only just), but WE WILL NOT GET AWAY WITH SIN!" (David Pawson, *Once Saved, Always Saved?*, pages 160-161).

HAVE YOU READ THE REST OF THE 1 CORINTHIANS?

If 1 Corinthians 3:15 taught that the worst thing that can happen to a believer on the day of judgement was only a reward-in-heaven loss, but never a place-in-heaven loss, why would Paul write in the SAME BOOK, this: "But I discipline my body and keep it under control, lest after preaching to others, I myself should be disqualified" (1 Cor. 9:27)? To get the right meaning of a controversial Bible passage, we must keep reading the rest of the book that particular passage is found in, to get further clues on how to rightly interpret that passage. So, what is the message of 1 Corinthians 9:27 which appears after 1 Corinthians 3:15? Paul had a healthy fear that he would be disqualified from getting to heaven, if kept yielding to his body's desires (in our context - he kept watching porn, he kept indulging in sexual immorality, etc). This view is further underlined by this fact: the next chapter –1 Corinthians 10 – warns New Testament believers that they could be 'destroyed' (go to hell), if they indulged in stubborn sin (vs. 9,10,11). **So, Paul did not subscribe to the meaning and implication the Hyper-Grace cult teachers ascribe to 1 Corinthians 3:13-15.** So, when Paul writes, "he will suffer loss, but he himself will be saved", he did mean this: God will not send anyone to hell, because of low ministry quality. But he clearly did NOT mean what the Hyper-Grace cultists teach: "God will not send any believer to hell, even if they live in stubborn sin!" If Paul believed this lie, he will not have penned these passages: (1) 1 Corinthians 6:9-11 (hell for believers stubborn in sin), (2) 1 Corinthians 9:27 (hell for preachers stubborn in sin) and (3) 1 Corinthians 10 (the God who destroyed his stubborn-in-sin people in the

Old Testament won't hesitate to do send the New Testament people of God doing the same thing to hell after graciously giving them enough chances).

CHAPTER 15

"JESUS LOVES SINNERS! BUT ONLY CONDEMNS THE SELF-RIGHTEOUS!" - IS THIS POPULAR DEFENSE OF HYPER-GRACE, BIBLICAL?



This is just a popular perception put out by cultic, hell-populating Hyper-Grace pastors/teachers. But if we carefully look at the Scriptures as a whole, we understand this: Jesus warned that stubborn sin will take ANYONE to hell - not just the Pharisees, Hypocrites and the Self-Righteous! Have you read this statement of Jesus, a statement that he made to someone he healed: "You look wonderful! You're well! Don't return to a sinning life or something worse might happen" (John 5:14, MSG). Because this man was a recipient of Jesus' grace — he was healed even though he did not deserve healing — Jesus expected and demanded that he be grateful for that grace received by living a holy life, a temptation-beating life, a victory-over-sin life! Grace received must lead to holy living! That was Jesus' point! That was the point of the Apostles, as well. If we

are truly grateful for God's grace, we will say 'no' to 'ungodliness' and 'worldly passions" (Tit. 2:11-12). In fact, the Grace of God enables us to say 'no' to sin, ANY SIN. Yes, self-righteousness, hypocrisy, a Pharisaic attitude, is a sin as is porn-watching, drunkenness, foul-language use, pride, lying, stealing and adultery. The writer to the Hebrews warned about this: we cannot 'obtain' the Grace of God and 'maintain' bitterness with people we have relationship-problems with (Heb. 12:15). This writer also says this: 'those strengthened by grace' (Heb. 13:9) should also keep their 'marriage bed pure' (Heb. 13:4), of course enabled by the same grace, lest they fall into God's judgment (Heb. 13:4). Jesus or the Bible does not differentiate between these two sins - self-righteous and other kinds of sins! **Let not Hyper-Grace cult pastors fool you in this regard by telling you this in-effect: "Don't worry about sin in your life, as long as you are not self-righteous!" You will go to hell along with them (should they not repent), if you believe this lie!** What is the 'something worse' that Jesus talked about in John 5:14 (in his conversation with the healed paralytic) which can happen to those who love to remain in stubborn sin? A life in hell - a place of eternal, ever-conscious torment (Rev. 20:10; 14:9; 21:8). I hope that none of us will go there!

This chapter is a response the author posted on his YouTube channel, "Duke Jeyaraj", in response to a public question/comment on one of his many anti-Hyper-Grace videos.

CHAPTER 16

"I AM THE RIGHTEOUSNESS OF GOD!" – HOW THE HYPER-GRACE CULT TWISTS THIS BIBLE PHRASE



You must tell the Devil, "I am the righteousness of God", when he brings temptation before you. That is the teaching of Apostle Paul in 2 Corinthians 5:21. This confession helps you to overcome temptation. "I am the righteousness of God. So, I will not lie! So, I will not watch porn! So, I will not use those Fs and Bs!" Yes, we can use these exact words during the times of temptation. Indeed, we can utter these very words when temptation comes to us!

What is the verse that is found right after 2 Corinthians 5:21? Well, it is actually found in the next chapter. Chapter and verse divisions were put in our Bibles for our convenience and were not inspired by God – we have already seen this. The verse next to 2 Corinthians 5:21 using which we can say, "I am the righteousness of God" is 2 Corinthians 6:1 (as 2 Corinthians chapter 5 has only 21 verses, and 2 Corinthians 6 verse 1 starts off

after 2 Corinthians 5 verse 21). This verse teaches that we should not be guilty of "receiving" "God's grace" in "vain" (2 Cor. 6:1; compare this verse with Titus 2:11-12, Romans 3:8 and Romans 6:1-2,15). What do we learn from 2 Corinthians 6:1? When temptation comes, use the Grace that God gives abundantly to you, to overcome temptation! If you don't use the Grace of God graciously given to you when temptation comes, you become guilty of "receiving" the "God's grace" in "vain" – which 2 Corinthians 6:1 warns against! Enabled by this Grace of God, we definitely will be able to say "I am the righteousness of God" when temptation strikes us! Victory over temptation will be a reality – be it the porn-surfing temptation or foul-words mouthing temptation! This is the context-honouring message of two verses placed right next to each other serving as one unit – 2 Corinthians 5:21 and 2 Corinthians 6:1!

So far, we have seen the correct teaching regarding 2 Corinthians 5:21. Next we will see how Hyper-Grace cultists tell us to use the same verse with scant respect to the context. They tell us to keep saying, "I am the righteousness of God" quoting 2 Corinthians 5:21 even after losing to temptation!

AFTER I PREACHED ON A NAUGHTY BOY FLIRTING WITH A FLIRTY AUNTY...

However, if you and I fall into temptation, we should not foolishly continue saying, "I am the righteousness of God" (as Hyper-Grace, heretic, hell-populating false teachers tell us to). After I preached a message

from Proverbs 7 – the lively story of a naughty boy flirting with a flirty aunty – outlining the sins youth of today had to repent from, **an American Indian Hyper Grace cult pastor** who preached after me, in a 2012 National Youth Conference with 1700 young people from India-over in attendance, quoted from 2 Corinthians 5:21 implying that there was no need for anyone to repent from any sin (at the end of my preaching session, young people came forward in response to my altar call to acknowledge that they were repenting from several sins, including the sin of sexual immorality). This typically happens when hyper-grace wolves-in-sheep-clothing minister along-side biblical-grace preachers! They are always looking to twist Scriptures to keep young people comfortable in sin!

The Bible, however, calls believers who are stubborn-in-sin with this name: "adulterers!" (Jas. 4:4). Want more biblical proof? Let me give it to you: the Bible called a church believer stubborn in the sin of having sex with his own mother as "wicked" – did you notice (see 1 Cor. 5:13)? He was not called 'the righteousness of God'! (Hyper-Grace cultists would wrongly say that he is 'the righteousness of God'). Notice, the Bible does not call believers stubborn-in-sin as "Children of God!" When we sin, we must repent from that sin and confess our sin immediately lest wrath of God keeps building up against us (1 John 1:7-9, compare this passage with Romans 2:4-5). Hyper-Grace false teachers tell us that there is no need to repent or confess our sins, even when we sin. False theology. Dangerous theology. Hell-leading theology. Why do I say that? I say that because Hell is the place for unforgiven people.

CHAPTER 17

WE SHOULD NOT BOTHER ABOUT OUR 'MORAL TRANSFORMATION' AS HYPER-GRACE CULT PASTORS TELL US? THE ANSWER STARTING WITH A ROHIT SHARMA STORY!



India beat Sri Lanka in the final group game of the 2019 One Day International (ODI) World Cup without breaking a sweat. They rode on a nearly 190-run opening stand between Rohit Sharma and KL Rahul, to top the table and set up a World Cup Semi-Final meeting with fourth-placed New Zealand on July 9, 2019. This gave me a good occasion to hit the rewind button on Rohit Sharma's career as I write these lines on July

7, 2019.

"How to cook maggi – boil with hot water, add masala and wait until Rohit Sharma gets out..." That was a troll Tweet about Rohit during the days when consistency was far from him in his pre-2013 career (he made his ODI debut for India in 2007). In a series in which he played 5 ODIs Vs Sri Lanka in Sri Lanka, the year being 2012, he scored a grand total of 13 runs in five innings (Read that again: 13 runs off five completed innings). His scores in the five games according to a NDTV, August 4, 2012 post: 5-0-0-4-4. Bowled, bowled, LBW, LBW and bowled. A sarcastic tweet was put after his last dismissal: "No difference between Rohit Sharma's legs and the stumps. Both don't move unless hit by a ball." It was the lowest total score by a specialist batsman in any international ODI series ever (at the point of writing)!

Rohit Sharma, the man who once scored the least number of runs among specialist batsmen ever in an ODI series, is the present highest run-scorer with another possible two games to go in the 2019 World Cup. What a transformation! What a stupendous U-Turn! His series of scores in the 9 group games in the 2019 ICC ODI World Cup: "Against South Africa, Rohit led a tricky chase for India with an unbeaten 122 before scoring 57 against Australia. He then smashed 140 against Pakistan before missing out against Afghanistan and West Indies. He then smashed 102 against England, 104 against Bangladesh before scoring 103 against Sri Lanka" (as the *India*

Today news magazine put it). As I write these lines, Rohit is likely to beat Sachin's World record of 673 runs in a single ICC ODI World Cup with two possible full innings to go!

In his interview to the media, post the Sri Lanka game, Rohit Sharma talked about the secret for this totally amazing transformation: his family (his wife and little daughter) who help him stay away from thinking about his cricket exploits, his forever focus on the present… etc.

Do you want your life to be transformed completely in every sense of the word? Are you tired of your old life? Then you need Jesus. The Bible says, "If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has gone, the new has come!" (2 Cor. 5:17). A living daily relationship with Jesus will transform your life! That's what the Bible teaches! Let the Holy Spirit fill you and your life will be changed. The Bible says in 1 Samuel 10:6 – "Then the **Spirit** of the Lord will come upon you mightily, and you shall prophesy with them and be changed into another man" (NASB). This Jesus transformed my life through his Spirit. Let me illustrate that with couple of incidents from my school life.

PRETTY GIRLS WALK IN AND I FORGET MY SCHOOL DRAMA LINE!

I could not even say two lines on the stage when I was in school. The presence of some pretty girls in a school drama I was in, made me super nervous. So nervous that I fluffed the lines I had to say in that school drama. I

went back home that day and told the Lord Jesus: "Never on stage for you, Lord!" But then the Lord Jesus filled me with his Holy Spirit. And I went back to the very same stage – a wooden stage in the Ida Scudder School – and preached a Gospel message for about 10 minutes (on August 9, 1991, as a 16-year-old 12th grader). I preached without notes on the subject of Hell. There were about 500 people who listened to it – both students and teachers. A senior-school girl fainted at the end of that message. My hot message on hell made her dizzy! I have not stopped preaching hence forth. It was a miraculous transformation – a transformation that happened because of Jesus who died for me on the Cross and His gracious Spirit who fills me with spiritual gifts.

Would you give your life to Jesus? He can completely transform your life? Would you stay filled with the Holy Spirit? Your life will never be the same!

'NO NEED FOR BEHAVIOR MODIFICATION' – HYPER-GRACE CULT PASTORS!

Let's move forward from the Rohit Sharma story and my story. Let's get back to the main topic of this book – false teaching. Hyper-Grace cult pastors say that believers should not be bothered about moral transformation. The **Singapore Megachurch Hyper-Grace** cult pastor put it this way in his November 16, 2010 post on Facebook: 'God is after heart transformation and not behaviour modification. Only the grace of God can do that in our lives.' I have heard the Chennai Hyper-Grace cult pastor repeat this verbatim.

Many modern young believers under the influence of such poison continue to live in continual, habitual sin. There are young people who have become believers under the influence of the Hyper-Grace False Gospel who continue to play music for secular songs with erotic lyrics. There are young people who have become believers under the influence of the Hyper-Grace False Gospel who continue to have sex outside of marriage regularly without thinking too much about it.

Though the New Testament is clear that we are NOT saved by behaviour modification, it does call for behaviour modification in those already saved.

Let's talk about Apostle Paul's writings and behaviour modification. He writes in 1 Corinthians 6:11 this: 'And that is what some of you were'. What were the Corinthian believers like before? 1 Corinthians 6:9-10 explains: 'Or do you not know that wrongdoers will not inherit the kingdom of God? Do not be deceived: Neither the sexually immoral nor idolaters nor adulterers nor men who have sex with men nor thieves nor the greedy nor drunkards nor slanderers nor swindlers will inherit the kingdom of God.' The believers of the church in Corinth were – once upon a time –sexually immoral, idol-worshipping, adulterous, homosexuals, thieves, greedy, drunkards, slanderers, swindlers, etc. But the Gospel touched them. Their lives were transformed. There was indeed a behaviour change in them. You could even call that behaviour modification. Now they lived a new life!

DEAR THIEF, QUIT STEALING!

Writing to the believers of the church at Ephesus, Paul underscored the need for moral behaviour modification in the simplest and most practical way: 'If you are a thief, quit stealing. Instead, use your hands for good hard work, and then give generously to others in need' (Eph. 4:28, NLT).

I wonder if Hyper-Grace Cult pastors even read their Bibles properly! If they did, they would not have the nerve to say, "there is no need for behaviour modification in the life of the believer!" I guess they would preach any half-truth that would sound like music to the ears of their sadly Bible-illiterate audience.

Paul talks about this moral transformation happening in the lives of these believers who got water baptised in the book of Romans. He wrote, 'We were buried therefore with him by baptism into death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, we too might walk in **newness of life**' (Rom. 6:4).

CHANGE IN SEXUAL MORAL BEHAVIOR PLEASE!

Author Luke records this behaviour modification expectation which the early church had in the lives of the believers. In Acts 15:20, Acts 15:29, and Acts 21:25 – in three different places – he records that a change in sexual moral behaviour is expected in the lives of the Gentile believer!

The author of the book of Hebrews also talks about the need for moral behaviour modification in the life of the born-again believer. He writes this in Hebrews 13:4: 'Let marriage be held in honour among all, and let the marriage bed be undefiled, for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterous.'

HEART TRANSFORMATION AND BEHAVIOR MODIFICATION CANNOT BE DIVORCED FROM EACH OTHER!

The **Singapore Mega-Church Hyper-Grace cult pastor** said, 'God is after heart transformation and not behaviour modification' (as mentioned above). Behaviour modification can be called 'obedience'. Think of all the Bible verses on the need to be obedient! And guess what, you cannot separate 'obedience' from heart transformation! Ask Apostle Paul! Paul uses the phrase 'obedience (behaviour-modification) from the heart' in Romans 6:17. The bottom line is this: heart transformation and behaviour modification cannot be divorced from each other! To excuse sin, Hyper-Grace cultists try to bring in an imaginary difference between heart transformation and behaviour modification which the Bible does not support!

We could go on and on regarding this, but we won't as the Bible is already clear: behaviour modification was mandatory in the life of the believer. A believer is not saved through this, but having been saved, the believer's life does go through a behavioural change. To say that the Christian Life is not about that – is yet another

brazen and shameless attempt by the Hyper-Grace gang to make believers stay comfortable in sinful living, something which is their main agenda.

HYPER-GRACE FALSE TEACHERS ARE INTO 'PILLOW DISTRIBUTION'!

I was called to take on Hyper-Grace False Teaching by a group of Sound Doctrine-embracing pastors/evangelists/Bible teachers in the year 2014 in a conference hosted by the New Life Assemblies of God Church in Chennai before a national audience of 800 people – all keen believers and church leaders. In that 20-minute talk which is now available on YouTube (search 'duke jeyaraj hypergrace biblical or heretical' and you should find it), I mentioned that the Hyper-Grace False Teachers are into pillow distribution! Pillow distribution? Really? Yes! They place the pillow of Hyper-Grace on the beds of modern believers so that these believers can sleep comfortably in their sin without being disturbed into repentance! Oh Lord, have mercy!

CHAPTER 18

"SALVATION BY GRACE; SANCTIFICATION BY WORKS – YOU GUYS TEACH THIS" – A RESPONSE TO THIS HYPER-GRACE CAMP'S ACCUSATION



THREE EXAMPLES OF PLACING THE OTHER PERSON BEFORE YOU IN PHILIPPIANS

In the book of Philippians, Paul talked about three examples of placing the other person before you (as someone put it beautifully): 1) Jesus and sinners: Jesus put sinners ahead of himself and died for them on the Cross (Phil. 2:6-10). 2) Timothy and the church at Philippi: Timothy put the welfare of the church at Philippian before his own welfare (Phil. 2:19-24). 3) Epaphroditus and Apostle Paul: Epaphroditus placed the life of Apostle Paul ahead of his own life
(Phil. 2:25-30).

WORK OUT YOUR SALVATION WITH FEAR AND TREMBLING – INTERPRETING THIS PHILIPPIANS' PHRASE CORRECTLY

We must keep this pattern in mind as we interpret Philippians 2:12 where we read this: "work out your salvation with fear and trembling" (ESV). The very next verse says this: "for it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure" (Phil. 2:13, ESV). This is the pattern of comparison in Philippians 2:12-13: the work of God in the life of the believer who works out his salvation with fear and trembling. As pointed out above, the second category in the comparison pair is more important than the first category (sinners were *more important* than himself for Jesus; the welfare of the church at Philippi was *more important* than his own welfare for Timothy; the life of Apostle Paul was *more important* than his own life for Epaphroditus). Keeping the same pattern in mind, we can confidently say this: the work of God in our salvation is more important than we ourselves working out our salvation for the simple reason that it is God who enables, empowers us to do that work. It is not a self-work, but a God-powered work! So, the glory goes to God, not to us! The credit goes to God, not to us! So, Philippians 2:12-13 does not teach salvation by works. We can confidently say that if we kept the context in mind. "Christians are recipients of God's initiatives of motivation and empowerment" (**Richard R. Melick Jr.'s** words).

WHEN I WROTE TO A GIRL PROPOSING IN MARRIAGE IN 1999

One principle we must follow to correctly interpret the epistles is this: we must read the letter in one sitting (don't we do the same when it comes to any normal letter as **Douglas Stuart** and **Gordon Fee** remind us?). When I wrote a letter proposing marriage to the Chennai-located Evan (my wife, now, and, fellow missionary kid, then) in the year 1999 as a 25-year-old Bible College student in Bangalore, she read that letter of several paragraphs in one sitting! She did NOT take a break of a few hours or days after reading a couple of paragraphs! So, if we read Paul's letter to the Philippi church in one sitting, we will not stop until we read the last verse of the letter which is this: "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with your spirit" (Phil. 4:23, ESV). So, what is the implication of this verse? All the things that Apostle Paul wanted the Philippian believers to do (including 'working out their salvation with fear and trembling') must be done enabled by the grace of the Lord! It must not be done through self-effort! This was the whole counsel of God from Apostle Paul as he wrote Philippians.

ENABLING GRACE OF GOD COUPLED WITH HUMAN CHOICE TO WORK HARD – IN TWO DIFFERENT BIBLE TEXTS!

So, a total trust in God's enabling grace would enable obedience to the command, 'work out your salvation with fear and trembling' (Phil. 2:12; Eph. 2:8-9). Elsewhere, in two places, Paul couples the gracious enablement that

God gives, with the human choice he made, to work hard (with the enablement of God, of course). **Colossians 1:29 is one such place**: "To this end I strenuously contend with all the energy Christ so powerfully works in me" (NIV). Though it is Paul who strenuously contends, we must not forget the complete enablement for this which came from the energy that Christ gave him! **1 Corinthians 15:10 is another such place** where Paul places God-given enablement along with the human choice he exercised to work hard: "But by the grace of God I am what I am, and His grace to me was not without effect. No, I worked harder than all of them – yet not I, but the grace of God that was with me" (NIV). So, even if, I, as a believer, work out my salvation with fear and trembling, it is not me who works, but the grace of God that is within me (1 Cor. 15:10 adapted into Phil. 2:12-13).

THE OUTCOME OF WORKING OUT OUR SALVATION WITH FEAR AND TREMBLING

What will be the fruit of working out our salvation with fear and trembling? Paul describes this in Phil. 2:14-18. There are things that we will not do: (1) we will not 'grumble' (Phil. 2:14), (2) we will not question authorities God has placed over us unfairly (Phil. 2:14), and, (3) we will not copy the crooked and depraved generation around us (the porn-watching, bi-sexuality embracing, bad-language-using generation). There are things we will do: (1) we will hold fast to the Word of Life (Phil. 2:16) – we will be diligent in Bible Study, (2) we will be ready to pour our very life for the sake of the Gospel (Phil. 2:17) – like how Jim Elliot, John Allen Chau were

ready to do and, (3) we will be glad and rejoice with our fellow believers (Phil. 2:18) – our happiness will not be dependent on happenings, but on Him (Paul was in a prison as he wrote this letter – Phil. 1:7).

THE REWARD FOR WORKING OUT OUR SALVATION WITH FEAR AND TREMBLING

And if we worked out our salvation with fear and trembling enabled by God's grace, what is the reward? "In the day of Christ" (the final day of judgment) we will make our spiritual mentors proud (Phil. 2:16). Notice this here: holiness is as important as forgiveness to inherit eternal life on the final day of Christ!

Yes, salvation is by grace (Eph. 2:8-9), but it will always result in good works (Eph. 2:10). Doing these good works will not save us. But if we are truly saved, we will produce Grace-enabled, Holy Spirit empowered good works as described in Phil. 2:14-18.

SOMEONE TO BELL THE CAT!

What is the connection between the humiliation and exaltation of Christ as described in Philippians 2:5-11 and the call to quit 'grumbling and questioning' in Philippians 2:14? Philippians 2:1-2 provides the clue. It is a call for unity among church believers. The Philippian church believers were perhaps arrogantly opposing the leadership of the church. There were many among this lot who were grumbling against the church leadership.

This is not to say that we must merely watch things happen when things go wrong in the church. When the local church acts in a way that the kingdom of God is destroyed, we must act. My wife and I have had to do that on a few occasions. When a visiting preacher said, "The Holy Spirit does not convict believers of sin", we took it up with the pastor who was responsible for inviting him! Our opposition to hell-populating false teaching has made us extremely unpopular over the years. But that did not matter to us. Someone must bell the cat and we were happy to volunteer! In the 2014 Hyper-Grace Awareness Conference in Chennai's New Life Assemblies of God, it was agreed that we the presenters would take up names of the Hyper-Grace false teachers following the example of Paul who also took up the names of certain false teachers (see I Tim. 1:19-20; 2 Tim. 2:17). When my turn came, I did not shy away from this, as God gave me the necessary grace to do the same!

CHAPTER 19

THE BLOOD OF JESUS IS NO EXCUSE TO CONTINUE IN WANTON SIN! BUT RATHER, IT IS....



'It does not matter if we lived holy lives or not, because, when the Father looks at us, believers, He sees the Blood of Jesus and He is perfectly pleased with what he sees!' – countering this brazen Hyper-Grace lie

If it is not possible to overcome besetting sin in our lives as believers, the Bible will not even call us for it. But it does! Hear the writer of the letter to the Hebrews: "Therefore, seeing we also are compassed by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us, and let us run with patience the race that is set before us" (Hebrews 12:1, KJ21).

There are those who are merely satisfied with the cleansing work of the Cross. Does the Cross cleanse us from sin? Of course! Apostle John wrote, "the blood of Jesus his son cleanses us from all Sin" (1 John 1:7, ESV).

The Cross of Christ does more than just PURIFICATION. It gives us POWER over habitual sin. The Cross of Christ does more than just WASH away sin. It gives us the wherewithal to WALLOP sin! The Cross of Christ does more than just CLEAN sin. It enables us to CRUSH sin's grasp over us!

Unfortunately, Hyper-Grace lie is this, in-effect: "God looks at the blood of Jesus when he looks at believers; so, it does not really matter whether you overcome sin in your life or not!"

The connection between the Cross of Christ and victory over besetting sin is so clearly established in Scripture that we will have to be either stone-blind or be heavily influenced by cultic Hyper-Grace hell-populating teaching not to notice it.

Apostle Peter expressed it clearly. He wrote, "He (Christ) himself bore our sins on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness" (1 Pet. 2:24, ESV). Apostle Paul penned the same thing using different words and imagery: "Those who belong to Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires" (Galatians 5:24). And when he wrote in Galatians 6:14, "the Cross of the Lord Jesus Christ, through which the world has been crucified to me, and I to the world", he was saying this: "thanks to the deep work of the Cross in my life, the besetting sin of worldliness is now dead (crucify here means death) in me!" **Jesus died so that we might have victory over sin in our day to day lives. The above Bible references make that crystal clear.**

Let me talk about various "P"s that help us understand how the blood of Christ gives us victory over daily, besetting sin.

PEACE AND THE BLOOD OF CHRIST

THE TEMPTATION TO WATCH A WEB SERIES FULL OF EROTIC SCENES...

Prophet Isaiah wrote, "the punishment that brought us peace was upon Him" (Isaiah 53:5). When we choose to sin against the Lord as a believer, the first result is a loss of peace. The knowledge that we will lose our peace when we sin should strongly deter us from walking down the familiar path of sin. **Yes, that journey to watch a web series full of erotic scenes is not worth it for it destroys our peace which was given to us because of the work of the Cross. Yes, that online affair outside the boundaries of marriage is not simply worth it because our serenity goes for a Six (to borrow an imagery from the world of cricket)**! Apostle Paul wrote, "we have peace with God because of what Jesus Christ our Lord has done for us" (Romans 5:1, NLT) on the Cross. "When I commit a wanton wickedness against my Lord, my peace will go for a huge Six. I don't want that to happen. So, I will overcome the temptation before me by tapping into the power of the Holy Spirit!" That is what we should say. That is what we should do.

PRECIOUSNESS AND THE BLOOD OF CHRIST

The Bible says, "You were ransomed from the futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable things such as silver or gold but with the precious blood of Christ" (1 Pet. 1:18-19). **When we realize the *preciousness* of the blood of Christ, we will realize how *atrocious* it is when we keep returning to the same old sin (that porn-watching, that drunkenness, that abusive language, etc.).**

SHE RETURNED TO THE RED LIGHT AREA TO BECOME A PROSTITUTE. BUT...

Hosea's wife left him to go to the Red-Light area for prostitution. But that did not put a red light (stop) on his love for her. He bought back his wife from the Red-Light District operators by paying 15 pieces of silver, five bushels of barley and a measure of wine (Hos. 3:2). These things were by no means cheap those days. They were very expensive. Exodus 21:32 and Zechariah 11:12 tells us that the price of a slave in the Jewish slave market was 30 shekels of silver. Translate that into today's world, where even to 'buy' a kidney, you need to shell out a bomb. Imagine the price of one full individual, then! Hosea paid this monstrous amount, partly in silver (15 pieces), and partly in agricultural produce (five bushels of barley and a measure of wine). After redeeming her, Hosea told her not to return to the Red-Light area as a prostitute (Hos. 3:3). **She had to put a 'red-light' (stop) on her life of sin having experienced a love from her husband which did not stop even though she went into**

the red-light area! Having been bought with something far more precious than what Prophet Hosea paid for his wife, which is the precious blood of Jesus, we must also take efforts to overcome sin. Since we were "bought" with a price – the utterly precious blood of Jesus – we must glorify God in our body, the Apostle Paul wrote (1 Cor. 6:20). We must stay away from sinful habits that destroy our souls and bodies – **torrid habits such as masturbation coupled with porn-watching, alcohol/drug consumption, sexual activity outside marriage, etc.**

THE PROFANING AND THE BLOOD OF JESUS

WATCHING A PROFANE WEB SERIES IS...

The author of the book of Hebrews wrote these powerful lines: "How much worse punishment do you think will be deserved by the man who has spurned the Son of God, and profaned blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified, and outraged the Spirit of Grace?" (Hebrews 10:29, RSV). And when do we profane the blood of Christ? The same author answers this question very directly: "when we deliberately keep on sinning after we have received the knowledge of the truth" (Hebrews 10:26, NIV). **So, when we are tempted to watch that profane web series that is being shown in that popular streaming service (Netflix and the like), we must tell**

ourselves this: "If I watch that, I will profane the precious blood of Jesus which I do not want to do. So, I will overcome that temptation empowered by the Spirit!"

Yes, it is possible to beat besetting sin through the blood of Jesus!

PERSECUTION AND THE BLOOD OF JESUS

John observed in the Book of Revelation this: "And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not lives even unto death" (Rev. 12:11). Yes, end-time believers overcame "the Devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world" (Rev. 12:9) through the blood of the Lamb (the Lord Jesus Christ). The Devil tried to threaten these believers with severe persecution but because they were inspired by the blood of the Lamb "they did not love their lives so much that they were afraid of death" (Rev. 12:11, EXB). Jesus was extremely bold as he marched towards the Cross. While his disciples ran helter-skelter when the Roman arrest party came, he very boldly marched towards them, saying, "I am he (the one you have come to arrest)!" (John 18:4-6). His bold voice threw the arrest party on the floor. They were flabbergasted. He was that bold! **So, His blood gives us the courage in the face of persecution that can come to us for saying 'no' to sin.** Therefore, when we say 'no' to sin inspired by the blood of Jesus, this complaint that the writer to the Hebrews made about his congregation will be no longer true about us: "In your struggle against sin you

have not yet resisted to the point of shedding your blood" (Heb. 12:4, RSV). Instead of compromising with sin and trying to escape the brickbats, we will conquer sin by being inspired by the blood of the Lamb despite the onslaught of severe persecution which may come from the Government or from your boss in the place of work.

Keep connecting the above-mentioned four "P"s – Peace, Preciousness, Profaning, Persecution – with the Cross of Christ! Habitual sin, which the Bible clearly warns us against (1 John 3:6), will be a thing of the past!

CHAPTER 20

CAN A SAVED PERSON BE EVER LOST IN HELL?



Understanding the dangers of Hyper-Calvinism/Hyper-Grace which teaches that 'Salvation cannot be lost even if a person lives in stubborn, till-death or till-second-coming sin'

LANCE ARMSTRONG STRIPPED OF HIS TITLES

A news report about American cyclist and cancer-survivor, Lance Armstrong set me thinking: 'Disgraced cyclist Lance Armstrong, who has already had his record seven Tour de France victories wiped from the record books, could now be stripped of the Legion d'Honneur, France's highest honour. Armstrong was awarded the title Chevalier de la Legion d'Honneur in 2005 in recognition of his seventh Tour win, but moves are now afoot to have the honour rescinded, according to a spokesman for the order. In January 2013, Armstrong, 41, admitted to Oprah Winfrey that he used performance-enhancing drugs during his record seven

Tour de France championships from 1999-2005. He was stripped of all seven Tour titles last year after a devastating report by the US Anti-Doping Agency (USADA), which accused the cyclist of taking part in *one of the biggest cheating operations in sports history'* (thestar.com.my, 2 March 2013 post). If a sports person could lose the titles he won, because he was wilfully committing fraud to win those titles, then are we correct in affirming that we will lose our salvation if we wilfully live in sin?

INDEED, AN ETERNITY AFFECTING QUESTION!

'Can a saved person ever be lost?'- this all-important head-splitting question has boggled and divided Christians world-wide down through the centuries. Differences over peripheral and circumferential doctrines can be overlooked. But as this question involves a doctrine at the heart of the Christian faith – salvation – this question needs careful unpacking, so that believers can come to an agreement over it – an agreement based on truth. In this chapter (which I first wrote as a 25-year-old while I was still in Bible college doing a Masters in Divinity course during the years, 1998-2001), I attempt to face the above eternal-destiny affecting question squarely and come up with my own conclusion.

THE DOCTRINE OF 'ETERNAL SECURITY' - THE VARIOUS VIEWS STATED

Let's put the doctrine we are debating about in 'black and white' in the words of **Dr. Robert Raymond** (1932-2013), a leading Reformed Theologian:

"Every true child of God, that is, every person whom the Father chose in Christ before the foundation of the world and for whom Christ died, whom the Father effectively called by His Word and Spirit unto repentance toward God and Faith in Jesus Christ, and whom he consequently justified and adopted unto his family, and who is consequently growing in grace, will never come into condemnation. That person can never be finally lost and is eternally secure. By virtue of God's preserving grace, he or she will certainly persevere in the state of salvation and be finally and eternally saved."

Theologians like Howard Marshall (1905-1995), however, warn that believers can backslide from the faith and consequently be damned if they don't persevere in their faith. Now the stage is set for a thorough check to see which position is biblical and correct.

THE DOCTRINE'S HISTORICAL DEVELOPMENT

Augustine was among the first to teach the doctrine of unconditional salvation. John Calvin believed that all saints could eventually persevere and that their free will have no part to play. Arminius, a Dutch Pastor,

challenged Methodist Church founder John Wesley saying that saints had no right to be certain of their salvation. **Arminius strongly believed that a saved person could go to hell if he chose to rebel against God.** John Wesley, who agreed with Arminius, put it this way, in-effect: "God does give sufficient grace to persevere, but it is up to us to whether or not we receive this grace." At any time, we can choose against God and be lost, he warned.

PRANAB MUKHERJEE AND SOME BIBLE SCHOLARS

India's (former) President **Pranab Mukherjee** set a record of sorts by sending a record number of convicts to the gallows, like no Indian President had. The rate at which he was sending convicts to the gallows was akin to the rate at which **Virender Sehwag** scored his runs or the speed with which **Usain Bolt** sprints! He rejected the mercy petition of **Ajmal Kasab**, the lone survivor of the team of 10 that attacked India on 26/11/2008, to have him hanged. He quashed the mercy plea of **Afzal Guru** accused of playing a role in the 2001 Parliament Terror attack, to have him hanged, shortly later. *The Times of India* reported that 'President Pranab Mukherjee has cleared the road to the gallows for four associates of slain forest brigand Veerappan by rejecting their mercy petitions' (on 13th Feb. 2013). Pranab Mukherjee by his actions was promoting this principle: no mercy will be shown for those who commit callous crimes! In the same way there are some Bible Scholars who have

arisen over the years to promote this teaching: no heaven for believers who deliberately live in sin without ever repenting till their death or till the return of Jesus!

Some of the twentieth century's outstanding Bible teachers and scholars like **Martyn Lloyd-Jones, Carl F. H. Henry, Buist M. Fanning, Randall C. Gleason and James Innell Packer** were hardened believers in the doctrine of perseverance of saints/the doctrine of eternal security. But in the last 40 years, a new crop of theologians/Bible Teachers like **Howard Marshall, Dale Moody, Grant R. Osborne, Gareth Lee Cockerill and David Pawson, Robert Shank, Craig S. Keener** have arisen to warn believers about the real danger of falling away from the faith – if they would choose to do so. In defence of their opinion, they give three lines of evidence – along Scripture, along philosophy, and along logic. Let us take them up one by one.

SCRIPTURE EVIDENCE AGAINST ETERNAL SECURITY

(A) OLD TESTAMENT TEACHING

(1) SALVATION WAS CONDITIONAL FROM THE BEGINNING

To the dejected Cain, who offered his second-best to Him, God said, 'it will be accepted if you respond the right way. But if you refuse to respond correctly, then watch out!' (Gen 4:7, NLT). Cain bunked the condition and was rejected. The New Testament writers warn us about his way (see Heb. 11:4; 1 John 3:12; Jude 11). Following

Cain's way is a way to cheat ourselves because Cain rejected God's important "if" condition for salvation. Cain refused the 'if condition' and he left the presence of the LORD (Gen. 4:16).

(2) SALVATION WAS CONDITIONAL IN THE ABRAHAMIC COVENANT

The "As for you" of Abraham in Genesis 17:9 balances the "As for me" of God in Genesis 17:4 (*The NIV Study Bible* notes). His faith must be accompanied by "obedience that comes from faith" (Rom 1:5).

(3) SALVATION WAS CONDITIONAL IN THE SINAITIC COVENANT

Before God signed off the Sinaitic covenant it was punctuated by eternal 'if' clauses. In fact, the list of curses for covenant disobedience is usually much longer than that of blessings for obedience (as in verses 3-13 in Leviticus 26).

(4) THE IF CONDITION IN THE DAVIDIC COVENANT

The 'if' clause here can't be missed. The Lord's words to David about Solomon confirm this: 'Your son Solomon will build my temple and its courtyards, for I have chosen him…And if he continues to obey my commands and regulations as he does now, I will make his kingdom last forever' (1 Chron. 28:6,7 NLT).

(5) THE IF CONDITION IN THE PROPHETS

The 'If 'clause here is crystal clear. Isaiah stressed this "if" factor in his message to Israel: 'If you will only obey me and let me help you, then you will have plenty to eat. But if you keep turning away and refuse to listen,

you will be destroyed by your enemies. I, the Lord, have spoken' (Isa 1:19,20, NLT). Prophet Azariah's words to king Asa is perhaps the most famous "if" statement in the Bible - 2 Chronicles 7:14. Jeremiah's famous 'temple sermon' has this again: "If you stop exploiting foreign orphans and widows; and if you stop your murdering, and if you stop worshiping idols as you now do to your harm. Then I will let you stay in the Land I gave to your ancestors to keep forever" (Jer. 7:6,7). Prophet Ezekiel preached the same: 'But if wicked people turn from their wickedness and do what is just and right they will live'. In the last book of the Old Testament, this 'if' message appears again: 'if you do not listen, and if you do not set your heart to honour my name.' says the Lord Almighty, I will send a curse upon you, and I will curse your blessings'(Mal 2:2).

(6) THE IF CONDITION IN THE NEW TESTAMENT

Yes, we were considering only the Old Testament material in this section up until this point! But I cannot resist the temptation to include a classic New Testament reference with an 'if': 'Therefore, my brothers and sisters, make every effort to confirm your calling and election. For if you do these things, you will never stumble' (2 Peter 1:10). So, the New Testament seconds the Old Testament's 'if' teaching, instead of contradicting it!

British Nobel laureate **Rudyard Kipling** wrote these famous lines in his poem, *If*, way back in 1895): "If you can dream - and not make dreams your master; If you can think - and not make thoughts your aim; If you can meet with Triumph and Disaster; And treat those two impostors just the same… If you can talk with crowds

and keep your virtue; Or walk with Kings - nor lose the common touch... Yours is the Earth and everything that's in it; And - which is more - you'll be a Man, my son!" We would be wise to grasp that we can indeed lose our salvation if we are not careful, as the multiple 'if' statements in the Old Testament indicates that we would.

MY DUTY TO TELL YOU ABOUT THIS GUY DUTY QUOTE!

Let's invite **Guy Duty** to seal this argument from the Old Testament for us: "There are 63 'if' texts in the Old Testament to prove that the Jewish Covenant are conditional. From God's 'if' to Cain, to Malachi's 'if' to his priests, the unified testimony of Scripture gives full approval to our doctrine of conditional salvation."

Let us now turn our attention to the New Testament:

(B) NEW TESTAMENT TEACHING

Three types of Scripture passages can be used to bust the doctrine, 'Eternal Security'.

(1) EXHORTATIONS TO CONTINUE IN THE FAITH – AN EXPLORATION

The following scriptures will seem ludicrous if there was no possibility of a believer falling away: 'But all of you who endure to the end shall be saved' (Matt.10:22). 'If you continue in my word, you are truly my disciples' (John 8:31, RSV); "When you're joined with me and I with you, the relation intimate and organic, the harvest is sure to be abundant. Separated you can't produce a thing. Anyone who separates from me is dead

wood, gathered up and thrown on bonfire" (John 15:5-6, MSG); "Keep your eyes open for spiritual danger, stand true to the Lord" (1 Cor. 16:13, TLB); "For we share in Christ, if only we hold our first confidence firm to the end" (Heb. 3:14, RSV); "Don't quit, even if it costs your life. Stay there believing. I have Life-Crown sized and ready for you" (Rev 2:10, MSG); "Keep tight grip on what you have, so no one distracts you and steals your crown" (Rev 3:11, MSG).

THE FIRST TIME I PICKED UP A THEOLOGY BOOK -- IT WAS NOT IN A BIBLE COLLEGE!

I would like to quote Renowned Charismatic Systematic Theologian, **J. Rodman Williams** (1918-2008) at this point. I picked up my first theology book much before I landed up in a Bible College. When I was a student in Allahabad Agricultural Institute (1993-97), my dad **Mr. A. Jeyaraj** gifted me a 'hurt' copy (that is, some parts of this book were termite-eaten) of the first volume of Rodman Williams' three-volume systematic theology book series. I devoured it. I taught the precious Bible lessons I learnt from that book to small groups of interested fellow students in hostel rooms. This was how God trained me to lead Bible Studies. By now, it has been my privilege to lead Bible Book summaries of all the 66 different Bible books for small groups. Rodman Williams says in-effect, **"There is nothing in the Bible which makes us believe in the unconditional perseverance of saved people still living in sin."** Starting from 1 Corinthians 10:12 – 'So if you think you are standing firm, be

careful that you don't fall!' – He lists the conditions for perseverance, arranging a gamete of Scripture verses under each condition. They are:

(a) our abiding (1 John 2:24-25; Heb. 2:1,3, John 15:3-4,6,7),

(b) our continuing (Col. 1:21-23; Rom. 11:11,22; 1 Tim. 4:16),

(c) our enduring (2 Tim. 2:10-12; Heb. 10:34-39, Matt. 24:12,13),

(d) our firmness (Heb. 3:1-6, 2 Pet. 1:10-11,5-7; 2:1,20,21)

(e) our faithfulness (Rev. 2:10; 2:4-5, Heb. 3:1-6, Heb. 6:4-8).

Knowing such emphasis will attract an accusation, "this is not salvation by good works," he brilliantly quotes Peter who talks about those saved this way: "who by God's power are being guarded through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed for the last time", he teaches quoting Peter (1 Pet. 1:5). We are saved by faith. And we guard our faith by continued faith. That's what Peter says. Yes, we are saved by faith and not works. **But if that faith is alone and is not expressed through works, that faith is not real saving faith (the message of the book of James is this very thing).**

The second set of scripture passages which question unconditional perseverance of saints are found below:

(2) WARNINGS AGAINST APOSTASY / BACKSLIDING

2 Peter 3:17 says, "Therefore, dear friends, since you already know this, be on your guard so that you may not be carried away by the error of lawless men and fall your secure position." Peter couldn't have stated this better. 2 Peter 3:18, in fact, expresses the same warnings in the positive terms: 'grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.' **If there was no real possibility of a believer permanently backsliding, then one must admit that the Spirit-inspired writers of Scripture were joking here or I dare say, lying (trying to deceive)!** In a discussion like this, we cannot leave out the famous and relevant passage found in Hebrews 6:4-8.

Commenting on this key text, **Grant R. Osborne** says, 'In conclusion we must say that **there is no more powerful or detailed description of the true Christian in the New Testament**, yet one has to be stone-blinded not to note that they were in the real peril of falling away.' **Grant Osborne summarizes brilliantly the danger of apostasy so persuasively and passionately presented in the book of Hebrews this way**: pay attention, lest you drift away, 2:1-4; do not harden your heart, lest you fail, 3:1-19; fear not, lest you fall short, 4:1-13; press on, lest you fall away, 5:11-6:12; hold fast, lest you die, 10:19-39; be careful, lest you fall short, 12:1-17.

A STEVE JOB QUOTE AND ABOUT BACKSLIDDEN BELIEVERS GOING TO HELL

Steve Jobs, the late Apple CEO said, "**Apple** has some tremendous assets, but I believe without some

attention, the company could, could, could — **I'm searching for the right word** — could, could **die**." When one reads the above paragraph, we would agree that the Scripture clearly teaches, "A believer is given the tremendous gift of Salvation when he repents and trusts Christ, but without actively remaining in Christ, the believer could die in sin to go to hell and burn there forever and ever!"

The third collection of Scriptures that shake the foundations of the 'once saved, always saved doctrine' –

(3) CASES OF ACTUAL APOSTASY/BACKSLIDING

In the parable of the Sower, Jesus spoke of those 'who believe for a while, but in the time of testing they fall away' (Luke 8:13). Jesus clearly predicted, 'At that time many will turn away from the faith. The love of most will grow cold' (Math. 24:10,12). Why would Jesus talk about believers 'turning away from faith' if they weren't already in the faith? They were genuine believers in the first place according to Jesus – something Calvinists always rush to deny. 1 Timothy 4:19 is blunt: some have shipwrecked their faith! Demas – a team-member in Paul's ministry team – deserted Paul and perhaps even the Christian faith for 'he loved the world' (2 Tim. 4:10). Peter described some teachers in the church who had known the way of righteousness yet turned their backs on the sacred commandment that was passed on to them (2 Pet. 2:20-22). If they had turned their backs on the sacred commandments, then without a shadow of doubt they once had their faces set on the commandments

– they were believers – once upon a time! But they became apostate. Finally, Revelation 22:19 shows that some can have their names removed from the book of life.

BELIEVER TRIO IN THE BOOK OF ACTS WHO WERE IN THE REAL DANGER OF GOING TO HELL

Another example of actual apostasy could be Ananias and Sapphira. F.F.Bruce writes, "We cannot be sure that they were not believers, unless we are prepared to say that no one who is guilty of a deliberate deceit cannot be a true Christian. The thrust of Simon the Sorcerer narrative in Acts leads us to conclude that there was a possibility of serious sin by the members of the church which could lead to their exclusion from eternal life, but at the same time there was a possibility of their repentance and restoration. In the Bible the root word for faith and faithfulness is the same. One can't have one without the other." **Ananias, Sapphira, and Simon the Socerer – these three could be added to the actual list of those believers who became apostate, believers in the real danger of going to hell.**

Prophets of eternal security will rush to quote their favourite proof texts in response to the above. Those texts deserve a second look.

THE 'WHAT ABOUT.....?' PASSAGES: EXEGETICAL NOTES ON TEXTS USED BY THE 'ONCE SAVED - ALWAYS SAVED' GROUP

Calvinists (the 'once saved, always saved' group) quote Jesus' prayer that the Father would keep the disciples (John 17:11,15,24). Even as He had kept them, He would keep each believer till the end as proof of eternal security of believers, they argue. But the very fact, Jesus is praying for them is proof that Jesus understood the real danger of them being lost for otherwise they would not need to be guarded. According to Howard Marshall, John 17 should not be seen in isolation from John 15:6,16 which warn the disciples about 'falling away'.

John 10:28,29 and John 5:24 is another favourite 'proof text' for the 'once saved, always saved' doctrine believers. But these texts should not be divorced from John 10:27 which records the words of Jesus this way: "My sheep hear my voice; I know them and they follow me." It is to be noted that all the verbs in this verse – especially the verb 'hear' – is in the present indicative tense in Greek original. **Robert Shank** notes, "The honest characteristic of the Greek present indicative is that it denotes the action is in progress." There is the incredible promise – "I give them eternal life, and they will never perish; no one will snatch them away from me" (John 10:28) – is only of whom Jesus can say, "My sheep keep listening to my voice, and they keep following me!" Wuest's translation of John 5:24, where-in he correctly retains the present tense ('having eternal life') argues

powerfully against using it as a text for an eternal security: "Most assuredly, I am saying to you that He who habitually hears my word and is believing the one whom he has sent me, has life eternal ....." **David Pawson** brilliantly flows along this thought line, as he summarizes the message of the book of Hebrews (in his *Unlocking the Bible* series), that "these people (the Old-Testament believers of Hebrews 11) were still living by faith when they died" (Heb. 11:13). This clearly shows that faith should be a present possession for a believer to make the eternal security promises work for him.

WHEN COACH GREG CHAPPELL SPOKE ABOUT VIRENDER SEHWAG

Greg Chappell, India's former Cricket coach wrote the following lines about **Virender Sehwag,** "Despite my frustrations with him during my tenure as Indian coach I could not help but love him. He is, after all, a loveable rogue. And he can bat better than most. In fact, he is the most gifted ball striker that I have seen.... To say that Viru was one of the great frustrations of my time with the team is an understatement. Sadly, he continues to disappoint and is in danger of squandering his God-given talent. The person who is least likely to be fazed by all of this is Virender himself. What I soon learned about him was that Viru did not want to dedicate himself to taking his talent to its zenith. He was happy to turn up and play and accept what came his way. No amount of cajoling from me could shift him from his insouciant way. This often happens to those with the greatest gift. Because he had never had to work hard at developing such a skill, Viru did not know how to dedicate himself

to disciplined training. It was only during periods of relatively poor form that he was prepared to spend time getting things back on track. As soon as he made some runs, he slipped back into old habits and appeared content to practise in the same old profligate way; until his form evaporated again... **He wants the prize but has been unwilling to pay the price**" (*The Hindu*, 27th Sept. 2012). What Chappell wrote about Sehwag here, I believe, is someway applicable to what the Bible teaches to believers who don't take efforts with God's help to guard their God-given free gift of salvation. **Believers are in the real danger of squandering their God-given gift of salvation by refusing stubbornly to remain in Christ while at the same time being lazy and lethargic in their battle against sin.**

'SEALED BY THE SPIRIT, SO BELIEVERS CAN'T GO TO HELL?'

There are those who point to Bible passages where it says the Holy Spirit has 'sealed' us 'eternally' for redemption to argue for eternal security of one's salvation (2 Cor. 1:22; 2 Cor. 5:5; Eph. 1:13-14; Rom. 8:9; John 14:16). In response, I would like to quote David E. Pratte: 'Some people mistakenly use such passages to claim that, since we have the Holy Spirit as a "guarantee," we cannot lose salvation - "once saved always saved." However, the "earnest" shows good intention on God's part; but that in no way guarantees the faithfulness of the humans in keeping our part of the agreement. It is not uncommon, in human transactions, for a party to back out of a purchase or violate a contract after earnest money has been paid. The point here is that God will

not back out, if we keep our part of the agreement. But if we humans do not keep our part of the covenant, God is surely not required to provide us eternal life. He can and will then withdraw His earnest, and we lose our reward.' That was correctly put. Even David acknowledged that the Holy Spirit could take the liberty of leaving him when he was living in open rebellion against God. That's why he prayed this prayer post his repentance from the Bathsheba affair: "Do not take your Holy Spirit from me!" (Psa. 51:11).

The references for the Holy Spirit sealing upon a believer come in two places in 2 Corinthians (2 Cor. 1:22; 5:5). If Paul meant via these references that there was absolutely no chance of a backslidden believer ever landing in hell, he would NOT have penned lines like these which imply exactly the opposite in the very same book: 'Examine yourselves *as to* whether you are in the faith. Test yourselves. Do you not know yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you?—unless indeed you are disqualified' (2 Cor. 13:5, NKJV). Those who do not live the 'Christ-in-me' life of holiness will be disqualified from entering heaven – that is the meaning here (I believe). In 1 Corinthians too, Paul issued a similar warning, taking himself as the example. He wrote, 'I'm staying alert and in top condition. I'm not going to get caught napping, telling everyone else all about it and then missing out myself' (1 Cor. 9:27, MSG).

WHEN THE SPIRIT OF GOD SPEAKS: 'THAT IS LUST'

Paul talked about being sealed in the Spirit in the book of Ephesians as well (Eph. 1:13-14). Does this mean that believers cannot be ever lost? Does this imply that believers have no chance of going to hell? No! In the same book where Paul says that the Holy Spirit has sealed believers, Paul also penned that the Holy Spirit is grieved whenever believers commit sin (Eph. 4:30). That verse reads like this: 'And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, with whom you were sealed for the day of redemption'. Some have argued, 'Though our sin can grieve the Holy Spirit, he will stay with us till the day of redemption – the Holy Spirit will take us to heaven without fail'. That will be true, if Paul never ever warned about believers going to hell in his letters. But he did. And he did so even in his letter to the Ephesians. Just read Ephesians 5:1-5 and you will get this. If believers stubbornly lived unholy lives like the unbelievers around them, the ultimate fate of the unbelievers will be "surely" (see Eph. 5:5) the fate of the stubbornly backslidden believer as well! So, the implication is this: the Holy Spirit will keep convicting the flagrantly sinning believer, the Holy Spirit will keep warning the wayward believer, but if the believer is still stubborn in sin, after a God-set, certain point, the grieving Holy Spirit (Eph. 4:30; I Thess. 5:19 would call the same thing quenching the Spirit), will finally leave the believer. Only God knows when this would happen. Once the ministry of the Holy Spirit is withdrawn from a believer, he or she cannot repent. Why do I say that? Because only the Holy Spirit can bring about a conviction of sin, in anyone's life (John 16:8; I Cor. 14:24). That's why, it is important to respond with immediate repentance when the Holy Spirit convicts us of

sin telling us gently things like these: 'that is lust... that is pride... that is selfishness... repent now'. If we keep disobeying the voice of the Holy Spirit, we will then store up the wrath of God against us – a wrath that will fully be fleshed out in eternal hell (Rom. 2:4-5; 2 Thess. 1:8-9).

'HOLY SPIRIT IN YOUR HEART FOREVER' - YES, TWO VERSES SAY THAT, BUT...

Paul words in Romans 8:9 ('if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ, they do not belong to Christ') and the words of Jesus in John 16:14 ('And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another advocate to help you and be with you forever—') have been also used to teach 'once saved, always saved'. These two verses have been used to teach: 'the Holy Spirit never leaves a believer'. However, I disagree with this interpretation.

Let us take up Romans 8:9, first. The phrase 'belong to Christ' is used there. Paul used this phrase first in Romans 1:6. He writes there: 'And you also are among those Gentiles who are called to belong to Jesus Christ' (NIV). What is the meaning? The Gospel was announced to the Gentiles; a remnant from among them chose to repent from sin and believe in Jesus. And consequently, they started to 'belong to Jesus Christ'. But if these Gentile believers, backslide, keep sinning stubbornly without repenting, then this Pauline statement is true about them: they are storing up God's Wrath against them – a wrath that will fully be fleshed out in eternal hell (Rom. 2:4-5; 2 Thess. 1:8-9). Therefore, those who once belonged to Christ can indeed go to hell. If that

is true, then those who once had the Spirit of Christ also can go to hell. This Spirit would wrestle with them, prodding them to repent. But if the Spirit's gentle voice is not heeded to, again and again, the Spirit has no choice but to leave, before the stubbornly backslidden believer is consigned to hell at the end.

What about John 16:14 – does it teach 'once saved, always saved'? No! Let me explain: What Jesus is saying here is this: the Spirit of God will be with the disciples of Jesus forever. This verse, obviously, is not talking about backslidden disciples of Jesus. Who is a true disciple of Jesus? Jesus answers this question in John 14:23. We read there this: 'Jesus replied, "Anyone who loves me will **obey** my teaching. My Father will love them, and we will come to them and make our home with them."' The Father and Son reside in the hearts of Jesus-disciples who show forth an ongoing obedience to the teachings of Jesus! Similarly, it can be said that the Spirit of God indwells in the hearts of the disciples who show forth ongoing obedience to the words of Jesus/the Word of God! But if the disciples of Jesus choose to disobey the words of Jesus by demonstrating an ongoing sinful stubbornness, the indwelling Spirit may finally choose to leave after giving that disciple adequate chances to repent. I say this because I have read the rest of the Gospel of John. The names of the disciples were written in heaven (Luke 10:20). But one of the disciples, Judas, whose name was also written in heaven, chose to keep sinning stubbornly, so records John's Gospel (John 12:6 – 'He did not say this because he cared about the poor but because he was a thief; as keeper of the money bag, he used to help himself to what was put into it'). Jesus gave him many chances. But finally, Jesus decided to put an end to all his chances of salvation. How do I know

that? These words which I read in John's Gospel: 'As soon as Judas took the bread, Satan entered into him. So, Jesus told him, "What you are about to do, do quickly"' (John 13:27). Judas was given many chances by Jesus. But he blew them all up. Judas had crossed the point of no-return. That's why Jesus spoke that way to him. Similarly, we can have the case of Satan entering a believer (if he could enter Judas, he can enter a believer like him – stubbornly into sin without repenting) and the Holy Spirit leaving that believer ultimately. After this happens, this believer cannot be saved. But only God knows if this has happened with any believer or not. I say this because it was Jesus, and no one else, who told Judas, 'What you are about to do, do quickly!'

THEOLOGICAL ARGUMENTS AGAINST ETERNAL SECURITY

I HAVE A PROBLEM ONLY WITH THE HYPER-GRACE EMBRACING CALVINISTS – NOT EVERY CALVINIST/ REFORMED THEOLOGIAN!

When shown outrageously clear proofs in Scripture that once saved people were lost, Classical Calvinists like **Stanley Grenz** articulates his theological argument for once-saved-always-saved this way: "Those who forsake the faith may someday return to faith, because the indwelling Spirit will complete the saving mission. Or they may never repent of their apostasy, revealing thereby that they were NOT genuinely converted." I have often said, I have no problem with the Classical Calvinists/Reformed Theology Embracing Believers like him.

While the Armenians would say that those stubborn in sin are lost, the Classical Calvinist would say that those stubborn in sin were not really saved in the first place (reference: J. Stanley Grenz quote above). **Both are saying the same thing using different terminology – that's all! My real problem is with the Hyper-Grace embracing Calvinists who would say: "Even if believers are stubborn in sin and won't repent, they remain saved!"**

Howard Marshall takes on the view put forth by scholars like **Stanley Grenz** with tact. He says that if the Calvinists theory were true, the warnings in the Bible would necessarily take such forms as: 'Make sure that you are really converted, beware lest what you think is an experience of salvation by faith is really nothing of the kind.' But the sorts of warnings are not there in Scripture. Put otherwise, the positive command is not to begin to be a genuine believer but to continue and persevere in the faith which one already has.

Calvinists (the group that teaches Eternal Security for salvation) allege that Armenians who emphasize human faith in one's salvation destroys its purely gracious character. This is simply not the truth. The Bible tells us in no uncertain terms faith is no work at all (Rom. 4:16). It is simply the surrender of the will to God, the stretching out of an empty hand to receive the gift of grace, argues **Clark Pinnock** (I do NOT subscribe to his pluralism-leaning writings, however). In an act of faith, we pour scorn at our self-righteousness. Faith, as a means of salvation and security doesn't encourage conceit and self-esteem – it actually excludes it.

THE LIMITATION OF THE CALVINISTIC 'LIMITED ATONEMENT' THEORY

Of course, I do NOT subscribe to the Limited Atonement theory of the Calvinists – a teaching that says that Christ died only for the elect (Mark 10:45 and Matthew 20:28 says that Jesus died for 'many' and the word 'many' referred to here, Calvinists interpret to be 'the elect'). When we read Romans 5:15-18 we get an answer for this confusion. Romans 5:15 says, 'MANY died through one man's trespass'. Further down below, Romans 5:18 says, 'as one trespass led to the condemnation of ALL men...'. So, in Bible language, 'MANY' means 'ALL' as you can see, they are used interchangeably here. So, Christ died for all. Both 2 Corinthians 5:14-15 and Hebrews 2:9 are crystal clear: Jesus died for all. If Jesus meant that he died only for 'many' (and not for all) in Matthew 20:28 why would he call for preaching to all in the same Gospel, not just once, but twice (see Matt. 24:14; 28:19)?

PHILOSOPHICAL ARGUMENT AGAINST ETERNAL SECURITY

The doctrine of eternal security teaches that God over-rides human free will of the believer to secure him forever. This creates serious philosophical problems for the Christians who believe in an absolutely good God. If God must by-pass human free will to secure salvation for believers, he becomes guilty of the greatest sin! Apologist and Theologian, **Norman Giesler** argues along these lines: 'Love is the greatest good for all free

creatures, but love is impossible without freedom. So only if freedom were destroyed, overridden, God can provide eternal security for believers. That would be evil itself because it would deprive free man of his greatest good – freedom. Hence if God bypasses human free will to secure believers eternally, he would be committing a sin. And that is a philosophical impossibility!'

WE ARE NOT ROBOTS, ARE WE?

Let me illustrate the above paragraph in a practical way. Those who teach that there is 'eternal' security for believers invariably imply that God has made us all mere robots sans a free will. But the Bible consistently teaches us that God has indeed given us a free will. In the Old Testament we read Joshua's classic words: "But if you refuse to serve the LORD, then choose today whom you will serve" (Josh. 24:15). In the New Testament we read Jesus' shocking words to his chosen disciples: "Do you also want to leave?" (John 6:67). Both these verses are among the many in the Bible that teach that we have a free will. **If we believed in the eternal security doctrine and that God secures our free will to serve him permanently, we, in-effect do not believe that he has given us a free-will! God will make our free will permanent only on the Day of Judgement.** On that day He might say to some of us, this: "You chose not to have fellowship with me while you were on this earth for these sixty-seventy years! Instead, you deliberately chose to rebel against me and play games with me. Now, I will make permanent, that choice you made using your free will. Today, I will freeze your free will choice to

wallow in sin while turning your back on me. Depart then to eternal hell, a place in which humans cannot have fellowship with me and live there forever in everlasting torment!"

PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS OF NOT BELIEVING ETERNAL SECURITY

It certainly challenges us, believers to test ourselves to make sure that we are solid in the faith, and we don't drift along taking everything for granted (2 Cor. 13:5). **David Pawson** points out, 'There is a beautiful balance in the New Testament between our responsibility to keep ourselves in God's love (Jude 21) and his ability to keep us from falling (Jude 24).' We can be cocksure about the faith that God will not and cannot fail to do what he has promised. The ball is in our court. We will do well if this understanding drives us to say with the great apostle Paul, 'I don't know about you, but I'm running hard for the finish line. I'm giving it everything I've got. I'm not going to get caught napping telling everyone else all about it and then missing out myself' (1 Cor. 9:24-27).

Billy Graham was once asked by the media, what his first reaction would be when he got to heaven. In an instant, he replied, "I would be relieved!" He agreed with what Puritan, John Bunyan wrote in his classic book, *The Pilgrim's Progress,* which went this way: "Then I saw that there is a way to Hell, even from the gates of Heaven."

This doctrine which states that there is a possibility of believers losing their salvation, produces serious Christians who don't dare to play games with God and take His Grace for granted. Though this study has not been exhaustive, one can say with confidence, in the light of the above study, that believers may lose their salvation if they chose to live in constant rebellion against God. The following scripture is a fitting conclusion to this absorbing theological debate of paramount importance to the Christian life:

If we endure hardship, we will reign with him. If we deny him, he will deny us (2 Tim. 2:12, NLT).

In the Bible, we do have an example of a person who once believed and was even baptised, only to be told by one of the Apostles that he could 'perish' with the money he dearly loved, if he did not repent (See Acts 8:13,20-22). Perhaps, if you have gone away from God would you also repent, instead of hoping falsely that you will be saved on the Final Day, as you were once saved someday in the past?

(Written with the help of Bible Commentaries, Study Bibles and personal reflection. Updated material was added periodically to this chapter, with the last lot was inserted in May 2024. God bless Prathyusha Nakka, our ministry volunteer, for taking time to type the first version of chapter, a hand-written Term Paper, which Duke wrote as a student of Masters in Divinity in Southern Asia Bible College, Bangalore, 1998-2001).

SECTION TWO

TAKING ON HYPER-SUPERNATURALISM

CHAPTER 21

"GREATER WORKS THAN JESUS" BIBLE PHRASE IS TALKING ABOUT FORENSIC PROPHECY OR MIRACLE MONEY?



There is an increasing craze to attend meetings where forensic prophecy and "miracle money" is the order of the day in the meeting. This craze is typical among those in the Hyper-Supernaturalism focussed churches. For those of you who do not know, forensic prophecy involves supposed "Holy Spirit" inspired bizarre revelations about details unknown to the preacher like phone numbers, date of birth, month of birth, bank account details, bank balance details, etc., of those in the audience/or those known to the audience. When these are mentioned by the so-called "prophet", the audience is stunned and they tell themselves, "How come this prophet knows all this! He is certainly guided by God! He is really a man of God and I must follow his teachings and support his ministry with my time, talents and treasures!"

There are popular preachers who are into forensic prophecy from India, Sri Lanka, United Kingdom and many other countries of the World. The main focus of the meetings these preachers organize and minister in, are forensic prophecies. They can be called hyper-supernatural preachers (preachers who excessively focus on the supposed supernatural and go beyond what the Bible explicitly teaches when it comes to the operation of miracles/healings/etc).

"FIRST RAISE 10 PEOPLE FROM THE DEAD AND THEN COME AND LECTURE ME!"

A very popular-on-YouTube worship leader who often calls a miracle-money focusing 'prophet' as his spiritual 'papa', said this in a rebuttal video clip which I saw as telecasted by a TV News Channel: "First raise 10 people from the dead and then come and lecture me from the Bible what true worship is!" (he says this to this critics). From the tone of this argument, we can conclude that he is Hyper-Supernatural. For him, the Bible does not seem to be final court of appeal. The final court of appeal for him, is miracles. If miracles happen, he feels, then that ministry is genuine. This is the typical assertion of the person who is swayed by the hyper-supernatural false teaching. We will refute this teaching later in this chapter.

In response to the question, "Why are you busy chasing forensic prophetic miracles and miracle money miracles?", the usual response given by such proponents is this: "Jesus said we who believe in him will do greater works than him as John 14:12 says. So, we do this!"

Such a response does not hold water. It is not adequate. It is not convincing. Let me explain:

Can this miracle-money/forensic-prophecy group say, "Jesus claimed to be the only way of Salvation. He also said that we, his followers would do greater works than him. So, we Jesus' miracle-working followers, are a greater way of Salvation than even Jesus himself!"? They cannot say that. Why? The Bible remains the final court of appeal for all matters of belief and behaviour. And the Bible is clear in John 14:6 and Acts 4:12 – Jesus is the ONLY way of Salvation! **We cannot have a Bible interpretation for any Bible verse that violates the Bible itself.**

First of all, we must seek to find out what the word "works" (NKJV/NASB) Jesus referred to in John 14:12 means. Do they mean "signs and wonders" as this Forensic Prophecy/Miracle Money group confidently says it means? We must read above and below this verse to understand its correct meaning. We must also read the rest of the Bible to arrive at the right interpretation for this verse.

BELOW THE PASSAGE

WILL YOU MARRY MANY WOMEN QUOTING JOHN 14:12, THE 'GREATER WORKS THAN ME' VERSE?

First, let us read BELOW that verse. We must read the next two verses – that is John 14:13 and 14 – to understand the meaning of the word that Jesus used. They go this way: "Whatever you ask in My name, that will I do, so that the Father may be glorified in the Son. If you ask Me anything in My name, I will do it" (John 14:13-14 NASB). The "greater works" (works greater than Jesus' works) are the works that believers do to bring God's glory (see John 14:13). These works must be worthy enough to be asked for in Jesus' name (see John 14:14). For example, No one should be saying, "Jesus never married any woman. But He said, 'I will do greater works than him!' So, I am going to marry, many women!" Why? That request does not bring glory to the Father's name. That request cannot be asked in Jesus' name (because it goes against the teachings of Jesus and what is clearly written elsewhere in the Bible!)

'GREATER WORKS' MUST LINE-UP WITH HIS COMMANDS

We are trying to find out the meaning of the phrase, "works" when Jesus said, "you who believe in me will do greater works than me" in John 14:12. Scroll further down and we read this, the words of Jesus: "If you love Me, you will keep My commandments" (John 14:15). So, the greater works we believers do, should be in line

with the commands of Jesus or the Word of God which is the final court of appeal for all matters of belief and behaviour.

Let us scroll down even further to get to the root of the meaning of "greater works" which Jesus spoke about in John 14:12. From John 14:16 onwards, Jesus starts to introduce the Holy Spirit. So, this is what he is saying: "To do the greater works, you need the fullness of the Holy Spirit, whom I will soon send!"

'YOU CAN FORCE GOD TO ANSWER YOUR PRAYERS EVERY-TIME'! REALLY?

In the book of Acts, the Holy Spirit came down. The disciples of Jesus and ordinary believers were filled with the Holy Spirit. They went about doing the "greater works" that Jesus spoke about in John 14:12. Of course, they did many miracles enabled by the power of the Holy Spirit. But at the same time, we must not fail to notice that miracles they sought did not always happen. For example, apostle James was imprisoned and killed (Acts 12:2), while Peter was imprisoned and miraculously escaped (Acts 12:7 following). While it was God's will to have Peter miraculously released, it was not His will that James should be released. We must conclude that James, like David, served the purposes of God in his generation and then died (we read this in the same book – the book of Acts in 13:36!). The Hyper-Supernatural preachers believe "you can force God to answer your prayers

every-time", the way you want him to, and this belief is plainly unscriptural! [What I have put with-in inverted commas is the subtitle of one of the books of a popular hyper-supernatural preacher].

SUFFERING FOR JESUS, A 'GREATER WORK'!

Here is another account of "greater things" that the disciples did in the book of Acts: "They took his advice; and after calling the apostles in, they flogged them and ordered them not to speak in the name of Jesus, and then released them. So, they went on their way from the presence of the Council, rejoicing that they had been considered worthy to suffer shame for His name. And every day, in the temple and from house to house, they kept right on teaching and preaching Jesus as the Christ" (Acts 5:40-42). Yes, they were flogged by the enemies of the Gospel, the Jewish leaders. **As they were bleeding, they were bubbling.** Bubbling with joy that they were counted "worthy" to suffer for the name of Jesus! **But despite the "battering" (the flogging) they kept at their "broadcasting" (of the name of Jesus)!** Wow! So, I conclude that suffering for the name of Jesus is part and parcel of the "greater works" that Jesus spoke about in John 14:12!

'GREATER WORKS' MEANS GEOGRAPHICAL AND NUMERICAL EXTENSION!

Respected Bible Scholars interpret John 14:12 where Jesus mentions about those who believe in him doing

greater works than him in this way: "Jesus had accomplished the greatest works possible, including raising the dead. How could He say believers would do greater works? The answer is seen in the extent of what the apostles did. Jesus' work on the earth was confined to Palestine; the apostles would preach everywhere and see the conversion of thousands. Peter's message at Pentecost brought more followers to Jesus than did Jesus' entire ministry. The disciples were able to do this work because Christ would go to the Father and send the Holy Spirit to empower them" (*The Nelson Study Bible*, 1997 Edition, page 1793). "These works are 'greater' not because they are more amazing miracles but because they will be greater in their worldwide scope…" (*The ESV Study Bible*, 2008 edition, page 2053). "Jesus was alluding here to ministerial labour in the power of the Holy Spirit (by believers), which would be "greater" than Jesus' in its geographical and numeric extension!" (*The Spirit of Reformation Study Bible*, 2003 edition, page 1732). So, while it is clear that the "greater works" that Jesus referred to was in terms of an unprecedented 'Jerusalem to Samaria, and to the Ends of the World' Acts 1:8 evangelism explosion unseen in the days of Jesus (who never left the boundaries of Israel as an adult), these modern day false teachers who are into forensic prophecy and miracle-money twist those words to sway a generation that does not know the Bible adequately.

ABOVE THE PASSAGE

GREATER WORK IS PROCLAIMING THE UNIQUENESS OF JESUS WITH PROOF

To understand the correct meaning of what Jesus meant when he said that those who believe in him would do greater works than him (in John 14:12), we must read ABOVE that verse as well. This is what we read in the verse above John 14:12, which is John 14:11 – "Believe me when I say that I am in the Father and the Father is in me; or at least believe on the evidence of the works themselves." Here Jesus claimed to be God and said that he offered his miracles as one of the proofs – though not the most important proof - that he indeed was God. The Jewish audience that Jesus spoke to, instantly understood that Jesus was making himself "equal" to God the Father (whom he called 'the Father' here). A few verses above, in John 14:6, Jesus claimed to be the only way to God – the only way to the Father! So, in the verses above John 14:12, Jesus basically gave the Gospel and an apologia for it, a defence for it. So, from the context above John 14:12, we can say this: those who believe in Jesus will do his work of presenting the unique Gospel and an apologia for the same, in a far wider scale (to more people in more locations). By doing that, they would do "greater" works than Jesus himself!

THE MIRACLES JESUS DID VS THE MIRACLES WE DO NOW

Also please note that there is a big difference between the miracles that Jesus did to prove his divinity than the miracles believers can do here and now. Jesus never faced any healing failure because he perfectly knew God the Father's mind about any miracle request. For example, he knew that God's time for John the Baptist was over, that's why he never went to raise John the Baptist from the dead even when he heard that he was unfairly

murdered. But that is not the case with us. We can pray for miracles. These miracles will happen subject to the Will of God. By his exemplary prayer in the Garden of Gethsemane, Jesus taught us, his followers, to sign out of every prayer – including prayers for miracles – using this phrase, 'not my will but your will be done'.

WHEN MY US VISA WAS REJECTED

God heard my prayer when I prayed for my daughter who was declared without heart-beat in her mom's womb (in 2007). He raised her up. She brings so much joy to our lives! But God did not hear my desperate prayer that my US Visa should be stamped when I faced the concerned Visa Officer in 2010 (an Organisation paid for my visa processing fees, was willing to pay for my flight to the US and back; I had to make a presentation in a Christian Conference there). There have been so many occasions when I have prayed for a miracle but the eagerly expected miracle not happen. If my fellow ministers of the Gospel spoke honestly, they would say that, this was their story, as well.

ALL THE BIBLE IN THE LIGHT OF THIS PASSAGE

CONSIDER WHAT THE REST OF THE BIBLE ALSO SAYS

We must not only see above and below any Bible passage to understand its right meaning – we must also see what the entire Bible says about what that passage seems to teach. Before we conclude what a particular Bible passage teaches, we must consider all that the Bible from Genesis to Revelation says about the topic/issues which that single passage under study throws light upon. For example, we cannot dogmatically conclude that the length of the millennium is 1000 literal years based on just one passage found in Revelation 20. We must check what the whole Bible teaches about the length of the Kingdom of Jesus/the Son of David.

'MONEY CREDIT INTO YOUR ANDHRA BANK ACCOUNT'

What about miracle money multiplication? I watched a social media video of a popular miracle money preacher from Kerala. He was preaching in Chennai in a meeting where a popular worship leader joined him on stage to interpret his Malayalam message into Tamil. The man who was called "Papa"/"Prophet" by the popular worship leader – claiming revelation from the Holy Spirit when he was praying – talked about a credit of 68 lakhs into the Andhra Bank account of someone in the audience before a specified date (a few months down the line). The audience was stunned. And he prophesied that the man in the audience this prophecy was targeted at (whom we shall call "Dorai" for convenience), carried an Andhra Bank Visa Debit Card in predominantly blue colour. Promptly, Mr. Dorai fished out an Andhra Bank Visa Debit Card with the specifications as mentioned by the "papa Prophet". The audience burst into raptures. The interpreter-worship leader threw his mike in the air and

caught it again, exuding the excitement of a cricket fielder who had taken a World Cup winning catch! Some time back, in a Chennai church meeting, the visiting "prophet" preacher accurately "revealed" (what the Holy Spirit supposedly revealed to him) the phone number of a person related to the man he pulled up from the audience much to the excitement of the hosting pastor. Meetings of this type, where these kinds of "forensic prophecies" are the main attraction are organized in different locations and hosted by different churches.

Was Jesus envisioning meetings like these (with a 'forensic prophecy' focus) when he said in John 14:12 that those who believe in him would do greater miracles than him? Absolutely not. We have no record of such a focus in miracle-doing in the book of Acts.

In the book of Acts, the apostles prayed for the sick. They looked to God when they were in a crisis (like when they were about to drown). They looked to God when they were imprisoned. And God responded as per his will (as we saw above). The miracles did not always happen. And when they did not, they did not frown. But they felt "fantastic" – their joy-level did not drop – and they kept doing what God had called them to do. When the Apostles needed money for any project, they did NOT start praying for miracle-money miracles. Instead they organised a collection for specific needs in the church universal (Rom. 15:26; I Cor. 16:1-2). 'They (the early church believers) sold property and possessions to give to anyone who had need' (Acts 2:45; Acts

4:34). Churches supported missionaries who travelled and ministered to multiple congregations, financially (2 Cor. 11:9; Phil. 4:15-16).

WHAT THE APOSTLE DID WHEN THEY NEEDED MONEY

Let me repeat this as this is important - when there was need for money, they did NOT pray for the multiplication of the money they had. They sold properties they had and brought the proceeds to the apostles (Acts 4:37). They picked up jobs that paid them like tent-making (Acts 18:1-3). They encouraged believers to give to the Lord instead of just receiving from Him (Acts 20:35). **Not once, did they pray for the money they had, to multiply!** We must copy the apostles who followed Jesus because of Paul's repeated call to follow Christ as he and other apostles followed Christ (1 Cor. 11:1; 4:16; Phil. 3:17; 4:9; 1 Thess.1:6; 2 Thess. 3:9). So, we must follow the apostles' way of doing greater things than Jesus and that does not include miracles like miracle money multiplication or forensic prophecy.

FORENSIC PREDICTIONS HAPPEN EVEN IN SECULAR TV SHOWS

In fact, forensic predictions routinely happen in secular, non-Christian TV shows like *America's Got Talent* (Just Google 'Colin Cloud'). Magicians who are not Christ followers do them with regularity. That is not something

to be surprised about. Don't we see Pharaoh's magicians do miracles in the book of Exodus (7:11,22; 8:7)? Did not even the Lord Jesus himself predict that "False messiahs and false prophets will appear and perform signs and wonders to deceive, if possible, even the elect!" (Mark 13:22)? Does not Jesus himself warn about those who would prophecy, drive out demons, and even do many miracles in his name who won't enter his Kingdom – make it to heaven but would rather go to hell - in the Gospels (Matt. 7:21-23)? Don't we see a demon-possessed young girl doing the same in the book of Acts, before the apostles sent the demon packing from her (Acts 16:16-18)? Doesn't Apostle Paul predict that the Anti-Christ (called "the Lawless one") will do "signs and wonders" that "serve the lie" and "deceive those who are perishing" in the last days (2 Thess. 2:9-10)? In the book of Revelation, don't we read of "demonic spirits which work miracles" (Rev.16:14 NLT)? Don't we see the Ultimate False Prophet part of the False Trinity who shows up in Revelation doing miraculous signs to delude those who receive the mark of the Beast (the Antichrist), only to land in eternal hell (Rev. 19:20)?

Doing miracles is not a proof that God approves what you do, for even Satan and his team can do the same (as seen above). Doing miracles will not even guarantee someone a place in heaven (as seen above). So do not believe and go after this group of so-called ministers of God who do these kinds of miracles. Stay rooted in the Word of God! Such ministers of the Gospel who flout the written Word of God and obvious biblical pattern are dangerous because they can really take you to hell with them! So, be wary of them!

WHY DO MIRACLE-MONEY PREACHERS CHARGE REGISTRATION FEES FOR THEIR MEETINGS?

Also have you not wondered why there is a registration fee for these meetings where there is supposed abundance of "miracle money" miracles? Why don't the organizers pray over their own bank accounts/ministry bank accounts so that there would be a dramatic money-multiplication which would be enough to meet the expenses of these meetings? You see, when believers are ready to be fooled, there would be no dearth of preachers who will be ready to fool them! This is the repeated, sad story when one goes through Church History. We must be 'wise as serpents' (Matt. 10:16) even as we deal with those who cooperate with the Ancient Serpent, the Devil, to promote devilish doctrines (Rev. 20:2)!

CHAPTER 22

THE BIBLE ON PESTILENCES PUT IN THE OUTLINE C-O-R-O-N-A: AN ANTI-HYPER-SUPERNATUALISM BIBLE STUDY



Transcription of a message the author shared online on 22 March 2020 via social media

EVEN CLERGY DIED OF CORONA!

Several Hyper-Supernatural servants of God quoted from Psalm 91 to teach that believers will not be affected by the Corona Virus, leave alone die because of it. But many believers did die of the Corona Pandemic. Dr. Darren Slade writes, 'The FaithX Project documented a total of 118 clergy

deaths that were directly related to the Coronavirus'! Not just believers, even pastors died of the Corona Pandemic – we know that!

As we have already pointed out in this book, it is dangerous to formulate a doctrine from just one passage in the Bible. I want to use the acronym C-O-R-O-N-A to teach what the WHOLE Bible, God's own Word, has to say about plagues and pestilences.

C – CREATOR CAUSED PLAGUES

The Bible repeatedly attributes the origin of plagues and pestilences to God. If the Devil causes a plague (In Luke 13:16, Satan causes a disease which could have been a result of a viral attack on the human body – see also Mark 9:17; 9:25 and Acts 10:38), he needs to get God's permission (see Job 1:12). God can permit the Devil to operate. God's Sovereignty is a major doctrine of the Bible, and no one can question God with a WHY (see Dan. 4:35).

The first reference to a plague is found in Genesis 12:17 when the Lord afflicted Pharaoh and his house in Egypt because Pharoah took Abram's wife Sarai (Gen. 12:10-20).

The next reference is Exodus 8:2, where the Lord plagues Egypt with frogs because Pharaoh would not release the Israelites from their bondage (Moses was their leader and he wrote the first 5 books of the Bible under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit).

In Exodus 9:3, it is the plague on livestock caused by the hand of God. In verse 14, we read that God sends all plagues on the Egyptian people to proclaim that "there is none like me (God) in all the earth." In all, there were 10 God-caused plagues that affected the Egyptians.

Exodus 32:35 states that God sent a plague because Aaron made a golden calf which the people of God, Israelites, worshipped. **They worshipped the CREATION rather than the CREATOR, attracting a plague-judgment from God.**

Numbers 11:33 tells us that even before the Israelites had fully consumed the flesh of the quail, God sent a plague because their perpetual complaints and ingratitude triggered God's anger.

In Numbers 16:46, Moses tells Aaron to carry a censer, take fire from the altar and use the incense as an atonement for the congregation since God's wrath had caused a plague.

The Bible is a library of 66 books and as we comb through it, we certainly see God causing plagues!

RAIN AS THE SEMEN OF BAAL!

Next, we come to Numbers 25 where we read of the religious prostitution of the men of Israel with Moabite women. These women were involved in the temple of Baal and Baal worship of the Israelites. The theology of Baal worship was gross: 'have sex with the temple prostitutes who lived around the Baal temple; the so-called Baal god would watch you do this; he will get sexually excited; he will masturbate in that excitement; his semen will flow down following the ensuing sexual climax – that is actually rain; so, if you want rain for your crops, visit a Baal temple and have sex with a Baal prostitute' (Old Testament scholar Walter C. Kaiser's notes put in my own words; see Hos. 4:12-14 & Amos 2:7)! Balaam, in Numbers 31:16 counselled the Israelites to worship the idol Baal-Peor in-effect (by a sex-dance with the women of Moab, see Revelation 2:14). And the consequence was a God-wrath-triggered (see Num. 25:4) plague that killed 24,000 (Num. 25:9).

Deuteronomy 28:59 records the farewell speech of Moses to Israelites before their entry to the Promised Land where he repeats the law and warns them of the fearful plagues that will affect their children and will last long and afflict them with sore sicknesses. In Deuteronomy 32:24, God warns the disobedient people that he will send hunger, heat, beasts, and poisonous serpents as agents of destruction. At the beginning of creation, the serpent is Satan's slave and speaks to Eve. However, in Matthew 10:16, God says "be ye therefore as wise as serpents".

"I PLAGUED EGYPT!"

Joshua 22:17 is a reminder of the plague on the congregation, triggered by sexual immorality. Joshua 24:5 in the ESV states, "I plagued Egypt" (I, stands for Yahweh). I Samuel 4:8 tells us how even the pagans realized God's protection over the Israelites when it came to plagues.

Psalm 78:50 speaks of a pestilence that God delivered his people to. In Zechariah 14:12, the Lord says that a plague will affect those who war against Jerusalem. In Zechariah 14:18, the Lord says that he will smite heathens with a plague, if they do not observe the Feast of Tabernacles/Booths.

The Feast of Booths/Tabernacles is a Jewish Festival which brings to memory of the Israelite journey through the wilderness in temporary shelters. As New Testament believers we need not observe the Feast of Tabernacles (Heb. 8:13). But we must constantly recall the spiritual meaning of this Jewish feast which is to rededicate ourselves to the spiritual journey with Christ through this temporary world as visitors (TLB), aliens (EHV), foreigners (NASB), strangers (HCSB), exiles (NIV), temporary residents (GW), pilgrims (KJ21), refugees (GNT) and sojourners (ESV) [1 Pet. 2:11]. We should remember that we are passing through, to reach a yonder city with no plagues (Rev. 21:4). As Jim Reeves sang, "this world is not my home, I'm just a passing through."

THE PLAGUE-CAUSING GOD OF THE NEW TESTAMENT!

In the New Testament, Revelation 18:8 speaks of God's judgement on establishments that are anti-God. Babylon is symbolic of this. The plagues will come in a single day – death, fire, famine. Revelation 22:18 warns with clarity that in response to people's rebellion, God can choose to send plagues. So, don't let a false teacher tell you that the plague-causing God is a God of the Old Testament. We very much meet him even in the New Testament!

With the help of the above references, we understand that the plague is CREATOR CAUSED. Yes, Satan can be given permission by God to cause plagues/diseases. But even then, the ultimate responsibility for causing a plague for reasons best known to him, lies with God. Without God giving permission for the same, no plague could have occurred – including the Corona Virus Pandemic – in the first place!

We are using the outline C-O-R-O-N-A to understand what the Bible teaches about plagues. C for Creator-Caused Plagues. O is the next letter under consideration!

O-OBLITERATED BY THE CROSS ON WHICH JESUS DIED? IS THAT TRUE ABOUT PLAGUES?

THE BIBLE VERSES SUGGESTS THAT BELIEVERS CANNOT HAVE PLAGUES AMONG THEM?

Obliterated means cancelled. Does the Bible teach that none of the believers will be attacked/affected by the virus? Is there such a theology in the Bible? This is the question. Exodus 12:13 ('The blood will be a sign for you on the houses where you are, and when I see the blood, I will pass over you. No destructive plague will touch you when I strike Egypt') speaks of the blood as an anti-dote for the plague. Revelation 18:4 refers to Babylon, which is symbolic of the system of evil and sin. We should say bye-bye to Satan, come under the blood of Jesus, and join the spiritual church. Should we, as believers, never experience a plague? Plagues are not for God's children says Numbers 8:19. Can Numbers 8:19 ('From among all the Israelites, I have given the Levites as gifts to Aaron and his sons to do the work at the tent of meeting on behalf of the Israelites and to make atonement for them so that no plague will strike the Israelites when they go near the sanctuary') be applied to believers of today? Psalm 91:10 is assuring – "There shall no evil befall thee, neither shall any plague come nigh thy dwelling. Revelation 18:4 says this: "be ye not partakers of her sins, and that ye receive not of her plagues." So, the question is this: will a believer who lives a holy life be spared from the Corona Virus infection as Revelation 18:4 seems to suggest?

Accelerated, passionate, cultic preaching, originally from South Africa, also echoed in Sri Lanka, India, propagated immortality which said that if you believe in Jesus, you will not die (experience physical death). Is this teaching correct?

THE FOUR 'D'S WHICH EVERY BELIEVER NEEDS TO GRAPPLE WITH

There are 4 things that every believer must grapple with as long as they are on this side of eternity: defilement, disease, death, and demonic attack.

THE 'ALREADY BUT NOT YET' THEOLOGY: IGNORE THIS AND YOU LAND UP IN FALSE TEACHING!

DEFILEMENT: Thanks to the work done on the Cross during his first coming, Jesus gave us power over defilement; he made us holy (I John 1:7-9; Heb. 9:14). Being cleansed from defilement does not give us the permission to use abusive words or get back to our pet sin, say porn-watching. We must gain victory over every kind of sinful habit (1 John 3:5-6).

ALREADY HOLY, BUT NOT YET HOLY!

The Bible reiterates about 300 times that Jesus is coming again. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says that Jesus has already made us righteous. But 1 John 1:8 ('If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us') states that we are not righteous. If we claimed that, we are lying, this verse says. James 3:2 says that we (believers) stumble in many ways. It is a paradox. We are "already" holy, but "not yet" holy! This is what is called

the 'already but not yet' theology – a theology that we must take time to understand! If we don't understand this theological truth which is soundly biblical, we will get into dangerous false teachings!

GRACE OF GOD, NOT A CREDIT CARD FOR SIN!

Grace of God is not a credit card to sin. We are not perfect, and we do sin, but must come back to Jesus in genuine repentance and confession (Rom. 2:4-5; 1 John 1:8-9). Even the Great Apostle Paul did slip into sin in his Christian Pilgrimage. This is the contemporary English rendering of one occasion when Paul sinned after he became a believer. But please notice that Paul said 'sorry' after the sinful slip-up. Here it is: 'Paul surveyed the members of the council with a steady gaze, and then said his piece: "Friends, I've lived with a clear conscience before God all my life, up to this very moment." That set the Chief Priest Ananias off. He ordered his aides to slap Paul in the face. Paul shot back, "God will slap you down! What a fake you are! You sit there and judge me by the Law and then break the Law by ordering me to be slapped around!" The aides were scandalized: "How dare you talk to God's Chief Priest like that!" Paul acted surprised. "How was I to know that he was the Chief Priest? He doesn't act like a Chief Priest. You're right, the Scripture does say, 'Don't speak abusively to a ruler of the people.'

Only in the New Heaven and New Earth [which is created only after the Second Coming of Christ (Rev. 19:11)] will there be complete absence of sin (Rev. 21:27, 'Nothing impure will ever enter it, nor will anyone who does what is shameful or deceitful, but only those whose names are written in the Lamb's book of life').

So, till the Second Coming we must keep on putting to death the acts of the flesh empowered by the Spirit (Rom. 8:13). So, in this sense, we are already holy but not yet holy!

DISEASE: The 'already but not yet' theology is also seen in diseases.

PROVISION MADE FOR HEALING, YET DISEASE PERSISTS!

Even though God has worked out the solution on the Cross, the provision for our healing, some do not get healed for mysterious reasons. Isaiah 53:5 – With His stripes we are healed. 1 Peter 2:24 - By whose stripes ye were healed. Yes, after the first coming Jesus made provision for our healing at the Cross. However, for some mysterious higher reason not all of us are healed here and now. 2 Timothy 4:20 - Paul left his fellow labourer Trophimus at Miletus sick, even though he had healed sick and possessed people, with handkerchiefs/aprons.

Matthew 8:16,17 records that Jesus healed ALL who were sick in a particular area fulfilling the prophecy of Isaiah 53:5. This is in line with Exodus 23:25 which says, "I will take sickness away from the midst of thee."

ELISHA PERFORMED DOUBLE THE NUMBER OF MIRACLES THAN ELIJAH. BUT....

Let us hit the rewind button on the characters of Elijah and Elisha. Elijah had performed 14 miracles –

1) Causing the rain to cease for 3 1/2 years (1 Ki. 17:1)

2) Being fed by the ravens (1 Ki. 17:4)

3) Miracle of the barrel of meal and cruse of oil (1 Ki. 17:14)

4) Resurrection of the widow's son (1 Ki. 17:22)

5) Calling of fire from heaven on the altar (1 Ki. 18:38)

6) Causing it to rain (1 Ki. 18:45)

7) Prophecy that Ahab's sons would all be destroyed (1 Ki. 21:22)

8) Prophecy that Jezebel would be eaten by dogs (1 Ki. 21:23)

9) Prophecy that Ahaziah would die of his illness (2 Ki. 1:4)

10) Calling fire from heaven upon the first 50 soldiers (2 Ki. 1:10)

11) Calling fire from heaven upon the second 50 soldiers (2 Ki. 1:12)

12) Parting of the Jordan (2 Ki. 2:8)

13) Prophecy that Elisha should have a double portion of his spirit (2 Ki. 2:10)

14) Being caught up to heaven in a whirlwind (2 Ki. 2:11)

Miracle after miracle and healing after healing – 14 as per this count and listing by David Pyles – but one day, he was taken in a whirlwind to heaven. He did not live on this earth forever! But his understudy who incidentally wanted double-portion of his mentor's anointing did 28 listed miracles! Here they are (thanks again to David Pyles):

1) Parting of the Jordan (2 Ki. 2:14)

2) Healing of the waters (2 Ki. 2:21)

3) Curse of the she bears (2 Ki. 2:24)

4) Filling of the valley with water (2 Ki. 3:17)

5) Deception of the Moabites with the valley of blood (2 Ki. 3:22)

6) Miracle of the vessels of oil (2 Ki. 4:4)

7) Prophecy that the Shunammite woman would have a son (2 Ki. 4:16)

8) Resurrection of the Shunammite's son (2 Ki. 4:34)

9) Healing of the gourds (2 Ki. 4:41)

10) Miracle of the bread (2 Ki. 4:43)

11) Healing of Naaman (2 Ki. 5:14)

12) Perception of Gehazi's transgression (2 Ki. 5:26)

13) Cursing Gehazi with leprosy (2 Ki. 5:27)

14) Floating of the axe head (2 Ki. 6:6)

15) Prophecy of the Syrian battle plans (2 Ki. 6:9)

16) Vision of the chariots (2 Ki. 6:17)

17) Smiting the Syrian army with blindness (2 Ki. 6:18)

18) Restoring the sight of the Syrian army (2 Ki. 6:20)

19) Prophecy of the end of the great famine (2 Ki. 7:1)

20) Prophecy that the scoffing nobleman would see, but not partake of, the abundance (2 Ki. 7:2)

21) Deception of the Syrians with the sound of chariots (2 Ki. 7:6)

22) Prophecy of the seven-year famine (2 Ki. 8:1)

23) Prophecy of Benhadad's untimely death (2 Ki. 8:10)

24) Prophecy of Hazael's cruelty to Israel (2 Ki. 8:12)

25) Prophecy that Jehu would smite the house of Ahab (2 Ki. 9:7)

26) Prophecy that Joash would smite the Syrians at Aphek (2 Ki. 13:17)

27) Prophecy that Joash would smite Syria thrice but not consume it (2 Ki. 13:19)

28) Resurrection of the man touched by his bones (2 Ki. 13:21)

YET MIRACLE-WORKER ELISHA DIED OF A SICKNESS!

Yet, Elisha, the mighty miracle-worker died of sickness (see 2 Kings 13:14). This is the story of all servants of God who have been graciously used in the ministry of healing. God used them to heal people with the power of the Spirit in accordance to his Will, but when their time came, all of them died!

BILLY GRAHAM: BOTH A HEALING-INSTRUMENT AND A PERSON WHO NEEDED HEALING!

My maternal aunt, **Mrs. Florence Williams**, was a just a teen, when **Billy Graham** preached in Palayamkottai in South India in 1956. She told me that she knows people who were healed when they merely touched the radios which broadcasted his simple gospel message where there was no focus on healing! But we know Billy Graham died at the age of 99, his body and memories ravaged by Parkinson's disease. Grant Wacker writing for the *Washington Post* on 21 February 2018 wrote this about Billy Graham's declining health: 'Aging quieted his trademark machine-gun sermons into talks that seemed more like fireside chats. He readily admitted that he

"yelled" less, and that he had come to favor less demanding indoor auditoriums over the outdoor stadiums that had propelled him to international fame. Yet serious illness took its inevitable toll. He collapsed while speaking in Toronto but climbed out of a hospital bed several days later to preach to a Sky Dome record crowd of 73,500 on the final night of an evangelistic crusade. More significant was the **Parkinson's disease** (later diagnosed as hydrocephalus). "You know what happens when you get Parkinson's? Your handwriting gets illegible and your sermons longer," he quipped. But his wife, Ruth Bell Graham, saw things more soberly. "This Parkinson's is no laughing matter," she judged. "Overnight he has become an old man."'

DR. NABEEL QUERESHI: DESPERATE PRAYERS FOR HIS HEALING

We also know that the apologist, Dr. Nabeel Quereshi who was working with Ravi Zacharias International Ministries, died of cancer at the age of 34 on 16 September 2017 (despite, literally the whole English-comfortable Christian world on social media, praying for his immediate healing). Nabeel even prayed this way (in-effect): "Lord, you can raise another preacher-apologist of the Gospel to the Muslims; but I am the only father to my little daughter Ayah! So, please have mercy and heal me from this terrible cancer!" But healing did not come! God released healing in the Old and New Testaments but here and now there is sickness, suffering, pain and the occasional healing/miracle/breakthrough. Plagues and pestilences that take human lives fall in

the category of suffering. They keep us humble. We are not in-charge of the earth. The Sovereign God is in control.

WHY INSTANT HEALING DID NOT HAPPEN IN THE BIBLE NARRATIVES

Paul, the author of many New Testament books, had a thorn in his flesh – some kind of ailment causing pain. He pleaded three times with God to take it away. But it remained. God told Paul, "My grace is sufficient for thee" (2 Cor. 12:9). 1 Peter 2:24 reiterates that we were healed by His stripes. But he still had to deal with the thorn in his flesh. If 1 Peter 2:24 means that we cannot be sick as believers, Paul would not have had the thorn in the flesh, staying on. The thorn remained, however. It was not removed miraculously. So, we conclude that believers can be sick, for reasons best known to God. John 9, the first few verses, indicate this happens for the glory of God. 2 Corinthians 12:7 indicates this happens so that we do not become conceited. When believers think, "We are gods!" that is being conceited. But I am human. I depend on God and others and this ushers in a beautiful, mutual dependence, and a spirit of teamwork. The area in which I am weak may be the strength of another person. There is a great spiritual blessing in our fragile spiritual existence!

THE 'ALREADY, BUT NOT YET' OF HEALING

While 1 Peter 2:24 teaches that Jesus has 'already' made provision for our healing, passages such as Romans 8:23 (which says that we await redemption of our bodies) teach that we are 'not yet' healed. After the Second Coming of Jesus (recorded in Revelation 19), there will be a time when there will be no more pain – no more disease (Rev. 21:4).

We have talked about Defilement in terms of the already but not yet paradigm. We have talked about Disease in terms of the already but not yet paradigm. Now to the next topic – Death.

DEATH:

THE SECOND COMING OF JESUS AND ITS CONNECTION TO DEATH

There are 2 stages in the coming of Christ – the first coming. If Jesus had planned to finish all his work about us (like defeating death) in the first coming itself, he would not have told that us that He is coming again. But he told us that he is coming again! **Jesus' First coming helps us overcome the 'fear of dying' (Heb. 2:15). Jesus' Second Coming brings us to a period in which believers will overcome death itself (In Revelation 19, Second Coming of Jesus becomes a reality and in Revelation 21:4, the phrase 'no more death' is used to describe life in New Heaven and Earth).** The fear of death is released, thanks to Jesus' work during his

first coming. The first coming of Christ deals with one dimension of death but the second coming deals with death in all dimensions. Only post his second coming will we receive a glorified, death-free, immortal body (1 Cor. 15:23; Phil. 3:20-21 says that our 'lowly' body – our sinprone and disease-prone lowly body – will be transformed into Christ's glorious body – a body with no sin or sickness – when Jesus comes again). The reward for giving up all and loving Jesus supremely is "Eternal" life (a deathless life) and this blessing is only available in the "life to come" (Luke 18:30) – not before that! We have "already" overcome fear of death (Heb. 2:15) but "not yet" experienced a total win over death as death is the last enemy which Christ will defeat "at his coming" (1 Cor. 15:23,26).

TALKING ABOUT A FORMER PORN-STAR TO REMIND OURSELVES THAT....

Some cult false teachers quote John 11:25,26 to teach immortality on earth. When Jesus said that those who believe in me will not die, we must check the context to understand the meaning of the word 'death'. If we say 'Sunny' – it could mean the weather, or it could mean the Indian Cricket Opener and the first to get to 10,000 Test runs (**Sunil Gavaskar**), it could mean the Nissan Car model (a sedan named **Nissan Sunny** released in India in the year 2011), or it could mean, **the weather! The context will determine what "Sunny" means!** In the same way the context of the word 'death' as Jesus used in John 11:25-26 indicates that he was talking about spiritual death. In Luke 9:20, Jesus says, "Let the dead bury the dead!" **He was referring to the spiritually**

dead people who will refuse to follow Jesus because they await the actual physical death of their parents! In Luke 15:24-25, Jesus referred to the alive-physically post repentance but once upon a time, dead-spiritually prodigal son. So, John 11:25-26 cannot be talking about immortality on earth (if you look at the context of these passages and map those with the rest of the Bible, you cannot believe in immortality on earth, here and now). It is talking about overcoming spiritual death and ultimately escaping second death which is hell punishment (Rev. 21:8). There is no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus (Rom. 8:1 KJV). There is no danger of second death when you believe and abide in Christ Jesus!

We are talking about **the 'already' but 'not yet' theology of the Bible** with regard to Defilement, Disease, Death and finally, Demons!

DEMONS:

THE DYING THIEF UNDERSTOOD THIS 'ALREADY BUT NOT YET' THEOLOGY!

Matthew 12:28 - Devils are cast out by the spirit of God. When this happened in Jesus' ministry the Kingdom of God has been established and Satan has been defeated. When Jesus died on the Cross the Devil was "already" defeated and shamed on the Cross. Read Colossians 2:13-15. Jesus defeated the devil on the Cross. But the final defeat of the Devil is still in the 'not yet' category. It is pending. The devil is still active deceiving

people and nations (1 Pet. 5:8). "Already but not yet theology" tells us that the work of God is inaugurated in His First Coming but completed in the Second Coming. Matthew 25:31-34 speaks about the separation of people and nations just as the shepherd-King (this is surely talking about Jesus) divides the sheep and goats (judges both believers and non-believers). God will complete the establishment of the kingdom of God after the Second Coming. So, His kingdom is still coming, in one sense. Luke 17:21 says that the Kingdom (of God) is (already) in you! But Luke 23:42,43 is a reference to the "not yet" kingdom. The dying thief, in that passage, says "Remember me when you come into your Kingdom" and Jesus responds "You will be with me in Paradise today." The Dying thief rightly had the 'already but not yet' theology and made the right request. Jesus did NOT tell him: "What rubbish are you talking about. I have already come into my Kingdom, 100%. What do you mean 'when you come into your Kingdom?' implying something I need to do in the future?" Mark 13:26 and Mark 14:62 talks about the coming Kingdom of Jesus in power by referring to Jesus coming in power in the clouds! Both these verses use the phrase 'you will see' implying that there is a Kingdom that is to come!

SATAN HAS NOT GONE TO HELL ALREADY, MIND YOU!

Satan is still active and can cause us harm if we are not alert and will only be sent to hell after the Second Coming of Jesus [Rev. 19:11 (Second Coming), Rev. 19: 20 (hell for the miracle-working False Prophet and Antichrist) and Rev. 20:10 (hell for the Devil)]. Note that we must not get carried away by false teachers who

say, "Look at my miracles!" because the ultimate False Prophet, one who is part of the False Trinity will also work miracles!

BEWARE OF THIS HELLISH FALSE TEACHING!

There is a group working with missionary zeal on social media that circulates teaching that we have victory over disease (so you can't have diseases), death (so you can't die now), and demons (and Satan poses no danger to you now). In the light of the above paragraphs, what they teach is hellish false teaching. I wonder why this group does not say, "Jesus died for our sins on the Cross, so we must not sin anymore!" But they say, "Jesus died for us on the Cross and we must not die anymore!" Their shallow, double-standards-embracing arguments tells the larger story of how they love "Balaam's wages" (2 Pet. 2:15) and so will only preach a message that will "tickle" people's ears (2 Tim. 4:3-4)! [Of course, the right teaching is this: Jesus died for our sins on the Cross and we can have power over sin (1 John 3:5-6), though only Jesus is sinlessly perfect (1 John 1:8)!]

WHEN WILL PSALM 91:10 BE A REALITY?

Balance Psalm 91:10 ('no evil shall be allowed to befall you, no plague come near your tent') with Hosea 13:14

where the prophet who served Yahweh even before the first coming of Jesus happens, foretells the future time after Second Coming where-in a Psalm 91:10 kind of protection will be a 100% reality! Second-coming effect heralding Hosea 13:14 is quoted by Paul in second-coming heralding reality talked about 1 Corinthians 15:55 – "O death, where is your victory? O death, where is your sting?" [we will become immortal (I Cor. 15:54) and will never ever die, have 100% victory over physical death (I Cor. 15:55) when Jesus comes again (I Cor. 15:23)]. In the absolute sense, Psalm 91:10 (no plague shall come near thy dwelling), will be ultimately true only in the New Heaven and Earth (Rev. 21:4) post the Second Coming of Jesus (Rev. 19:11) and not before that, in an absolute sense. While on earth, before the Second Coming, we can experience the 'first-fruits' of the promises found in passages like Psalm 91:10 (see Rom. 8:23). But the 'full-fruit' will come only after the Second Coming!
What do you mean by 'first-fruits'? May I explain this via a personal
story?

THE DAY WHEN I FELT THAT I WAS CORONA POSITIVE...

During the pandemic, one morning I felt that I had the Virus. But I prayed and prayed. I did not even tell my family knowing that they would fear the worst. Within an hour, I felt fine. God had healed me! Psalm 91:10 was a reality in my life. However, this did not mean, I can never ever die of a disease or an accident. I may die in such

unfortunate circumstances. But once I reach heaven, I will have no disease or death. I would have graduated from receiving 'first-fruit' now to 'full-fruit' in the next life!

We are using the outline C-O-R-O-N-A to learn what the Bible teaches about Plagues.

C-reator-Caused plagues; O-bliterated by the Cross plagues here and now (absolutely not!); now for the third letter in this acronym, R….

R - REDEMPTION FROM THE PLAGUES

What can be humanly done to stop a plague (knowing ultimately it is God's prerogative to do so)?

1. SACRIFICIAL ENTRY INTO GOD'S PRESENCE:

In 2 Samuel 24, we read about David's pride and arrogance when he wanted to count the troops instead of counting on God. God sends a pestilence and 70,000 men died. A sacrifice had to be made in a particular piece of land for the plague sent by God to stop. That piece of land was available for free for King David. But he wanted to pay for it. "I will not offer to the Lord, burnt offerings that cost me nothing!" – he said (2 Sam. 24:24). Then finally the altar was built. The sacrifice was offered. The Lord answered the prayer and then the plague stopped.

We must increase our prayer time and kneel instead of watching different screens all day and night (I am talking about the phone, iPad and the TV). Spend time with family around His word, in prayer. We can fast and pray and say "NO" to the things we love with a sacrificial David-like spirit; we can give sacrificially and support missionary organizations. Then, God may choose to stop the plague!

Numbers 16:21 onwards speaks of the grumbling against Moses, the rumbling, and the humbling of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram. The earth swallowed them up and their houses. A fire consumed 250 men that offered incense. 14,700 died from the plague. Moses begged for mercy. Aaron offered incense as an atonement which is symbolic of the prayers and intercessions of saints. Revelation 5:8 speaks of golden vials full of odours which are the prayers of saints. Yes, we have a biblical warrant to intercede!

AN OPPORTUNITY TO INTERCEDE ALONGSIDE A REMNANT VIA ZOOM

We as the Grabbing the Google Generation from Gehenna Mission ministry have a monthly fasting and prayer time over Zoom where we focus on a time of intercession named "Fountain of Tears against Mountain of Fears". In this Wednesday night online event, we spend a little over an hour, praying for the nations, our nation (India), the google generation (modern youth) and for the tensions of those who join the Zoom (for their personal

needs in other words – need for a job, for a baby, for peace in marriage, etc). You are welcome to join this remnant in case you want to. Find out more details via our social media handles.

What can be humanly done to stop a plague (knowing ultimately it is God's prerogative to do so)? First, Sacrificial entry into God's presence.

2. SEPARATION FROM THE WORLD

Revelation 18:4 warns us not to partake in the sins of Babylon, lest we share in her plague. When we live a life of holiness and separation, then God may choose to stop the plague!

Others use foul language; we too use foul language. Others watch soft porn via Netflix, we too do the same! This CAN'T be done! For the plague to end, we must choose holiness and separation from the world. Then God may choose to end the plague!

What can be humanly done to stop a plague (knowing ultimately it is God's prerogative to do so)? First, Sacrificial entry into God's presence. Second, Separation from the world.

3. PROCLAMATION OF THE STANDARDS OF GOD'S HOLINESS:

We should preach the truth about God's holy standards from His Word taking the cue from Phinehas. In

Numbers 25, we read of Phinehas and how he removed evil and stopped the plague which killed 24,000. He killed people involved in sexual immorality. We should turn away from filthy thinking and adultery. God's word is the sword which divides holy and sinful people. Psalm 106:29 speaks of the outbreak of the plague. "They provoked him to anger with their inventions." Phinehas literally sent a spear into a couple that was into sinful Baal worship through sexual intimacy inside the privacy of a tent (Numbers 25:6-8). As New Testament believers, we will not kill people physically that way. Instead, we will use the sharp sword of the Word of God (Heb. 4:12) and preach it to people so that their hearts are "cut" (Acts 2:37). My book, *Straight Talk*, brings such frank Bible teaching on sex, love, marriage, petting outside marriage, homosexuality, porn, phone-addiction etc.

We are using the acronym C-O-R-O-N-A to outline the message of the Bible on the topic of plagues. And the next letter to consider is O…

O – ORDERLY QUARANTINE HAS TO BE MAINTAINED DURING THE PLAGUE:

The laws of quarantine set by the local government have to be followed. Leviticus 13:36 speaks of social distancing and isolation: As long as they have the disease, they have to separate themselves from others and

stay outside the camp. We must obey in order to stop the spread of the disease. Read Leviticus 5. Cleanliness can be marred by having an issue, leprosy or touching the dead – Numbers 5:2.

Leviticus 15:6,17,18,32; Deuteronomy 23:10,11; II Kings 7:3; 15:5. Read these Scriptures that vote for orderly quarantine during times of plague or contagious disease long before medical science was as advanced as it is during our time!

In 2 Samuel 24, we read about David's sinful act of counting the people of Israel and Judah. God sends a pestilence in response and 70,000 men died (see verse 15). In 2 Kings 15:5, the king became a leper until his death and lived in a separate house. 2 Chronicles 26:21, Uzziah the king was a leper till his death and lived in a separate house. Read Leviticus 22:14.

Romans 13:1 teaches that we must obey the Government when it comes to laws passed by it that does not contradict the written Word of God. When the Government calls for a lock-down or consequent 'stay-at-home' via an order to stem a pandemic from spreading thick and fast, we Christians need to obey such orders for the larger good of the people. The mushrooming of online Christian meetings which took place during the Corona Pandemic has made it possible for us to get the Gospel/Word of God even to nations/groups closed to traditional Christian Work – thanks to the presence of the Internet world-over!

We are using the acronym C-O-R-O-N-A to outline the message of the Bible on the topic of plagues. And the next letter to consider is N…..

N – NEARNESS TO THE SECOND COMING OF JESUS:

"And great earthquakes shall be in diverse places, and famines, and pestilences; and fearful sights and great signs shall there be from heaven" – Luke 21:11.

Many signs of Jesus' second coming are seen. From 1981, 35 million lives were lost due to the HIV pandemic; 1.4 billion were infected globally by the Swine Flu in 2009. 11,325 died and 28,600 cases were reported in the world due to the West African Ebola in 2014; in 2015 the Zeke virus caused by mosquitoes affected South and Central America and in 2020 we have the Corona Virus globally. Many lives have been lost in China, Italy, U.S.A., Iran, etc.

In Deuteronomy 23:10,11, we read about an unclean man who must cleanse himself.

Cleanliness is next to Godliness. God can help us to be clean! Clean husbands will please wives and vice-versa! The Lord's coming will be like a thief at night (1 Thess. 5:2) and we must be ready for it any-second.

We are using the acronym C-O-R-O-N-A to outline the message of the Bible on the topic of plagues. And the next letter to consider is A…

A – ALIVE DURING THE TIME OF PLAGUE AND SO WE MUST...

Amos 4:10, ['"I sent plagues among you as I did to Egypt. I killed your young men with the sword, along with your captured horses. I filled your nostrils with the stench of your camps, yet you have not returned to me," declares the LORD and Luke 13:1-5 instructs us to repent or perish, turn from sin or burn in hell! We must repent from pride (Prov. 6:16-17), porn-watching (2 Sam. 11:27) and prayerlessness (I Sam. 12:23). In Luke 13:1-5, we read of Pilate who mingled the blood of some Galileans with his pagan sacrifices. Many Galileans died because of this ruler's cruelty. 18 people died because the tower of Siloam fell on them. These people did not die because they were worse sinners than the others, Jesus pointed out. Those alive, those who escaped the sword of Pilate and the crumbling stones of Siloam tower must repent and come to Jesus! That was the message of Luke 13:1-5! We are all living with the virus of sin, and if we are still alive, we must all heed to Jesus' call to REPENTANCE. Hebrews 11:25 mentions to us about the passing pleasures of sin. Are we pre-occupied with those? If we are alive today, then we should eagerly expect and wait for the Second Coming of the Lord Jesus Christ, the Savior who died for us. Without repentance, we will perish, he told us twice in Luke 13:1-5. Yes, we need to repent.

Jesus tells us about the ten lepers in Luke 17:12. Those affected by leprosy had to stay outside the city and could not touch anyone – the Old Testament records. Upon sighting any individual who came towards

them unaware of their leprous condition, they had to cry out, 'Unclean! Unclean!' (Lev. 13:45) to maintain the mandatory social distancing. But Jesus bulldozed through all those barriers and healed them all. Likewise, Jesus comes close to us, touches us, and heals all those of us reeling with the sin virus who are repenting right now! He, the only one who never ever sinned, does not turn and go away from us, because we have the sin-virus! He does not push us away! He does not want us to stay away from him, quarantining ourselves in shame and guilt! He loves us! He wants to hold us close! After all, He does not want our riddance, but only wants our repentance! Shall we come now to him who said, "the one who comes to Me I will by no means cast out" (John 6:37 NKJV)?

Stubbornly embracing sin and Satan – will only keep us in our living hell now and then take us to a literal hell later, the Bible warns (Rev. 21:7-8). Let us come to Jesus in repentance and faith, now! Would you pray this prayer, which follows, meaning it with all your heart?

PRAYER OF REPENTANCE – WOULD YOU PRAY THIS NOW?

'I HAVE A VIRUS THAT IS DEADLIER THAN CORONA'

Dear Lord Jesus, I am sorry for my sins. I have a virus deadlier than CORONA, the virus of sin. Wash me with your blood that you shed on the cross. Cleanse me right now from this. Thank you for dying for me. Thank you

for rising again. Thank you for being willing to be my friend, a friend closer than my brother. From this day onwards, I want to relate to you, love you, and follow you.

Thank you for cleansing me, washing me. Thank you that I am born again. In your name I pray.

Amen.

MY PRAYER FOR YOU

Lord, I ask for your miracle healing for all reading this chapter, healing released by your nail-pierced hand, healing according to your Will! Lord, we know you do more than we ask for or imagine! Amen.

God bless Mrs. Malini Prabakar who did the preliminary transcription work for this article using the video recording of the author's message posted on his YouTube Channel, 'Duke Jeyaraj'.

CHAPTER 23

THE MIRACLES IN THE BOOK OF ACTS AND THE MIRACLES IN OUR TIME



Evangelin Duke (The author's wife)

I have been reading a chapter from the Book of Acts daily of late. Acts has 28 chapters and a typical month has 30 days/31 days. So, that means I end up reading the full book of Acts before the month is done with a few days to spare. And I get to repeat this godly discipline every new month. I also did a fully online course on the book of Acts from South Asia College of Advanced Christian Studies (SAIACS) recently (as part of my post-graduate diploma in Biblical Leadership course with this Bangalore-based college). This gave me a chance to dig deep into this book. I learnt crucial truths about miracles from this book – lessons which contradicted what I heard about miracles from hyper-supernaturalist false teachers popular on social media. Here they are:

MIRACLES HAPPENED EVEN THROUGH DEMONIC POWER IN ACTS

The unnamed female slave Luke talks about in Acts 16:15-24 was right in her recognition of the apostolic team of preachers as the 'servants of the Most High God'. But she did that through the power of a demonic spirit, Luke, the author of Acts clearly notes (Acts 16:16). Her accurate recognition of the apostles or the precise prediction of someone's future could not be taken as a validation – validation of her 'ministry' of fortune-telling through the power of demons! David Peterson in his excellent commentary on the book of Acts writes, 'The evil spirit within the slave girl enabled her to acknowledge the true identity of the travellers ('these men are servants of the Most High God') and the true nature of their mission ('who are telling you the way to be saved')'. Because this could have led to a confusion that the God that Paul and Silas proclaimed could be Sabazinus or Zeus as well as Yahweh Sabaoth (the Lord of Hosts), Paul drove the demon inside of her 'in the name of Jesus' as if to underline that Jesus was the only God who can save (Acts 16:19) (Peterson's point). The point is this: while there can be folks galore who do miracles, these miracles cannot be an automatically seen as proof of the work of the one True Divine Being in their lives! Also, we see that the seven sons of a high priest could not drive out demons even though they used the name of Jesus (Acts 19:11-20). 'The refusal of the demons to be cast out makes it clear that the name of Jesus is not a magical incantation to be used at will' - so writes Peterson about this event. Even the name of Jesus cannot be used as a magic charm to bring healing and miracles on demand - I learn this from this narrative.

MIRACLES DID NOT HAPPEN EACH TIME THE APOSTLES PRAYED IN ACTS

God expects us to trust him when we can't trace his paths. That is the teaching we see from multiple Bible passages: Daniel 3 (Daniel's friends in the fire story), Habakkuk 3 ('Even if the fig tree....'), Job 13 (vs. 15, 'Though he slay me....), 2 Samuel 12 (vs. 20, David got back to his normal routine and worshipped the Lord after the death of his 'love' child with Bathsheba even after much prayer). This same truth is re-hammered in the book of Acts using another style. The book of Acts is the New Testament version of Habakkuk 3 – we can say that, as the book of Acts is a frank record of persecution, problems and pains faced and endured by the apostles despite unwavering faith in the Lord Jesus. *Our Daily Bread*, lists trials faced by believers and those in ministry, in the book of Acts: 'Peter and John arrested, imprisoned, and scourged (4:1-8; 5:22-41); Stephen stoned to death (6:8–7:60); Christians scattered through persecution (8:1-3); James executed (12:1-2); Paul stoned (14:19-20); Paul and Silas arrested, scourged, placed in stocks (16:22-28); Paul arrested and tried (chapters 21–28).' The epistles continues this record of problems and pain, anguish and anxiety. According to *Our Daily Bread*: 'Paul was whipped with 39 lashes 5 times, beaten with rods 3 times, shipwrecked 3 times, adrift on the sea for 24 hours, often sleepless, hungry, thirsty, and cold (2 Cor. 11:22-27); Paul was afflicted with a "thorn in the flesh" from which he was not delivered (2 Cor. 12:7-10).' The false teachers who teach that Acts talks about a totally problem-free life for the believer must have to scissor out several passages from the same book and from the epistles as it is clear from the above list!

After the fireworks of miracles, the time of darkness can begin. Yes, after the fizz of miracles, the Coke can taste flat for sometime. Yes, after the high of miracles, all of us will have to go through suffering as long as we are on this side of eternity. The apostles taught this so plainly and directly: "Anyone signing up for the kingdom of God has to go through plenty of hard times" (Acts 14:22, MSG).

THE 21 COPTIC CHRISTIANS BEHEADED BY ISIS TERRORISTS: NO SUPERNATURAL INTERVENTION WHEN THEY WERE SLAIN!

Jack Deere writes, "There is a supernatural event or a supernatural revelation or the report of such in every chapter of Acts..." While this is true, there are also clear cases of the eagerly expected miracle NOT happening in every other chapter of the book of Acts, as well. What was true in Biblical history was also found to be true in current church history, if one carefully observed this sad, shocking event: There was no supernatural intervention when the ISIS beheaded **21 Coptic Christians** who were blindfolded and made to kneel by a Libyan beachside in the year 2015 (Haven't we seen that video on our Whatsapp?). Both Stephen in Acts 7 and James in Acts 12 were martyred. They were not saved. Quoting 2 Timothy 4:6, 16-20, Wayne O'Donnell, writes, "near the end of Paul's ministry, he couldn't even heal his own coworkers".

ONE GOT PREGNANT, TWO OTHERS DID NOT!

I have seen the 'pain' experiences and 'power' experiences going together in my ministry. A couple who did not have children for seven long years were blessed with a child following prayer at one of our meetings (I am sure many others also prayed for this couple to have children). Now this 'once childless even after seven long years into marriage couple' are blessed with two children – a boy and a girl! A clear case of a miracle happening in response to prayer. On the other hand, there are atleast two other couples I have prayed for asking the Lord to bless them with a child. I still await the positive answer from the Lord for this prayer. If the gifts of the Holy Spirit are distributed "according to the will of God", miracles also happen according to God's Will and not as per our words of command or faith (Heb. 2:4).

ACTS 12 VS HEBREWS 11

A careful Bible Reader will see that there is a link between Acts 12 and Hebrews 11. Acts 12 records the story of James' execution and Peter's miraculous escape from prison. Both these stories - one story of suffering unto death and the other story of miraculous escape from death – are found in the same chapter. We find the same thing in the book of Hebrews too. In Hebrews 11:11 we read the story of the miracle of childbirth in very old Sarah's life. We also read of miraculous escape from certain death situations by children of God who had

faith in verses 33,34 of the same chapter. However, in the same chapter we also read about how some others who had the same faith were tortured and butchered (see Hebrews 11:35b,36,37). Hebrews 11:33 alludes to Prophet Daniel's escape from the Lion's den while Hebrews 11:37 alludes to Prophet Isaiah been sawn into two (as D. A. Carson and others note). One prophet's faith was not lesser than the other's the same way James' faith was not lesser than Peter's. While James was executed, Peter was saved (the story of Acts 12). But even Peter would be eventually crucified upside down for the sake of Christ! My point is this: the 'prescription theology' of the book of Acts calls us to endure suffering when it comes to us and expect God to do miracles in our lives, albeit according to His Sovereign Will (not according to our whims and fancies).

THE SO-CALLED MIRACLES WE SEE TODAY WERE NOT ENDORSED BY JESUS AND THE APOSTLES

I also believe that we must not ignore how the apostles - the leaders of the early church - understood and followed the commands of Jesus. We must follow Jesus the way the apostles followed Jesus – this I believe. I believe this as Apostle Paul repeatedly says (in-effect) that we must follow Christ as he followed Christ so many times in the New Testament (1 Cor. 11:1; 1 Cor. 4:16; Phil. 3:17; Phil. 4:9; 1 Thess.1:6). The writer to the Hebrews also writes, 'Remember your leaders, who spoke the Word of God to you. Consider the outcome of their way of life and imitate their faith' (Heb. 13:7). I say this because some twist the words of Jesus to make it mean something which the Apostles never saw it being meant. For example, many young people twist the words of

Jesus in John 14:12 – 'Very truly I tell you, whoever believes in me will do the works I have been doing, and they will do even greater things these, because I am going to the Father' – to accommodate practices like forensic prophecies in their prophecies like phone number prediction, bank account balance prediction of people they minister to, etc. These things are alien to the ministry of the apostles. The call even in the book of Acts is this: we must devote ourselves to the apostles' teaching (Acts 2:42). That means we must interpret Jesus and his ministry the way the apostles interpreted Jesus and his ministry. Let me cite an example. Jesus said, 'I am the way the truth and the life,' in John 14:6. The apostles repeated that in their own style in the book of Acts where we read that salvation is found in no one else except in Jesus (Acts 4:12). As the apostles upheld the uniqueness of Jesus (taught in the gospels) in Acts, we must also uphold the same.

These lessons about miracles from the book of Acts need to be embraced and shared widely.

This is a modified version of the assignments that Evangelin Duke, the wife of the author, wrote as part of her Post Graduate Diploma in Biblical Leadership with SAIACS, Bangalore – a fully online program.

CHAPTER 24

ARE WE MAKING WHAT THE BIBLE CALLS "THE LAST ENEMY", A FRIEND, IF WE EXPECT TO DIE (SHOULD JESUS' COMING TARRY)?



A Counter To the Claims Of Cult Pastors Who Teach Immortality On Earth Via A Run-through Of 1 Corinthians 15

"The last enemy to be destroyed is death", so writes Apostle Paul (1 Cor. 15:26). Using this verse as a proof-text, 'Immortality on Earth' cult preachers and pastors say that believers in Christ need not have to experience earthly deaths ever and those who expect a physical death should the coming of Jesus delay are befriending what the Word of God clearly calls 'enemy'! What is the full story concerning this?

MAKING PAUL SAY SOMETHING THAT HE NEVER MEANT TO SAY

One needs to read the full chapter – 1 Corinthians 15 – to understand that Paul did not ever want his reference to death as "the last enemy" to be taken to mean that there will be no death for the believer. One needs to only revisit the full chapter – 1 Corinthians 15 – to gather that one is not befriending what God calls 'enemy' by assuming believers will die natural deaths, if the coming of the Lord tarries!

WHY IS PAUL UPSET AS HE WRITES I CORINTHIANS 15?

Let me show you how: Till verse 7 of this chapter, Paul talks about the key elements of the Gospel. One such element is the resurrection from the dead of Jesus Christ (1 Cor. 15:4). From verses 5 through 8, Paul talks about the people, the Alive Again Anointed One, Jesus, appeared to. In verses 9 and 11, Paul issues a personal note about how hard he worked enabled by the grace of God to preach the Gospel which has to have the mention of the resurrection of Jesus! From verses 12 through 14, Paul is upset that there are some who claimed that there was no resurrection of the dead while mentioning why it is important to believe that Jesus rose from the dead.

NO IDENTIFICATION WITH JESUS, NO VICTORY OVER SIN!

From verse 15, Paul starts to talk about dead believers. J. B. Phillips renders verse 15 in a way we can easily grasp: 'For if the dead do not rise neither did Christ rise'. But the fact of the matter is this: Christ rose from the dead, and one day, dead believers will rise again.' This is rehammered in verse 16. In verse 17, he writes that "we are still in our sins" if we do not believe in the resurrection. I am reminded of Paul's words in Romans 6:3-4 where he says that a believer needs to rehearse his identification with the death, burial and resurrection of Jesus in order to overcome sin in his life. A believer needs to say, "My old body of sin is buried along with Jesus who died for me on the cross. Now, I am spiritually resurrected as a new person just as Jesus literally rose again from the dead. I will not return to the same old sinful habits my old body and self once enjoyed, before I died with Christ and rose again with Christ!" A person cannot live in victory over sin without spiritually identifying himself with the death, burial and resurrection of Jesus!

IT WAS COMMON FOR BELIEVERS TO DIE IN THE EARLY CHURCH!

In verse 18, Paul talks about "those who have fallen asleep in Christ" (ESV). He was talking about dead believers here! This is the FIRST TIME PAUL TALKS ABOUT BELIEVERS DYING in 1 Corinthians 15. We understand from Paul's words here that it was very common for believers to die in the Early Church! Paul assumes believers will

die here! Paul did not believe in immortality on earth for believers! Paul's point was this: if Jesus did not rise from the dead, then believers who died also will not rise from the dead and will not be ever seen again! But Jesus did rise from the dead and believers who died will rise again one day!

WE BELIEVERS ARE MOST PITIABLE WHEN...

It is at this time, Paul makes this famous statement: "If it's only for this present life that we have put our hope in the Messiah, we are the most pitiable members of the human race" (1 Cor. 15:19, NTFE).

But the good news is this: Christ has indeed risen from the dead! Paul calls Christ rising from the dead as the part of the "first fruits" (verse 20). Believers who are dead rising from the dead will then be the "later fruits"! (This can be understood when we read verse 20). This is the SECOND TIME PAUL TALKS ABOUT BELIEVERS DYING IN 1 CORINTHIANS 15.

PAUL ASSUMES ALL BELIEVERS WOULD DIE ONE DAY, SHOULD JESUS' COMING TARRY

Paul goes on to talk about the contrasting effects that Adam and Christ have on us in the next few verses – verse 21 and 22. In Adam, we all die and in Christ we all will rise again from the dead. Paul assumes that all

believers will die (have a spiritual and natural death, if the coming of the Lord tarries). This is the THIRD TIME PAUL TALKS ABOUT BELIEVERS DYING IN 1 CORINTHIANS 15.

THE EVENT THAT PRECEDES THE RESURRECTION OF DEAD BELIEVERS

In verse 23, Paul clearly teaches this: Only after the Second Coming of Jesus will believers who are dead be resurrected from the dead; their resurrection will be the "later fruit", while the historic resurrection of Jesus is the "first fruit". In John 5:29 and I Thessalonians 4:16-17, the Bible teaches that when Jesus returns, dead believers will also be resurrected. In John 5:29, dead believers are called "those who have done good" and in I Thessalonians 4:16-17 they are called the "dead in Christ". Prophet Daniel predicts a day of resurrection of the dead in Daniel 12:2. Instead of saying that believers will not die, the Bible says that even though they may eventually die, one day they will be resurrected. Paul clearly makes this event after the return of Jesus in two places – one here in 1 Corinthians 15:23 and two in I Thessalonians 4:16-17.

TWO PLACES WHERE THERE IS NO DEATH

After Jesus returns, He will start to rule the earth in a way He has not already done – Paul talks about this in 1 Corinthians 15:24,25. It will be at this juncture that all of Jesus' enemies will be put under the feet of His Father,

Paul writes here. Revelation 20:9-10 talks about the defeat of the Devil and his forces and their consignment to eternal hell, an event that takes place after the return of Jesus (mentioned in Revelation 19:11 and the reign of Jesus mentioned in Revelation 20:1-8). But one enemy will remain, the last enemy, which is death. Paul talks about this enemy in 1 Corinthians 15:26. In the New Heaven and New Earth which Jesus will inaugurate after the Second Coming, death will be finally defeated and there will be no more death (Rev. 21:4). People in hell won't die – they will be tormented forever (Rev. 20:10). People in heaven won't die – they will praise God forever! In this way, death the final enemy will be defeated! Therefore heaven and hell are the only two places where death, is fully defeated, where there is no death. On this present earth, death will regularly happen, should Jesus' coming delay.

In 1 Corinthians 15:29 Paul talks about the unbiblical practice of baptising dead people which some ignorant people followed. They believed in the biblical doctrine of resurrection of the dead. That is why in desperation they baptised the dead hoping that through this ritual the dead person will be saved and when resurrected will come to heaven instead of going to hell. Their practice of baptism for the dead is wrong because there is no chance for salvation after death (Heb. 9:27). But their belief in the resurrection of the dead is right. This was Paul's point in 1 Corinthians 15:29.

PAUL'S HABIT OF COMPARING FALSE TEACHERS TO ANIMALS

Next in 1 Corinthians 15:30-32, Paul says that he was ready to take extreme risks while doing the ministry – he stared death on the face – because he knew that even if he got killed in the process, he would rise again. The 'beasts at Ephesus' whom Paul fought (verse 32) could be a metaphor for false teachers in Ephesus as Paul had the habit of comparing false teachers to animals (he called the false teachers operating in Philippi as dogs in Phil. 3:2). Here for the FOURTH TIME PAUL IMPLIES BELIEVERS CAN DIE. In 1 Corinthians 15:32b, Paul says, if there was no resurrection of the dead, he would be only be busy in two activities: over-eating and drinking alcohol! The implication is this: there is resurrection of the dead, so Paul would rather be busy in risky ministry.

WHAT YOU REALLY BELIEVE WILL IMPACT YOUR BEHAVIOR

In 1 Corinthians 15:33-34, Paul warns the believers of the church in Corinth about intimate association with folks who did not believe in the resurrection of the dead. Why? What they believed impacted their behaviour. They often got drunk because they believed that once they died, they simply stopped existing. There was no resurrection of the dead for them and a life in eternal hell thereafter for them. So they lived a life of indulgence. You see, what you really believe will impact your behavior!

In 1 Corinthians 15:35-41, Paul answers the specific question of the gang that did not believe in the resurrection of the dead: "How are the dead raised? With what kind of body do they come?" In verse 36 for the FIFTH TIME in 1 Corinthians 15, PAUL ASSUMES THAT BELIEVERS WOULD DIE (UNLESS THE RETURN OF JESUS PRECEDES).

WORD PICTURES GALORE TO SIGNIFY FAILING HEALTH AND SURE-TO-COME DEATH

Paul, next, talks about immortality only after talking about DEATH THAT WILL COME TO BELIEVERS FIVE TIMES! In verses 42-43, Paul writes that dead believers will one day be resurrected and be given an imperishable body. Till that time, the believer's body is prone to growing "dishonour" and "weakness" (Paul's word pictures for fading beauty and failing health); the believer will eventually die and be buried, a process, Paul calls "sowing" (verse 43). Paul talks about this process elsewhere as well: "...our outer nature is wasting away..." (2 Cor. 4:16). He calls our bodies as "tents" that would collapse (die) one day only to be re-erected in heaven (2 Cor. 5:1).

A CLEAR CASE OF TWISTING SCRIPTURE TO LEAD PEOPLE TO HELL

The false teachers who teach immortality on earth ignore the fact that Paul has already talked about the possible death of believers five times in 1 Corinthians 15! They selectively go on to latch onto the latter half

of 1 Corinthians 15 to teach that believers in Christ will not have to die on this earth at all. It is a clear case of taking a text out of context. **It is a clear case of twisting Scripture to teach hell-populating false teaching.** I say hell-populating false teaching because, as Paul warned in 1 Corinthians 15:32-34, wrong beliefs about what the Bible says about death and resurrection from the dead will lead to sinful behaviour; and if this indulgent behaviour persists without repentance, it will take the person who believes these lies to hell.

THE WRONG INTERPRETATION OF 'TRUMPET' BY CULTISTS

In 1 Corinthians 15:50-54, Paul talks about the only possibility of believers becoming immortal even when they are on earth. This will happen if they are around when the trumpet sounds, and the dead will be raised. The only time this will happen is during the Second Coming of Jesus as Paul clearly spells out in 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17, something that Paul already referred to in 1 Corinthians 15:23. Sadly, the cult pastors who teach Immortality on Earth say that the trumpet call referred to in 1 Corinthians 15:52 does not talk about the Second Coming of Jesus. This refers to the preaching of a new generation in the church, a preaching that teaches we can be immortal now, even before the Second Coming – they say quoting an irrelevant Old Testament verse. They are wrong here. **Why do I say that? Here is why: According to 1 Corinthians 15:52, the dead will rise when the trumpet sounds! Have all dead people been resurrected after they heard these cultists preach, "You can be immortal here and now"? Absolutely not!** As I mentioned, these dead people will

only be resurrected when Jesus returns (see 1 Thess. 4:16-17). Revelation 20:13 says that on the final day of the Great White Throne Judgment, every dead person up until that point in history will be resurrected and judged. Even if they were drowned in the ocean to their death (remember Malaysian Airlines MH 370, remember Osama Bin Laden's burial?), their dead bodies will be reunited with their ever-alive spirits and they all would be judged by the one who sits on the Great White Throne Jesus! Post that great day of judgement is consignation of people whose names are NOT found in the Lamb's Book of Life into hell, called the lake of fire here (Rev. 20:15) – a place already occupied by the False Prophet, the Antichrist (Beast) (Rev. 19:20) and Satan (Rev. 20:10). Only for those in Christ Jesus (and for those who have slept in Jesus), there is no condemnation (Rom. 8:1). They are given an immortal body (Phil. 3:20-21). This event follows the "noisy" (surely the sound of the trumpets adds to all this noise, I believe) public return of Jesus (see Rev. 19:6).

WHAT CHOICE WILL YOU MAKE?

You have a choice: to believe in the lies of the cultic pastors who teach that "unless a generation rises up which believes that we will be immortal and won't die a physical death, JESUS WILL NEVER RETURN!" Or you can believe in the plain teaching of God's Word that Jesus will return and only post that, will a life of immortality be ushered.

HOW IS DEATH SWALLOWED UP?

Let's wrap up this survey of 1 Corinthians 15 against the backdrop of the immortality on earth cult by turning our attention to the last few verses of this chapter. Paul writes that post the sounding of the trumpet, which in turn means the Second Coming of Jesus, there will be a time when "death is swallowed" (eradicated) and won't be able to "win" over anyone anymore (physical death will not be the experience of anyone) (verses 54-55). Yes, there is no death in heaven. There is no death in hell as well! This way death is "swallowed up in victory" (1 Cor. 15:54).

You need to read 1 Corinthians 15:56 in different versions to understand it: "It was sin that made death so frightening and law-code guilt that gave sin its leverage, its destructive power..." (MSG); "Sin came *into this world*, and death's sting *followed*. Then sin took aim at the law and gained power *over those who follow the law*" (VOICE). "Death gets its power to hurt from sin, and sin gets its power from the Law" (GNT).

TWO ASPECTS OF A LIFE WITHOUT CHRIST

If Adam had not sinned, death would not have been a part of human existence. After introducing Jesus as the Second Adam, Paul writes that we have borne the image of Adam (1 Cor. 15:44-49). Yes, as Adam died following sin, we will also surely die one day (should the coming of the Lord tarry), because just as Adam chose

to sin, we too choose to sin. In this sense, "the sting of death" is caused by sin as Paul writes in 1 Corinthians 15:56. Another trigger for sin is our effort to be saved by following the law without the enablement from the Lord and the Spirit. This can be frustrating. In this scenario, the Law will only seem as the enabler for sin! That is why Paul uses the phrase, "the power of sin is the law" (1 Cor. 15:56). In Romans 5:20 and Romans 7:7-11, Paul presents the law of God as a sin-enabler for the person who wants to follow the Law without a relationship with Jesus Christ. He makes the same point here, without giving adequate space for explanation because he is confident that the believers of Corinth will pick this up. So, the message of 1 Corinthians 15:56a is this: death would not have even come in the first place, had we not sinned like Adam. The message of 1 Corinthians 15:56b is this: the law of God as found in the Bible defines what is sin and what is not sin; this law, at times, triggers sin; this law would not have been even given, but for man-kind's choice to sin from the time of Adam! 1 Corinthians 15:56 describes two aspects of a torrid life devoid of a relationship with Christ: (1) It is a life that heads to a hopeless grave and to hell beyond; (2) It is a life of trying to obey the law with a self-righteous spirit but instead finding yourself going deeper into the hole of lawlessness and iniquity.

LET'S FIGHT BEAST-LIKE FALSE TEACHERS!

1 Corinthians 15 does not end in a despondent note. Verse 57 begins with the word, "but" (ESV), and the message is this: through a living, daily relationship with Jesus we have victory over sin; by a life of abiding

in Christ, we are given power to obey the Law on a consistent basis! 1 Corinthians 15 ends with a call to be "steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that in the Lord your labour is not in vain" (verse 58). In the same chapter, he talks about how he did the "work of the Lord" by putting his life in risk (1 Cor. 15:30-31), fighting with beast-like false teachers (1 Cor. 15:32). We too must follow suit! In fact, this chapter and this book is my way of fighting false teachers!

CHAPTER 25

GETTING CARRIED AWAY: VIRAT KOHLI AND MODERN-DAY HYPER-SUPERNATURALISM AFFECTED BELIEVERS!



WHEN KOHLI PLAYED ACROSS THE LINE AND INDIA LOSES NARROWLY

India were within sniffing distance of a famous Test win in the **first Test of the 2018 England-India series in Edgbaston, England**. A flurry of boundaries by **Hardik Pandya** made them and the Indian spectators believe that they could win that Test! That's when Joe Root, England's Captain (then) threw the ball to **Ben Stokes**. **Virat Kohli** got a little carried away when he played across the line to an in-cutter from Ben Stokes and he was out leg before wicket. Mark Nicolas wrote the following about that match-result changing moment: "But at 11.47, this Saturday morning Ben Stokes trapped Kohli in front of the stumps he had protected so vigorously and successfully since he first arrived at the wicket during the first session of play on Thursday (2

August 2018)." With Kohli gone, India's hopes also evaporated and they lost the Test by 31 runs, their fourth narrowest Test loss when you considered the runs by which they lost a Test (then). Kohli cannot be blamed for India's defeat. Other Indian batsmen – M. Vijay, Shikar Dhawan, KL Rahul and Ajinke Rahane – had to chip in. But they did not.

THIS WAS NO ODI OR T20 MATCH WITH ASKING RATE CLIMBING UP!

But the question remains: Why did Kohli play across the line, instead of playing with a straight bat (something he is so good at), when India needed him to stay at the crease till the job was done? This was no ODI or T20 match chase with the asking rate climbing up! This was just the Day 4 of a 5-day Test! Potentially 150 overs were remaining to get those 50-odd runs and sew-up a sensational Test win! There was no compulsion whatsoever to play across the line. He could have waited for the loose ball to come to score. Did Kohli get carried away by the way Hardik Pandya hit those boundaries and tried to step up the gas to close the contest quickly with an eye already on India's champagne-bottle celebrations post the Test, a Test that could have well been called "The Kohli Test" (given his innings of 149 runs in the first innings and 51 in the second)? Possibly.

India needed 53 runs with two wickets in hand after Kohli got out to get what could have been the most famous Test wins ever! Hardik could have continued his aggression and boundary flurry after Kohli left. Scoring

20-runs in an over is no big deal for Hardik Pandya. That would have been a wise thing to do after the dismissal of Kohli with just two tail-enders to give him possible company. But Hardik switched off his aggressive intent the moment Kohli got out. India eventually lost this totally thrilling Test match as Hardik got out last, 31 runs short.

GETTING CARRIED AWAY AND REFUSING SEX EVEN INSIDE MARRIAGE!

From the Cricket Field to the Bible doctrine, let us make a switch. The Bible warns us that we must not "get carried away by all kinds of unfamiliar teachings" (Heb. 13:9). There are teachings popular today which I put in the category of getting 'carried away'. Even during Apostle Paul's time, this happened. Paul wrote to the Corinthian church this: "Already you have all you want! Already you have become rich! You have begun to reign —and that without us! How I wish that you really had begun to reign so that we also might reign with you!" (1 Cor. 4:8). This statement of Paul was indicative of Paul's concern that the Corinthian church believers had gotten 'carried-away' and landed-up in an "over-realized eschatology" which basically meant the blessings that could be theirs only after they reached heaven, they felt they already had them here and now or felt that they must have it here and now.

EXAMPLES OF OVER-REALIZED ESCHATOLOGY

For example, since the Corinthians believed this, they said, "It is good for a man not to have sexual relations with a woman" (1 Cor. 7:1). You see, there is no sex in heaven! So, the Corinthians, carried away by this 'I am already in heaven' teaching, did not want to have sex even inside marriage (even though they still lived very much on this earth). That's why Paul had to counsel them to have sex inside their marriages in I Corinthians 7:2-5. **Gordon Fee,** noted New Testament Scholar, explains this further: "Corinthians seems to have considered themselves to be already like angels, thus truly spiritual, needing neither sex in the present (1 Cor. 7:1-7) nor a body in the future (1 Cor. 15:1-58)". But Paul believed there were some things that would only happen on the Final Day. That's why he wrote this to them: "Therefore judge nothing before the appointed time; wait until the Lord comes" (1 Cor. 4:5). Basically, Paul was telling them: "Don't get over-board!" Because when we go over-board, we fall into error. And when we fall into error in doctrines that affect salvation, we land up in hell. It is that dangerous!

WHAT A CHENNAI PASTOR TEACHES: 'YOU CAN BE IMMORTAL, NOW!'

Another example of an over-realized eschatology is the wrong teaching that we will be immortal here and now on this side of eternity. A Chennai based pastor quotes 1 Corinthians 15:26 which says "the last enemy

to be defeated is death" and teaches that until a generation of believers beats death here and now – that is becomes immortal now – only then Jesus will come back to the earth (he asserts)! Till that happens, Jesus would NEVER come back, he says! What a heresy! The plain teaching of the Bible is this: "Man is destined to die once and after that face judgment" (Heb. 9:27). In the same chapter quoted by this Chennai pastor – 1 Corinthians 15 – we have evidence to know that death will be finally defeated only when Jesus comes back the second time and not before that. In 1 Corinthians 15:52 he writes that the transformation of our body into immortal, imperishable bodies will happen when the "trumpet" will sound. "In a flash, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, the dead will be raised imperishable, and the mortal will put on immortality," that verse reads. In 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17, Paul clearly writes that when the trumpet sounds Jesus would return the second time to this earth. When this happens, death will be defeated, by Christ-followers when Christ returns (1 Cor. 15:54-56). So, we believers, in case we are alive when Jesus returns, will become immortal then! The Christ-followers who have died will be raised from the dead during that time and join those Christ-followers who are alive! Both these categories will be given immortal bodies that will not die ever, when that happens (when Jesus Christ returns). Not before that!!! Let us not fool ourselves!!!!

'ONLY IF THESE FALSE TEACHERS DIE, THEIR SENSELESS FOLLOWERS WILL GET SOME SENSE'

This teaching was made famous by a South African preacher who died after preaching this very thing – "You

will not die on this earth here and now, if you believe in Jesus!" One of my preacher friends said, "Only if the guys who teach these bizarre things die, only then their senseless followers will get some sense!" I would say, "I don't want that to happen. God forbid! But even if that happens, it is unlikely that some of these folks will repent from teaching hell-taking false doctrine – they are so sadly sold to it totally! That's very sad! These words that you are reading are only an attempt to stem the tide of more people following such rubbish, than to correct these sadly stubborn false teachers/cult leaders!"

WHY SUCH TEACHINGS ARE POPULAR IN THE FIRST PLACE?

I believe such heretic, cultic teachings are passed on because this generation does not like to hear these very biblical, yet unpopular messages: "Where will you go if you died tonight?" (based on Luke 12:20, Luke 17:32). So the cult false teachers and pastors want to teach in-effect: "Why worry about death – you will not die at all!" What a deception! What a tragedy!

Let us steer clear of all such teachings that go 'over-board' because that will mean a "loss" – as it was the case for Virat Kohli and his men in the first Test of 2018 Series versus England in England. For us believers, 'loss' would mean loss of eternal life, and a life in hell, ultimately (2 Peter 2:1 warns about 'destructive heresies' and

the heresy of this kind is certainly one among them). Let us escape these strange false teachings and embrace sound doctrine from the Bible!

CHAPTER 26

DOES THE BIBLE TEACH IMMORTALITY ON EARTH?



Jesus said, "I myself am the resurrection and the life," Jesus told her. "The man who believes in me will live even though he dies, and anyone who is alive and believes in me will never die at all. Can you believe that?" (John 11:25,26 PHILLIPS).

Does this verse teach 'immortality on earth' as cult pastors from South Africa, Sri Lanka and South India (of late) have taught? Does this verse mean that believers will never need to experience physical death?

First, the answer comes from God's very CHARACTER (only God is immortal).

These verses – John 11:25,26 – does not teach that man will have immortality on this side of eternity. These verses do not teach that believers will not experience physical death. Why do I say that? Because I have read 1 Timothy 6:16 which says, "He (God) alone is immortal and dwells in immortal light..." This, Apostle Paul,

writes after He perhaps read Jesus' seemingly immortality now supporting words recorded in John 11:25-26. Therefore as God only is immortal as Paul asserts, John 11:25-26 could not have taught immortality now before the Second Coming! **We must interpret the words of Jesus the way the Apostle interpret it – not according to our whims and fancies**. We cannot interpret Jesus' words according to the way some cult pastors interpret it. We must follow Christ, as Apostle Paul followed Christ. We must interpret Christ as Apostle Paul interpreted Christ!

Second, the answer comes from list in that famous CHAPTER (Rom. 8).

Also, don't forget, that Apostle Paul included 'death' in the list of the things that cannot separate a believer who abides in Christ, from Christ (Rom. 8:38). If he believed in immortality/physical death cancellation, he would not have included death in this list with multiple entries!

Third, the answer comes from what Paul wrote to the believers of CORINTH.

If he believed that death is not for a believer, Paul would not have acknowledged that a 'sentence of death' hung over him and the other apostles doing God's Work (1 Cor. 4:9). The word 'sentence' in this verse implies a thing that is sure to come – yes, death is sure to come for a believer!

So, what did Jesus mean when he said, "anyone who is alive and believes in me will never die" (John 11:26)? We must ask the question, "What did Jesus mean by the word 'die' here?" This question brings us to the different meanings of the word 'death' in the Bible. A careful study of the word 'death' in the Bible tells us that **there are three kinds of death**.

Four, the answer comes from the fact that there are COUPLE of more kinds of deaths, the Bible mentions, other than physical death.

HE WAS THE LIFE OF THE PARTY, WHILE HE WAS DEAD – DEAD IN SIN!

First, there is spiritual death. In fact, the first reference in the Bible about death, concerns spiritual death. God told the first couple: "but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die" (Gen. 2:17). Did Adam and Eve experience physical death instantly when they ate the forbidden fruit? No. But they died spiritually speaking. For Jesus, this concept of death was foremost in his mind. In Luke 15:32, the Loving, Waiting Father says that the prodigal, lost son was "dead" but now "alive" after he repented and returned! Was the prodigal younger son "dead" – physically or literally? No. He was very much alive! He squandered his father's wealth in 'reckless LIVING' (Luke 15:13). He was the "LIFE" of the party

(to use today's youth's language) when he partied hard living in open sin, yet he was DEAD (according to his dad, according to Jesus who narrated this parable). Only after his repentance and return to God, did he find LIFE! Otherwise he was DEAD. Luke 15:32 is clear. Apostle Paul also taught the same thing. Those living in sin are "dead in sin" he wrote concerning the Ephesian believers before they found Jesus (Eph. 2:1).

WHY DON'T THEY QUOTE VERSES SUCH AS JOSHUA 23:14 AND 1 KINGS 2:2?

The second kind of death, the Bible talks about is physical death. When the Bible says in Genesis 5:5, "Thus all the days that Adam lived were 930 years, and he died", it is talking about physical death. Physical death is called the 'way of all the earth' (Josh 23:14, Joshua's words; I Kings 2:2, David's words). Joshua heard Moses, his mentor asking those he led to "choose life and not death" (Deut. 30:19, 29:2). Yet he knew while he found spiritual life through Yahweh, he did have to die physically! **A cultic pastor in Madurai** quotes 'choose life' (from the Old Testament) at the end of an immortality-promoting sermon! Why not also quote Joshua 23:14 and I Kings 2:2 and other Old Testament passages that clearly say that death is for all – including Yahweh followers and believers in the Messiah (Jesus) to come! In the light of the full message of the Bible, choose 'life' did not mean Physical Death's end (Joshua, who heard it did not see it that way)!

SECOND DEATH EQUALS EVERLASTING LIFE IN HELL

The third kind of death is eternal death. For Apostle John – the author of John 11:25-26 (the favourite verse of no-physical-death-for-believers-bluffers) – this was the meaning of death. He called it 'second death' or ultimate death. Eternal Hell punishment was 'second death' for John (Rev. 21:8). If you have not read Revelation 21:8 which the author of Gospel of John also wrote, here it is: "But as for the cowardly, the faithless, the detestable, as for murderers, the sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, and all liars, their portion will be in the lake that burns with fire and sulphur, which is the second death."

THE KIND OF DEATH JESUS ENDURED FOR US ON THE CROSS

When Jesus died on the Cross, He endured 'second death' punishment for us. We should have gone to hell which the Bible calls as 'second death' (Rev. 21:8). But Jesus endured hell – which is ultimate death – for us. As he hung on the Cross, he cried out, "My God! My God! Why have you forsaken me!" Jesus experienced the hell of separation from his father! As he hung on the Cross, he cried out, "I thirst!" Those were the words that the Rich Man spoke after he died (physical death) to endure second/eternal death (punishment in hell) (Luke 16:24). Jesus spoke those very words while he hung on the Cross! We can see it in this way: Jesus endured ultimate death – which the Bible calls 'second death' in Revelation 21:8 – so that we will not have to go to

hell! In Romans 5:8-9 and I Thessalonians 1:10, Apostle Paul also explains how Jesus' death on the Cross saved believers who would abide in him from 'second death' – hell punishment (or the coming wrath).

SO, THE MESSAGE OF JOHN 11:25-26 IS, 'NO ETERNAL DEATH FOR JESUS-BELIEVERS'

So, the message of John 11:25-26 is simple: Jesus died to save us from hell-punishment; if we live in Christ, we will never go to hell. I tell youth this: If you come to Jesus now, he will save you from your living hell (the disappointment you have when you find out that 'you never found in sin, what you entered sin to find') and literal hell (burning Sulphur furnace punishment).

LET NOT THE CULT-PASTORS-BRIGADE CONFUSE YOU!

So, Jesus was not teaching about physical death cancellation in John 11:25-26 (as what he said would contradict what he spoke through the Holy Spirit through Apostle Paul that only God can be 'immortal', 1 Tim. 6:16). The meaning of John 11:25-26 is this: "those who keep believing in Jesus will be resurrected from spiritual death and be kept from eternal death – hell punishment!" Let not the cult-pastors-brigade confuse you by making you believe that these verses – John 11:25-26 mean something else!

JESUS COULD HAVE RESURRECTED JOHN THE BAPTIST! BUT HE DIDN'T!

There is another reason why I believe that Jesus did not teach physical death cancellation for the believer in John 11:25-26. If there was to be no death for his followers why did he allow John the Baptist to die (Matt. 14)? Jesus did not attempt to resurrect John the Baptist when the news of his death was brought to him (Matt. 14:13). Instead of marching towards the place where John's headless body was placed, Jesus 'withdrew to a solitary place', the Bible says in Matthew 14:13. If death, here and now, is never God's will for humankind as this cult combine of Pastors claim, then he would have resurrected John the Baptist the way he resurrected the Luke 7 young man, the Matthew 9 little girl and John 11 Lazarus. But he did not. Jesus knew that God has a duration for everyone's life and after that a person must die, if His coming tarried.

'WHY DID JESUS ALLOW JAMES THE APOSTLE TO DIE? WHY WAS THERE A RISK OF EPHAPHRODITUS DYING?' - QUESTIONS FOR FALSE TEACHERS

If there was to be no death for believers, why did Jesus allow James the apostle to die (Acts 12)? If there is no death for New Covenant believers why did Apostle Paul commend Epaphroditus, one of his ministry team members, for risking his life for the Lord and almost dying (Phil. 2)? If death was cancelled for believers, then believers cannot be ever at 'risk' of dying – isn't it? But Epaphroditus faced this real risk according to Paul. So,

Apostle Paul never believed what these cult pastors are saying that he believed in! **Apostle Paul never believed in immortality on earth!**

MY RESPONSE TO THEIR TWISTING OF HEBREWS 9:23-28 AND 2 CORINTHIANS 5:15

These cult pastors twist Scriptures to teach that Hebrews 9:23-28 and 2 Corinthians 5:15 to bring this false teaching: "When Jesus died, we all died; when Jesus rose, we all rose. Since the Risen-from-Dead Jesus will not ever die again, we believers, also, need NOT have to die!" The Madurai cult pastor argues: "Since we were buried with Christ when we got water baptized (see Rom. 6:3), we will not have to die again!" Really? The writer to the Hebrews called for faithfulness to Jesus unto death in Hebrews 12:4, in-effect! Surely, he did not believe in immortality on earth! **Paul, the author of 2 Corinthians, who talked about 'the sentence of death' hanging over him and his team because of the Gospel (2 Cor. 1:9), surely did not believe in Physical Death cancellation!**

NO GRAIN OF TRUTH IN 'NO-DEATH-FOR-BELIEVERS' FALSE TEACHING!

So, John 11:25-26 must be interpreted with the light of the rest of the Bible. If Jesus meant physical death cancellation for the believer in John 11:25-26, he would not have called his disciples to be martyrdom ready

using the 'grain of wheat' imagery in John 12:24. But he did! You see – cancelling physical death, here and now, was never part of Jesus' plan for us! Thanks to the 'grain of wheat' imagery that Jesus used – there is no grain of truth in the 'no-death-for-believers' false teaching!

DID PAUL DIE BECAUSE HE GAVE PERMISSION TO GOD TO TAKE HIM?

These cult pastors also claim that Apostle Paul kept beating death (in the sea amidst storms, in the island of Malta – they quote these examples). But he ultimately died because he chose to die. God took Apostle Paul because Apostle Paul gave permission to God to take him away when he wrote, "I finished the race" (2 Tim. 4:7) – this is their bizarre claim. Apostle Paul – hear me good – never for a single second, thought that he would be immortal as he wrote that ONLY GOD can be immortal (1 Tim. 6:16). The Chennai cult pastor says Paul, like Jesus had the right to lay down his life on his own accord (John 10:18). What blasphemy! This is an attempt to make Paul, a mere human as God, by this cult pastor! Only God has the power over the duration of one's life. King Hezekiah understood that correctly. That's why he pleaded with God to extend his life weeping bitterly. We see the same truth in the New Testament when in Acts, we read that Jesus is the 'author of life' (Acts 3:15). I dare these false teachers to openly declare this (in line with their false teachings): "I do not give permission for God to take away my life. Paul did. But I won't. And so, I will never ever die!" Even if they dared to do this, if

the coming of Jesus tarries, THEY WILL DIE! In fact, the South African no-death-to-believers teaching preacher, died!

THIS IS WHEN PHYSICAL DEATH WILL BE CANCELLED

Yes, Jesus will stop physical human death, one day. That is after his Second Coming! Revelation 21:4 talks about a time when there will be no more death in this world! Notice that this happens only after Jesus' return to the earth riding a white horse which is recorded in Revelation 19! So, do not get confused and get carried by what these cult false pastors teach.

THIS DOCTRINE THEY TEACH SLACKENS HOLINESS-RESOLVE

The Chennai cult pastor asserts that Jesus will not come back until a generation in church rises to beat death. He quotes Psalm 110:1/alluded to in 1 Cor. 15:25 to 'prove' this: He says after reading this verse, "Jesus is sitting right now at the right hand of the father. His body and legs are the church. And the church should make all enemies the footstool! And death is the last enemy to be defeated (1 Cor. 15:26)! So, when a generation rises in the church that beats death by believing in immortality, only then Jesus will come back. Till then, he will only sit at the right hand of the father!" This interpretation is wrong. Why? It violates the principle in the

Bible that Jesus will return without giving any warning to anyone. Four Scriptures teach that Jesus will return like a thief in the night (Matt. 24:43; 1 Thess. 5:2,4; Rev. 16:15). The meaning is plain as day: Jesus will return when no one expects him! Only a fool will say, "Jesus can never come until this happens!" The truth of the Bible is this: "Jesus can come anytime!" If Jesus will not come till a generation beats death (as this Chennai pastor asserts), that again gives youth, time to live in sin without the fear of being "left behind" during his coming! So, this teaching put forth by these cult pastors leads to the slackening of the believer's resolve for daily, minute-by-minute, holiness! That's why these doctrinal deviations are taking people to hell! That's why these doctrines put forth by this immortality company of pastors are "doctrines of demons" whose final destiny is hell if they don't repent.

JESUS WILL DEFEAT THE FINAL ENEMY CALLED DEATH – NOT BELIEVERS!

And if you carefully read Psalm 110:1/1 Cor. 15:25 (also quoted in Matt. 22:22 and Heb. 2:8) that verse says that Jesus must reign until "He" has put everything "under his feet" (re-read 1 Cor. 15:25)! But this Chennai cult pastor is talking about believers – not 'He' meaning Jesus – working to put everything "under his feet!" So, it is Jesus who will defeat the final enemy called Death. Believers will not do it! It is Jesus who will do it! That's why Paul writes, "to those who… Seek immortality" (Rom. 2;5) following repentance (Rom. 2:5), Jesus will give eternal life (Rom. 2:7). We must get that clear – immortal life for believers is only in future eternity ('will give').

DO NOT LAND IN HELL ALONG WITH THESE UNREPENTANT FALSE TEACHERS!

These cult pastors have an agenda. Their main target is the younger generation. If youth are told, 'no more death', then that would give youth (or anyone else who will believe this rubbish), the license to sin. Because after death there is no chance for salvation as the Bible teaches (Hebrews 9:27). After death, there is going to be only judgement! And if we are found to be living in secret sin and not abiding in Christ then hell is where we will go! So, by removing death from the equation, by twisting and giving a gross misinterpretation of Bible verses, they want to remove the fear of God from the youth and give them the license to sin with freedom! Let us not welcome such teaching and share in their wicked work (2 John 10,11) and land in hell with them!

THE REAL REASON WHY THEY PREACH IMMORTALITY ON EARTH: TO COMFORT PEOPLE IN THEIR SIN

I say this because both the Chennai cult pastor and the Madurai cult pastor readily admit that they may die anytime but they say that they will still preach immortality "as it is in the Word of God"! As we have seen here above – it is not in the Word of God! So, what is the real reason behind them preaching this poison? The real reason they preach immortality is to comfort young people in their sin. I implore them to repent and start

preaching like Jesus: "Tonight your life will be demanded from you…." (Luke 12:20)/ "Mrs Lot did not have lots of time to repent… so remember Lot's wife… (Luke 17:32)!"

CHAPTER 27

'D' FOR DIRECT TEACHING FOUND IN THE BIBLE AGAINST IMMORTALITY CULT



Using the Acronym D-E-A-T-H to Counter The 'No-death For Believers' Cult

In April 2020, there was a much publicised conference, planned on how believers can be immortal and need not die, in Chennai. A few preachers across the world have been teaching that if you believe in Jesus, you don't have to die – you can be immortal, here and now. A few of my friends from across the World requested me to respond to this teaching. I want to respond to this via a Bible Study. To make these Bible Studies memorable, I want to use the acronym D-E-A-T-H to counter the no-death-for-believers cult.

D-Direct Teaching found in the Bible, that we must not believe that we can be immortal now before the return of Jesus!

WHEN YOU DON'T NEED A PREACHER TO TEACH....

In fact, you don't need a preacher to teach these things! If you use www.BibleGateway.com or www.BibleHub.com and search the word 'death' there, you may figure out these things for yourself!

Let us look at some Scriptures which DIRECTLY teach that we must not believe in the "immortality" cult!

MOSES KNEW HE WOULD DIE ONE DAY!

Let us look at Deuteronomy 31:29 – a direct passage from the Bible that tells us that we should not be believing in the 'Immortality Now' cult. Here, Moses says,

"For I know that after my death you will behave very corruptly and turn from the way which I have commanded you; and evil will confront you in the latter days, because you will do that which is evil in the sight of the LORD, provoking Him to anger with the work of your hands" (NASB).

These are words of Moses (see Verse 24). So, Moses did not have whims and fancies about being immortal! Here, he uses the phrase, 'After my death….'. In other words, he is saying, "One day, I am going to die!" He talks about this very normally.

Let's now move to Joshua.

Joshua 23:14a - "Behold, this day I *am* going the way of all the earth." These are words from Joshua's farewell speech. Joshua understood that death is the way of all the earth!

Joshua heard Moses who said in Deuteronomy 30:15-19, this:

15 "See, I have set before you today life and good, death and evil, 16 in that I command you today to love the LORD your God, to walk in His ways, and to keep His commandments, His statutes, and His judgments, that you may live and multiply; and the LORD your God will bless you in the land which you go to possess. 17 But if your heart turns away so that you do not hear, and are drawn away, and worship other gods and serve them, 18 I announce to you today that you shall surely perish; you shall not prolong *your* days in the land which you cross over the Jordan to go in and possess. 19 I call heaven and earth as witnesses today against you, *that* I have set before you life and death, blessing and cursing; therefore choose life, that both you and your descendants may live;

JOSHUA ALSO KNEW THAT HE WOULD DIE ONE DAY!

In verse 15 and verse 19, Joshua heard Moses asking people to choose 'life' and not 'death'. And he chose life! He was not perfect, but he was obedient! He entered the Promised Land! He understood that he had indeed received 'life' as he obeyed God (as Dt. 30:15-19 commanded and promised). He was the most obedient

among the people of Israel along with Caleb. Joshua chose to "love His God". There are those who say, "Old Testament says something. New Testament says something else. We are New Testament covenant ministers." However, I believe that there is nothing "new" in the New Testament! We don't have a confused God! What he said in shadow in Old Testament, he said directly in the New Testament. In both the testaments we are called to "love" God! Even the Old Testament calls us to a "love" relationship with the Lord, not a "Law" relationship (Dt. 30:16)! There are other passages that also call us to love God in the Old Testament (see Dt. 6:5; 13:3; 19:9; 30:6; 30:20; Josh. 22:5; 23:11; Neh. 1:5; Isa. 56:6; Jer. 2:2). So, here we see that in obedience to Moses, Joshua chose life. But nevertheless he expected to die a normal death as it is evident by his usage of the words, "I am about to go along the way of all the earth" (Josh. 23:14)! So Joshua understood the 'life' which Moses promised in Deuteronomy, chapter 30 spiritually, not literally. And of course Joshua knew that after his death, he would have eternal life. But physical death, Joshua knew, was inevitable for him as following Adam's fall, the entire humanity was on the path to physical death, here and now. Some of these folks even lived beyond 900 years of age. But they all understood that they would die one day!

KING DAVID ALSO KNEW THAT HE WOULD DIE ONE DAY

The same experience was King David's! In I Kings 2:2 we read,

"I go the way of all the earth; be strong, therefore, and prove yourself a man (NKJV).

I Kings 2:10 talks about the death of King David. But before he died, he used the phrase 'the way of all the earth' (verse 2:2) in his conversation with his son, Solomon. That phrase is a classic Old Testament phrase which expressed that death was inevitable for all. Two outstanding Old Testament leaders – Joshua and King David – both say that death is 'the way of all the earth'.

Deuteronomy 32:39 says,

See now that I, I am He,

And there is no god besides Me;

It is I *who* put to death and give life.

I have wounded and *it is* I *who* heal,

And there is no one who can save *anyone* from My hand (NASB).

This is a classic Scripture portion! If you see the title of that passage, it is 'the song of Moses'. What I understand from the above verse is this: God can make a person live for a particular length of time and God can also take that person's life after that! God may choose to allow suffering into our lives, and God can also take away that suffering! God is absolutely Sovereign! There is only one person who has control over when we will die and that is God! This is clearly taught in Deuteronomy 32:39!

WHAT HANNAH SAID IN-EFFECT GOES AGAINST IMMORTALITY ON EARTH

Hannah says in 1 Samuel 2:6 this: 'The LORD kills and brings to life; he brings down to Sheol and raises up' (ESV). Hannah saluted the Sovereignty of God here. She was basically saying this: "The Lord is able to put a life into my long-barren womb! In fact, he did! He put Samuel into my womb! But the same Lord can also take away life! None of us can think we are immortal!"

THE WORDS OF RUTH AGAINST IMMORTALITY ON EARTH

This next passage can be considered a classic when it comes to direct passages in the Bible that teaches that we must not believe in immortality on earth! This passage is so plain! If it is a fact that I am growing bald, this is also a fact that this passage I will refer to next, is about anti-immortality on earth! I am talking about Ruth 1:17 which says,,

"Where you die, I will die,

and there I will be buried.

May Yahweh punish me,

and do so severely,

if anything but death separates you and me" (HCSB).

Both Naomi's married sons have died. Both her daughters-in-law are left as widows. They lifted their voices and wept. Orpah kissed her mother-in-law good bye. But Ruth clung onto her. And when her mother-in-law urged Ruth to follow her co-sister in kissing her goodbye, that's when Ruth spoke these golden words that come directly against the 'immortality now' cult. She assumes that one day her mother-in-law, Naomi would die. She assumes that one day, she would die. Only death could separate her and her mother-in-law, she asserts. This verse, Ruth 1:17, is very clear that death comes for all, for the daughter-in-law and the mother-in-law, for all, in-fact! Death comes for all, this verse stresses twice! Ruth, as a Moabite was perhaps worshipping false gods. But she perhaps gave up all that when she married Naomi's Yahweh-worshipping son (presumably). But her husband died tragically. There was nothing in the theological understanding of Ruth which suggested that if you worshipped Yahweh, the true God, one would not die! Her husband died! She too expected to die one day! She expected her mother-in-law, a godly woman of faith to also die! Faith in the living God is not a guarantee against death!

PATRIACH JOB COMES AGAINST THE NO-DEATH CULT

Let's move to another Bible book in this survey of the Bible to discover direct passages that come against the no-death-for-believers cult. We will now go to the book of Job.

Job 7:6: And my days are running out quicker than the thread of a fast-moving needle (CEV).

Job is talking about the brevity of human life. Again in Job 9:25-26, we read:

"My days go by faster than a runner;

they fly away without my seeing any joy.

They glide past like paper boats.

They attack like eagles swooping down to feed" (NCV).

In Job 14: 1-7, we read:

Job: Humankind, born of woman,

has a few brief years with much suffering.

[2] Like a *short-lived* bloom,

he springs up only to wither;

like the brief shade *gained by a fast-moving cloud,*

he passes swiftly.

[3] *Lord,* is this why You turn Your gaze on such a creature:

to bring me, *a mere human being,* alongside You for judgment?

[4] Who can take what is impure *and defiled*

to fashion something pure *and pristine*?

No one! *We are, after all, so different in nature.*

[5] Since a person's life is fixed,

and You *are the One who* determines the number of his months,

And You set a limit on the length of her life,

and since they are incapable of exceeding Your decree,

[6] *The least You can do is* turn Your gaze away from him until they pass,

so that he can enjoy his day like a hired worker.

[7] *You know,* at least there is *a kind of* hope for a tree:

if it gets cut down, it may yet sprout again *out of the roots*.

And very likely then, its *tender* shoots will not die (VOICE).

In all these three passages referred above, Job, using various Spirit-given analogies and carefully chosen word-pictures, teaches that death not only comes to all, but also concedes that it can come pretty soon! Job 14:1 says, 'Humankind, born of woman, has a few brief years with much suffering'.

WHEN WE COMPARE WITH ETERNITY....

Toby Saunders writing for a BBC website wrote, 'The oldest living person as of January 2024 is María Branyas Morera. She is 116 years old. Born on 4th March 1907, the American-Spanish supercentenarian is the world's oldest person. She currently lives in a nursing home in Olot, Catalonia, Spain, and even runs her own X account.... Jeanne Louise Calment is the oldest verified person to have ever lived. The Frenchwoman lived to the ripe old age of 122 years and 164 days old. She was born on 21 February 1875 and passed away aged 122 on 4 August 1997' (ScienceFocus, 07 January 2024). **When compared to eternity coming after death, even a life of 116 or 122 on this earth, is a short life!** So, we all only have a brief life to live as Job put it! Also notice that even the New Testament underscores what Job says in Hebrews 9:27: 'And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment' (ESV). "Men", meaning all, including believers and non-believers, male and female, are expected to die one day! In Hebrews 13:4 we read, "Let your marriage bed be kept pure..." There, the Hebrews-writer is restating. in his own style one of the 10 commandments found in Exodus 20: "Do not commit adultery". In the same way in Hebrews 9:27 the same writer is restating classic passages like Job 14:1 on the inevitability of death in his own style. So, both the Old Testament and New Testament directly teaches that we cannot be immortal here and now.

YOU MIGHT DO A BETTER JOB THAN ME IN THIS REGARD!

As I have already mentioned at the start of this chapter, these references that I have used in this chapter, you too can independently pick up via www.biblegateway.com or www.biblehub.com by searching the topic 'death' there. You might do a better job than me in writing this chapter on "direct references in the Bible against immortality on earth"!

We are not done yet. Let us go to another book. The book of Ecclesiastes. Ecclesiastes 3:11 says,

He has made everything beautiful in its time. Also, he has put eternity into man's heart, yet so that he cannot find out what God has done from the beginning to the end (ESV).

The first part of this verse is a favourite of several Christian wedding card designers in India. Have you noticed this phrase in this verse - "He has put eternity into man's heart"? God placed 'eternity' not in the earthly body of man, but in his 'heart' (that is, in his inner being, his soul). Though the body will die, the soul will go on living for eternity! I say this with confidence because the same writer writes this in Ecclesiastes 8:8, 'No man has power to retain the spirit, or power over the day of death. There is no discharge from war, nor will wickedness deliver those who are given to it '(ESV).

PREACHERS SHOULD NOT BE AFRAID TO SAY THIS

Bible believing preachers should not be afraid to say during their sermons: "You could die anytime. You have a soul within you, that will go on living forever! That soul will be reunited with the body on the day of judgment. Then depending on what you do with Jesus, you will go to eternal heaven or eternal hell!"

In this chapter, we have taken direct teaching verses to establish that the Bible directly teaches that we cannot believe in immortality on earth.

EVEN MOSES DID NOT BELIEVE IN IMMORTALITY ON EARTH!

Here is **one more direct Bible reference against Immortality on Earth** false teaching: Psalm 90:10. It goes this way:

We can expect seventy years, or maybe eighty, if we are healthy, but even our best years bring trouble and sorrow. Suddenly our time is up, and we disappear (CEV).

Throughout the Bible, unless you act blind, you will see that the Bible repeatedly and directly says that our life can be full of trouble and we should all expect to die (should the coming of Jesus tarry). Psalm 90 was written by Moses. And Moses directly teaches that we cannot be immortal here and now.

NEW TESTAMENT CHARACTERS WHO ACKNOWLEDGED THEIR POSSIBLE DEATH

Another Scripture we will read in this Old Testament-heavy chapter comes from the New Testament. Let us read **Romans 8:38-39**. It goes this way:

38 For I am sure that neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers, nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, 39 nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord (ESV).

WHEN PAUL WROTE IN ROMANS 2:7, 'SEEK IMMORTALITY', WHAT HE MEANT...

Yes, Paul wrote in Romans 2:7, 'seek immortality' in-effect. But that does not mean that he believed that we will be immortal here and now. If he believed in immortality here and now, he would not have included 'death' in the list of things that cannot separate us from the love of Christ. The meaning of Romans 8:38-39 is this: 'We could die. But death cannot separate us from the love of Christ'. Apostle Paul who wrote, 'seek immortality' in Romans 2:7 did not believe in immortality on earth! That's why we have Romans 8:38-39. That's why we have Romans 14:8-9 too:

[8] For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord's. [9] For to this end Christ died and lived again, that he might be Lord both of the dead and of the living (ESV).

Paul also directly taught against immortality now in 1 Timothy 6:15-16

[15] which he will display at the proper time—he who is the blessed and only Sovereign, the King of kings and Lord of lords, [16] who alone has immortality, who dwells in unapproachable light, whom no one has ever seen or can see. To him be honour and eternal dominion. Amen (ESV).

In this passage, Apostle Paul clearly says "ONLY" God alone has immortality, here on this earth. And to claim that for ourselves before the second coming is nothing short of blasphemy.

THE 'TENT' IMAGERY MAKES A DENT INTO THE NO-DEATH-FOR-BELIEVERS CULT TEACHING!

In 2 Corinthians 5:1-2 Apostle Paul directly contradicts the 'Immortality Now' teaching. He writes, 'For we know that if the earthly tent we live in is destroyed, we have a building from God, an eternal house in heaven, not built by human hands. Meanwhile we groan, longing to be clothed instead with our heavenly dwelling'. Paul is using figurative language here. He is comparing the bodies of believers to tents here. He talks about this tent being destroyed here. He is referring to bodies of believers that will die on the earth. The 'tent' imagery

here makes a dent into this crazy no-death-for-believers teaching! Paul next talks about 'an eternal house in heaven'. What he means to say is this: "Don't worry if this 'tent' of yours, that is 'body' of yours, dies on this earth! You will go to heaven!" Then Paul says in-effect: "You will not long to live long on this earth; but would groan to get to heaven!"

There are days when I stay up late and write articles that will bless and build the Kingdom of God. As I type these lines, the time is 3:04 am!

ME, OVER-SLEEPING IN ITARSI JUNCTION!

During the days when I was a student of B. Tech in Allahabad Agricultural Institute, I often made long train trips from Chennai to Allahabad. The journey took around 36 hours. At times, I would split this journey into two parts: Chennai to Itarsi; Itarsi to Allahabad. Itarsi is a place in Central India where there is an intersection between two popular train routes: Chennai to New Delhi and Kolkota to Mumbai. I recall that I arrived at around 11 pm from Chennai in Itarsi junction. And the connecting train to Allahabad, from Itarsi was scheduled to depart at 3:30 am, the following day. In between, I decided to take some rest. I decided to sleep for some time. And when I finally woke up, I was aghast to realize that the departure time for my train to Allahabad had elapsed – the clock showed 4 am! Well, I missed my train! I had to wait for a few more hours for the next train

to Allahabad to show up in Itarsi Junction! We will shortly see how Paul used the phrase 'departure time' to hammer the truth that believers may have to die should the coming of Jesus tarry.

In 2 Timothy 1:10, Paul writes that "Jesus abolished death and brought immortality to light through the Gospel". This phrase is used by cultic false teachers to propagate immortality on earth. I too will believe in immortality if the person who wrote these words believed he would be immortal. However he did not. Apostle Paul who wrote these words did not believe in immortality on earth. He expected to die soon. That is why he wrote, "For I am already being poured out as a drink offering, and the time of my departure has come" (2 Tim. 4:6). Eugene Peterson rendered the same verse this way and I love it: "You take over. I'm about to die, my life an offering on God's altar" (MSG). So what does 2 Timothy 1:10 mean? It means that immortality comes through the full gospel, not just the gospel. And in the full gospel, we have not only the first coming of Jesus, but we also have the second coming of Jesus. When Jesus returns, he gives the gift of immortality to waiting believers (1 Cor. 15:52-54).

So, do not believe in cultic false pastors who teach that believers need not die!

CHAPTER 28

‘E’ FOR EXAMPLES FOUND IN THE BIBLE AND CHURCH HISTORY AGAINST THE IMMORTALITY NOW CULT



Using The Acronym D-E-A-T-H To Counter The ‘No-Death For Believers’ Cult

PREDICTIONS FOR THE UPCOMING YEAR – BE CAREFUL OF MAKING THEM!

In James 4:13-15, the Bible says,

13 Now listen, you who say, "Today or tomorrow we will go to this or that city, spend a year there, carry on business and make money." 14 Why, you do not even know what will happen tomorrow. What is your life? You

are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes. [15] Instead, you ought to say, "If it is the Lord's will, we will live and do this or that."

This passage talks about the utter folly of making predictions! But the 'Immortality Now' cult with followers from South Africa, Sri Lanka and even from Chennai and Madurai in India have the audacity to make predictions that talks about several years into the future when they wrongly teach that we, as believers will not die ever! How ridiculous can this be? How insane can this be? How unbiblical can this be? James 4:13-15 clearly says that we cannot make predictions concerning even the next year of our life! Our death can possibly even occur in the one year about which we made the fanciful prediction about! James 4:13-15 brings a direct teaching from the Bible against the Immortality Cult.

THAT HIGH PRIEST IS EXPECTED TO DIE!

Let us look at some examples against the Immortality Now cult found in the Bible. Let us go to Numbers 35:25. It reads this way: 'The assembly is to protect the manslayer from the hand of the avenger of blood. Then the assembly will return him to the city of refuge to which he fled, and he must live there until the death of the high priest, who was anointed with the holy oil.' If you committed a murder, you can run to a city of refuge until the death of the high priest. After the death of the high-priest, that murderer can return to his own town

where he committed the murder. So in this passage, via examples, the Scriptures clearly teach us this: we can expect believers/servants of God to die under normal circumstances. This passage slams the Immortality on Earth false teaching.

URIAH'S DEATH TELLS US THAT....

Let me talk about another Old Testament example – the example of Uriah the Hittite. Let us read 2 Samuel 11:24:

"Then the archers shot arrows at your servants from the wall, and some of the king's men died. Moreover, your servant Uriah, the Hittite is dead."

Here we read of the tragic circumstances in which Uriah, the Hittite died. Faithful Uriah, the Hittite, who was flaming for Yahweh – we died. He obeyed the order of devious King David and he consequently died. He was not sinless but definitely a righteous person. His tragic death tells us that even believers in the living God can face death – even sudden death.

A VEHICLE HIT ME AND I FELL ON THE ROAD....

The other day, I took a printout of my book, *Straight Talk,* from a printout shop in Secunderabad and I rushed

to cross the road. That's when a vehicle hit me and I fell flat on the road. Had another speeding vehicle come that side, I would not be alive now to write this book.

Apostle Paul also had several close shaves with death. In Acts 21:13, we read:

Then Paul answered, "Why are you weeping and breaking my heart? I am ready not only to be bound, but also to die in Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus."

WHEN PAUL TALKED ABOUT THE POSSIBILITY OF HIS DEATH...

If Paul believed in Immortality on Earth, why would he even make this above statement where he talks about the possibility of his own death! This verse – Acts 21:13 – is a very clear reference to his possible death! Paul did not believe in immortality on earth!

JESUS PREDICTED HOW PETER WOULD DIE

Next, we read about Peter, whose death. Jesus himself predicted, here in
John 21:18-19:

Truly, truly, I tell you, when you were young, you dressed yourself and walked where you wanted; but when you are old, you will stretch out your hands, and someone else will dress you and lead you where you do not want to go." Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God.

This, Bible scholars agree, is an accurate prediction of how Peter would die – he would be crucified upside down! Not only was the death of Peter predicted, but also the way in which he would die was predicted!

ARE WE ABLE TO MEET ENOCH AND ELIJAH TODAY?

The heretic, hell-populating false teachers who teach immortality on earth would quote selective passages such as Genesis 5:24 which say - Enoch walked faithfully with God; then he was no more, because God took him away – to support their false teaching. But they would not quote Joshua and David who both said that death is the way of all the earth! This is strange and unacceptable.

The immortality now false teachers also quote the example of Elijah who did not die but was taken up into God's presence (2 Kings 2:11-12).

Enoch and Elijah can be examples of immortality now, if they continued to live on the earth even now! That is what this cult group teaches: those who believe in Jesus will continue to live on THIS EARTH. Can we now meet Enoch and Elijah? We should be able to meet them if they were still on earth (as per the Immortality Now

false doctrine)! However, if we normally die, or if Jesus returns, or if the Lord plans us an extraordinary exit from Earth like he did for Enoch and Elijah, we can all meet them on the other side of eternity!

HOW HEBREWS 11 MEMORABLY COMES AGAINST THE IMMORTALITY ON EARTH FALSE TEACHING!

In Hebrews 11:37-39 we read another passage which presents the death of believers in clear-cut terms:

37 They were put to death stoning; they were sawed by two; they were killed by the sword. They went about in sheepskins and goatskins, destitute, persecuted and mistreated— 38 the world was not worthy of them. They wandered in deserts and mountains, living in caves and in holes in the ground.

39 These were all commended for their faith, yet none of them received what had been promised

Notice that the death of believers is referred to here ('these were all commended for their faith' – Heb. 11:39). The one who was 'sawed in two' was perhaps Prophet Isaiah according to Bible Scholars. The live man cut by a hack-saw in Hebrews 11:37, Bible Scholars tell us, is Prophet Isaiah. The heretical immortality now teachers say that if you have faith, you can be immortal here and now. But Hebrews 11:39 talks about those were commended for their faith. Who had this faith? Those sawed into two, those killed by the sword, those who went about in sheepskins and goatskins, destitute, persecuted and mistreated! When people were placed

in sheepskins and goatskins, it resulted in bone-crushing death as these animal skin shrunk, thanks to the work of the weather. This was an innovative way of sending people into slow, painful death. The end of these people, followers of the living God with faith, was not immortality on earth. But martyrdom and death. You can have the faith that you will be immortal even now. But that faith will not make you immortal! The Bible teaches with clear examples that immortality on earth before the return of Jesus is not a possibility.

BY NOT RAISING UP JOHN THE BAPTIST FROM THE DEAD, JESUS....

Let us move on to another example against the heretic immortality on earth teaching. For that we need to move to Matthew chapter 14. Yes, Jesus is a 'funeral-spoiler'! Did he not raise Lazarus from the dead? Did he not raise the young man, the only son of his mother, and give him back to her? Did he not raise up a little girl? But I want to say that Jesus would only spoil funerals of his choice! If we carefully read the Gospels, we would know that Jesus did not go around spoiling every funeral. Let's us read Matthew 14:12-13:

"John's disciples came and took his body (John the Baptist's body) and buried it. Then they went and told Jesus. When Jesus heard what had happened, he withdrew by boat privately to a solitary place. Hearing of this, the crowds followed him on foot from the towns."

This passage tells us that the same way people gave the news about Lazarus' death to Jesus, they also gave the news of John the Baptist's death to Jesus. **But the Jesus who chose to raise up Lazarus from the dead, did not choose to raise up John the Baptist!** If it was Jesus' absolute will that He would raise up all dead people he came in touch with, then he would have resurrected John the Baptist. John the Baptist's death comes against the immortality on earth false teaching. The theology of Jesus comes against the immortality on earth teaching, as we can see via the above passage. John the Baptist was given a purpose in life. Once that purpose is fulfilled, the concerned persona is taken away from this world, should the coming of the Lord tarry. This is as simple as that. "Now when David had served God's purpose in his own generation, he fell asleep; he was buried with his ancestors and his body decayed" (Acts 13:36).

When the news of John the Baptist's death reached Jesus, he could have definitely reached the spot and raised him from the dead. But he did not choose to do that. John the Baptist's task of preparing people for Jesus' first coming was done. So I was not surprised that when he died, Jesus did not raise him from the dead!

JAMES DID NOT THUNDER, "I AM IMMORTAL!', BEFORE HE DIED!

We are looking at examples in the Bible to illustrate that even believers in Jesus can experience normal death. In this connection we will see the passage, Acts 12:1-2 next:

It was about this time that King Herod arrested some who belonged to the church, intending to persecute them. He had James, the brother of John, put to death with the sword.

This James, who died, is a disciple of Jesus, is also among the "sons of thunder" (Mark 3:17). We must notice that this death of a Jesus-believer took place post the death and resurrection of Jesus. We must not forget that James' martyrdom took place after the Cross of Christ. If the apostles believed in Immortality on Earth, Luke, the author of the book of Acts could have added this line: 'Believers in Jesus do not die, but for some strange reason, James had to die.' But we read no such line! The apostles did not teach immortality on earth! This is a strange new heretic teaching which modern cultic preachers – like the pastor in Chennai and Madurai have sadly invented! For Luke, the author of the Book of Acts, the death of a disciple of Jesus, was something that would normally happen as Jesus' coming was delayed (In Acts 7, Stephen, another believer, who held responsibilities in the church also died as a martyr). So do not believe in the Immortality on Earth lie. It is a lie, because there is no Scriptural support for the same. We have direct teaching from the Bible against this teaching (see previous chapter). We have many examples from the Bible against this teaching as we are seeing in this chapter. No one in their right sense will believe this lie! This teaching is clearly stupid!

So James, the son of thunder did not thunder: "I believe on Immortality on Earth! I believe on Immortality on Earth!" I am sure he was ready to die for Jesus the way Stephen was.

So, where is the ground for us to believe in Immortality on Earth? Where are the examples? Just because Paul narrowly escaped a few deaths, it does not mean that he believed in immortality on earth! Otherwise he would not write, "Even death cannot separate us from the Love of Christ" (Rom. 8:35-40).

HOW MY WIFE AND I READ THE BIBLE TOGETHER DURING LOCKDOWN!

During the lockdown, my wife and I started reading the Bible using an innovative Bible Reading plan! **We read one chapter each from eight different sections of the Bible! First**, we read one chapter from the law books of the Bible, the section which comprises of Genesis to Deuteronomy; **Second**, we read one chapter from the Old Testament History books of the Bible, a segment which contains all books from Joshua to Esther; **Third**, we read, one chapter from the Poetry section of the Bible, a section that encompasses all books from Job to Song of Songs; **Fourth**, we read next, one chapter from Isaiah to Malachi, the Old Testament Prophetic Chunk of the Bible; **Fifthly**, following that, we read a chapter from Mathew to John, the Gospels section of the Bible; **Sixthly**, we read next, one chapter from the important book of Acts; **Seventhly,** we read one chapter from the epistles section of the Bible, Romans to Jude; **Eighthly** and finally, we read one chapter from the New Testament Prophetic section of the Bible, the book of Revelation.

ANTIPAS – A LITTLE-KNOWN BOOK OF REVELATION-MENTIONED MARTYR WHOM I WANT TO POPULARIZE TO QUELL THE 'NO DEATH FOR BELIEVER' CULT....

This meant that on the second day of doing this, we were reading Revelation 2. In Revelation 2, we bumped into an ignored example against the immortality on earth teaching. I am referring to Antipas here. Jesus has this to say about him as he spoke to the church at Pergamum: "I know where you dwell, where Satan's throne is. Yet you hold fast my name, and you did not deny my faith even in the days of **Antipas**, my faithful witness, who was killed among you, where Satan dwells" (Rev. 2:13, ESV). 'Amid oppressive paganism, a believer named **Antipas** had sealed his testimony with his life, and Jesus shares with Antipas his own title, **faithful witness (see Rev. 1:5)' – so we read in the ESV Study Bible! Think of it – Jesus shared his own title of 'faithful witness' (Rev. 1:5) with Antipas (Rev. 2:13), who was ready to die for the sake of Jesus!** When believes who die have Jesus' appreciation, then who are these cult teachers to tell us that "believers should not die"! They are anti-Jesus definitely!

Reading the Bible, a chapter each from different sections, also helps us to steer clear of false teaching, as I have illustrated above!

Also we have a sad example of one of the believers of the premier church, that teaches immortality on earth, dying! He was relatively young! Yet even after that, the Chennai pastor continued to teach immortality on earth! How terrible!

"THOSE WHO PREACH HOLINESS, STUMBLE. SIMILARLY, 'THOSE WHO PREACH 'IMMORTALITY ON EARTH' CAN ALSO DIE!" - A REBUTTAL

The Madurai pastor, who also teaches 'immortality on earth' came to the rescue of the Chennai Pastor who teaches 'immortality on earth' by employing this bizarre argument: 'those who preach holiness, don't they sin? So, why not those who preach immortality experience death in their ranks!' Let me offer a rebuttal to this. First of all those who preach holiness would not say that believers would stop sinning on this side of eternity. 1 John 1:8 says, 'If we claim to be without sin, we deceive ourselves and the truth is not in us.' The writer of this letter, Apostle John, the senior most church leader alive then, includes himself in this category of those who sin by using the word 'we'. Apostle James said in James 3:2 in the same vein, "We all stumble in many ways". So holiness preachers, if they taught the Bible accurately, would never talk about sinless perfection. Of course they will talk about fighting sin till death (Heb. 12:4). In case there is failure, there needs to be immediate repentance (Rom. 2:4-5). The believer who was told to be excommunicated from the church for his sexual affair

with his step-mother in the city of Corinth (1 Cor. 5) apparently repented. That is why Paul wrote these words: so you should rather turn to forgive and comfort him, or he may be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow. So I beg you to reaffirm your love for him (2 Cor. 2:7-8). Only in the new heaven and in the new earth, will there be no sin because when Jesus appears for the second time, we will be like him without sin (1 John 3:2). So the argument, "since those who preach about holiness commit sins at times, those who preach about immortality on earth can also die," is not water-tight. It is, infact, a shallow, stupid argument.

WHY IMMORTALITY ON EARTH FALSE TEACHING IS BEING PREACHED: MY ANALYSIS

So why is this immortality on earth teaching being served among the Body of Christ? I think I know why! The Biblical evangelists keep warning their audiences about any-time death! Because that kind of preaching does not sound like music to the listener's heart, so false teachings which directly come against it like immortality on earth are put forth! But Jesus preached those kinds of messages in-effect. He talked about the case of a Sudden Death in the Old Testament – the death of Lot's wife – and said, "Remember Lot's Wife!" (Luke 17:32). She became a pillar of salt when she had one last look at sin! So Jesus' message was this, in-effect: "Remember, you too can die when you want to have one last look at sin – one last look at that porn site for example! Come to me, now, in repentance!" Because this generation does not like this kind of straight preaching, we have these false teachers who say, "you won't have to die" (cherry picking some verses from the Bible as the support – all

verses taken out of context). Yes, if you are going to be immortal here and now as these false teachers assert, you cannot ask the classical evangelistic question based on Luke 12:20, "if you die tonight, where will you go?" So, these Immortality-Now cultists surely want to promote their teaching and, not surprisingly, find a following huge among the many who hate classical, biblical evangelistic preaching. If you believe this wrong teaching, you cannot preach this: "Only if you abide in Christ on a minute-by-minute basis, can you go to heaven! And if you were to suddenly die when you are living in stubborn sin, you will not go to heaven!" (an assertion that can be made on the basis of Romans 8:1 which say that there is no condemnation for those who ARE in Christ Jesus, not ONCE UPON A TIME were in Christ). Preaching immortality on earth puts a stop on that kind of biblical preaching – can you see?

DEATH IS A MEANS TO REACH GOD'S PRESENCE! THE BIBLE SAYS SO!

'Precious in the sight of the LORD is the death of his saints' (Psa. 116:15). Why is death of the saints precious in God's eyes? The moment the saint dies, he gets to be with Jesus as the New Testament tells us, the way Adam and Eve lived with the Living God before the Fall, literally (Phil. 1:23 - I am torn between the two: I desire to depart and be with Christ, which is better by far). Immortality now cultic pastors do not understand that death is a Bible-mentioned means by which we enter the very presence of Christ and they needlessly oppose it.

Revelation 14:13 is the New Testament version of Psalm 116:15. It says,

'Then I heard a voice from heaven saying, "Write: The dead who die in the Lord from now on are blessed." "Yes," says the Spirit, "let them rest from their labors, for their works follow them!"'

The Old Testament says "precious" and the New Testament says "blessed" when it comes to the death of the saints/believers! They both more or less mean the same thing! There is nothing new in the New Testament as one Bible Scholar said! The New Testament repeats what the Old Testament says in shadow, in substance!

SIX TIMES IN JOHN 15, THE SCRIPTURE SAYS 'ABIDE'!

Instead of taking breaks to live in sin, we must seek to always remain in Jesus by saying 'no' to sin. This is a command given in John 15 in-effect. It says there in that chapter, a six stunning times – see verses 4,5,6,7,9,10,11 – that we must 'abide' in Christ. The meaning – no taking short breaks to commit sin as and when we feel like it! Should his coming get delayed, we will all definitely die. But the Goodnews is this, death is not a tragedy for the believer – it is simply an out-of-turn promotion into the literal presence of God.

CHAPTER 29

'A' FOR ANNOUNCEMENT OF IMMORTALITY IN THE BIBLE AND COUNTERING 'IMMORTALITY NOW' CULT'S WRONG INTERPRETATION OF THESE



Using Acronym D-E-A-T-H To Counter The 'No-death For Believers' Cult | Interpreting Correctly The Bible Passages Which Immortality Cult Preachers Quote From

My purpose in writing this book is this: a remnant would embrace sound doctrine and escape from hell-populating false teaching. This doctrine, we are now discussing, has been variously called by these names: Immortality on Earth, Immortality Now, Physical Death Cancellation, etc. We now move to the third letter in the D-E-A-T-H acronym, we are using to counter this Physical Death cancellation cult.

The letter is "A". And that reminds us of the Announcement of Immortality in various Bible passages and the correct interpretation for the same. The false teachers will quote these passages as their 'proof' text. But as we keep reading this chapter with an open mind, we will figure out that the false teachers are wrongly interpreting the Bible.

As I mentioned before, four popular preachers (**Chennai Pastor/Madurai Pastor/South India's Leading Christian YouTube Sensation-Singer/Kerala 'Prophet' with a church in Adoor**) were to address a conference in which Physical Death cancellation would be taught in Chennai (April 2020). This conference was cancelled. The Covid pandemic put an end to it. But we continue to hear these kinds of strange teachings in South India and other parts of the World, even as I write these words.

Now back to this long Bible Study, we are doing as a rebuttal of these strange teachings.

A MAN TRAVELLING FROM JERUSALEM TO JERICHO: THE SHALLOW BIBLE READER VERSION!

Let me start this chapter with a story, I heard a preacher narrate:

A Sunday School teacher asked Sam this, "Will you tell me the parable of the Good Samaritan?" Sam replied, "Yes sir, I will!" And Sam went on:

"Once there was this man travelling from Jerusalem to Jericho. And he fell among thorns. And the thorns sprang up and choked him. And as he went on his way, he did not have any money. And there he met the queen of Sheeba and she gave him a 1000 talents and 100 changes of raiment. And he got into a chariot and drove furiously. When he was driving under a big Juniper tree, his hair got caught on the limb of the tree. And he hung there for many days. And the ravens brought him food to eat and water to drink. And he ate 5000 loaves of bread and two fishes. One night, as he was hanging there asleep, his wife Delilah came along and cut off his hair and he dropped and fell on the stony ground. He got up and went on and it began to rain. And it rained and rained for forty days and forty nights. And he hid himself in a cave and lived on locusts and wild honey. And he went on till he met a servant who said, "Come take supper in my house". And he made up an excuse and said, "I have married a wife and I can't go". And then the servant went to the highways and hedges and compelled everyone to come in. After supper, he went in and came down to Jericho. And when he got there he looked up and he saw the old queen Jezebel sitting down, up high in the window. She laughed at him. "Throw her down," he said. And the people next to her, threw her down. And he said "Throw her down again!" And they threw her down, seventy times seven. And of the fragments that remained, they picked twelve basketfuls besides women and children. And they said, "Blessed are the piece makers! Now whose wife will she be on that Judgment Day?"

That's what Sam said when his Sunday School teacher asked him to narrate the story of the Good Samaritan!

As you are smiling away listen to what the preacher said after narrating this joke: 'That's brilliant. Great story. Wrong context! And you know what, a day is going to come when people won't even laugh at a story like this because they won't know what is funny about this! They will not know enough of the biblical narrative to see the messed up context this creative genius has
done!'

This Sunday School boy has messed up the context, mixed up characters from different narratives and come up with a fantastic story! But a few days down the line, a few months down the line, a few years down the line, or perhaps even now, Christians will not know what is funny about such a story. Because Christians of our time do not know the Bible narrative well. That is the sad reality!

WE HAVE PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION AND SUCH CULTS BECAUSE WE HAVE SO MANY SUCH SHALLOW BIBLE READERS

And may I say we have teachings such as physical death cancellation because of this kind of ignorance of biblical narrative and messed up contexts? Yes, these kinds of strange teachings that violate the over-all message of the Bible have followers in our time, as people do not know the full story of the Bible or have not read and comprehended the message of the Bible. Dear reader, Hell-populating false teaching take full

advantage of the fact, that you may not be reading the Bible as thoroughly as you should! That is why, I close this book with a chapter on the importance of reading the Bible.

We are now going to use the "A" of the acronym DEATH as the main core for the rest of this chapter.

"A" stands for Announcement of Immortality in the Bible (with the correct interpretation). In Acts 12, Luke talks about the martyrdom of James, the church leader. This is after Jesus died on the Cross. This is after Jesus rose from the dead. This is after Jesus starts to pray for the believers sitting at the right hand of God. It does not say in the book of Ruth or for that matter, any where else in the Bible, this;: "Believers are not supposed to die, but somehow Apostle James
died!"

1 Corinthians 15: 23-26 is often quoted by the 'no death' camp as proof. Let us unpack it. It goes this way:

But each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then at his coming those who belong to Christ. [24] Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and every authority and power. [25] For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. [26] The last enemy to be destroyed is death.

Please underline the phrase "at his coming" at the start of this passage. It is only after the coming of Jesus, the last enemy (even death) will be destroyed.

A Chennai pastor says that the feet of Jesus mentioned in 1 Corinthians 15:25 is the church as Colossians 3:18 calls the church as the body of Christ. And he goes to say, "And so the church, you and I, will destroy death (moving on the next verse). That is, church believers need not die."

THE BIZARRE INTERPRETATION OF THE PHRASE 'FEET' OF JESUS IN 1 CORINTHIANS 15 BY 'NO DEATH FOR BELIEVERS' CULT

But it is very clear from 1 Corinthians 15:23 that what is spoken of here happens only at the Second Coming of Jesus. It is clear from 1 Corinthians 15:24 that after the Second Coming, Jesus will destroy every rule, authority and power. This has not clearly happened as Jesus has not yet come back. So the context of 1 Corinthians 15:23-24 suggests that the "feet" referred to in 1 Corinthians 15:25 is the literal feet of Jesus, the Jesus who returns as a Judge and wages war against all who oppose Him and obliterates them. Therefore, to say that the "feet" of Jesus are believers and that they will obliterate death in their lives before the Second Coming is a bizarre interpretation that totally disregards the context of 1 Corinthians 15:23-26.

CHENNAI PASTOR'S WRONG COMBINATION BIBLE INTERPRETATION ERROR

This error by this Chennai Pastor is called 'wrong combination' by Sound Bible Interpretation Principle teachers.

To illustrate this, they give a famous example. Here it is: A man opened the Bible randomly and his eyes fell on Matthew 27:5 which said, "Judas went and hung himself." He closed his Bible and he opened his Bible again. This time His eyes fell on Luke 10:37 which said, "Go and do likewise". He told himself: "Judas went and hung himself. And you go do likewise". He was perplexed at the suggestion. And closed the Bible yet again and opened it randomly and read this verse which was John 13:27, which said, "What you are about to do, do quickly!" And he combined the three verses to say: "Judas went and hung himself. Go and do likewise. And what you are about to do, do quickly!" When we wrongly yank Bible verses out of context and combine them, even suicide can be defended. This is a terribly wrong way, shall we say, it is a suicidal way of Bible Interpretation! We know that wrongly combining Bible verses pulled out of context will bring us to commands that are clearly contradictory to the overall message of the Bible. Suicide is not an option for a child of God as Jesus is the author of life (Acts 3:15) and none of us have the right to take it away.

USING WRONG COMBINATION BIBLE INTERPRETATION METHOD TO WRONGLY SUPPORT TERRORISM

Let me give you another example of 'wrong combination' when it comes to Bible Interpretation. Let's say someone randomly opens the Bible and finds Matthew 10:11 which says, "when you go into the city or village

look for people". And then you close the Bible and agai open the Bible randomly and your eyes fall on Deuteronomy 13:5 which reads, "You must kill the residents of the city with swords and destroy the city and everyone in it." So is the Bible asking us now, "Destroy any city we enter in the twenty-first century with swords and kill everyone in it"? No! The Bible clearly does not support a terror attack! Another example of dangerous Bible interpretation using wrong combination!

This is not the correct way to interpret the Bible! Wrong combination in Bible interpretation amounts to dangerous interpretations! It is a brazen violation of the Bible context! We are called to handle the Word of Truth in the right way (2 Tim. 2:15).

JESUS, WHEN HE RETURNS, WILL DESTROY THE LAST ENEMY DEATH

Let us look at the announcements about immortality made in the New Testament carefully. One announcement is from 1 Corinthians 15:23-26. We already saw the right interpretation for that passage. This passage is very clear. Who must reign over everything according to this passage? Jesus. Who must destroy death, the last enemy? It will be Jesus according to the full weight of this passage. And when will death, the last enemy, be finally defeated? 1 Corinthians 15:23 clearly says that it will happen 'at his (Jesus') return'. When the plain meaning of the Biblical text makes sense, we must not look for some other meaning! This is a cardinal rule

of Bible Interpretation! But hell-populating false teachers do that with this passage and several other passages! The Bible is very clear: Jesus, when he returns (1 Cor. 15:23) will destroy the last enemy of death (1 Cor. 15:26).

READING ONE CHAPTER FROM APOCALYTIC BIBLE CHAPTERS DAILY!

The Bible teaches the same thing elsewhere, as well. Let us turn to the Book of Daniel. During the Covid lockdown, I began a practice where I read one chapter from the apocalyptic ('end of the world') literature of the Bible. The Book of Revelation with 22 chapters is one such book. And also, Daniel 7 through 12 (five chapters) is another clearly apocalyptic section of the Bible. I would read the chapter corresponding to the day of the month from the book of Revelation. And from Day 23 of the month I would switch to the book of Daniel, chapter 7. This way I would be wrestling with the apocalyptic chapters from the Bible daily! This habit greatly enhanced my understanding of these heavy-duty chapters and gave me an understanding of what would happen during the last days of world history. Yes, some of us read five chapters from the Book of Psalms every day – a process that will help finish the full book of Psalms in one month (a book with 150 chapters). Yes, some of us read one chapter from the Book of Proverbs every day – a habit that will help us complete the full book of Proverbs in one month (as this Book has 31 chapters). Yes, some of us read one chapter from the book of Acts daily – a process that helps us complete this book even before the month ends. But reading a chapter from

apocalyptic literature of the Bible (Revelation 1-22; Daniel 7-12) is also something we must definitely try. These godly habits will greatly benefit our spiritual growth.

DANIEL'S MESSAGE: JESUS RETURNS FIRST, ONLY THEREAFTER, IMMORTALITY!

Let's go to Daniel 7:13-14. It goes this way:

13 "In my vision at night I looked, and there before me was one like a son of man, coming with the clouds of heaven. He approached the Ancient of Days and was led into his presence. 14 He was given authority, glory and sovereign power; all nations and peoples of every language worshiped him. His dominion is an everlasting dominion that will not pass away, and his kingdom is one that will never be destroyed.

The message of this passage is very simple and direct: Jesus is coming back and only after that would there be everlasting life! Instead of the word 'immortality' as in 1 Corinthians 15, here in Daniel 7, it is 'everlasting'. So from both, 1 Corinthians 15 and from Daniel 7, I understand that Jesus returns first and thereafter the believers will experience immortality.

We come across this key truth in Daniel 7:22 and 27 yet gain. We read this there:

'22. until the Ancient of Days came and judgment was passed in favor of the saints of the Highest One, and the time arrived when the saints took possession of the kingdom.

27. Then the sovereignty, the dominion and the greatness of *all* the kingdoms under the whole heaven will be given to the people of the saints of the Highest One; His kingdom *will be* an everlasting kingdom, and all the dominions will serve and obey Him.'

Daniel 7 introduces Jesus, as the 'one like a son of Man coming with the clouds of heaven'. Surely this passage is talking about the second coming of Jesus (compare with 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17). The Bible is a remarkable book – even before the first coming of Jesus happened as a historic event, the Second Coming of Jesus is predicted (in Daniel 7:22). Not just that, the Bible predicted the upcoming judgement of the saints in Daniel (see Dan. 12:2)! And in Daniel 7:27, we read a description of the kingdom of the Ancient of Days, a kingdom he will establish after his return, and that kingdom will be an 'everlasting kingdom'!

If we carefully understood the message of Daniel 7:22-27, we would not miss-out and mess-up the very similar message we read in 1 Corinthians 15:23-26!

MATTHEW'S MESSAGE: JESUS RETURNS FIRST, ONLY THEREAFTER, IMMORTALITY!

The same thing is mentioned in Matthew 25. Matthew 25:31-32 reads, "But when the Son of Man comes in His glory, and all the angels with Him, then He will sit on His glorious throne. All the nations will be gathered before Him; and He will separate them from one another, as the shepherd separates the sheep from the goats."

This is a clear mention of the second coming of Jesus. After that what happens? Scroll down. Read verse 46 of the same chapter. And this is how Matthew 25:46 reads, "These will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life."

The order of events in Mathew 25 is also similar to Daniel 7 and 1 Corinthians 15: first the return of Jesus, then the day of judgement and finally believers being given the gift of 'eternal life' (or immortality, or no-death life). There is no way the believers can have eternal life before the return of Jesus, in the literal sense!

PAUL'S MESSAGE IN THESSALONIANS: JESUS RETURNS FIRST, ONLY THEREAFTER, IMMORTALITY!

The truth of Daniel 7, 1 Corinthians 15, Matthew 25 is repeated in 1 Thessalonians 4. There, Apostle Paul confirms what the Bible declares so clearly elsewhere, this way: For the Lord himself will come down from heaven, with a loud command, with the voice of the archangel and with the trumpet call of God, and the dead in Christ will rise first. After that, we who are still alive and are left will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And so we will be with the Lord forever (1 Th. 4:16-17).

Notice the order here: the return of Jesus and only after, that believers get to live with the Lord forever (or have literal immortality).

WHETHER ONE BELIEVES IN ONE SECOND COMING OR RAPTURE FOLLOWED BY SECOND COMING....

Though there are Bible Teachers who teach that I Thessalonians 4 talks about the secret rapture, there are those who believe that I Thessalonians 4 talks about the public second coming of Jesus which is also one and the same as what is called as 'rapture'. This is a big topic and is beyond the scope of this book. But the fact remains, without Jesus returning secretly or publicly, believers cannot live 'forever' (or have 'immortality on earth' experience). Whether one believes in one Second Coming or one believes in Rapture followed by Second Coming, the fact remains, immortality for believers does not happen before rapture or before the Second Coming (whatever school of eschatology you belong to).

To make matters worse, this cultic no-death group believes that Jesus will not return until a generation rises in the universal church which believers believe that they will not die here on earth (again based on a twisting of 1 Corinthians 15:52).

But this I Thessalonians 4 passage clearly says that Jesus will first come back and only after that we believers will be with the Lord forever (meaning, we believers will reach a state where we will not die).

So, the wrong interpretation of 1 Corinthians 15 made by this cultic hell-populating Immortality-Now group is clearly righted by what the Bible teaches in Daniel 7, Matthew 25 and even here. As I write these lines, I hope

I also gave you an idea as to how to formulate sound Christian doctrine. We have a doctrine only when the Bible repeatedly talks about one matter in different places! We cannot make a doctrine with one stray reference to support what we say! We also need to see what the epistles say about the matter in which we want to formulate a doctrine. Why? We need to follow Christ as the apostles followed Christ (see 1 Cor. 11:1) – not according to our whims and fancies. He and other apostles repeat the same thing using different words many more times in the epistles.

FOLLOW THE APOSTLES WHEN IT COMES TO DOCTRINE: THIS IS REPEATED 11 TIMES!

Here is the exhaustive list of verses where we are told that we need to follow the apostles when it comes to practice and doctrine:

#1

They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer (Acts 2:42)

#2

Therefore I urge you to imitate me (1 Cor. 4:16)

#3

Follow my example, as I follow the example of Christ (1 Cor. 11:1)

#4

Now I commend you for remembering me in everything and for maintaining the traditions, just as I passed them on to you (1 Cor. 11:2)

#5

Join one another in following my example, brothers, and carefully observe those who walk according to the pattern we set for you (Phil. 3:17)

#6

Whatever you have learned or received or heard from me, or seen in me, put it into practice. And the God of peace will be with you (Phil. 4:9)

#7

And you became imitators of us and of the Lord when you welcomed the message with the joy of the Holy Spirit, in spite of your great suffering (1 Thess.1:6)

#8

For you, brothers and sisters, became imitators of God's churches in Judea, which are in Christ Jesus: You suffered from your own people the same things those churches suffered from the Jews (1 Thess. 2:14)

#9

Not that we lack this right, but we wanted to offer ourselves as an example for you to imitate (2 Thess. 3:9)

#10

We do not want you to become lazy, but to imitate those who through faith and patience inherit what has been promised (Heb. 6:12)

#11

Remember your leaders who spoke the word of God to you. Consider the outcome of their way of life and imitate their faith (Heb. 13:7)

There you have it – at least 11 times you have the teaching that we must follow Jesus as the apostles followed Jesus! So, for doctrine and conduct we must return to what the apostles said about that matter or issue!

If the apostles do not endorse a teaching, we should not endorse such a doctrine! Clearly the apostles were NOT teaching immortality on earth before the return of Jesus in 1 Corinthians 15!

Paul's teaching about this matter is comprehensive in I Thessalonians 4: He says that some believers have died and will continue to die should the return of Jesus delay. That is why, he pens these words: 'Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope' (1 Thess. 4:13). And those who died in Christ will come back with Jesus when He returns to the earth, Paul writes (1 Thess. 4:14 – 'For we believe that Jesus died and rose again, and so we believe that God will bring with Jesus those who have fallen asleep in him'). And in the same chapter, I Thessalonians 4, Paul writes that there will be other believers who could remain alive until the return of Jesus – these believers will be made immortal when they meet the returning Jesus (1 Thess. 4:16-17). When we understand this straight from the Word of God we will not be certainly fooled by the no-death cult which bluffs us saying 'no death for believers in Christ'!

BOOK OF REVELATION'S MESSAGE: JESUS RETURNS FIRST, ONLY THEREAFTER, IMMORTALITY!

Even the book of Revelation teaches that people become immortal after the return of Jesus – did you know?

Revelation 19:11 talks about the return of Jesus. Here it is: 'I saw heaven standing open and there before me was a white horse, whose rider is called Faithful and True. With justice he judges and wages war.'

Post that, there will be an eternal reign of God, as Revelation 22:5 says:

'There shall be no night there: They need no lamp nor light of the sun, for the Lord God gives them light. And they shall reign forever and ever.'

That means, before the return of Jesus, there is no 'forever and ever' life for believers! They may have to die! Yes, they (believers) will 'reign forever and forever'! After the Second Coming! Not before it!

In this chapter, we are using the acronym D-E-A-T-H to understand why the no-death-for-believers teaching is cultic. We are currently in the letter "A" in the acronym. And A stands for Announcement of Immortality in the Bible – the right interpretation.

ONE MORE ANNOUNCEMENT WITH REGARD TO IMMORTALITY IN THE LATER PART OF 1 CORINTHIANS 15

There is yet another announcement of immortality in the Bible in the latter part of 1 Corinthians 15.

This announcement comes from 1 Corinthians 15:50 onwards. Let us read that passage:

50 I tell you this, brothers: flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom of God, nor does the perishable inherit the imperishable. 51 Behold! I tell you a mystery. We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, 52 in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trumpet. For the trumpet will sound, and the dead will be raised imperishable, and we shall be changed. 53 For this perishable body must put on the imperishable, and this

mortal body must put on immortality. [54] When the perishable puts on the imperishable, and the mortal puts on immortality, then shall come to pass the saying that is written:

"Death is swallowed up in victory."

[55] "O death, where is your victory?

O death, where is your sting?"

As you can see, there is an announcement concerning immortality in 1 Corinthians 15:53 – this perishable body must put on the imperishable and this mortal body must put on immortality (ESV).

This passage talks about death being defeated as well (see 1 Cor. 15:54-55).

So when will both these things happen – the believer's body becoming immortal and death being defeated? 1 Corinthians 15:52 is very clear: these twin things will happen "When the trumpet will sound….".

These hell-populating, heretic false teachers take advantage of the fact that there is no explicit reference to the second coming of Jesus to the trumpet and give it a bizarre twist. They say that the teaching that they give which says, "Believers in Jesus are immortal here and now before the Second Coming" is actually the trumpet which is being talked about in 1 Corinthians 15:52. **This fanciful interpretation is not true.** This is a wrong teaching – a wrong teaching that can land the heretic pastors and their congregations in hell.

INTERPRETING THE WORD 'TRUMPET' IN 1 CORINTHIANS 15:52

How do we interpret the word trumpet? The most obvious way is to ask, "Did Apostle Paul use the word trumpet in his other letters?" If you use a website like biblegateway.com and set the version to the reliable, essentially literal translation such as the English Standard Version (ESV) and search for the word 'trumpet', you will find out that Apostle Paul used the word trumpet only one other time in his New Testament writings. And that is in 1 Thessalonians 4. There he writes,

> For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first (1 Thess. 4:16, ESV).

Here Paul uses the word 'trumpet' in connection with the second coming of Jesus. Therefore it is reasonable to say that the trumpet used in 1 Corinthians 15:52 is talking about the trumpet call that comes along with the second coming of Jesus. And as Jesus comes with the trumpet blaring believers who are still alive will become immortal and will defeat death. The meaning of the trumpet is the second coming announcing trumpet not the cultic preaching of the Immortality-Now brigade! We must interpret Scripture with Scripture and it makes sense to interpret Paul with his own writings elsewhere! Also in 1 Corinthians 15:23-26 Paul teaches the same thing again in 1 Corinthians 15:50-55: the second coming of Jesus precedes believers who would be alive that

point in history becoming immortal and defeating the last enemy death. If the reference of trumpet is vague in 1 Corinthians 15:52, we must ask where else Apostle Paul wrote about the trumpet and connect with what he wrote in 1 Corinthians 15:52. And the reference that Apostle Paul made to the trumpet in 1 Thessalonians 4:16 concerns that trumpet that sounded as Jesus returns to the earth. So it is safe and sound to say that when the trumpet call of the second coming is sounded the believers alive then on the planet will become immortal and defeat death literally.

DO NOT TWIST SCRIPTURE TO MAKE IT SAY SOMETHING WHICH THE WHOLE OF THE BIBLE DOES NOT CLEARLY SAY!

There is one reference to 'trumpet' in the book of Hebrews that is worth a mention. In Hebrews 12:19 we read of a trumpet. This trumpet-sounding was featured in an Old Testament event which already took place. So this trumpet has no connection to the 1 Corinthians 15:52 trumpet. The Hebrews 12:19 trumpet talks about the historical event recorded in Exodus 19. Here Moses goes up the Mount Hermon (Mount Sinai) to receive the 10 Commandments from God even as the people were waiting below. **There is a reference to a trumpet in Exodus 19:13, 19:16 and 19:19. Ibn Ezra (born 1093), a Hebrew scholar and Pentateuch Bible commentator of repute, says an angel sounded this trumpet.** The trumpet at Mount Horeb was not sounded by humans. Even

if this cross-reference is considered when it comes to interpreting the trumpet found in 1 Corinthians 15:52, we can say this: the trumpet of 1 Corinthians 15:52 is not sounded by humans and therefore cannot be compared to human preaching of the Immortality-Now false teaching (as the no-physical-death cultists wrongly teach). The no-physical-death cult should be warned not to fool people by twisting scripture to come up with bizarre conclusions that violate the overall New Testament message.

TWISTING JESUS' DEATH FOR ALL TO TEACH, IMMORTALITY NOW CULT

We will move to another major New Testament theme which the no-physical-death cultist use to teach immortality now for believers before the return of Jesus. They use the New Testament passages that talk about the substitutionary death on the Cross to wrongly teach about immortality on earth.

They argue this way: "Jesus died on our behalf. So because Jesus died, we don't have to die!" They quote 2 Corinthians 5:14 which says this as their proof text: 'For the love of Christ controls us, because we have concluded this: that one has died for all, therefore all have died.'

The Madurai Immortality-Now pastor says this in-effect: "Yes, Hebrews 9:27 says 'man is destined to die once and after that face judgement'. But I have already died when Jesus died for me according to 2 Corinthians

5:14. So I will not have to die again! I am already immortal now!" But this is a wrong interpretation! Let me explain why.

Read the very next verse and you will understand that this is a wrong interpretation! If we do not read the Bible in context, we will start to believe in hell-populating false teaching! This verse, 2 Corinthians 5:15 says this: 'and he died for all, that those who live might no longer live for themselves but for him, who for their sake died and was raised'. Please notice that the life that Jesus gave us even as he died on the Cross, as 2 Corinthians 5:14 says, is a spiritual life of unselfish living. When we start to live for others, we may have to give up even our lives for them, as Apostle John mentions in 1 John 3:16. It reads this way: 'By this we know love, that he laid down his life for us, and we ought to lay down our lives for the brothers'. So the life that Jesus died to give us – we must be ready to lose it! **John Allen Chau** lost it as he tried to unselfishly share the Gospel with some tribals in one of the island the Andamans in 2018. **Jim Elliot, Nate Saint, Pete Fleming, Roger Youderian,** and **Ed McCully** died in 1956 as they tried to unselfishly share the Gospel with the Huaorani people who lived in the area between two the tributaries of the Amazon River in Ecuador.

THE MEANING OF THIS IS SURELY SPIRITUAL!

This is not the only place where Apostle Paul stresses on the spiritual meaning of the 'life' that Jesus gives us,

thanks to his death on the Cross. Let me give you another reference. It is Galatians 2:20. It says, "I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me." Paul could have easily said here: "Christ died. I too died along with Christ. So we are immortal now!" But he did not teach that. Rather he focussed on the spiritual meaning of that Christ-given life here. The meaning is this: "Christ's death on the Cross has given me a new life which I need to demonstrate to others, transformed by this faith, that Christ died for me and I too died (spiritually) with him." If we (literally) live even after being 'crucified' (spiritually) with Christ according to Galatians 2:20, we can also die (literally) after living the life (spiritually) that Christ gives us by his work on the Cross! Galatians 2:20 teaches that "the (spiritual) life I now live" with my wife, kids and co-workers will be greatly impacted by Christ who died for me and imparts spiritual life into me! The meaning is surely spiritual!

This is even more clear in Galatians 5:24. It says, 'And those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.' The meaning implied is spiritual surely because the word 'crucified the flesh' is spiritual. If that phrase is not to be taken spiritually, then all of us have to arrange for a pastor to nail us on a Cross literally and die in that process in obedience to Galatians 5:24! We may laugh reading these lines! Permit me now to say that it is also laughable when Immortality-Now cult pastors teach, "Jesus died for us on the Cross to give us life and so we will not ever have to die!" The meaning of the 'life' Jesus gave us through His work on the Cross is spiritual as seen above! Yes, literally we will eventually be given immortality when Jesus

returns as so many Bible passages teach (we have seen them above). But until then, we all have a very good chance of dying!

What is the spiritual message of Galatians 5:24? The desire to watch porn, the desire to go into fits of rage, the desire to over-sleep, we must 'crucify' (put to death), thanks to Jesus' work on the Cross!

PAUL WRITES ABOUT THE CERTAINITY OF DEATH FOR BELIEVERS SHOULD JESUS' COMING DELAY, IN CORINTHIANS!

What is another reason why we cannot use 1 Corinthians 5:14 to teach immortality on earth? This: Paul elaborately writes about the certainty of death in the same set of letters – Corinthians!

2 Corinthians 4:8-12 says,

[8] We are afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not driven to despair; [9] persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed; [10] always carrying in the body the death of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be manifested in our bodies. [11] For we who live are always being given over to death for Jesus' sake, so that the life of Jesus also may be manifested in our mortal flesh. [12] So death is at work in us, but life in you.

PAUL WAS READY TO DIE – HE DID NOT BELIEVE IN THE 'IMMORTALITY NOW' LIE!

This passage says that the apostles were ready to die, put their lives at risk as they went about with the task of evangelism. So that the life of Jesus will be made manifest in the churches, they ministered in, with a 'death may come to me, but I don't care' attitude! What is the worst thing that can happen when you preach the Gospel? You can get killed? The apostles were fine with that eventuality (See Paul's words in Acts 20:24; 21:13; Rom. 8:35; 2 Tim. 4:6). The apostles knew if they died while they were preaching the Gospel, it would only mean an out of turn promotion to immortality – an eternal life in heaven! They were not scared. As was Jim Elliot and his four friends. He famously said, "He is no fool to give what he cannot keep (that is, one's own life – we are going to die one day, if Jesus' return delays), to gain what he cannot lose (an eternal life in heaven)!"

There is another place in Corinthians where Paul clearly indicates that death here and now is a possibility. 2 Corinthians 5:1 says, 'For we know that if the tent that is our earthly home is destroyed, we have a building from God, a house not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.'

Here Paul uses the imagery of tent for the believer's body. There is a possibly that the tent can be destroyed, he says (meaning, the body can cease to live). But, we have nothing to worry as there is an eternal home waiting for us!

So, right in the book of Corinthians itself, there is a clear teaching about the possibility of believers dying. So, there is no way that Paul would have taught immortality on earth when he wrote 1 Corinthians 5:14 ('For Christ's love compels us, because we are convinced that one died for all, and therefore all died').

Let me copy paste from the excellent VOICE version of the Bible, the four times Paul said he did not mind dying for the sake of the Gospel:

Acts 20:24

But that's OK. That's no tragedy for me because I don't cling to my life for my own sake. The only value I place on my life is that I may finish my race, that I may fulfill the ministry that Jesus our King has given me, that I may gladly tell the good news of God's grace.

Acts 21:13

Paul: Please, you're breaking my heart with your tears! *I know exactly what I'm doing*. I'm fully prepared to be bound, and more—to die for the name of Jesus, the King.

Romans 8:35

So who can separate us? What can come between us and the love of God's Anointed? Can troubles, hardships, persecution, hunger, poverty, danger, or even death? *The answer is, absolutely nothing*

2 Timothy 4:6

For I am already being poured out, *and the last drops* of this drink offering *are all that remain*; it's almost time for me to leave. [Love *The Message* version of the same verse which goes this way: You take over. I'm about to die, my life an offering on God's altar].

There you have it – not just once, not just twice, not just thrice but four times did Paul say, "I would/ could die!"

So, to use any of Paul's words to teach immortality on earth is a travesty as he himself did not believe for a second that he could be immortal here and now!

The Immortality-on-Earth gang also uses Hebrews 9:27 to teach the faulty doctrine: "No death for believers in Jesus"!

This is what Hebrews 9:27 says,

'And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.'

The no-physical-death cult teaches that, as this verse says, it is only "appointed for MAN" to die once, this verse cannot be therefore used to teach that death can come to BELIEVERS! To use this verse to teach that believers can also possibly die here on earth, this verse must read like this: "It is appointed for believers to die once and after that face judgement..." (their argument). But since this is not the case, Hebrews 9:27-28

also cannot be used to support the no-death cult (Two Christian Leaders, leaders of two big Pentecostal denominations in India, quoted this verse to counter this no-physical-death cult in their short videos/sermons).

But, Hebrews 11:36-40 talks about the possibility of death for believers, did you know? Let us read it together in the VOICE version:

[36] Others suffered mockery and whippings; they were placed in chains and in prisons. [37] The faithful were stoned, sawn in two, killed by the sword, clothed only in sheepskins and goatskins; they were penniless, afflicted, and tormented. [38] The world was not worthy of these saints. They wandered across deserts, crossed mountains, and lived in the caves, cracks, and crevasses of the earth. [39] These, though commended by God for their great faith, did not receive what was promised. [40] That promise has awaited us, who receive the better thing that God has provided *in these last days*, so that with us, our forebears might finally see the promise completed.

IN THE MIND OF THE AUTHOR OF HEBREWS, NO-DEATH-FOR-BELIEVERS TEACHING, NEVER EVER ENTERED!

Here, the writer of the epistle to the Hebrews (could have been Priscilla or Barnabas or Apollos or someone else) talks about the shining examples of believers (they were commended by God for their faith – see Hebrews

11:40) who were 'sawn in two, killed by the sword' (see Hebrews 11:37). So in the mind of the author of Hebrews the doctrine "believers in Christ do not die" did not enter! Some would argue that Hebrews 11 talks about Old Testament believers only and so won't apply to present-day believers. However, in Hebrews 11:40, the writer of Hebrews uses the phrase, 'us who receive the better thing' (meaning the New Testament covenant sealed with the work of Jesus who died on the Cross) to club New Testament believers with the Old Testament believers as one group. The Old Testament believers looked forward to Jesus and were saved (John 5:39; John 12:41; Acts 10:43; 1 Peter 1:11). We, the New Testament believers look back to Jesus (and his work on the Cross which is an event that already took place inside the Trinity's mind in Eternity-past – Revelation 13:8) and are saved! Both the categories of believers were saved by Jesus and His Work on the Cross!

FOR THE SECOND TIME IN HEBREWS, THE AUTHOR TALKS ABOUT BELIEVERS DYING!

Also, in Hebrews 12:4, the same writer issues a complaint to this predominantly Jewish church where several believers were backsliding briskly. They were sadly returning to their old Jewish faith (which was well-accepted by the local government). If they did not return to the Jewish faith, their property was plundered. But the believers who once upon a time accepted this plundering 'joyfully' (Heb. 10:34), were now backsliding. This was the complaint of the writer to the Hebrews: the church he wrote to, was not ready to die for Jesus, but he wanted them to be **martyrdom ready**! This is how I understand Hebrews 12:4 which reads this way: 'Among

you, in your striving against sin, none has resisted *the pressure* to the point of death, as He did' (Heb. 12:4, VOICE). We know that this Spirit-inspired anonymous writer talks about the Cross at the start of this chapter – Hebrews 12. So just as Jesus was ready to die to offer salvation for us, we also must be ready to die as we live the Saved Life and as we proclaim this Salvation among hostile peoples! **There you go again – for the second time, the writer of the epistle of Hebrews is talking about believers dying!** So, to suggest that he wrote Hebrews 9:27 ('man is destined to die once…') not referring to believers but only unbelievers is wrong! The book of Hebrews is clearly not teaching immortality on earth! Of course, the rest of the Bible also does not! Only these hell-populating cultists sadly do!

Let me remind you what we are doing in this long chapter: we are using the letter "A" in the acronym D-E-A-T-H before us to remind us why we must not believe in the 'no physical death for Jesus-followers' cult. 'A' stands for Announcement of Immortality. We have studied passages in the Bible that announce about the Immortality on Earth. We have so far seen how these cultic, hell-populating, Immortality-Now pastors are twisting these 'announcement' passages to bring the false teaching that 'believers in Jesus need not experience physical death if they choose to before the return of Jesus'.

REFUTING THE USE OF 2 TIMOTHY 1:10 TO SUPPORT IMMORTALITY NOW

2 Timothy 1:10 is also quoted by the Immortality-Now gang to support their unbiblical teaching. The verse reads this way:

"but it has now been revealed through the appearing of our Savior, Christ Jesus, who has destroyed death and has brought life and immortality to light through the gospel."

I have seen that whenever I post an 'anti-immortality now' post on social media, this verse is the most commonly posted rejoinder! They say, "There you have it – in 2 Timothy 1:10. That verse says that the gospel brought immortality to us!" How do we interpret 2 Timothy 1:10 which is commonly quoted by Immortality-on-Earth cult preachers? Read the two verses above it. Read the verse in context! I cannot adequately stress the importance of reading the Bible in context!

WHEN AN AMERICAN CULT QUOTED THE BIBLE OUT OF CONTEXT TO PROMOTE SEXUAL IMMORALITY

The **'Children of God'** is **an American cult** that notoriously quoted a verse in Acts to teach that Believers can have sex outside of marriage to bring people to Jesus. Do you know what verse they quoted? They quoted Acts 2:44 which says, 'All the believers were together and had everything in common'. This cult taught based on this

verse, 'The early church believers lived together and even shared husbands and wives between themselves'. This is not true! The book of Acts, the book from which they cherry-pick this verse, warns against sexual sin three times – in Acts 15:20, Acts 15:29 and Acts 21:25. So obviously, when we read the Bible in context, Acts 2:44 does not teach that husbands and wives were shared between believers in the Early Church.

In the same way, when we read the two verses above 2 Timothy 1:10, it becomes obvious that 2 Timothy 1:10 was not teaching immortality on earth! What is the thrust of 2 Timothy 1:8-10? It is this: "I am in prison right now. I may be killed anytime. But the Goodnews is this: even though I be killed, I am in-effect immortal as I will be raised up from the dead. You remember what I wrote to the Thessalonians, dear Timothy? We who are dead shall raise up when Jesus returns in the clouds!" And in 2 Timothy 4:6, Paul underlines the same thing: he is about to die. I am posting different versions of 2 Timothy 4:6 to underline this:

For I am already about to be sacrificed [my life is about to be poured out as a drink offering]; the time of my [spirit's] release [from the body] is at hand and I will soon go free (AMPC)

As for me, it is nearly time for me to die. My death will be like a drink offering that they pour out to God. My life as God's servant will end (EASY)

[For] My life is being ·given as an offering to God [L poured out as a drink offering; Num. 28:24; Phil. 2:17], and the time has come for ·me to leave this life [my departure]. (EXB)

As for me, the hour has come for me to be sacrificed; the time is here for me to leave this life (GNT)

You take over. I'm about to die, my life an offering on God's altar (MSG)

As for me, my life has already been poured out as an offering to God. The time of my death is near (NLT)

PAUL COULD NOT HAVE REFERRED TO HIS POSSIBLE DEATH IN 2 TIMOTHY IF HE MEANT BELIEVERS CAN BE IMMORTAL NOW IN 2 TIMOTHY 1:10!

Paul cannot teach in 2 Timothy 1:10 that believers will not die in this earth as the 'physical-death-cancellation' cult says, when he says, that he himself is expected to die in 2 Timothy 4:6 – is it not? Yes, if Paul taught immortality before the return of Jesus in 2 Timothy 1:10 (as Immortality Now cult pastors claim), he won't be talking about his immanent death in 2 Timothy 4:6! Paul could have said in 2 Timothy 4:6: "You read me correctly in 2 Timothy 1:10 – the gospel we preach includes a immortality now package! So even though I am close to death now, I will forever keep escaping it! I will still be around to meet you all physical-death-cancellation teaching pastors in 2024!" Jokes apart, Paul says NONE of that! In fact, he says just the opposite: I am about to die – in a few seconds, or minutes, or hours, or days or months or years. So 2 Timothy 1:10, 'announcement of immortality' does not teach immortality on earth!

ROMANS 2:7 AND THE 'IMMORTALITY ON EARTH' CULT TEACHING

Let us go to the final passage which contains an announcement of immortality used by Physical Death Cancellation cultists. And that is Romans 2:7. It reads this way: 'To those who by persistence in doing good seek glory, honor and immortality, he will give eternal life'. The Chennai Physical-Death-cancellation cult pastor says, quoting this verse, "If 'immortality now' is not possible before the return of Jesus, why does Paul say in Romans 2:7, 'seek immortality'?" My response would be this: "We cannot make a doctrine out of one verse! Just as the Colossians 1:15 phrase, used for Jesus, 'the first born of all creation' cannot mean that Jesus is not God and is a created being as Jehovah Witnesses wrongly say! There are other clear passages that attribute Divinity to Jesus. Titus 2:13 for example! And there is a convincing explanation for what Paul is trying to say in Colossians 1:15. In the same way, there are other clear passages, such as Romans 14:8 (If we live, we live for the Lord; and if we die, we die for the Lord. So, whether we live or die, we belong to the Lord), which contradict the teaching that Jesus-followers would be immortal. And there is an explanation for what one reads in Romans 2:7!

What is Romans 2:7 effectively saying? **Apostle Paul would perhaps say this in response**: "We must seek not just immortality but also glory and honor. How? By getting intimate with the only one who has all these qualities already – God. Immortality, honor and glory are all gifts! But as you know very well from ages past,

you must seek the Giver of the Gift who is God, not the mere gift (remember the Lord Jesus' words in Matthew 6:33). Yes, he alone is Immortal and worthy of Honor and Glory! Read what I, Paul, wrote to Timothy in 1 Timothy 6:17 (Copy pasting that for your convenience: 'Now unto the King eternal, immortal, invisible, the only wise God, be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen')! Yes, God alone is worthy of glory and honor! Our God does not give his glory to another or his praise to idols as Prophet Isaiah put it eloquently in Isaiah 42:8. Yes, all honor belongs to our God as our big brother John put it in Revelation 7:12. So, in an ultimate sense, all glory, honour and immortality belongs only to God! But wait, he is about to share this with us in the future in a way He sees fit! Yes, God will give all these to us when we cross over to eternity and spend eternity with him! There is an ultimate glorification we look forward to as believers! **After we die or after Jesus returns, we believers will all get a disease-free glorious body**. So, wait! Don't jump to the conclusion after you read Romans 2:7 that you can all become immortal now itself if you seek immortality!"

Paul continues his explanation of Romans 2:7, this way (in my Bible-soaked imagination): "Read Romans 8:18 where I, Paul, say this: 'I consider that our present sufferings are not worth comparing with the glory that will be revealed in us.' Notice I use the future tense here! 'The glory that will be revealed in us!' This happens in the future! We have a glory that awaits us in heaven! We will be given glorious bodies when Jesus returns as I, Paul, mention clearly in Philippians 3:20-21! In the same way, we will be given honour in the future (the honour of hearing Jesus' well-done to you as mentioned in Matthew 25:23) and OfCourse, we will be given the

gift of immortality, when Jesus returns – I will speak about this more clearly in I Thessalonians 4:16-17 and 1 Corinthians 15:50-52! So, by looking forward to the return of Jesus, you look forward to your glory, honour and immortality! Aren't you excited?"

I want to underline this here: while the false teachers seek to divert us by asking us to seek the gifts (like immortality) by taking verses out of context, like in the case of Romans 2:7, we must not forget the over-all message of the Bible is this: we must seek God, the giver of these gifts first, and then all these things will be added to us in due time according to the Scriptural time-frame (after-death or after the Second Coming)!

Again, please do not forget this: no verse from Romans (including Rom. 2:7) can be used to teach immortality on earth or the 'no physical death for believers' false doctrine as Romans itself talks about the possibility of death in Romans 8:35!

WIELD THE BIBLE SWORD RESPONSIBLY

Let's interpret the Bible responsibly and escape hell-populating false teaching! The Bible is sharper than a double-edged Sword (Eph. 6:17; Heb. 4:12). And this super-sharp Sword needs to be wielded (interpreted) responsibly. If we wield it without sense, without applying obvious rules of interpretation like how the Hyper-Grace/Hyper-Love/Hyper-Supernaturalism false teachers gang does, taking Bible verses out of context and

giving meaning to the Biblical text which the Divinely inspired authors never intended to give in the first place, it is a very dangerous thing to do! It will land the wielder of the Sword and those affected adversely, in hell! Not only that, these false interpretations will make life on the earth, a living hell, for those who propagate and believe it!

It is my prayer that a remnant of the multitudes deceived by hell-populating false teachings such as Hyper-Grace, Hyper-Supernaturalism, Hyper-Love will be rescued! It is my prayer that an army of Bible Teachers will arise to faithfully proclaim the Word of God using sound principles of Bible Interpretation! It is my prayer that this group will proclaim the truth of God's Word even if it does not sound like music to the ears of the hearers! It is my prayer that this small group (as it is likely to be) will complete their ministry without being distracted so that they can hear the Lord's 'well-done' on that Final Day!

CHAPTER 30

'T' FOR THREE KINDS OF DEATH, THE BIBLE MENTIONS



Using Acronym D-E-A-T-H To Counter The 'No-death For Believers' Cult

Four young preachers were to preach in a conference in the last week of April 2020 in Chennai, teaching believers, who would come there, on "immortality on earth". The pandemic forced them to cancel this. But we continue to hear teachings like these from them: "If you believe in Jesus, you can choose not to die!" We have so far used the outline D-E-A-T-H to sound a bugle against this false teaching. Hopefully, this acronym will make the biblical points against the physical-death-cancellation cult memorable! We have finished till the "A" of this acronym. Revisit the previous chapters to get a hang of this. In this chapter, I take up the "T" of this acronym. T stands for the three kinds of death, the Bible Talks about.

THE *IRUTTU KADAI ALVA* SHOP OWNER: HIS SAD STORY

He was the owner of a famous sweet shop in Tirunelveli in South Tamil Nadu. His name was Hari Singh. His *alva* (famous sweet of Tirunelveli) shop was Iruttu Kadai (the shop of darkness). This shop was well known. One newspaper said, "Unlike well-illuminated modern-day sweet shops, this shop was lit by a single bulb which previously used to be an oil lamp in the dark, earning its name!" The shop was not known for its ambience but for the quality of sweets it churned out to the folks who would wait in a queue to buy sweets from there. Within an hour of being told that he tested positive for the Corona Virus, Hari Singh, 80 years of age, hung himself to death from the bathroom window of the private hospital he took treatment in, using a towel (various newspaper reports on 26 June 2020).

MORE SHOCKING SUICIDES!

This chapter is about the worst thing a disease-causing virus can do to you (they can make you die). **Sushant Singh Rajput** also ended his life at the age of 34, in 2020. **Preksha Mehta**, a 25-year-old actress known for her roles in one of the longest running crime shows on TV in the world, *Crime Patrol*, hung herself to death in her home in Indore, in 2020. She hung to death from a ceiling fan. She left a note as she died. This note said, "My shattered dreams have broken my confidence. I can't live with dead dreams. It is difficult to live in this

negativity. I am trying since one year to do that." If I had a one-on-one conversation with you, you may also perhaps tell me about your dead dreams and meaningless existence! I am not done yet: let me share one more real story of death by suicide. **Siya Kakkar**, just 16, a social media star with 2 million followers in TikTok, ended her life by suicide on 25 June 2020. If 2 million people want to follow your content, you should be wanting to live in this world creating fresh content for your followers! But the exact opposite happened: she chose to end her life!

Yes, death by suicide can come to folks who appear to have everything, including riches and fame! Only a relationship with Jesus will 'free those who all their lives were held in slavery by the fear of death' (Heb. 2:15 NRSV). Notice here that the writer to the Hebrews does not say that a relationship with him will save us from death, here and now. Instead, he says, that Jesus saved us from 'the fear of death'!

THE LAST TIME YOU HEARD A SERMON ON DEATH WHEN THE OCCASION WAS NOT A FUNERAL OR MEMORIAL SERVICE?

We are in the "T" of the D-E-A-T-H acronym which we are using to establish from the Bible that death is not cancelled for those who trust in Jesus as their Saviour. The letter T stands for Triple Death. Yes, the Bible talks about three kinds of death. **The word 'death' is used in the English Standard Version of the Bible 459 times.**

You are perhaps part of a church as you read these words of mine. You are perhaps following the ministry of your favourite preacher over social media. When was the last time you heard a message on death in your church or from your favourite preacher (and the occasion was NOT a funeral service or memorial service)? The Bible talks about death, more than 400 times. If the church you go to emphasised what the Bible emphasised, then you will definitely hear sermons on death. If the man of God you regard greatly, preached to you what you must hear and not just what you want to hear or what sounds like music to your ears, then he would most definitely preach to you about death, for the Bible talks about it, 459 times! If your church wants you to hear the full truth from the Bible, and not just the half-truth (which in-turn is a full lie), then you will hear Bible sermons on death.

THE BIBLE SAYS, 'BE CONSCIOUS OF YOUR MORTALITY'; 'IMMORTALITY NOW' CULT FALSE TEACHERS SAY, 'BECOME CONSCIOUS OF YOUR IMMORTALITY'!

In Ecclesiastes 7:1, the Bible says, 'the day of death than the day of birth'. Why? Because after we die, we get to live in the very presence of God (Phil. 1:23). The Bible says in Psalm 90:12, 'So teach us to number our days that we may get a heart of wisdom'. The message here is simple: we must be ever-conscious of our mortality; we must be ever-conscious of the fact that we can die at any moment (See how this sharply contrasts the false

teaching of these false pastors from Chennai and Madurai who say exactly the opposite in-effect: "We must come to a consciousness that we can become immortal now"!).

MEETING OUR GOD: THE TWO POSSIBILITIES!

The Bible tells us in Amos 4:12 that we must prepare to meet our God. How do we do that? There are two possibilities: 1. We go to meet him. 2. He comes to meet us. How do we go to meet him? When we die! How does he come to meet us? When He returns to the earth to judge the earth in the Second Coming. So we must be ready for both: our any-second death or Jesus' any-second Second Coming! That is how we obey Amos 4:12!

APOSTLE PAUL WAS OKAY WITH BOTH OPTIONS!

If some of you, reading this are perhaps saying, "This is from the Old Testament!" I must tell you that there is nothing new in the New Testament (as one Bible Scholar put it). We don't have a confused God who communicates in contradicting ways. In the Old Testament, Jesus was in *Shadow*. In the New Testament, Jesus is in *Substance*. In Romans 14:8 we read: "For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord's." From this, it is very clear that Apostle Paul was okay with both the two options presented in Romans 14:8:

1. Living for Jesus till the Second Coming.

2. Dying while He was still on the Earth so that He can Live with Jesus forever in eternity.

The Bible talks about three kinds of Death. The context of the passages will tell us that. In the English language the same word has different meanings.

THE THREE DIFFERENT MEANINGS OF 'SPRING'!

For example, take the word "Spring". It has three different meanings as per the context of usage. It means "a natural flow of water from beneath the ground." Spring also means a season of the year between winter and summer. A Spring also can mean, "a coil of wire which bounces back to its original shape".

THE FOUR DIFFERENT MEANINGS OF 'DATE'!

The word "Date" has three meanings. Meaning number one, it is a fruit ("Datasha's favorite fruit is Date."). Meaning number two, it is a romantic interaction between two people ("Duke took his wife, Evan on a date."). Meaning number three, a time period ("What is your date of birth?"). [There can be a fourth meaning for the English word, 'Date', if we included **Kimiko Date**, a Japanese professional Tennis player who ranked as high as Number 4 in the World in the year 1995!]

Likewise the word 'death' in the Bible means three different things depending on the context it is used in. So, when the cult pastors quote John 11:25-26 to say, "Believe in Jesus and you won't die", do not believe them. Instead ask, "What kind of death does this passage speak about?"

Let us talk about the three kinds of Death, the Bible talks about. **The first kind of Death is Spiritual Death.**

The first step of being saved is a realisation that we are spiritually dead before our encounter with Jesus.

WHAT DID GOD MEAN WHEN HE TOLD ADAM, 'YOU WILL CERTAINLY DIE'?

In Genesis 2:16-17, God spoke about death when he addressed the first man, Adam. He said, "And the LORD God commanded the man, "You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat from it you will certainly die." God was primarily referring to spiritual death here. I already told you that the word "Spring" has different meanings in different contexts. I already told you that the word "Date" has varied meanings in varied contexts. **Similarly the word "death" has different meanings in different contexts.** God told Adam, "In the day you eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you will die" (Gen. 2:17). And Adam and Eve when they ate from the same tree did die – they died spiritually. They would eventually die again – that would their physical death (another kind of death) [Genesis 5:5 records Adam's physical death at the ripe old age of 930; so, in the day Adam ate of the fruit,

Adam died spiritually and many years later, he died physically]. And if they (Adam and Eve) were not abiding in Yahweh when they died, they would die eternally (another kind of death which is no death at all – it means living in Hell forever and ever, see Rev. 21:7-8).

WHEN THE FATHER OF THE PRODIGAL SAID, 'THIS SON OF MINE WAS DEAD', WHAT DID HE MEAN?

In the New Testament, when Jesus went about doing his ministry, he talked about death a lot. He does so in the parable of the Lost Son. The Lost Son spent all the money he grabbed from his father in wild living. And when he finally came back with a repentant heart, the Father told him this: 'For this son of mine was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found' (Luke 15:24). Was this son dead, literally speaking? No! Spiritually speaking, he was dead! His spiritual deadness was equivalent to his utter sinfulness. What was the Lost Son's sin? He spent his energy in "wild living" ("living lecherously" says WYC version), trying to fill the vacuum in his heart (Luke 12:13). Going by what his older brother felt about his formerly bold-in-sin younger brother, this lost son also "spent all (his dad's) money on prostitutes" (Luke 15:30, PHILLIPS). The lesson here is clear: living in sin – be it porn-watching or sex outside of marriage or any other sin – results in spiritual death. In fact, we are all born

spiritually dead as the Bible talks about the original sin in our lives which was passed onto us by our sinful parents (Psa. 51:5; Jer. 13:23; Rom. 5:12,19).

WHAT DID JESUS MEAN WHEN HE TOLD A DISCIPLE, 'LET THE DEAD BURY THEIR OWN DEAD'?

Jesus also talked about spiritual death in Matthew 8:21-22 where the Gospel writer records an interaction between Jesus and a disciple of Jesus. The narrative goes this way: 'Another disciple said to him, "Lord, first let me go and bury my father." But Jesus told him, "Follow me, and let the dead bury their own dead."'

When Jesus used the phrase, 'let the dead bury their own dead', he was referring to spiritual death. The New Living Translation of the Bible puts Matthew 8:22 this way: But Jesus told him, "Follow me now. Let the spiritually dead bury their own dead." What Jesus said can be rephrased this way: "Don't wait for your unsaved, spiritually dead father to grow old and die before you become my Disciple who follows me wherever I go! Come now!" The truth of the matter was this: this Disciple's dad was very much alive! What he was telling Jesus in-effect was this: "Let my dad first die! Obviously we do not know when he would die. Yes, He could even live for the next 20 years! Or next 25 years! Once he dies, let me finish the funeral and then I will follow you Jesus! So I need some time to come and follow you, Jesus!" If his dad was dead, he would not be talking to Jesus – he would be at the funeral of his dad! So what the disciple was bringing to the attention of Jesus, was, at best,

a lame excuse not to follow Jesus immediately! But Jesus wanted his service, right-away! Jesus wanted him to 'follow Him, the Lamb, wherever he went' (Rev. 14:4, this phrase used for the 1,44,000 can be applied to the disciples of Jesus). It was a powerful call against procrastination when it comes to matters like joining full-time ministry citing family commitments! **Jesus was of the viewpoint that those unsaved (who were deemed spiritually dead) in that disciple's family will most definitely bury his dad (whenever his dad would die)!** That is why the phrase 'let the dead bury the dead' is used in Matthew 8:22 by our Lord. This is not to say that the Bible teaches that we must not attend funerals. The Bible says, 'You learn more at a funeral than at a feast—After all, that's where we'll end up. We might discover something from it' (Eccl. 7:2). But Jesus, the God who knows everything, knew that **the disciple we meet in Matthew 8:21-22 was only giving him a lame excuse trying to postpone his missionary journeys with Jesus**, he would have to undertake as a disciple. We could also say that that Jesus was effectively calling this disciple spiritually dead. "If you do not seek first God's Kingdom and its righteousness but have misplaced priorities that leads to procrastination when it comes to being an on-road disciple of mine, you are spiritually dead!" – we get this sense as well, from Jesus' words to this disciple.

So, the first death the Bible talks about is spiritual death. It is quite possible that as you read these words of mine, you are spiritually dead, in sin. Realizing that you are spiritually dead is the first step of salvation.

Paul talks about this in the book of Ephesians. He writes in chapter 2:1-3,

'And you were dead in your offenses and sins, in which you previously walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience. Among them we too all previously lived in the lusts of our flesh, indulging the desires of the flesh and of the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, just as the rest.'

The hallmark of one dead in offenses and sins as pointed out by Paul here, is this: they indulge in the desires of the flesh and of the mind (Eph. 2:3). In our context, it can mean those given to the habit of watching porn and having sex outside of marriage. It could mean being proud and prayerless (1 Sam. 12:23, even prayerlessness is sin).

What is the end result of being dead in sin? This passage says that such people are 'by nature children of wrath' (Eph. 2:3). The implication is that they were headed to hell. Life in Hell is also one kind of death. We shall shortly see that as well. It is called **Eternal Death, the third kind of death, the Bible talks about.** We will come to that kind of death shortly.

The first step of salvation is a recognition of spiritual death and only Jesus can resurrect us from our spiritual deadness. Other religions talk about bad people becoming good. **The Christian faith is the only faith which talks about dead people becoming alive! It is unique!** It is one of a kind! There is no parallel to it!

SEE THE CONTEXT FIRST – DON'T RUSH TO BELIEVE BIBLE-QUOTING PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION PASTORS!

Exodus 10:17 reads this way: "Now therefore, forgive my sin, please, only this once, and plead with the LORD your God only to remove this **death** from me" (ESV). Here the word, 'death', does not mean literal death. But the meaning is this: the pain which the locust plague brought to Pharaoh, was as piercing as the pain which literal death normally brought, and, he wanted immediate relief from it. This goes to show that when Physical Death cancellation pastors quote a Bible verse to 'prove' that believers need not die, you don't have to rush to believe them. Instead, you must ask, "What does the word 'death' mean in this context?"

We are using the acronym D-E-A-T-H to understand why the "no death for believers" teaching is against the Bible. We are in the T of the acronym now. T stands for Triple Death, the Bible talks about. And the first kind of death the Bible talks about is Spiritual Death.

The second kind of death the Bible talks about is Physical Death. We can talk about Physical Death mentioned in the Bible all day as the Bible talks about many characters who experienced actual, literal, physical death. The people whose deaths we talked about at the start of this chapter, perhaps believed that physical death was a gateway for all their problems to cease. But that is not true. When you commit suicide, it is like jumping from a fire pan into the furnace. Jesus is the "Author of Life" (Acts 3:15). And only He has the right

to be the finisher of our life! Not you! Not a doctor who administers Euthanasia death to you. This Author of Life says, "Come to Me, all who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest" (Matt. 11:28). All our suicide-causing restlessness can become rest only if we repent from sin and come to Jesus who died for us on the Cross, by faith. If you reject Jesus and commit suicide, you will die and go to a place which is far worse, hell (the third kind of death the Bible talks). Committing suicide, as I already mentioned, is akin to jumping from the fire pan into the furnace. Don't do it!

WHEN THE BIBLE SAID THAT THIS MAN DIED, IT WAS TALKING ABOUT HIS PHYSICAL DEATH!

Yes, the second kind of death the Bible talks about is Physical Death. In the chapter where we talk about the E part of this D-E-A-T-H acronym, we have provided several Examples (E for example) of many Bible Characters who have experienced Physical death.

One man in the Bible got ready for his physical death in a bizarre way. His name was Ahithophel. In 2 Samuel 17:23, we read this about his death arrangements: 'When Ahithophel saw that his advice had not been followed, he saddled his donkey and set out for his house in his hometown. He put his house in order and then hanged himself. So he died and was buried in his father's tomb.' Who was Ahithophel? He was a counsellor and advisor to King David, the greatest king of Israel (2 Sam. 15:12). "He put his house in order and then hanged

himself," the Bible says about him (2 Sam. 17:23). A better way to put your house in order would have been to repent and put his trust in the Coming Messiah, Jesus! This trust would have prevented him from attempting suicide – a suicide that was triggered by a professional failure [his core job was to give advice to the rulers; his latest advice to prince Absalom was spurned (2 Sam. 17:1-6) and he just could not handle it].

WHAT DAVID DID, HURT AHITHOPHEL DEEPLY

We also know that something that David did deeply hurt Ahithophel. David killed his grand son-in-law (not sure, if there is a word like this, but you sure get what I am saying, right?) and David took his grand-daughter. Who was Ahithophel's grand son-in-law? Uriah, the Hittite! Who was his grand-daughter? Bathsheba! These days, you don't need a Bible Teacher to tell you this! The Bible cross-references, that tell us this are just google searches away! 2 Samuel 11:3 and 2 Samuel 23:34 give us enough clues to make Ahithophel the grandpop of Bathsheba. Ahithophel carried a grudge against David, Bible Scholars say. So when Absalom, David's son, rebelled against David, Ahithophel joined the ranks of Absalom. There were times when Absalom listened to Ahithophel. Once, Ahithophel said to Absalom, "Sleep with your father's concubines in the palace terrace in the sight of all Israel!" and Absalom obeyed this counsel immediately! So, we can see here that Ahithophel gave ungodly advice, vengeful advice.

IF ABSALOM LIVED TODAY, HE COULD BE A MALE PORN STAR

As a result of Ahithophel's advice, Absalom became one of the earliest stars of blue films – porn movies (we can see it that way). 2 Samuel 17:14 says that God was upset with Absalom and he was planning judgement upon him. A lesson for us here: the sins of porn-watching or porn-production (which Absalom was involved in) angers God and we must repent of it. And an advisor for porn-production, Ahithophel eventually felt so empty that he committed suicide! Ahithophel's next counsel to Absalom was sound and not as sickening as this one, but Absalom did not obey it! And Ahithophel took his life! Ahithophel's second counsel to Absalom was basically a good plan to finish off David quickly. But Absalom listened to the advice of David's mole in Absalom's ranks, Hushai. And perhaps, Ahithophel feared backlash from King David and killed himself. The sins he committed (evil counsel and supporting porn-production) left Ahithophel empty and he ended his life. **Porn-watching and porn-production still leaves us that way, if we spoke the truth! Let us repent of those and come to Jesus and receive a cleansing from His Blood!**

It is quite possible that as you read these lines, you are about to lose your job or have already lost your job! It is quite possible that you have faced an embarrassing professional failure like Ahithophel did! Don't think of ending your life because of that! Why? We have a God who knows the end from the beginning (Isa. 46:10). He is

able to do a miracle for you according to His Will. He can open a way for you and provide you a better job than that you previously had.

WHEN A MINISTRY LEADER TOLD ME, 'YOU WILL NEVER MAKE IT IN MINISTRY'!

In 2005, a Christian Leader who I reported to, told me, "You will never make it in ministry!" He said this because he was angry with my resignation letter which I handed over to him. I had to resign because the work I was given, did not match what was told to me about the nature of my work. I trusted God even as I took this daring step – quitting a job without an appointment for the next one. In February of 2006, my wife and I started a ministry called Grabbing the Google Generation from Gehenna Mission (G4 Mission). And today, as I type these words, I can say that God has blessed G4 Mission and us beyond belief. God has given me the grace to preach His Word in 20 different Indian States and in seven nations (including Germany, United Arab Emirates and Singapore) with the organisers paying for my travel and sending me the ticket in advance – a noble way of doing ministry. The God who took care of me, can take care of you as well.

We were in the mind of God before we entered our mother's womb (Eph. 1:4). So as long as we have life in our nostrils, we must live life and glorify God. We must not end our life like Ahithophel did.

So that's about physical death. Be ready for it. But do not commit suicide. **Committing suicide is a sin, as it is an attempt to usurp God's exclusive right to take away life (1 Sam. 2:6).** Live your life in a way that it becomes a blessing to others committing it to the Author of Life, Jesus (Acts 3:15).

So this is what I tell myself: "Duke, God has created you to be a donkey who must carry His Word for the Google Generation. So, as long as you have breath in your nostrils or till the return of Jesus, fulfil your call!"

So this day, let it be a blessing to our family and to the families of this earth (Gen. 12:1-3).

So far we have seen two kinds of death: spiritual death and physical death. **Finally, we get to talk about a death which none of us should experience! That is eternal death!**

The Bible talks about Eternal Death so many a times. In Revelation 20:6, the Bible says, 'Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection! Over such the second death has no power, but they will be priests of God and of Christ, and they will reign with him for a thousand years.'

THE WAY TO ESCAPE SECOND DEATH – ETERNAL DEATH (LIFE IN HELL)

If you believe that Jesus died on the Cross for your sins and that Jesus rose again from the dead (that is the first resurrection), you escape second death (life in hell – see Revelation 20:14 and Revelation 21:8, both of which say that life in the lake of fire, is second death). Second death is nothing but everlasting torment in the lake of

fire. Why do we call Jesus' resurrection as the first resurrection? I will tell you why: while there are people who rose from the dead, they all died yet again – alive-again Lazarus died again, the alive-again little girl died again, the alive-again son of the widow died again! But Jesus' resurrection is the very first resurrection where there is no death again after the resurrection! So in short, Revelation 20:6 says that even if we experience a physical death, we will not experience second death (which is eternal death, an everlasting life in hell), because of our faith in the first resurrection (the resurrection of Jesus)!

'DEATH AND HADES WERE THROWN INTO THE LAKE OF FIRE' - THE EXPLANATION

Let us read Revelation 20:14 again. It says, 'Then death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. The lake of fire is the second death'. Notice here that even death and hades was thrown in the lake of fire! What is the meaning? First, let us talk about death which is mentioned here. When a person enters the lake of fire, his ability to die, dies! Why? Because there is no death in the lake of fire! Because the life in the lake of fire is a place of eternal torment from which there is no respite, no escape via death (Rev. 20:10). So death 'died' in the lake of fire which is also called hell (Mark 9:47-48). Till death dies in Hell making its occupants live forever as Revelation 20:10,14 predicts, there will be physical death on this earth! Why does the Bible say in Revelation 20:14 that even hades is thrown into the lake of fire? In Luke 16:23, we read that even in hades (hades is hell, as it is, at this very second, not that different from hell or lake of fire of the future – see Rev. 20:14 which says that

all occupants of hades will be thrown into the lake of fire after the Day of Judgment) the Rich Man who had ignored Lazarus was being tormented. So, all those unbelievers and backslidden believers in the inter-mediate state of unbelief will be packed off to the lake of fire. In the lake of fire there will be all folks from the dawn of time who rejected the Lamb of God, previously dead or presently alive (see Rev. 20:15). Jesus called that place as hell adding that the torment for its occupants will be forever quoting Isaiah 66:24 (Mark 9:47-48). The cult group in Chennai that teaches that believers need not die if they chose that option, also teaches that we can cross over from hell to heaven. They are speaking lies. You could go to hell and burn there forever along with them! Don't believe their lies! Let us pray for their repentance! I speak straight because I love you, the reader! I love you and therefore I cannot but tell you the truth! Eternity is at stake here! If you went to a doctor and the doctor knew you had cancer, you would love the doctor if he told you the truth and sets you on a path for cancer treatment! That is what I trying to do, spiritually speaking, here!

ETERNAL DEATH IS ETERNAL! YES, HELL PUNISHMENT IS FOREVER!

Mark my words: the Bible repeatedly teaches about eternal conscious punishment for those who go to hell (they will not die there; they will not cease to exist). Revelation 21:8, written for believers says this: 'But the cowardly, the unbelieving, the vile, the murderers, the sexually immoral, those who practice magic arts, the idolaters and all liars—they will be consigned to the fiery lake of burning sulphur. This is the second death.'

These false teachers say that the only sin that takes us to hell is the public denial of Jesus. However, passages like Revelation 21:8 tell us that even sins (plural), when we stubbornly stay in them without repenting, can take us to hell. So, we must be careful to overcome sin, enabled by His Grace! No, we will not be perfect on this side of eternity (Phil. 3:20-21; 1 John 3:2, when we see Jesus as He returns again, we shall be made perfect)! But the striving towards perfection is the call for each one of us (Matt. 5:48)!

Any false teaching that tells you to remain comfortably in sin is plainly anti-biblical. Read Revelation 2:20-23 and you will figure this out! The woman teacher talked about there, Jezebel, who made others comfortable in sin of sexual immorality – punishment was being planned by Jesus for her!

SO, THE MEANING OF JESUS' WORDS, 'EVERYONE WHO LIVES AND BELIEVES IN ME WILL NEVER DIE'?

So what is the implication when Jesus says in John 11:25-26 this: "I am the resurrection and the life; he who believes in Me will live even if he dies, and everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die. Do you believe this?" Does it mean that we will not die if we believed in him? No! It simply means that if we believed in him, we will not die spiritually and we will not die eternally! Why? In the same book, in the next chapter, Jesus talked about death, physical death. He does so, in John 12:24 where He says, "Very truly I tell you, unless a kernel

of wheat falls to the ground and dies, it remains only a single seed. But if it dies, it produces many seeds." He was not literally talking about a kernel of wheat or corn of wheat here. He was referring to himself and his disciples here. They must be willing to die, he was saying here, using figurative language. The one who called us for readiness for death in John 12:24 could not have implied that there was no death via his words in John 11:25-26! Certainly not! If you abide in Jesus, you are resurrected from your spiritual death! If you abide in Jesus, there is no eternal death for you! But physical death may come if his coming is delayed!

In Matthew 10:28, Jesus said this: 'Do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather, be afraid of the One who can destroy both soul and body in hell.' So do not be afraid of any virus that may cause death to you or any human who may kill you for your faith in Christ! What is the worst thing that they can do according to Jesus? They can kill you! That's it! But what you get is an out-of-turn promotion into heaven!

Would you make a commitment to Jesus at the end of this chapter without procrastination? Would you repent of your sin (Luke 13:1-5)? Would you put your faith in Jesus who died for you on the Cross (John 1:12)? Would you say this prayer of commitment by meaning every word? "Dear Lord Jesus, I am sorry for my sins. I put my trust in you – you who died for me on the Cross and rose again! Thank you for saving me!"

CHAPTER 31

'H'-EAVEN & 'H'-ELL, ONLY THERE, THERE IS NO DEATH!



Using Acronym D-E-A-T-H To Counter The 'No-death For Believers' Cult

This book is written for the remnant who seek sound doctrine from the Bible. This book is for those who are willing to listen to inconvenient truth from the Bible. I am hoping that you will be willing to embrace these truths and allow it to change your life!

We have been using the acronym D-E-A-T-H to sound an alarm against these teachings. Now we are in the letter "H" of the acronym. This letter stands for this: Only in Heaven and in Hell is there no more death!

Let us read Revelation 21:1-4 to understand this:

"Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth passed away, and there is no longer *any* sea. And I saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, made ready

as a bride adorned for her husband. And I heard a loud voice from the throne, saying, "Behold, the tabernacle of God is among men, and He will dwell among them, and they shall be His people, and God Himself will be among them, and He will wipe away every tear from their eyes; and there will no longer be *any* death; there will no longer be *any* mourning, or crying, or pain; the first things have passed away."

PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION CULT ADVOCATES ARE LIKE PROVERBIAL CASHEW NUTS: THEY WANT TO JUMP TO IMMORTALITY BEFORE THE SECOND COMING OF JESUS, CREATION OF NEW HEAVEN/EARTH!

This is the clearest New Testament passage which talks about the end of death. When does this happen? It happens when the new heaven and new earth appears (Rev. 21:1). We know that the new earth (and heaven) will come only after Jesus' return to this earth. Revelation 19 talks about his return. Not just there, 2 Peter 3 also says that Jesus' return must happen before the destruction of this earth. 'But the Day of the Lord will come like a thief. The heavens will disappear with a roar, the elements will be destroyed by fire, and the earth and its works will be laid bare' (2 Peter 3:10). 2 Peter 3:3-4 talks about how scoffers will mock when the Second Coming of Jesus is even mentioned. So the thrust of 2 Peter 3 is this: the much-scoffed return of Jesus will finally happen and then the existing heavens and the earth will disappear (2 Peter 3:10, PHILLIPS: 'In that day

the heavens will disappear in a terrific tearing blast, the very elements will disintegrate in heat and the earth and all that is in it will be burnt up to nothing'). 2 Peter 3:13 talks about the creation of a New Heaven and a New Earth which will come after the promise (of the Second Coming as the context makes clear) is fulfilled. When we join what we learn from 2 Peter 3 with what we learn from Revelation 19-21 (three chapters), we understand that the New Heavens and the New Earth will be created post the Second Coming of Jesus – not before that. 2 Peter 3 is an abridged version of the more elaborate Revelation 19-21 – we could say that. Revelation 19-21 is only explaining in greater detail what Peter has already clearly spoken about in 2 Peter 3! The hallmark of the new heaven and new earth is this: the literal presence of God among people of God (Rev. 21:2-3). **It is only in that future reality that there would be "no death" (Rev. 21:4)**. "Mourning, crying and pain" will also cease only then (Rev. 21:4). So the plain teaching of the Bible is this: till the return of Jesus post which new heaven and earth will be created, mourning, pain, crying, death will be there in our lives! Let no false teacher fool you by talking about the possibility of 'defeating death', 'cancelling death', etc., before the return of Jesus and the appearance of the new heaven and new earth! That's an impossibility! That won't happen! Let me retrace the chronology of these future events here: return of Jesus publicly (Revelation 19); the Day of Judgment (Revelation 20); the creation of new heaven and earth where there is no pain and death (Revelation 21). The folks embracing the death-cancellation cult do not want to see the first two of these events, return of

Jesus and the Day of Judgment (both unpleasant topics for them), unfurling. They want to jump like a proverbial cashew nut to the third event: the cancellation of death! They are in error! Don't believe them!

THE IMPLICATION OF THE ANY-SECOND RETURN OF JESUS

2 Peter 3:8-9 says this: 'But do not let this one *fact* escape your notice, beloved, that with the Lord one day is like a thousand years, and a thousand years like one day. The Lord is not slow about His promise, as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing for any to perish but for all to come to repentance.' The implication of these words penned by Apostle Peter under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit is this: Jesus can return even before you finish reading this sentence or he could return even after a thousand years or even more. We simply do not know when! We must be ready for the 'any-second-it-is-possible' return of Jesus! We have not been given the option of happily remaining in sin! If we are stubborn in sin when Jesus returns at a second we did not expect him to return, let's say, stubborn in the sin of porn-watching, let's say, stubborn in the sin of pride, etc. then this is what would happen to us: we could go into an eternity without Jesus! I say that because I have read the words of Jesus in Mark 13:35-36:

'Therefore, keep watch, because you do not know when the master of the house will return—whether in the evening, at midnight, when the rooster crows, or in the morning. Otherwise, he may arrive without notice and find you sleeping.'

WILL A BELIEVER, LIVING IN SIN STUBBORNLY, WHEN HE DIES SUDDENLY, OR, WHEN JESUS COMES, MAKE IT TO HEAVEN?

The same truth jumps out from the Parable of the 10 Virgins. Over there we read: 'Truly I tell you, I do not know you' (Matt. 25:12). The spiritually 'drowsy, sleepy' (Matt. 25:5) and the stubbornly procrastinating (Matt. 25:10) would be shocked by the 'I do not know you' words from Jesus on the Final Day! Whoever told you that the Bible offers you a cushion for stubborn sin without the possibilities of eternal consequence did not read Mark 13 and Matthew 25! So a believer, living in stubborn sin, when he dies suddenly, or, when Jesus comes back, will NOT go to heaven!

If the earth we live in, is going to be destroyed as 2 Peter 3 clearly says, we should not be attached to it! We should not be like the Rich Man of Luke 12 who was obsessed about getting a bigger barn to store all that he had amassed! Instead, we must sing along with the hymn-writer who wrote, "This world is not my home, I

am just a-passing through/My treasures are laid up somewhere beyond the blue!/ The angels beckon me, from heaven's open door/And I can't feel at home, in this world anymore" (and mean it).

THE POSSIBILITY OF THE ANY-SECOND RETURN OF JESUS IS A MOTIVATION FOR...

2 Peter 3:13 says, 'But in keeping with his promise we are looking forward to a new heaven and a new earth, where righteousness dwells.' Since we are headed to a place where righteousness dwells, we must strive for righteousness, here and now! That is why Peter wrote, in 1 Peter 2:11, this: 'Dearly beloved, I beseech *you* as strangers and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lusts, which war against the soul' (KJ21). 2 Peter 3:11 is not much different: 'Since everything will be destroyed in this way, what kind of people ought you to be? You ought to conduct yourselves in holiness and godliness'. **The possibility of the any-second return of Jesus teaching found in 2 Peter 3 is presented as an ongoing motivation for daily holy living!**

DOES ISAIAH 65:20 TEACH IMMORTALITY ON EARTH? NO!

In this connection, I must mention Isaiah 65:20. Some people say that this verse teaches immortality on earth! Really? Let's read that verse again. It goes this way: 'No more shall there be in it an infant who lives but a few days, or an old man who does not fill out his days, for the young man shall die a hundred years old, and

the sinner a hundred years old shall be accursed' (ESV). The NLT renders it this way: "No longer will babies die when only a few days old. No longer will adults die before they have lived a full life. No longer will people be considered old at one hundred! Only the cursed will die that young!"

WHEN YOU HEAR 'KVB' IN KODAMBAKKAM...WHEN YOU HEAR 'WASHINGTON' IN THE USA...

When will this reality happen? Will it happen here and now? Just read the set of three verses above and you will understand when this will happen! We must read the Bible in context! **As I have already mentioned, we naturally tend to read everything else (except the Bible) in context!** If you lived in an area called Kodambakkam in Chennai, if 'KVB' was mentioned, you would naturally ask right-context-placing questions such as: **'is it the bank (Karur Vysya Bank) or the Biriyani shop (Kalyana Virundhu Biryani)?'** If you lived in the USA and you heard 'Washington' being mentioned, you will naturally ask right-context-placing questions such as, **'Is it the Washington State near the United States North-West? Or is it the Capital in the East of the USA? Or is it George Washington, the former President? Or Denzel Washington, the Hollywood actor?'** IN THE SAME WAY, WE MUST ASK CONTEXT-PLACING QUESTIONS WHEN WE READ ANY BIBLE TEXT. IF WE DON'T, THEN THE MEANING OF THAT TEXT COULD BE LOST. We could end up getting a meaning which never entered the mind of the original, human author of that text, who was writing it under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit!

To get the context of Isaiah 65:20 which says, 'people will no longer be considered old at one hundred' (NLT), let us read the previous three verses (Isa. 65:17-19). They go this way:

"For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth; And the former shall not be remembered or come to mind. But be glad and rejoice forever in what I create; For behold, I create Jerusalem as a rejoicing, And her people a joy. I will rejoice in Jerusalem, And joy in My people; The voice of weeping shall no longer be heard in her, Nor the voice of crying."

This will happen when God creates the new heavens and the new earth, Isaiah 65:17 says. After we have read the rest of the Bible, including the books of 2 Peter and Revelation, we know for a fact that the new heavens and the new earth cannot happen without the coming of Jesus happening prior! Also Isaiah 65:18 uses the phrase, 'rejoice forever in what I create'. This reality of the 'people no longer being considered old at one hundred' (Isa. 65:10, NLT) happens when it is the 'forever' rule of God (who executes it through Christ). Only after Jesus returns, will this 'forever' rule be established. Daniel 7:13-14 confirms this:

"I was watching in the night visions, And behold, *One* like the Son of Man, Coming with the clouds of heaven! He came to the Ancient of Days, And they brought Him near before Him. [14] Then to Him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, That all peoples, nations, and languages should serve Him. His

dominion *is* an everlasting dominion, Which shall not pass away, And His kingdom *the one* Which shall not be destroyed" (NKJV).

UNDERSTANDING THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN HADES AND LAKE OF FIRE! UNDERSTANDING THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN PARADISE AND NEW HEAVEN AND EARTH!

"Isaiah 65:20 seems to talk about death. Will there be death in the new heaven life post the Second Coming of Jesus?" – well that might be your question now. Revelation 20:14 talks about death (dead-unbelievers, backslidden believers who go Hades like the Rich Man of Luke 16) and Hades (those who dwell in Hades) being thrown into the 'lake of fire'. Meaning? Those unbelievers swallowed by death and have consequently proceeded to Hades (where there are flames that causes eternal torment to those inside, Luke 16:23-24) will be forever alive in the lake of fire which is also hell. What is the corollary of Revelation 20:14? Death (dead-believers, this time, who go to Paradise like the repentant dying thief of Luke 23) and those in Paradise (the opposite of Hades) will be thrown into 'the new heavens and the earth'. In the same way, it must be true that believers swallowed by death and those who have proceeded to paradise (like the repentant dying thief) will be forever alive in the New Heavens and the new Earth. In that sense, that 'death' landing into New Heavens and Earth is not actually death! Isaiah 65:20 is talking about a death that is destroyed once a person enters the New

Heavens and Earth – this I believe. Revelation 21:4 clearly tells us that death dies in the New Heaven and Earth! That is, there is no more death in New Heaven and Earth. This way, the last enemy which is death (1 Cor. 15:26) is defeated in the New Heaven and Earth, which is created after the return of Jesus (I Cor. 15:23). Isaiah 65:25 talks about no hurt or destruction in the holy mountain of God (new heavens and earth). This seems to be a parallel to Revelation 21: 4 which says that in the New Heavens and the Earth there will be no pain. **So Isaiah 65:20 is not talking about any literal 1000-year rule where there could be actual death, but it is talking about eternal life in New Heaven and Earth symbolically. This is my considered opinion.**

SO, NO LITERAL THOUSAND-YEAR RULE?

So, is there no literal 1000 year rule? There is one reference to the 1000 year rule in the entire Bible – in Revelation 20. We cannot make a doctrine from one passage of Scripture. Deuteronomy 19:15, Matthew 18:16 and 2 Corinthians 13:1 talks about the need for two or three witnesses to establish a matter as truthful. The same thing we read using another imagery in Isaiah 34:16 (if it is a key truth then there would be a mate or mates for it). Since we have only one witness in the whole bible about the literal one thousand year rule, we need not feel compelled to make that as a doctrine. What the one thousand year rule of Christ symbolizes is beyond the scope of this chapter.

CHAPTER 32

HOW SOUND BIBLE INTERPRETATION PRINCIPLES SOUNDS ITS BUGLE AGAINST IMMORTALITY NOW TEACHING



Simple, Sense-making Examples Of Sound Bible Interpretation

THEY INSTINCTIVELY INTERPRET JESUS BEING THE LIGHT IN THE SPIRITUAL SENSE, BUT....

Questions for 'Immortality on Earth' Cult Pastors: If you preach from John 11:26, that people who believe in Jesus should not experience PHYSICAL death then you should also preach from John 8:12 that people who believe in JESUS will not be in PHYSICAL DARKNESS! That is, you should teach your congregation this: 'do not switch off your lights when you sleep, because John 8:12 says that those who walk

with Jesus will never live in the dark!!' But you don't do that right?! You instinctively interpret the 'light' of John 8:12 to be 'spiritual light', right? You instinctively interpret the 'thirst' that Jesus talked about in John 4:14 as spiritual thirst, right? Then why this double standard only with John 11:26? **Oh, for consistency in Bible Interpretation!**

ASSIGNING HEBREWS 2:14-15 A MEANING WHICH THE WRITER OF HEBREWS DID NOT ASSIGN

Hebrews 2:14-15 teaches that Jesus frees the believer from the fear of death, and not death itself. Otherwise this book would not teach this: "Just as people are destined to die once..." (Heb. 9:27). Otherwise this book would not call believers for possible martyrdom: "In your struggle against sin, you have not resisted to the point of shedding your blood" (Heb. 12:4). To assign a meaning to Hebrews 2:14-15 which the writer of Hebrews itself did not assign, is wrong and is a clear case of wrong interpretation of the Bible.

ASSIGNING ROMANS 2:7 A MEANING WHICH APOSTLE PAUL DID NOT ASSIGN

'Immortality on Earth' cult pastors quote Romans 2:7 where it seems to say that we must seek "immortality". But the "immortality on Earth" or "believers need not die" false teaching never entered the mind of the author of Romans, Apostle Paul. In the same book, he writes, "For if we live, we live to the Lord and if we die, we die

to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord's" (Rom. 14:8). So to say that Romans 2:7 teaches that believers need not die if they choose not to die, is to assign a meaning to it which the author did not intend to give that verse and is also a clear case of wrong interpretation of the Bible.

WILL WE EAT THE FLESH OF JESUS LITERALLY?

The Words of Jesus himself is seen by these cultic "no physical-death for Jesus-believers" doctrine teachers as 'proof' for their false teaching. What words of Jesus? John 6:50-51. Let me reproduce them:

"This is the bread which comes down out of heaven, so that one may eat of it and not die. I am the living bread that came down out of heaven; if anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever; and the bread also which I will give for the life of the world is My flesh."

If we take the "will not die" of this passage literally, we must also be willing to take the part which says that we must eat the flesh of Jesus literally. This passage is loaded with metaphors. Jesus is not bread. But he compares himself to bread here. He is bread because he gives us food that satisfies the hunger of our souls. The phrase 'eats of this bread' implies intimacy with Jesus, for Jesus is the bread that is spoken of here. In Revelation 3:20, written by the same author, Apostle John, the same eating imagery is used for intimate fellowship with Jesus. **The Christian life is akin to going for dinner dates with Jesus, spiritually speaking!**

Jesus, elsewhere in a clear passage, recorded by the same author, Apostle John clarifies what 'will not die' means. We read this in John 11:25-26: Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life. Whoever believes in Me will live, even though he dies. And everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die. Do you believe this?"

WE SHOULD HAVE MET, THE ALIVE-AGAIN LAZARUS IN 2024 IF 'PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION' CULT WAS BIBLICAL!

These are Jesus' words to Martha. Lazarus the one who was dead, believed in Jesus. Yet he experienced physical death. Jesus resurrected him. Yet, Lazarus died again (though the Bible does not record this). That is why we have not yet met the resurrected Lazarus in our Planet (as I write these words in June 2024). Lazarus died the second time and he was buried. One day, he will rise up and meet Jesus in the clouds as Paul mentions in I Thessalonians 4:16-17. So when Jesus said, "everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die", in John 11:25-26, he could not have meant no physical death will occur for those who believe in him because Lazarus, a believer in Jesus, died.

The false teachers think Jesus was promising immortality on earth here as they read John 11:25-26. No way! Otherwise, why would Jesus talk about the future death of Peter (who certainly believed in him)? He does so in John 21:18-19 where we read this:

'Truly, truly, I tell you, when you were young, you dressed yourself and walked where you wanted; but when you are old, you will stretch out your hands, and someone else will dress you and lead you where you do not want to go." Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God.'

Not just that. If believing in Jesus cancelled out physical death altogether, why would John, the author of this Gospel admit that Jesus never said that he would not die ever (see John 21:22)?

'Can any one of you by worrying add a single hour to your life?' (Matt. 6:27). By saying that, Jesus was saying that he knew that all would eventually die, should his return get delayed.

CHAPTER 33

MY RESPONSE TO WHAT AN IMMORTALITY NOW CHENNAI PASTOR SAID WHEN A YOUNG BELIEVER FROM HIS OWN CHURCH DIED!



THIS BOOK IS AN ATTEMPT TO BARK AGAINST HELL-POPULATING FALSE TEACHING

In the month of April 2020, four popular and prominent young preachers were to gather a crowd in a resort in East Coast Road and teach them this: 'If you believed in Jesus, you don't have to die!' One of these preachers also said that he wanted to be the first one to live at least for 200 years as he believed that the Bible guaranteed 'long life' for believers who took it seriously. However the Corona Pandemic scuttled their plans. But these unbiblical, cultic, teachings continue to be taught not just in Chennai but world over. But this book is a humble attempt to raise a red flag against these kinds of wrong teachings! This book is an attempt to

bark like a watch dog against these kind of false teachings!

MY PRAYER: "LORD, PLEASE SEND DEATH TO ME, IF THAT WILL..."

I have prayed this way in exasperation: "Lord, if you will allow it, I will be most glad to become a believer in these 'immortality now' churches. And you please send death to me. And upon seeing my death, the believers in these congregations would stop believing in the 'physical death cancellation' false teaching!" I used to chat with God this way! But you know that God would not allow that. There is no compromise that God makes with lies. We too should not make such compromises!

A PROMINENT YOUNG BELIEVER IN A 'PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION' CULT CHURCH IN CHENNAI DIES....

But guess what, in 2021, the death of a prominent young believer who was involved in church-activities actively, happened in one of these churches. It did not matter where this death happened – be it in Chennai, or Madurai or San Francisco! As I extended heartfelt condolences when I did a YouTube video on this topic in 2021, I do so even now all over again as I pen these words in 2024. As I said earlier, I would have been most glad to be that person if God would have given me permission. After the death of a young believer in that 'immortality

now' embracing church I was hoping that somehow there would be a change in perspective, a repentance from the preaching and propagation of false teaching by the senior pastor. This occasion was an excellent occasion to say, "We have been wrong in teaching that those who believe in Jesus need not die if they chose to. We regret teaching that and misleading believers. Now we will back up and embrace the right teaching from the Bible!"

IN THE FUNERAL SERVICE OF HIS DEAD CHURCH MEMBER, THIS CHENNAI 'PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION' CULT PASTOR DEMOSTRATES HIS LOVE FOR WICKED CONVENIENCE!

The prominent 'Immortality Now' teaching pastor continued to assert the false teaching of 'immortality now', even after the death of a young believer in his church in 2021! He continued to assert that believers in Jesus need not die if they chose to, even after this death in his church! How did he explain the death of the believer in his church? He came up with this bizarre teaching from Mark 12. He quoted verse 26-27 to say that even though Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were dead, God was calling himself the 'God of the Living'. In God's eyes, Abraham, Issac and Jacob were alive! Then this pastor said: "In the same way, the brother who died amidst us though he is dead is seen as being alive in God's eyes! So, we too must see him like that! He is rejoicing in God's

presence now!" **How wickedly convenient it is to say this after having fooled his church members saying, "no death will come for those who believe in Jesus!"**

THIS CHENNAI CULT PASTOR WOULD HAVE EARNED MY RESPECT, IF HE HAD...

Yes, Abraham is still alive. Jesus talks about Abraham in a conversation with Lazarus who went to the fire of Hades in Luke 16. But to conveniently switch to the traditional biblical view of believers who died when you (I am talking about this Chennai 'Immortality Now' cult pastor) have taught that believers won't die is so cunning! He would have earned my respect if he said: "I was wrong in asserting that believers can't die. I repent now. Yes, believers can die. And as Bible-believing churches across the planet have rightly taught, all these centuries, dead believers would be with the Lord in the Lord's very presence!" But sadly, he did not say that! And he continues to wrongly assert that believers have conquered death, here and now!

This Chennai cult pastor also responded this way to the death of a young believer in his church! He quoted Matthew 10:8 which says this: 'Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse those who have leprosy, drive out demons. Freely you have received; freely give.' **I** thought after reading this Scripture, this pastor would pray for the dead young believer to rise up from the dead even as the event was being live-streamed. I thought, this Chennai cult pastor, would say these words, "The young man should NOT have died! As those who believe in

Jesus cannot die! A small mistake has happened. He is now dead. So, I commend him to raise from the dead!" But he said none of those words. Instead of a miracle demonstration, all he did was a Mathew 10:8 exposition! If I was there, I would have prayed for his resurrection from the dead with the open acknowledgement that the dead can be raised if it is God's Will for them to be raised in that particular case! I would have quoted the true story of how my daughter was raised from the dead from inside her mother's womb in April 2007. The doctor said after a scan that there was no heart-beat in the baby and we had to return for an abortion as a dead baby inside a mom's tummy was dangerous for the mom's life. I would narrate how we prayed for a miracle. I would tell, how when we went for another scan, before we went to the Good Friday service of the local church we were a part of, then, in Hyderabad that April. This other scan confirmed this miracle: God gave back the heart-beat of my daughter! She was born as a normal child on November 12, 2007. She brings so much joy into our lives even now as I write these words in 2024. I would narrate all this in the funeral and pray for the dead person to rise. But if the dead person does not rise I will not hesitate to mention two Scriptures. One, Acts 13:36. It reads this way: '...after David had done the will of God in his own generation, he died and was buried with his ancestors, and his body decayed'. I would say, "So and so did the will of God in his life as far as I know and now Jesus has received him into his presence!" I would quote another Scripture too in the funeral service. This: Mathew 14:6-12. The Bible says that the news of John the Baptist's tragic death is brought to Jesus. But Jesus did not resurrect him. What is the implication? John the Baptist had completed his God-given assignment and

now was ready to return to the Father God! I would say this: "Our dear brother, I believe, has finished his God-given assignment and now has returned to his Maker! It is time to praise God for His life!"

HOW CUNNING WAS THE BEHAVIOR OF THIS CHENNAI PASTOR IN THE FUNERAL SERVICE OF A YOUNG MAN WHO TRAGICALLY BELIEVED HIS 'PHYSICAL DEATH CANCELLATION' LIE!

The Chennai cult 'physical death cancellation' teaching bringing pastor went onto quote another set of verses in the funeral service of his young believer in 2021. He quoted Ephesians 3:14-16. He said that since we have Our Father who has created one family with some members in heaven and some members on earth, it did not matter if we were alive or dead, after all we all belong to one big family! And went to say that this young dead believer was dancing in the presence of God! How cunning that he switches back to the traditional biblical view when he must comfort the family of the young person who just died! Why does he not preach to those alive now: "It does matter whether you are dead or alive…."? Why does he continue to preach the 'physical death cancellation' teaching even now? As long as there are church believers who are ready to be fooled, these kinds of pastors will continue to fool them! This is so sad!

'DON'T DECEIVE PEOPLE WITH EMPTY ARGUMENTS' - THE BIBLE SAYS SO, ATLEAST, FOUR TIMES!

So, this pastor's continued teaching of immortality-on-earth turns out to be a classic case of deceiving people with empty arguments! And the Bible repeatedly says that we must not do that! I counted that the Bible does so, at least four times!

See Ephesians 5:6. It says, 'Let no one deceive you with empty words, for because of these things the wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience.' Bringing teaching that involve just 'empty words' brings the wrath of God! It is so dangerous!

Paul mentioned this to Timothy, the young man, he was training for ministry. He wrote in 1 Timothy 1:3-6, the hallmarks of the false teachers there involved, "meaningless talk"(verse 6, NIV)/ "vain discussion" (verse 6, ESV). If you thunder that those who believe in Jesus need not die(wrongly) and then your church believer dies, and that too at a young age, you don't raise him from the dead, at least as a reputation-saving grace, but in the funeral service say the exact same things that are usually said in typical funeral services held by those embracing traditional evangelical doctrine, it is clear that your ongoing teaching of 'immortality now' is just 'meaningless talk' and 'vain discussion' (this is what I want to say to that Chennai cult pastor).

We are looking at the different times the New Testament warns us about empty talk. There is yet another such warning from 1 Timothy. It comes from 1 Timothy 6:4-5 which is rendered this way in the excellent J. B. Phillips version: 'if anyone tries to teach some doctrinal novelty which is not compatible with sound teaching (which we base on Christ's own words and which leads to Christ-like living), then he is a conceited idiot! His mind is a morbid jumble of disputation and argument, things which lead to nothing but jealousy, quarrelling, insults and malicious innuendoes – continual wrangling, in fact, among men of warped minds who have lost their real hold on the truth but hope to make some profit out of the Christian religion.' There you have it: these kinds of teaching involving 'doctrinal novelty not compatible with sound teaching' comes from 'conceited idiots' who are focussed on 'making some profit out of the Christian religion'! From the word of God I want to make this assertion: those who teach false teaching that sound like music to ears like these – 'you won't die if you believe in Jesus' – do so because they want to become rich quick using Christian ministry, so-called. Because God's Word calls them out and red flags them, I too want to as this is so blatant and brazen!

The phrase used in 1 Timothy 6:4 in the ESV has this phrase: 'quarrels about words'! After hearing what the Chennai cult 'immortality now' pastor said in the funeral service of the young believer who died in his church, **I can say that all that this Chennai pastor does is this: he does is 'quarrels about words'.** Let me explain here why I say that: believers in other churches die, believers in your church also die; and you say exactly the same things that are usually told in funerals – the person who died, as he is a believer, is in God's very presence; but

you still have the nerve to continue teaching the 'immortality on earth' false teaching! What is this but mere fruitless, useless, quarrel about words? (my words directed to this Chennai pastor).

Paul wasn't done yet! He wrote in 1 Timothy 6:20-21, warning Timothy to be wary of preachers who use 'empty words' to hide their deceptiveness and their secret focus on quick financial gain. He writes, 'O Timothy, guard the deposit entrusted to you. Avoid the irreverent babble and contradictions of what is falsely called "knowledge," which some have professed and in so doing have departed from the faith.' I also include 'quick financial gain' as one of the goals of these kinds of false teachers because the Bible says talking about the same group of false teachers this: 'For the love of money is a root of all *kinds of* evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows' (1 Tim. 6:10 NKJV).

'BUILDING A SOUND DOCTRINE BASED CHURCH TAKES TIME, SO LET US TAKE A SHORT CUT!' – THE CUNNING THINKING BEHIND THESE FALSE TEACHERS

In my opinion, this is what goes on in the minds of these hell-populating false teachers: "To establish a church of the size of say around 500 people with around 100 families tithing while preaching Sound Doctrine will take a while. But we can achieve that goal quickly if we twist some Bible verses and bring teaching that sound like music to people's ears! Let's gather a crowd quickly with teachings like these: 'God does not look

at how you live – whether you are holy or not, as he looks only at ever-holy Jesus, who is your righteous representative!' (Hyper-Grace), 'You won't die if you believe in Jesus! So, this disease you have now will SURELY get healed! So, you don't have to worry about repenting now, this very second, lest you die and go into hell unrepentant, because you are never going to die in the first-place!' (Hyper-Supernaturalism)." It is my considered opinion that this is what goes on in their wicked minds! Somebody must red-flag this! Somebody must bell the cat! That is why, I am writing this book! This is just a trickle against a torrent of false teachers! We need more senior Christian leaders to speak up against such teachings that is taking thousands and millions of church believers to hell!

If you teach 'immortality on earth' and a believer in your church dies, you must come up with a good explanation as to why that happened! Or you should publicly repent of that false teaching! You must do either one of these things! (my words to that Chennai 'immortality now' teaching cult pastor). What we don't want to hear is useless discussion, irreverent babble, vain talk which Apostle Paul warned us against (my words to the Chennai 'physical death cancellation' teaching bringing, pastor).

THESE ANTI-JESUS, EYES-ON-QUICK-BUCKS, FALSE TEACHERS PREACH THIS WAY...

Not just Apostle Paul, Apostle Peter as well warned against such 'empty talk'. He writes, 'Those false teachers

only want your money, so they will use you by telling you lies' (2 Pet. 2:3 NCV). I have mentioned elsewhere in this book but let me say it again. These hell-populating false teachers bring these kinds of teachings only to get a big gathering (who would give them offerings in turn) quickly. Preachers of old like Billy Graham have preached, "Tonight if you die where will you spend your eternity?" This way of preaching is very much Jesus-like! Why do I say that? I say it because I have read Luke 12:20 ("But God said to him, 'You fool! This very night your life will be demanded from you. Then who will get what you have prepared for yourself?') and Luke 17:32 (Remember Lot's wife). But many modern young preachers and pastors feel that if you preached this way, people will not come to your church and give offering. That is why they bring a new teaching "in their greed" (as Peter put it, 2 Peter 2:3). But these anti-Jesus, eyes-on-quick-bucks, false teachers preach this way: "Why bother about dying tonight when those who believe in Jesus will never die!" They can't have a field way! The least we can do for the sake of the good health of the Kingdom of God is to question them!

DON'T ATTEND THESE FALSE TEACHING PROMOTING CHURCHES!

We should not be even attending these kinds of churches, leave alone volunteer with these churches or give offerings to these churches and their hell-populating pastors! I say this because I have read 2 John 10-11 which says this: 'If anyone comes to you and does not bring this teaching, do not take them into your house or welcome them. Anyone who welcomes them shares in their wicked work'. In those days, the local churches

met in the homes of people. And here the senior-most leader of the church then, the Apostle John, clearly says that if a hell-populating false teacher seeks to run his church in your home, you should say 'no' to him. If we welcome such a false pastor and support his ministry, we too will share the judgement that God has in store for him/her. We too will land up in hell along with him! The point of me writing all this is this: that false pastor and you will read this and repent and come to heaven!

ACTUALLY, YOU DON'T NEED A BOOK LIKE THIS, IF ONLY THIS GENERATION READ THE BIBLE...

As I bring this chapter to an end let us not forget the most direct set of Bible verses against this immortality-now teaching, which is Romans 14:8. It goes this way: 'for if we live, we live for the Lord, or if we die, we die for the Lord; therefore whether we live or die, we are the Lord's'. **You don't need a preacher or even a book like this to tell you that the Bible does not teach immortality on earth before the return of Jesus!** It is so outrageously obvious even to the most casual reader of the Bible! Because we have a generation that does not even take time to read the Bible even that casually, we have a group of preachers and pastors who take advantage of that and bring in hell-populating false teachings like immortality on earth! Let us repent of the Bible-neglect which has led to the mushrooming of hell-populating false teaching, dear brothers and sisters!

Romans 14:9, the next verse says: 'For to this end Christ died and lived again, that He might be Lord both of the dead and of the living'. This verse is telling us that even after Jesus died on the Cross and rose again, believers can die as it introduces Jesus as the Lord of both the dead and of the living! Don't believe the false teachers who try to tell you that after the Cross of Jesus, a believer in Jesus need not die! Hold on to the Word of God!

THEIR ATTEMPT TO FOOL YOU CONTINUES, SADLY!

On May 7, 2024, the Chennai cultic pastor during the book-release of his Malayalam book on 'Immortality Now', says this over a YouTube video (in-effect): "You can see that I am wearing glasses. You may wonder why. I do not make my own experience as the standard for the (immortality-on-earth, healing-always-now) gospel; I make God's Word as the standard! And God's Word teaches immortality now and healing now!" He is trying to fool you! He is bluffing! If he REALLY believed the immortality-on-earth Gospel that he preaches, he would not wear glasses even if he faced challenges! And he would believe that God would immediately and eventually heal his eyes (which is what he believes the Bible teaches, albeit erroneously; Yes, God can heal him, if it is His Will to do so – that is what the Bible teaches, we know)! Jesus warned about hell-heading hypocrites who do not practice what they preach (Matt. 23: 3,33). However, I do not want him to practice what he preaches, in this case, because what he preaches is erroneous and unbiblical. I just want him to repent from this kind of grossly

unbiblical, deceptive preaching! I am baffled by how these cunning pastors try to pull a wool over our eyes, by not even practicing what they preach!

OUR STONY SILENCE HAS LED TO THE MUSHROOMING OF HELL-POPULATING FALSE TEACHINGS

Let me cite another example! The 'prophet' who released the Chennai pastor's Malayalam 'immortality now' promoting book is a well-known 'miracle-money' preacher! But in one of his church services (broadcast over YouTube on 13 April 2024) the Chennai Pastor appeals for a fund of Rs.15 lakh from his church members to install a centralised Air Condition (AC) in his church. My question to him is this: 'Why not have the 'miracle-money' prophet who released your Malayalam 'immortality now' book to do a miracle-money miracle for you and raise that Rs.15 lakh instantly?' Our stony silence has led to the unchallenged mushrooming of hell-populating false teachings! We must speak up! This book is a humble effort in that direction!

CHAPTER 34

CAN WE COMMAND DISEASE TO GO? CAN WE COMMAND GOD IN PRAYER?



ERNEST PRAYERS FOR A BELIEVER WHO GOT STUCK IN A NARROW CAVE

The family of **John Edward Jones** prayed earnestly for his rescue from the cave he was trapped in. He was trapped inside one of the famous caves called Nutty Putty caves in Utah, USA. The cave was over 400 meters long. As it meandered under the earth, it reached a depth of over 40 meters. At one point, this cave led to a narrow passage called the birth canal. John Jones got caught in that section with his head in the bottom and only his shoes being visible to others who followed him in the cave. Dave Roos and Austin Henderson wrote this about the November 24, 2009 visit to the cave: 'Jones tried to squeeze headfirst through the tight spot and turn around, but he became hopelessly stuck upside down at a 70-degree angle.'

He disobeyed the self-evident, cardinal rule for safe-caving: never go head-first if you see the cave turning to the bottom of the earth even slightly. For 27 hours, John stayed stuck inside that narrow section of the **Nutty Putty cave**. Skinny cavers tried to rescue him. They tried to drill a pulley inside the cave and pull him out with a rope. The pulley inside the cave ripped off smashing the face of one of the rescue volunteers. Prayers for a miracle rescue were raised. But in the end, John went to be with Jesus and his family had to decide to leave his body inside that cave.

In this chapter, we will talk about the nitty-gritties of praying 'healing prayers' or 'miracle prayers' which hyper-supernatural pastors talk about.

The Hyper-Supernaturalism cult leaders often emphasize that we must command disease to go! Some in this camp also say that we must even command God to do according to what we want to see happen at that given time! This teaching is called Dominion Theology! These false teachers often use the phrase, "I command...", "I decree..."

What does the Scripture say about this?

The Bible tells us through direct teaching and example that we must always ask things according to the Will of God.

The Apostle James taught this directly. He wrote,

[13] Now listen, you who say, "Today or tomorrow we will go to this or that city, spend a year there, carry on business and make money." [14] Why, you do not even know what will happen tomorrow. What is your life? You are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes. [15] Instead, you ought to say, "If it is the Lord's will, we will live and do this or that" (Jas. 4:13-15).

And Jesus became the premier example for this when he prayed this way in the Garden of Gethsemane: "**My** Father, if it is possible, may this cup be taken from me. **Yet not** as **I will**, but as you **will" (Matt. 26:39).**

PAUL WANTED TO FOLLOW GOD'S WILL IN MATTERS SMALL AND BIG

Apostle Paul who often told us that we must follow Jesus the way he followed Jesus (in 1 Cor. 11:1 and in many other places) made it plain that he always submitted to the Will of God. Paul wrote this to the church at Rome: "For God is my witness, whom I serve with my spirit in the gospel of his Son, that without ceasing I mention you always in my prayers, asking that **somehow by God's will** I may now at last succeed in coming to you" (Rom. 1:9,10 ESV). Even for a simple thing as visiting a church, Paul made sure that he was in submission to God's Will. If it was God's Will, he would visit a church. Otherwise, he would not! He repeats this all over again because it was important. After stressing the need for submission to God's will in Chapter 1 of Romans, he does so yet again in Chapter 15. He wrote, "that I may be delivered from the unbelievers in Judea, and that my service for

Jerusalem may be acceptable to the saints, so that **by God's will** I may come to you with joy and be refreshed in your company." (Rom. 15:31-32 ESV).

WHEN PAUL WANTED TO APPRECIATE HIS CO-WORKER, HE TALKED ABOUT THE WILL OF GOD AGAIN

And when Paul wanted to appreciate one of his co-workers, Epaphras, he again brought in the topic of the will of God. Paul wrote, 'Epaphras, who is one of you, a servant of Christ Jesus, greets you, always struggling on your behalf in his prayers, that you may stand mature and **fully assured in all the will of God**' (Col. 4:12, ESV). He appreciated Epaphras for making prayers grounded in all the will of God! While Epaphras wrestled for others in prayer, he made sure that he never wrestled against the will of God! Oh, how many believers – influenced by hyper-supernaturalism teaching – wrestle against the will of God while they pray!

MIRACLES HAPPEN ACCORDING TO THE WILL OF GOD – SO SAYS HEBREWS 2:4

The author of the letter to the Hebrews connected the working of miracles to the will of God. He wrote, 'while God also bore witness by signs and wonders and various miracles and by gifts of the Holy Spirit distributed according to his will' (Heb. 2:4, ESV). I like the New Living Translation rendering of the same verse which goes

this way: 'And God confirmed the message by giving signs and wonders and various miracles and gifts of the Holy Spirit whenever he chose' (Heb. 2:4, NLT).

There you have it – miracles and healings take place only whenever God chooses! They do not happen at our whims and fancies! They do not happen at our command! Do not let the hyper-supernaturalism false pastors deceive you!

JESUS WILL NOT DO MIRACLES AS PER OUR WHIM AND FANCIES: ASK HEROD

Herod hoped that Jesus would do a miracle for him when he met Jesus enroute to Calvary's Cross. Luke writes, 'Herod was very glad to see Jesus; for a long time he had wanted to see Him because he had heard about Him and was hoping to see some miracle performed by Him' (Luke 23:8, HCSB). But Jesus never did a miracle in front of Herod! Why? It was not Jesus' will to do miracles at our whims and fancies! It is not Jesus' will to do miracles as per our timetable as per our demands! Jesus only does miracles when it is His Will to do so!

In fact, God does healings and miracles in three different ways. Let me share what I discovered from the Bible regarding this.

First, God does miracles and healings INSTANTLY! Peter told the lame man outside the temple this: But Peter said, "I have no silver and gold, but what I do have I give to you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth,

rise up and walk!" (Acts 3:6). And this was the effect: "And he took him by the right hand and raised him up, and immediately his feet and ankles were made strong" (Acts 3:7). Notice the word, "immediately"! This miracle happened in an instant! When Peter said, "In the name of Jesus Christ, rise up and walk" he was saying this in-effect: "According to the authority of the name of Jesus, I speak to you; if it is the will of Jesus for you to walk, you will walk now – I have no doubt!" I say this after having read what the full Bible has to say about healing! I am sure that one of the apostles would have said, "In the name of Jesus let Apostle James' beheading be miraculously stopped, the same way Isaac's murder was stopped by the supernatural voice of God in the Old Testament!" But the beheading did not stop! James was indeed beheaded! (see Acts 12:2). The lesson: instant healings happen if it is God's Will for them to happen!

Second, God does miracles and healings in the JOURNEY! Luke records this kind of healing as having happened in the ministry of Jesus. He writes, 'And as he entered a village, he was met by ten lepers, who stood at a distance and lifted up their voices, saying, "Jesus, Master, have mercy on us." When he saw them he said to them, "Go and show yourselves to the priests." And as they went they were cleansed' (Luke 17:12-14). Notice here that these ten folks with leprosy were not healed instantly. Rather, they were healed as they journeyed! Yes, God does miracles in different time-frames according to His Will! Sometimes, the miracles happen instantly! Sometimes, these miracles happen during the journey of life! Let not hyper-supernaturalism false pastors deceive you saying that miracles must always happen, right now!

Third, God does miracles and healings in eternity! Paul writes about this kind of healing in his letter to the Romans. He writes, 'For we know that the whole creation has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth until now. And not only the creation, but we ourselves, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we wait eagerly for adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies. For in this hope we were saved. Now hope that is seen is not hope. For who hopes for what he sees? But if we hope for what we do not see, we wait for it with patience' (Rom. 8:21-25). What Paul says here is this: 'We are still awaiting the total redemption, the total healing of our bodies! That will happen at the time when all of creation will be redeemed! That of course happens when Jesus will return (as Peter would say in 2 Peter 3 and John would say in Revelation 21)! Till then we have hope! Till then we must have patience!' Paul connects the Second Coming of Jesus with the total healing of our bodies as he wrote to the Philippians in this way: 'But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body, by the power that enables him even to subject all things to himself' (Phil. 3:20-21). Yes, our lowly, disease-filled bodies will become glorious, disease-free bodies when Jesus returns to this earth! Therefore, it is biblical to say, "God heals some diseases only in eternity!"

So, if we command disease to leave a body we must do so in the name of Jesus! This does not mean the miracle will happen at once always! It only means the miracle will happen in the time decided by the authority of Jesus!

What about passages in the Bible that seem to tell us that healings have to happen whenever we command it to happen? Read on.

DID JESUS ENVISION A DISEASE-FREE, DEATH-FREE LIFE FOR HIS FOLLOWERS?

Let us take one such passage for example. It comes from Jesus' instruction to his disciples as they start out for ministry. He said to them, "Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons. You received without paying; give without pay" (Matt. 10:8). But Jesus was not envisioning a disease-free, death-free life for his followers if only they obeyed this command! If he had, he would NOT be saying this in the same sermon: 'And do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell' (Matt. 10:28). By speaking these words, Jesus conceded that there could be times when death because of persecution could come for his followers. But his disciples should not ever fear death. Keeping in mind what the whole Bible has to say about disease, death and healing matter, we could say that this was Jesus' point in Matthew 10: pray for healing! Pray for the dead to raise! But know that even after you pray, the disease may remain, death may come! But don't worry, your body is not destroyed! It will live with me forever, disease-free one day!"

WHAT ABOUT MOVING MOUNTAINS VIA PRAYER?

Some others quote the following words of Jesus to support their erroneous 'we can command disease/problem we face to go away' doctrine: '"Truly I tell you, if you have faith and do not doubt, not only can you do what was done to the fig tree, but also you can say to this mountain, 'Go, throw yourself into the sea,' and it will be done. If you believe, you will receive whatever you ask for in prayer" (Matt. 21:21-22). It is apparent that Jesus made this kind of statement twice because we read a similar statement by Jesus in Matthew's gospel again: 'Truly I tell you, if you have faith as small as a mustard seed, you can say to this mountain, 'Move from here to there,' and it will move. Nothing will be impossible for you"' (Matt. 17:20). And in two places in Matthew's Gospel Jesus seems to have said the same thing - 'ask anything you want and I will give it to you immediately': (1) in Matthew 7:7 - 'Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and the door will be opened to you.' (2) in Matthew 18:19 - "Again, truly I tell you that if two of you on earth agree about anything they ask for, it will be done for them by my Father in heaven" So, the question posed by those who embrace the Hyper-Supernatural false teaching is this: Repeatedly, Jesus says to his disciples/followers in-effect (at least in four places in Matthew's gospel alone), 'Ask anything with faith and you will get it'! So, what is wrong in believing in the 'Name it and claim it' doctrine? It is a biblical thing to do!"

This would be my response. We must remember the words of Jesus who said, 'You should have practiced the latter, without neglecting the former' in the same Gospel of Matthew (Matt. 23:23). He pronounced a 'woe' on the religious leaders who failed to follow the WHOLE COUNSEL OF GOD. He will also pronounce a 'woe' on us, if we formulate a doctrine just based on the above four passages from Matthew's Gospel – a doctrine that suggests 'whatever we ask, according to our whims and fancies, God will definitely give'!

What is the WHOLE COUNSEL OF GOD (a super phrase that Apostle Paul used in his farewell speech to the Ephesian church elders in Acts 20:27 to indicate that **we must consider all the Bible when we formulate a doctrine** and not just a few verses here and there taken out of context) with regard to this matter? We get the full counsel of God about whether we can command disease or problem to go from the Spirit-Inspired writings of John, the Apostle, the senior most Christian Leader alive at that time. John wrote the Gospel named after him and four other epistles (1 John, 2 John, 3 John and Revelation) after Matthew, Mark and Luke had written their Gospels. This gave John the chance to clarify some of the seemingly confusing and apparently controversial statements made in the earlier Gospels (Matthew was one) and epistles regarding whether we can command disease of problem to go.

JOHN'S GOSPEL'S TAKE ON PRAYER, EXPLAINS MATTHEW'S GOSPEL'S SEEMINGLY PRO-HYPER-SUPERNATURAL PRAYER PASSAGES

John recorded these following words of Jesus on the same subject – on asking God for anything in prayer – on three occasions. Here is the first occasion:

(1) John 14:13 – 'And I will do whatever you ask in my name, so that the Father may be glorified in the Son' (the message of this verse is simple: God will only do things that are asked in the name of Jesus for the glory of the Father! To ask anything in the name of Jesus, it simply means to ask in prayer 'with the permission of Jesus' (what is asked will not violate the written Word of God), with the clear understanding that Jesus will give us what he wills, at a time he would choose, for the sole purpose of bringing glory to His Father).

KNOWING ME, WOULD MY SON ASK ME FOR DRUGS, ALCOHOL OR PORN?

Let me illustrate this with a human example. Let's say I tell my son Dale Nathan this: 'I will do whatever you ask in my name, dear Dale, so that Jesus will be glorified' (trying to word what I said with the words of Jesus in John 14:13). And He, in response, would he ever ask me for drugs or alcohol or cigarettes or pornographic magazines? He knows that his Bible-honoring dad will never approve of these things. And He in response, even while asking for something he needs, let's say an iphone, would always sign-off from that request, "Dad, I want

an iPhone; but see your convenience!" Why would he say that? Because, He knows that I know the best time to give him an iPhone or whether I need to give him an iPhone or a value-for-money Andriod Phone! In the same way, when we ask in Jesus' name, we will never ask what Jesus does not approve in His Written Word. And also, when we ask in Jesus' name for the glory of the Father, we will always say, 'not my will, but yours' because we know that even if we ask God for a good blessing that does not violate Bible-principles, which we believe is necessary for us (say the blessing of a child after marriage), God knows, what would be the best time for Him to give us that blessing, if at all, He chooses to give us that blessing!

John recorded these following words of Jesus on the same subject – on asking God for anything in prayer – on three occasions. Here is the second occasion:

(2) John 15:16 – 'You did not choose Me, but I chose you. And I appointed you to go and bear fruit--fruit that will remain--so that whatever you ask the Father in My name, He will give you' (the message of this verse agrees with the message of the previous verse; here one condition for answered prayer is also mentioned additionally – we must be fruit-bearing believers. Again, this verse is not saying, 'Whatever a fruitful believer asks, God will give'. It says this, rather: 'Be fruitful. And when you ask anything in the name of Jesus (which simply means to ask in prayer 'with the permission of Jesus', with the understanding that he will give us what he only wills'), he will give it to you!'

John recorded these following words of Jesus on the same subject – on asking God for anything in prayer – on three occasions. Here is the third occasion:

THE FOUR THAT JESUS HIT!

(3) 1 John 5:14 – 'This is the confidence we have in approaching God: that if we ask anything according to his will, he hears us'. If you have even a slight doubt about why we interpreted John 14:13 and John 15:16 to mean that Jesus answers only prayer according to His Will, the plain text of 1 John 5:14 will blow away all those doubts which hyper-supernaturalism false teachers may have sown in your heart! 1 John 5:14 makes it plain and simple: Jesus answers prayer as per His Will, not ours; he answers prayer according to His Will, not ours! No wonder, Jesus himself, to provide a model for us in prayers, prayed, 'not my will, but your will be done, Father' TWICE, once in his model prayer and the second time in the Garden of Gethsemane! In the model prayer, Jesus taught that we must always pray surrendering to the Will of God by praying this way: your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven (Matt. 6:10); and in the Garden of Gethsemane he exemplified what He taught in the Model Prayer by praying this way: "My Father, if it is not possible for this cup to be taken away unless I drink it, may your will be done" (Matt. 26:42). In fact, in Gethsemane alone, Jesus surrendered to the will of His Father THRICE, because we read this, three verses above Matthew 26:42, in Matthew 26:39 this way: "My Father, if it is possible, may this cup be taken from me. Yet not as I will, but as you will." And in

Matthew 26:44 we read, "So he left them and went away once more and prayed the third time, saying the same thing" (Matt. 26:44). The phrase 'saying the same thing' here indicates that Jesus prayed yet again for the will of His Father to be done! **So, atleast FOUR TIMES IN TOTAL (Matt. 6:10, Matt. 26:39, Matt. 26:42 and Matt. 26:44), Jesus taught us to pray only according to the Will of God**. Jesus hit a four when it came to stressing via his personal example, the need to pray according to the will of God (to use a cricket analogy)! So instead of only focussing on the passages that seem to suggest that what we ask, God will always give, here and now, embrace the FULL COUNSEL OF GOD FOUND IN THE BIBLE (Acts 20:27)! And it is abundantly clear that GOD ANSWERS PRAYER ONLY ACCORDING TO HIS SOVEREIGN WILL!

JAMES 5:16 TEACHES THAT GOD ALWAYS HEALS IMMEDIATELY?

Some quote James 5:16 to teach that God always heals immediately. Let's read that verse: 'Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working.' This passage teaches that we must pray for healing. The very word 'pray' means that we must request God. This passage of Scripture comes against the hyper-supernatural cult teaching which goes this way: "We must never pray for healing! We must just command healing to happen!" I have shown above that even when we say 'be healed in Jesus' name', we are actually submitting to the will of Jesus as that means 'be healed in the authority of Jesus who may choose to heal you now, if it is His Will to do so!'

James 5:16 is not teaching that it is God's Will to heal always! As I have already pointed out in this chapter, James 4 teaches that everything we do must be subjected to the will of God, even a business trip we plan to make! Having learnt about submission to the Will of God from James 4 we arrive to the next chapter, James 5, where we read that the prayer of a righteous believer availeth much! So what is the whole message of James 4 and James 5? This: God will answer the prayer of a righteous believer if it is His Will to so!

DID PROPHET ISAIAH ASK US TO COMMAND GOD IN PRAYER?

What about commanding God in prayer? Hyper-Supernatural pastors use the King James version (KJ21) of Isaiah 45:11 to bring this doctrine. What does that verse say? 'Thus saith the LORD, the Holy One of Israel, and his Maker, Ask me of things to come concerning my sons, and concerning the work of my hands command ye me' (Isa. 45:11 KJ21). This unfortunately is one rare case of wrong translation. The ESV gets it correct. Isaiah 45:11 in the ESV goes this way: Thus says the LORD, the Holy One of Israel, and the one who formed him: "Ask me of things to come; will you command me concerning my children and the work of my hands?" The NLT makes this correct translation even better: 'This is what the LORD says— the Holy One of Israel and your Creator: "Do you question what I do for my children? Do you give me orders about the work of my hands?"' So the bottom-line is this: we must NOT command God while in prayer. Instead, we must surrender to His Will, in prayer!

BELIEVER, DON'T PRAY THAT GOD WILL HELP YOU MARRY THAT UNBELIEVER!

As I finish this chapter, I want to faithfully proclaim **a warning that the Bible gives about asking things, that we know for sure, would displease God, as they are clearly against his written Word, when we pray. One example for such anti-Bible prayers would be this: "Lord, somehow open a way for me to marry that handsome/pretty unbeliever!" (We know marrying unbelievers as believers is against the written Word of God – I Corinthians 7:39).** There are passages in the Bible which suggest that God will, at times, answer our prayers according to our selfish wills, instead of His Sovereign will. He will do so in exasperation. He will do so, in wrath. And when He does that, it will NOT be for our blessing. Why do I say that? I say that because I have read **truly scary Bible passages** like these: (1) Psalm 106:15 - 'So he gave them what they asked for, but sent a wasting disease among them' (2) Psalm 78:29-31 – 'They ate till they were gorged— he had given them what they craved. But before they turned from what they craved, even while the food was still in their mouths, God's anger rose against them; he put to death the sturdiest among them, cutting down the young men of Israel' (3) Acts 13:21 - 'Then the people asked for a king, and he gave them Saul son of Kish, of the tribe of Benjamin, who ruled forty years';
(4) Hosea 13:11 - 'So in my anger I gave you a king, and in my wrath I took him away.'

EXEMPLARY GOD'S WILL-SALUTING CHARACTERS!

As I finish this chapter, I invite you to see the different Bible passages which presents **exemplary Bible Characters submitting to the will of God:**

2 Samuel 12:15-20:

And the LORD afflicted the child that Uriah's wife bore to David, and he became sick. David therefore sought God on behalf of the child. And David fasted and went in and lay all night on the ground. And the elders of his house stood beside him, to raise him from the ground, but he would not, nor did he eat food with them. On the seventh day the child died. And the servants of David were afraid to tell him that the child was dead, for they said, "Behold, while the child was yet alive, we spoke to him, and he did not listen to us. How then can we say to him the child is dead? He may do himself some harm." But when David saw that his servants were whispering together, David understood that the child was dead. And David said to his servants, "Is the child dead?" They said, "He is dead." Then David arose from the earth and washed and anointed himself and changed his clothes. **And he went into the house of the LORD and worshiped.** He then went to his own house. And when he asked, they set food before him, and he ate.

David's worship after his prayer request was getting flatly rejected was a sure sign of his absolute surrender to the Will of God.

Daniel 3:16-18:

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego answered and said to the king, "O Nebuchadnezzar, we have no need to answer you in this matter. If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. **But if not,** be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

Even if God chose not to save these three people, they would still not commit the sin of idol worship – their surrender to the will of God was that strong!

Esther 4:15-16:

15 Then Esther told them to reply to Mordecai, 16 "Go, gather all the Jews to be found in Susa, and hold a fast on my behalf, and do not eat or drink for three days, night or day. I and my young women will also fast as you do. Then I will go to the king, though it is against the law, and if I perish, I perish."

Even if the king killed Esther for barging in, she would have accepted it as God's will for her!

Hab. 3:17-18:

Though the fig tree should not blossom,

nor fruit be on the vines,

the produce of the olive fail

and the fields yield no food,

the flock be cut off from the fold

and there be no herd in the stalls, yet I will rejoice in the LORD;

I will take joy in the God of my salvation.

Agricultural disasters happening in the prophet's life according to the Will of God would not stop the prophet from rejoicing in the LORD.

Oh, how exemplary these God's-Will saluting characters are! They inspire us to reject the Hyper-Supernaturalist's unbiblical proposition: "God does miracles at our beck and call!"

THE 'PERHAPS' THEOLOGY WHICH RE-HAMMERS THIS: ALL OUR PRAYERS MUST BE SUBMITTED TO THE WILL OF GOD!

In the Bible, we are repeatedly told that God is Sovereign. That means, God always does what He wants to do, and none can stop him (Daniel 4:35 is a classic verse on the Sovereignty of God). Not just our healing, even our salvation depends on his Sovereign Will – did you know? I understand this when I read Zephaniah 2:3 which goes this way: 'Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land, you who do what he commands. Seek righteousness,

seek humility; *perhaps* you will be sheltered on the day of the LORD's anger.' The word 'perhaps' here tells us that even Salvation from sin and salvation from the day of the Lord's anger happens because of his Sovereign Will. We cannot command God to even save us from sin – that is what Zephaniah 2:3 tells us. He will of course save us when we call unto him for salvation from sin on this side of eternity because he has told us repeatedly in his Word that it is his will to save us from sin (Ezek. 18:32; Ezek. 33:11; 1 Tim. 2:4; 2 Pet. 3:9). But we do not have repeated statements like these when healing is concerned.

The word 'perhaps' is found in the vocabulary of several other characters, not just Prophet Zephaniah – a word that shows total submission to God's Will. Here are some examples:

1. **Jonathan**: 'Jonathan said to his young armour-bearer, "Come, let's go over to the outpost of those uncircumcised men. **Perhaps** the LORD will act in our behalf. Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few"' (I Sam. 14:6).

2. **King Zedekiah**: "Inquire now of the LORD for us because Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon is attacking us. **Perhaps** the LORD will perform wonders for us as in times past so that he will withdraw from us" (Jer. 21:2).

3. **Prophet Amos**: 'Hate evil, love good; maintain justice in the courts. Perhaps the LORD God Almighty will have mercy on the remnant of Joseph' (Amos 5:15).

This is not just an occurrence found just in the Old Testament. Listen to Paul's Words to the Simon the Sorcerer:

'Repent therefore of this your wickedness and pray God if **perhaps** the thought of your heart may be forgiven you' (Acts 8:22).

Perhaps some who wrongly believe – atleast a remnant – that one can command disease/sickness/trouble to leave will change their mind after understanding this piece of theology – a theology I call **'perhaps'** theology from the Bible!

ARE WE LITTLE GODS WHO CAN COMMAND A MIRACLE?

To further their claim that we can command a miracle to happen, hyper-supernatural false teachers teach that believers are gods! A Madurai pastor proclaims that believers are gods. He quotes Psalm 82:6 to teach this. It goes this way: I said, "You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you". This verse is again quoted in John 10:34. But Psalm 82:6 does not teach that believers are gods. What then is the correct interpretation of Psalm 82:6? It is this: Other gods do not exist. There is only one true God (he exists as a Trinity, we know, as Jesus is God – Titus 2:13 - and so is the Holy Spirit – Acts 5: 3-5)! Let's assume that other gods exist just for argument's sake! If they exist, these gods are under the judgment of the God of Israel who is the only God of the world.

He is going to judge all the people and the so-called other gods! So, that's the meaning of Psalm 82:6. Psalm 82:6 does not teach that believers are gods. In Acts 12:21-23 via the Herod-struck-down-by-angel-of-the-Lord story, the Bible clearly teaches that believers are not gods and those who claim to be god or take the glory of God can be even judged instantly or in eternity. In this passage, Herod speaks and someone said, "This is the voice of God!" At that time as Herod does not deflect the praise to the true God, the angel of the Lord struck down Herod and he died instantly. If Herod was a little god, the angel of the Lord should not have struck down Herod! But he was killed by the angel of the Lord as he tried to usurp God's position. So do not get fooled by the hyper-supernatural cult pastors! **So don't believe that Madurai pastor who says that we are little gods!** Hold onto the truth of God's Word! Walk the narrow path of sound doctrine! Do not get side-tracked! Remain in the word of God! Let us remain in our Crete (our Crete can be Chennai, Bangalore or Hyderabad) like Titus did and fight false teaching (Titus 1:5-9)! Let us remain in our Ephesus (our Ephesus can be Noida, Pune or Vizag) like Timothy and push-back wrong teaching (1 Tim. 1: 3)! Let us shun anti-biblical new teachings!

DOES EXODUS 4:16 AND EXODUS 7:1 TEACH WE ARE GODS?

Some Hyper-Supernatural false teachers quote Exodus 4:16 and Exodus 7:1 to teach that believers are gods. Don't forget that the same book of Exodus also says, "You shall not have any other gods before me" (including yourself) [Exodus 20: 3]. Deuteronomy 6:4, Isaiah 43:10 are some of the many references that tell us straight

that there is only one God. So, we are not gods. Only Yahweh, Jesus and the Holy Spirit are the One God who exist in three persons. There is no fourth or fifth person who is a god. Clear, direct passages take precedence when it comes to doctrine formulation. God saying to Moses, "You shall be as God to them" in Exodus 4:16 simply means that Moses shall be the mouthpiece of God to them. It does not mean Moses was God. God uniquely inspired people like Moses to write His words (2 Tim. 3:16). Now the canon of Scripture is closed. This means that we cannot keep adding fresh books or material to the 66 books of the Bible which are inspired by the Holy Spirit and recognised by Church Leaders as God's Word. We have a faith that was delivered to us "once for all" (Jude 3). Exodus 7:1 also says that Moses was made "like a God" before Pharoah. The implication is the same: Moses was God's ambassador to Pharoah. We too are "Christ's Ambassadors" when we share the Gospel (2 Cor 5:20). But that does not mean we are gods.

CHAPTER 35

ARE YOU DESPERATE FOR A MIRACLE?



This Chapter Is Authored By The Author's Wife, Evangelin Duke

Note: Having an understanding about what the Bible really teaches about receiving miracles guard us from the Hyper-Supernaturalism Doctrine which wrongly says, "God will always do miracles, here and now!" This chapter is a Sound Doctrine embracing, balanced, practical study on the topic of miracles.

EINDHIRAN'S REEL MIRACLES

The 2010 movie, *Eindhiran (in Tamil/Telugu)/Robot (in Hindi)*, starring **Rajinikanth**, I read in an article, has several 'jaw-dropping' moments. Yes, miracle-moments! Miracle-moments like Rajini, the Robot, tracing out and talking to mosquitoes from the West Mambalam area of Chennai that stung his lady-love in that movie, **Aishwariya Rai Bachchan**. Magic-moments like Rajini, the Robot, helping a lady deliver a

baby. Incredible moments like Rajini, the Robot, running atop and alongside a zipping electric train to rescue his lady-love; out-of-the-world moments like Rajini, the Robot, multiplying into million other look-alike robots and causing utter chaos and havoc, etc. We know that these 'miracle-moments' were just made up to pull the public into the movie theatres and keep them at the edge of their seats. They simply were not real. They only belong to the reel (the movie reel). But I want to talk about experiencing real miracle moments in our life, in this chapter.

MY REAL MIRACLE

I recall the time when I was a working woman, staying in the Women's Christian Hostel, Chennai (in the 1990s). I faced a tight financial situation as I was between jobs. I did not want to ask my parents for money at that point in my life. "They are missionaries, so why should I burden them?" I told myself. I did not want to borrow money from my friends. "Borrowing money, however severe your need is, is not a good habit!" I lectured myself. I just prayed about it. "Lord Jesus, help me," I mumbled. Meanwhile, the due date to pay my hostel fees neared. At that time, I was told that there was a guest who came to visit me in my hostel. I wondered who it could be. A lady showed up. She told me that God had spoken to her to give me some money. Even as I was still numb with disbelief, she handed over that money and disappeared. When I counted the money, it was exactly what I needed to pay my hostel fees! The Lord Jesus had done a miracle for me!

I believe in miracles. I really do. That's why I write this chapter. During the Christmas Season we often hear Isaiah 9:6 being read. The first title, this verse gives Jesus is this: "Wonderful". Yes, the very name of the God I worship is "Wonderful!" Yes, our God does wonders! Amen, our God does miracles!

Recently, I spent time reading and mulling over the recorded miracles of Jesus found in the Gospels. There are 36 different miracles that Jesus did according to a list in the *Dictionary of Jesus and the Gospels* (page 551). When my husband and I re-read them and studied them, we learnt many wonderful things about the wonderful acts of Jesus. Most importantly, we learnt about the things we could do to expect a miracle from Jesus. Are you desperate for a miracle today? Then, these lessons are for you!

It must be noted at the outset that none of these steps serve as a guarantee for miracles. But they are guidelines to receive miracles from the presence of Jesus, if it were His Will to do a miracle for us at any given point in time. What are the things we can do best in order to receive a miracle from Jesus?

1. SURRENDER YOUR LIFE TO JESUS

COLORLESS LIFE? TASTELESS LIFE?

Jesus' first miracle was turning the tasteless, odorless, colorless, water into tasty, blood-red colored wine with a great aroma (John 2). Is your life tasteless, today? Is your life flat without purpose and meaning? Is your life

colorless and dreary? Let Jesus, the miracle worker, touch you. If you allow Him to do that, then your life will change. It will become colorful and tasty.

DISEASES CAUSED BY SIN?

Not all diseases are caused by sin (The story in John 9 teaches us this). Not all problems we face are because of the wickedness in our lives. But we do understand from certain Bible records of Jesus' miracles, that we must first repent from our sins to receive our miracle. When his four friends told the paralytic man that they would be carrying him to the Jesus Meeting in a home, I do believe, he repented from his sins, confessed them to Jesus and asked for forgiveness. Otherwise, why would Jesus tell him as soon as he was lowered down through a ripped-open roof in that crowded home, "My son, your sins are forgiven" (Mark 2:5)? Jesus always gets to the root of the problem because, as God in flesh He knows everything. He was effectively telling that man: "You know that you became sick because of your sin. I see that you have repented from that sin and sought for my forgiveness. Now I forgive you of your sins!" That paralytic man took up his bed and walked in front of the stunned onlookers at the word of Jesus.

THE BIGGEST MIRACLE

You desperately want to receive your miracle. But, do you also want to repent from the secret sin you are perhaps practicing? You must. Come to Jesus. His blood that was shed for you on the Cross of Calvary will cleanse you from every sin. The greatest miracle that can happen in your life is the miracle of true and total repentance from sin. And this miracle often leads to little miracles like physical healing, financial breakthroughs, and so on!

2. SIMPLY OBEY THE SCRIPTURES

WHEN A FISHERMAN LISTENED TO A CARPENTER

Would you, as a seasoned fisherman, listen to the advice from a carpenter on fishing? It is highly unlikely. You would tell the carpenter: "Mind your business, brother! I know what I am doing!" But Peter, the fisherman, listened to the advice given to him by a carpenter. The Carpenter we are talking about is Jesus, God in flesh and bones. He instructed Peter, "Now go out where it is deeper, and let down your nets to catch some fish" (Luke 5:4 NLT). I like Peter's answer to Jesus' instruction: "Master, we toiled all night and took nothing! ***But at your word*** I will let down the nets." When Peter took Jesus at His Word and obeyed Him instantly without asking questions or making clarifications, there was a boat-sinking, net-breaking miraculous catch of fish (verse 6).

MBA TEXTBOOKS VS THE BIBLE

Do you want a boat-sinking, net-breaking, and not-enough-room-to-receive-it sort of miraculous blessing in your life? Take the written Word of God, the Bible, seriously and obey it instantly. For example, the written Word of God talks pretty plainly about believers taking water baptism by immersion. On the other hand, your church tradition administers water baptism by sprinkling water when young as babies. Throw your church tradition to the trashcan and just obey what the Bible teaches.

To cite another example, the Bible talks about serving others with a servant-spirit as the only way to become the 'greatest' of all. But the best-selling MBA textbook would talk about bossing over people and manipulating them as a successful method to make it to the top. Just toss away what the MBA textbook says and embrace what the Holy Word of God says. When you have done that, you have moved closer to your miracle day (according to God's good will and grand plan for you)!

3. SURRENDER TO THE WILL OF THE FATHER

GOD IS NO HOTEL WAITER

A man with leprosy came to Jesus one day. He went down on his knees before Jesus (Mark 1:40). I like his posture here. It was a posture that spoke volumes about his submission to God. He cleared his throat and spoke up to the Lord. He said, "If you are willing, you can make me clean!" (Mark 1:40).

I also like what he said in his prayer. What he did equaled to what he said. He was willing to be submissive to the will of Jesus and the will of the Father in Heaven. His words and actions 'moved' Jesus to do a miracle for him (Mark 1:41, ESV). Jesus stretched out his hand, touched him and told him, "I am willing, be healed!" (Mark 1:41, NLT). And he was healed! Instead of becoming 'unclean' by touching a leper, Jesus, God Almighty on earth-duty, makes the leper clean by healing him and by giving him fresh, baby-like skin! The lesson we take home is very direct: we must be submissive to the will of God in order to receive a miracle; we cannot dictate terms to God and try to twist His arm in order to force Him to do a miracle for us; you cannot behave as if you are eating in a hotel, with God playing the role of a waiter who is at your beck and call to do what you tell Him to do! God is no waiter and you are not his customer (when it comes to praying for miracles)!

MY MIRACLE BABY'S STORY

I was very excited when I became pregnant for the second time in February 2007. My first child was a boy and so my husband and I naturally wished that this time, God would bless us with a baby girl. But darkness struck

at noon. When I went for one of my routine medical checkups during my early pregnancy, after examining my scan report, the doctor told me that the baby had no heart beat! She even suggested that I abort the baby immediately. I walked out of the doctor's room with my eyes welled up. This news was equally shattering for my husband who was dreaming about having a daughter who would one day come and ask him, "Dad, How do I look in this saree?" My husband and I did not want to commit the sin of abortion. We just committed the matter to the Lord Jesus. We told Him, "Lord, we really want this baby. We believe that You can do a miracle for us, in this regard. But nevertheless, let Your will be done."

After this prayer we went to yet another Medical Scan Centre, one of the best in the city of Hyderabad, the city where we lived (2005-2021). There, they told us, the baby inside was breathing and was alive and well! Jesus had done a great miracle for us when we submitted ourselves to His Will and prayed! I delivered that very baby, safely on November 12, 2007. We named this beautiful girl child as 'Datasha' – an Indianized version for a girl baby name from the Bible word for 'royal command'.

GETHSEMANE/GOLGOTHA LIFE SITUATIONS...

In the Bible we read of people who after much prayer remained in the same condition. When Paul repeatedly requested God to remove the thorn from his flesh, God told him, "My grace is sufficient for you!" (2 Cor. 12:9).

In other words, God was telling Paul, "Paul, the thorn will remain. But I will give you grace to bear it and you will become better in this seemingly bitter process!" The same Paul left his ministry associate, Trophimus sick at Miletus and moved on (2 Tim. 4:20). Paul and his team perhaps prayed night and day for Trophimus to recover. Nothing happened. No miracle took place. They perhaps concluded that it was God's will not to heal Trophimus immediately. So, they moved on.

Would you surrender to the will of your Father in Heaven whose ways and thoughts are higher than your ways when it comes to the issue of a miracle? Would you imitate Jesus who signed out from His prayer to His Father for a rescue from Gethsemane and a certain death at Golgotha saying, "Yet not as I will but Your will be done" in those heart-breaking "Gethsemane/Golgotha-life-situations"?

4. SAY A SUBMISSIVE PRAYER OF FAITH

THE BISHOP AND THE BOSS

In our study of the miracles of Jesus, one of the most exciting discoveries my husband and I made was this: two 'big-shots' prayed the most submissive of prayers and walked away with a miracle! The two 'big-shots' I am referring to, are Jairus, 'one of the synagogue leaders' (Mark 5:22) and the Roman Centurion (Matt. 8:5). One

can be called 'the Bishop'; the other can be called 'the Boss'. But the beauty is, both these 'big-shots' - Bishop and the Boss - prayed prayers that oozed with humility.

First, let us look at the prayer of the Bishop: "My little daughter is dying. Please come and put your hands on her so that she will be healed and live!" (Mark 5:23, TNIV). As a synagogue leader, this man was part of the organized Jewish religion. Jesus was the leader of rebels of this organized religion, so to speak. It must have been tremendously humbling for a man of such stature and background to come to Jesus (the rebel leader of a minority group) and ask for help. But he did! His dead daughter was raised up, as a result!

Let us also look at the prayer that the Roman Centurion prayed: "Lord, I do not deserve to have you come under my roof. But just say the word, and my servant will be healed!" (Matt. 8:8 TNIV). From this man's prayer, we understand that there is no compulsion whatsoever for God to even save us from sin, leave alone, heal us. If we are saved, it is because of His Grace. If we are saved, it is because He graciously decided to enter our sinful hearts when we repented from sin and invited him to do so (Rev 3:20). If we get healed or experience a miracle, again, it will be because of His great grace and mercy!

At the end of the Roman Centurion's encounter with Jesus, we read that 'his servant was healed at that very hour' (Matt. 8:13). See how Jesus responds to prayers that do not brag about who we are and what we have

achieved but exude humility and show forth utter desperate faith in God! Are you ready to make such prayers in your tight tangles and tough times? Then, who knows, your miracle could arrive in that very hour!

THE FINGER OF GOD IN A PRINTING PRESS!

Late one night, I was casually glancing at the PDF version of page 43 of my husband's book, *Straight Talk* (the first edition released in 2010), and this was after we had received news that it was already printed in the press. I was deeply disappointed to see that the last few paragraphs of the chapter in the book, I was most interested in, *How I Met and Married My Wife,* had completely gone missing. In that PDF version, which my husband approved and sent to the press, that particular chapter ended with a comma and three crucial closing paragraphs were totally absent.

Baffled and broken, I brought this to the attention of my husband who told me: "It is my mistake. I should have checked this more carefully before sending it to the Press." We prayed the following humble prayer together: "Lord, we don't deserve to publish a book on what the Bible teaches on hot youth issues. But it was You who gave us the friends and funds to do it, so very graciously. At this point in time, please intervene! You are the God who does creative miracles! You can, even now, enter the Press and ensure the full matter is printed on page 43 of this book!" After this prayer we went to bed and slept soundly.

The next day, my husband called the printer. He asked him to read page 43 from the printed version of that particular book. When the printer read that page, my husband was totally shell-shocked to know that the whole matter was printed (including the concluding paragraphs!). What had happened was simply out-of-the world! The God who came down on Mount Sinai thousands of years ago to write the Ten Commandments with His own fingers, we believe, entered the Press after we prayed, and wrote with His own fingers, the concluding paragraphs of page 43! The God we serve still works miracles in response to humble prayer!

5. SOW INTO THE KINGDOM OF GOD

PAYING FOR SPIRITUAL FOOD RECEIVED!

The little boy in Jesus' meeting that drew about 5000 men, volunteered to give his little lunch box with five loaves and two fish to *Uncle* Andrew who was looking for volunteers on Jesus' instruction, to feed the large crowd (John 6:8,9). "Jesus fed this large crowd with spiritual food for hours together. I too was fed. I must give back something in return out of gratefulness for the wonderful way that Jesus has blessed me spiritually in this meeting. I just had Spiritual Biryani in the Jesus Hotel – if it can be seen that way. I can't walk away without paying my bill. Now Jesus wants to give this huge crowd physical food after serving them spiritual food. Let me help Jesus in this project with ALL that I have!" – Those were perhaps the thoughts of that little boy. His

thoughts were perfectly in line with Paul's thoughts expressed in 1 Corinthians: We must materially/financially support the servants of God who have blessed us spiritually (I Cor 9:11). What was the end result after the boy sowed generously into the Kingdom work done by Jesus? 5000 men were miraculously fed via the miraculous multiplication of food in the little lad's lunch box!

SPLASHING, NOT CAREFULLY CALCULATING!

Wondering why you have not yet received your long-awaited miracle? The answer may be very simple – you may have been very stingy when it comes to giving offerings to servants of God who have blessed you spiritually. Don't be. Sow without holding back like the little lad. Splash your offering like Mary who splashed a costly perfume on the feet of Jesus, instead of carefully measuring out and calculating your offering (John 11:2). And when this very same Mary who had proved her love for Jesus through extravagant giving told Jesus, "Lord, if you had been there, my brother would not have died", Jesus immediately performed the greatest ever of His recorded miracles in quick response – he raised the dead-for-four-days Lazarus up from the grave (John 11:32-44).

The point I am making here is not that miracles from Jesus can be purchased by money. They cannot be. But we must understand that we cannot truthfully claim to love God or claim to be grateful to God without giving our time, talents and treasures to Him!

6. STICK WITH JESUS TILL THE MIRACLE ARRIVES

CALLED BY GOD AS 'DOG'!

"Much of our praying can be likened to the little boy who rang the doorbell and left before the door opened!" I read this sublime quote on prayer somewhere. It is particularly true of prayers for miracles. There is no better example for persistence when it comes to praying for miracles than the Greek woman from Syrian Phoenicia, who came to request Jesus for deliverance for her demon-possessed daughter.

Jesus effectively called her a 'dog' (See Mark 7:27). But she did not give up, get offended and run away from the presence of Jesus. But she stayed on. She hung in there. She persisted. She kept talking. She said, "Lord, even the dogs under the table eat the children's crumbs!" (Mark 7:28). In other words, she admitted that she was a dog to Jesus. I am very sure that Jesus, God Omniscient in human form, knew this woman's inner life the way He knew the Samaritan woman's whom He met near a well. The Samaritan woman had five husbands and was living in with the sixth man. This woman too was perhaps steeped in sin in her private life, despite knowing

the true God. Like a dog, she perhaps returned back to her vomit by repeated backsliding (See 2 Peter 2:22, where this imagery is used). So, there is no doubt that Jesus was accurate when He called her a 'dog'. But the great thing about this particular lady is that she persisted! She kept talking to Jesus despite hearing those hard-to-swallow words from Her Maker. She accepted that she lived a dog's life and she expressed her desperateness to consume the litter under the table of Jesus, like a dog would! Such was her surprising persistence and shocking humility! In response, Jesus did a miracle for her – the demon was gone from her daughter's life immediately!

Are you thinking of quitting your relationship with Jesus because the miracle you have been long expecting has not arrived? It is possible that you have been married for many years, and yet there is no sign of that miracle baby. Or maybe you have been working hard for many years in your company and there is no scent of your promotion orders. Don't give up! Persist in humble prayer! At the end of this long winding road, there is a miracle waiting for you according to the will of God!

7. SAIL WITH JESUS SILENTLY WITHOUT THINKING TOO MUCH OF THE MIRACLE!

Yes, we must pray for miracles in our life. But we also meet folks in the Bible who just sailed along in their lives,

silently serving God and without making a big fuss, even though they had a huge need for a miracle. Jesus intervened in their lives voluntarily and did a miracle for them – we have no record that they even prayed or asked God for a miracle!

THE FUNERAL DISRUPTER!

Take for example the amazing incident in which Jesus raised the dead young man – the only child of a mother in Nain (Luke 7:11-15). Jesus literally interrupted that funeral service – no one, including the mother of that dead young man asked him to intervene. Jesus became the 'funeral disrupter' by raising the dead young man who was being carried in a funeral procession! Jesus gave the dead young man he raised, 'back to his mother', the Bible records very interestingly (Luke 7:15).

It was as if Jesus told her, "I see that this son of yours is your only child. I know you have no one else, humanly speaking, to care for you! I see your tears. I see your spirit that says, *I will continue serving God even through this*! I want to intervene and do a miracle for you out of my free will and unique plan for you!" Jesus gave back this once-dead young man back to his mother, the same way he gave John, his closest disciple, to his earthly mother while He hung on the cross! But it must be noted here that Jesus did not go around interrupting every funeral procession during His earthly life. In fact, when he heard that John the Baptist was beheaded for

speaking the truth to the adulterous Herod, Jesus did not raise him from the dead! So, the principle we learn here is this: we must continue to serve God whatever the circumstances without complaining bitterly. When we do that He may choose to intervene and do a miracle for us at the most unexpected time!

I have experienced what I am talking about here. After Duke and I moved to the Tirumalgiri area of Hyderabad in 2008, I would often notice this huge triplex house built in a modern style every time we drove on our scooter to the main road from our rented house located near an arrack shop around 2 kms inside from the main road, the Military Dairy Farm Road. This triplex house was close to the main road, just behind the Indian Oil petrol pump (the Kanajiguda Petrol Bunk). I thought to myself: *How wonderful it would be, if we had this house as the base for ministry! We can host our meetings for youth here! Many people can come as it is close to the main road!* But, I did not even start to pray for this. Within days, God so graciously directed events so that we met the owner of this house in our local church (then). And what was more, he offered to give this house to us for rent at a very reasonable price. And without much delay we moved in there. Since then, God brought many Google Genners to this place to bless them with His Word and His Presence during our six-year stay there (2009-2015)! It was at this rented ministry base-cum-residence that my husband Duke, made great progress and completed the monthly journey of leading a study of God's Word for small groups, summarizing entire Bible books using acronyms. The very names of the respective Bible books were used as acronyms. This journey of study, which covered all the sixty six Bible books, was completed here. I launched the Fountain of Tears

Against Mountain of Fears Fasting prayer monthly event here. Miracles were witnessed by those who showed up. Our Month-end Mid-night Prayer was launched here. Corporate Pros entered the new month in God's presence, from here. From here, we went for Gospel tracts outreach, covering different parts of Hyderabad, using our *Bubbly* and *Dhoni* tract. Indeed, God blessed us with a miracle – this fabulous rented ministry base cum residence – without me even praying for one by giving us this place for rent! He is so good!

PROBLEMS 12/18/38-YEARS OLD? IT CAN BE SOLVED!

Your problem may be 12 years old. Your addiction to that bad habit may be 12-years long. But an encounter with Jesus can transform that embarrassing problem into an earth-shaking miracle like it happened for the bleeding woman who met Jesus (Mark 5:25-29). Your trouble may have lasted for 18 years. But a meeting with Jesus can change all that in a single day, like it happened for the woman who had a bent back for 18 years and Jesus healed her instantly so she could walk tall all her life (Luke 13:11-13). Your sickness may be 38 years old but when you run into Jesus that 38-year-old terrible condition can run away the same day, like it happened to the sick man by the pool of Bethesda (John 5:1-9). Or is it quite possible that the harrowing experience that you are currently going through has basically existed all your life? But when Jesus touches you, like how it happened to the man born blind, your life-long harrowing experience can become a heaven-experience instantly (John 9:1-41)! So, don't give up!

(The first draft of this chapter was edited by Stephen Jothiraj and Adeline Asirvatham, in December 2010).

CHAPTER 36

WHAT THE BIBLE TEACHES ABOUT DISEASE AND SICKNESS PUT IN THE OUTLINE C-A-N-C-E-R



This Sound Doctrine Emphasizing Teaching on Disease and Sickness Will Help Us Counter The Hyper-Supernaturalism false teaching which goes this way:
"God will always heal you, here and now!"

A 'cancer' in the Body of Christ is the wrong understanding of what the Bible teaches about sickness and disease.

I figured out that we could learn about what the Bible teaches about Sickness and Disease using the outline, C-A-N-C-E-R.

Let's do it! The first letter in the acronym CANCER which we are about to use to learn about what the Bible teaches about sicknesses and disease is C:

DEVIL-SENT OPPRESSION

C-Creation of Disease and Sickness: Peter pointed that the Devil was the source of sickness when he said this while preaching in the home of Cornelius: 'God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him' (Acts 10:38). He was repeating what he learnt from the words of His Master, the Lord Jesus who talked of the woman who had a bent back for over 18-years this way: 'And ought not this woman, a daughter of Abraham whom Satan bound for eighteen years, be loosed from this bond on the Sabbath day?' (Luke 13:16).

GOD-ALLOWED DISEASE AND SICKNESS

This is only one side of the story. When we read the whole of Scripture we will quickly know something else about the 'creation' or source of disease and sickness. A careful reading of the New Testament tells us that, at times, God uses disease and sickness, as a means of inviting people to repentance and holy living, as baffling as it sounds. Apostle Paul was 'filled with the Holy Spirit' (Acts 13:9) when he said that Elymas would become blind for being a stubborn stumbling block to those who sought to come to a faith in Jesus (see Acts 13:10-11). Jesus does something similar in Revelation 2. He warned Jezebel, a woman in ministry in the early church. Jesus said that she would be thrown in the sickbed! By who? By Jesus himself! This disease would deter her from

further leading God's people into a life of sexual immorality, Jesus felt (Rev. 2:20-23). Some of you can't believe that Jesus would do such a thing! But it is there in the Bible. Revelation 2:22 records the words of Jesus this way: 'Behold, I will throw her onto a sickbed, and those who commit adultery with her I will throw into great tribulation, unless they repent of her works'. Yes, disease, at times is a tool in God's hands to make us fall at his feet in repentance!

'YOU HAVE THIS SICKNESS BECAUSE OF THIS SIN' — DON'T SAY THAT EVER!

But at the same time, we must not make the mistake of saying to a sick person, "You have this particular disease because of this particular sin that you have committed". This right is only reserved for Bible-authors who were directed by the Spirit (Acts 13:9-11) and for the Lord Jesus himself (Rev. 2:20-23). Only on the day of judgement will we know why a certain disease came upon a certain person and a lot of other details. So, do not jump the gun. God calls us to pray for the sick. Let's stick to that.

A writer for the *Our Daily Bread* gives further explanation from the Bible for what I just said: 'Simply put, this old formula says that if you're suffering, you must have sinned. When Job tragically lost his livestock, children, and health, his friends used the formula on him. "Who, being innocent, has ever perished?" Eliphaz said, suspecting Job's guilt (Job 4:7). Bildad even told Job that his children only died because they had sinned

(8:4). Ignorant of the real cause of Job's calamities (1:6–2:10), they tormented him with simplistic reasons for his pain, later receiving God's rebuke (42:7).'

The next letter in the acronym CANCER which we are about to use to learn about what the Bible teaches about sicknesses and disease is 'A'.

PERFECT HEALTH, ONLY IN HEAVEN!

A-Annulment of Disease: The annulment of all disease will only happen on the other side of eternity. The Bible makes this clear in Revelation 21:4, where we read this: "He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away." Please notice the future tense used in this verse. So only after the return of Jesus, the creation of new heaven and earth, will there be a time when there is no disease or sickness in this world. Apostle Paul also implied this, when he wrote, we the children of God "await" the "redemption of our bodies" – the total healing from every sickness (Rom. 8:23). Till such a time dawns after the return of Jesus and setting up of new heaven and earth, we can enjoy the 'first-fruits' (meaning partial, reversible healing according to the will of God on a case by case basis) (Rom. 8:23). Even those raised from the dead by Jesus and the Apostles, eventually died, didn't they? Paul compares our bodies to a tent that will be destroyed one day (if the Lord's

coming tarries). He writes, 'For we know that if the earthly **tent** we live in is destroyed, we have a building from God, an eternal house in heaven, not built by human hands' (2 Cor. 5:1). Paul believed that even if our disease-hit body eventually dies, we will live in perfect health in heaven.

The next letter in the acronym CANCER which we are about to use to learn about what the Bible teaches about sicknesses and disease is N.

N-Now, Yes Even Now, We Can Be Healed From Any Disease, If It Is God's Will To Do So! The Bible is full of examples and exhortation actively asking us to seek healing here and now. That is why Jesus gave this instruction to his disciples: 'Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse those who have leprosy, drive out demons. Freely you have received; freely give' (Matt. 10:8).

MY WHEEZING GONE INSTANTLY AFTER MY PROFESSOR PRAYED FOR ME

May I share a personal story in this regard? I have suffered with wheezing right from my childhood. I remember telling my mom, "Mom, I want to die. I cannot bear these bouts of wheezing!" As a student of Agricultural Engineering in SHUATS, Allahabad, I was even admitted in the hospital situated opposite to the college campus because of a severe attack of wheezing. I prayed for a healing. Dr. D. S. Emmanuel, my professor, also visited me

and prayed. The Evangelical Union student leaders in that campus also prayed. I have never ever had another bout of wheezing in all these years! It has been over 25 years since I graduated from college, now!

HEALING WILL HAPPEN IN EACH CASE, WE PRAY FOR?

Does that mean healing will happen in each case we pray for? Absolutely not. There was an occasion when Paul left Trophimus, a valued team member 'sick' at Miletus (2 Tim. 4:20). The implication is this: Paul prayed for Trophimus' healing, but the sickness did not go away and consequently Paul decided to move on leaving him behind. **Healing also was not perhaps instant in the case of atleast three more New Testament people of God**: Epaphroditus (Phil. 2:25-27, the prayers for his immediate healing when his health started to first deteriorate. perhaps went unanswered but he was healed just in time when he was about to die), Timothy (1 Tim. 5:23, he had 'frequent illness' which makes us wonder about the times, the churches he blessed, must have for surely prayed for him, for instant healing from whatever bothered him, these prayers obviously went unanswered) and Paul himself (2 Cor. 12:7-10, three times Paul prayed for the 'thorn' in his flesh, a nagging disease he perhaps had, to be removed, but God did not remove that thorn – he only promised the sufficiency of His Grace that would be with Paul even as the stubborn thorn stayed on).

The next letter in the acronym CANCER which we are about to use to learn about what the Bible teaches about sicknesses and disease is 'C' (again).

C-Church Elders Will Be God's Instruments When It Comes To Healing: James make this clear as he writes the following words: 'Is anyone among you sick? Let them call the elders of the church to pray over them and anoint them with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer offered in faith will make the sick person well; the Lord will raise them up. If they have sinned, they will be forgiven' (Jas. 5:14-15). Church leaders must regularly pray for the sick. But again this passage is not teaching that healing will always happen, irrespective of God's Will. The same author, James, writes this under the Spirit's inspiration: 'Why, you do not even know what will happen tomorrow. What is your life? You are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes' (Jas. 4:14). The implication is this: while some will get healed and get a fresh lease of life, some others could pass away, perhaps affected by a dreaded disease or by anything else.

The next letter in the acronym CANCER which we are about to use to learn about what the Bible teaches about sicknesses and disease is E.

THE BLESSINGS OF HAVING AN ILLNESS

E-Explanations, for why sickness comes, the Bible offers these. Jesus explained why a man was born blind as

his disciples questioned him about that. Jesus said that he was born blind to display the works of God (John 9:1-3). So, we can be assured that there is a purpose of God in each and every sickness. As I already mentioned, in Acts 13 and in Revelation 2, we see that sicknesses would have a sanctifying effect on those upon whom it comes – this is God's expectation. Paul was not unfamiliar with this kind of situation. God told him that 'His grace was sufficient' when he prayed for a stubborn thorn in his flesh – perhaps a painful disease in his body - to be removed from him (2 Cor. 12:7-12). What's more, this persistent thorn which can be seen as a sickness, was God-allowed (notice the phrase 'was given') to keep Paul from being 'conceited' as he himself admitted (2 Cor. 12:7).

In Galatians 4:13, the apostle Paul said, "As you know, it was **because of an illness** that I first **preached the** Gospel to you." In this case, the arrival of the sickness was a blessing in disguise for Paul. As he stayed sick in Galatia, he preached the Gospel in Galatia. You may be sick in a hospital bed now. But as you share the Goodnews with the medical personnel and fellow sick people there, you fulfill one of the purposes that God had, in allowing a sickness to come to you (Job 1). If Lazarus had not died, Jesus could not have resurrected him. And because Jesus resurrected Lazarus, people saw him and believed in Jesus (John 11:45). When healing happens in response to prayer, people come to Jesus.

The final letter in the acronym CANCER which we are about to use to learn about what the Bible teaches about sicknesses and disease is R.

R-Relentless we must be, when it comes to prayers for those who are sick. The Bible is clear: we must not give up when it comes to prayer for anything, including for those who are sick. Jesus' point was this: 'you ought to always pray and not give up' (Luke 18:1). The deliverance from the disease in response to this prayer may come instantly (see Acts 8:7), or with some delay (see Luke 17:14), or on the other side of eternity (see Rev. 21:4).

It is my prayer that believers will embrace all what the Bible teaches on healing, sickness and diseases instead of being selective. This outline, C-A-N-C-E-R will help us recall all what the Scriptures teach about healing, sicknesses and diseases!

SECTION THREE

TAKING ON HYPER-LOVE

Chapter 37

WILL THOSE WHO LAND IN HELL, STOP EXISTING, AS AN ELDERLY ENGLISH BIBLE SCHOLAR SUGGESTED THAT THEY WOULD?



An elderly statesman of the evangelical faith from Britain wrote these shocking words: *'Emotionally, I find the concept [of eternal conscious torment in Hell] intolerable and do not understand how people can live with it without either cauterizing their feelings or cracking under the strain. But our emotions are a fluctuating, unreliable guide to truth and must not be exalted to the place of supreme authority in determining it . . . my question must be—and is—not what does my heart tell me, but what does God's word say?'*

And after he examined what God's Word does say on this subject he suggested that those who go to hell, stop existing there. He wrote, 'So both the language of destruction and the imagery of fire seem to point to

annihilation (people who go to hell, stop existing in hell).' This teaching has been called Conditional Immortality or Annihilationism.

How do we respond to this kind of Hyper-Love teaching? A teaching that goes this way: "God is so loving that he will destroy with fire those who land in hell so that they will not have to endure hell torment, forever and ever"?

We can 'fire' this hell-populating false teaching using the acronym F-I-R-E!

IF ETERNAL LIFE MEANS CONSCIOUS JOYOUS ETERNAL EXISTENCE IN HEAVEN, ETERNAL PUNISHMENT MEANS CONSCIOUS TORMENT IN HELL!

'F' STANDS FOR THE FIRE IMAGERY FOR HELL USED IN THE BIBLE. *A careful observation of those references in the Bible will reveal this: fire keeps burning the ever-alive bodies of hell-dwellers!* Matthew 18:8, Matthew 25:41 and Jude 7 – in all these three places the Bible attaches the word 'eternal' to 'fire'. So the fire of hell always keeps burning! This fire not only torments the Devil and his angels but also humans who stubbornly have followed the Devil and share his fate. Matthew 18:8 and Jude 7 talk about humans in eternal fire. Jesus said in Matthew 25:46 that the righteous will land up in heaven with eternal life but the wicked will be given eternal punishment. **If we foolishly argue that people will stop existing in hell because the fire that consumes imagery is used in the Bible, then, we should also be willing to say, using the same line of argument, that,**

life in heaven also is not eternal! But Jesus attaches the very same word before 'punishment' (in hell) and 'life' (in heaven) in Matthew 25:46: eternal. If 'eternal' before 'life' means that life in heaven is literally eternal, then the 'eternal' before 'punishment' surely also means that life in hell will involve non-stop, ever-lasting torment!

We are using the acronym F-I-R-E to understand that hell punishment involves forever torment. F stands for the Fire imagery. **The next letter, 'I', STANDS FOR 'ING'.** Words ending with "ing" indicating a present reality found in the Bible that helps us understand that hell punishment is forever.

Matthew 13:42 says, "and throw them into the fiery furnace. In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth". What Jesus implies here is this: "Hell is a fiery furnace, a place where there will be two ongoing actions – weeping and gnashing of teeth!" **Notice the 'ing' placed next to the words 'weep' and 'gnash'!** This means both weeping and gnashing are ongoing actions.

DO CHRIST-REJECTING HUMANS STOP EXISTING AFTER THEIR DEATH? YOU WILL SAY 'NO' IF YOU HAVE READ THE RICH MAN IN THE FLAMES STORY WHICH JESUS HIMSELF NARRATED!

The Rich Man of Luke 16 was being tormented inside Hades, a place much like the lake of fire mentioned in Revelation. it makes it abundantly clear that he was in everlasting state of torment (Luke 16:24, NCV – So he

cried out and said, "Father Abraham, have mercy on me! Send Lazarus to dip his finger in water and cool my tongue, because I am **suffering** in this fire"). Notice the 'ing' after the word 'suffer' in this verse! The Rich Man did not land in the fire of punishment and stop existing! He continued to exist long after the fire started to eat him alive! He is able to talk to Abraham even as the fire kept tormenting him! The talking and the tormenting goes on side by side! Jesus did not end the story by saying, "The Rich Man stopped existing". The Rich Man is told that he could not cross over from his state of eternal punishment to Lazarus' place of eternal rest (Luke 16:26 – 'And besides all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed, so that they who would pass from here to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that would come from there')! Millard J. Erickson writes, 'This story (Lazarus and Rich Man story of Luke 16 which Jesus himself narrated) actually refutes the idea that unbelieving humans cease to exist at death.'

DID ADAM AND EVE STOP EXISTING AFTER (SPIRITUAL) 'DEATH' CAME TO THEM? NO. NEITHER WILL THOSE WHO EXPERIENCE 'SECOND DEATH' STOP EXISTING AFTER THEIR LAKE OF FIRE ENTRY!

There is yet another line of argument pro-annihilation false-teachers/scholars use which I get reminded of by the letter "I" which is part of the acronym F-I-R-E. And that word is '**IMMORTALITY'.** Let me explain: Pro-

annihilation false-teacher/scholars say this: 'Mankind is mortal; this ability to be immortal was taken away when the fall happened; however, belief in the Gospel brought back immortality into the equation.' They quote 2 Timothy 1:10 as the proof-text for this. This verse says that Jesus 'broke the power of death and showed us the way to everlasting life though the Good News" (2 Tim. 1:10 NLT). But this argument would be valid if unbelievers ceased to exist after death. But that is not the case. The rich man who died went to Hades to suffer with his consciousness intact there (see Luke 16). Ajith Fernando argues this way: if Adam and Eve did not stop existing after 'death' (spiritual death) came to them (Genesis 3), then unbelievers and stubborn sinners who experience 'second death' (Rev. 21:7-8 called life in lake of fire as 'second death') will also NOT stop existing after their lake of fire entry.

Did the unbelievers who landed in the lake of fire stop existing after Revelation 21:7-8, where it is mentioned that they went there? No. Keep reading. Revelation 22:15 speaks of their continued existence using the word 'are'. It says, 'Outside are the dogs and sorcerers and the sexually immoral and murderers and idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices falsehood.'

THE SMOKE OF THEIR TORMENT WHICH ROSE FOREVER AND EVER SPOKE OF THE LENGTH OF THEIR TORMENT AND THAT LENGTH IS SURELY ETERNAL

We are using the acronym F-I-R-E to understand that hell punishment involves forever torment. 'F' stands for Fire imagery. **'I', stands for two things: (1) THE 'ING' BIBLE WORDS TO DESCRIBE ETERNAL PUNISHMENT and (2) the fallacy of the 'IMMORTALITY-A-GIFT-GIVEN-ONLY-FOR-BELIEVERS' ARGUMENT. The next letter in this F-I-R-E acronym that we are using to 'fire' the annihilation false teaching on hell is the letter 'R'. 'R', ACCORDING TO ME, STANDS FOR REST MISSING FOR THE LAKE OF FIRE-DWELLERS/HELL-DWELLERS. Let us first read the passage which** clearly presents this teaching:

"And a third angel followed them, calling out in a loud voice, "If anyone worships the beast and its image, and receives its mark on his forehead or on his hand, he too will drink the wine of God's anger, poured undiluted into the cup of His wrath. And he will be tormented in fire and sulphur in the presence of the holy angels and of the Lamb. And the smoke of their torment rises forever and ever. Day and night there is no rest for those who worship the beast and its image, or for anyone who receives the mark of its name" (Rev. 14:9-11). **Millard J. Erickson's** comment on this passage is useful: 'According to Revelation 14:11 the smoke from this fire of torment of the beast and the false prophet will be forever. They (Pro-annihilation false teacher-scholars) contend that the smoke, not the punishment, is everlasting. However, how there can be smoke without

something being burned? If these bodies are burned up, consumed and destroyed, how can smoke still be there? What would produce smoke, unless something was burning? For that matter, why would the lake of fire continue to exist, with nothing left to burn?' Brilliant! Yes, the smoke of their torment which rose forever and ever spoke of the length of their torment and that length is surely eternal! You will have to be a wishful-thinking fool to believe in the annihilation false teaching!

This passage clearly says that there is 'no rest for those who worship the beast and its image' (Rev. 14:11). Eternal conscious punishment is what is meted out for those destined to hell.

EVEN A SINGLE SIN AGAINST THE INFINITE GOD MERITS....

The final letter in the acronym F-I-R-E, we shall use to nullify annihilation false teaching is 'E'. **'E' reminds me of "EVERYTHING SCRIPTURE SAYS WE EMBRACE, HOWEVER EMOTIONALLY DISTURBING".** Paul writes in 2 Thessalonians 1:7-8 this: 'dealing out retribution to those who do not know God and to those who do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus. And these will pay the penalty of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power...' (NASB 1977). The full truth of this passage is this: the same God who graciously allows believers to live in his literal 'presence' is the one who puts out unbelievers from his presence so that they would forever be destroyed! Just as those in his presence go on living forever, those

banished from his presence will also go on living forever! The phrase 'eternal destruction' means that ongoing destruction of the ever-alive individual. The closest thing that comes to my mind when I ponder upon the 'eternal destruction' imagery is the imagery from Isaiah 66:24 which Jesus quoted in Mark 9:45-48. Jesus says, for those in hell, the worm is the agent of destruction. The worms will keep feasting on the ever-alive human bodies inside hell! This way, the process of destruction is endless! We must embrace everything the Scripture says about the eternal destiny of humankind, not just the parts we like! Afterall 'all Scripture' is God-breathed (2 Tim. 3:16)! Tony Gray writes, 'Perhaps sin against God requires infinite punishment, because God is an infinite being'.

THE SCARY CHRONICLES OF GOD'S JUDGMENT ON THIS SIDE OF ETERNITY ANTICIPATES....

This senior British evangelical scholar who argued for annihilation in hell quoted from Revelation 20:12, where it says God will judge people 'according to what they have done'. He argues that the punishment for sin must be comparable with the length of the life of sin. This is a false argument. One should study God's judgement record in Scripture to unearth his response to what we would call 'little sins'. If the example of Lot's wife is taken: sudden death for a brief look over the shoulder (Gen. 19:26)! Or if the case of Nadab and Abihu is studied: they 'fell dead before the LORD' (Num. 3:4) even as they went about their own way of sacrificing to the LORD. We are not done yet! This scary chronicles of God's judgments on this side of eternity certainly

anticipates everlasting anguish in hell-fire for those who reject Jesus. An unnamed man was pelted to death as per God's Command (Num. 15:32-36). His sin? He gathered sticks on a Sabbath Day! As Luke correctly points out in the account of Ananias and Sapphira's sudden death, our sins are not against finite men but against an infinite God (Acts 5:4). The argument for eternal conscious punishment for the unsaved is super simple: even a single sin against an infinite God, deserves eternal infinite judgement!

CHRIST'S LOVE 'SURPASSES KNOWLEDGE' — DOES THAT MEAN IT DOES NOT EXIST? SIMILARLY....

A controversial Canadian theologian, who was once a strong evangelical, wrote that the endless torment doctrine "does not make sense...A God of love will not torture people forever for sins done in a finite life". Clearly, this liberal-leaning theologian sadly leaned onto his logical faculties rather than on God's Word. John Blanchard, writing in the book, *Whatever Happened To Hell?* makes a penetrating point in response to this: This Canadian theologian seems to say: if the Scriptures 'makes sense,' we must accept it; if not we must look for an explanation. It is puzzling to know how any honest theologian, let alone an evangelical, could come to that kind of conclusion. Christ's love 'makes no sense' — the Bible says it 'surpasses knowledge' (Eph. 3:19); does it mean

that, it must not be taken seriously? The Bible says that the 'peace of God, transcends understanding' (Phil. 4:7); does this mean that, there is no such thing?

When the Bible seems to defy logic, faith takes precedence over rationale. Prophet Isaiah wrote that God's thoughts are higher than our thoughts and his ways are higher than our ways (Isa. 55:8).

SINNERS AND CHRIST-REJECTORS CHOOSE HELL USING THEIR OWN FREE WILL – GOD CANNOT BE BLAMED FOR THE SAME

One must remember, in the context where God's justice and love is under fire, it is sinners who themselves make a choice to go to hell. They know for sure the destination of Christ-rejectors will be hell (2 Thess. 1:7-8). So, when they deliberately choose to live a life of sin, in constant rebellion against Christ, they voluntarily choose to go to hell. When they refuse the remedy to escape hell, hell becomes their own choice! C. S. Lewis put this truth in inimitable style:

"There are two kinds of people in the end: those who say to God, 'Thy will be done,' and those to whom God says in the end, 'Thy will be done'. All that are in Hell, chose it!"

So the 'E' of the F-I-R-E acronym that tells us of ways to 'fire' the false teaching that says people stop existing once they land in hell means EVERYTHING THE SCRIPTURES SAYS, WE MUST EMBRACE

HOWEVER EMOTIONALLY DISTURBING IT IS. This E can also mean another thing: EXEGESIS. Using Exegesis (false exegesis, I will have to say), the hell-populating false teachers, argue that those who land in hell will stop existing. They do so using the 'vocabulary of destruction'. What's that? Several Bible passages seem to suggest total destruction and therefore cessation of existence when it describes the final fate of the ungodly (see 1 Thess. 5:3; 2 Thess. 1:9; 2 Peter 3:9). The assumption of this meaning is a result of a very unfortunate process of exegesis. Let us assume that whenever the Bible uses the word 'destruction', the meaning implied is 'annihilation'. The same word is used to describe the 'ruined' wineskin in Matthew 9:17. The same word is used to describe the lost son or coin or sheep in Luke 15. For all the three entities – be it the coin, son or wineskin – it is obvious that when this word or its root is used in conjunction with those entities, it doesn't mean cessation of existence!

WHERE 'DESTRUCTION' IMPLIES CONTINUED EXISTENCE – VERY CLEARLY

The Bible says that the beast will go into its 'destruction' (Rev. 17:8-9). According to **hell-populating annihilation-teachers,** 'destruction' is to be taken as 'annihilation.' American Systematic Theologian, **Robert A. Peterson's** counterpoint to this false argument is razor-sharp: 'Two chapters after the prophecy of the beast's 'destruction' (17:8,11) the Beast and the False prophet are thrown alive in the lake of fire and brimstone (19:20). They will be there one thousand years later (20:7,10)...John wrote... 'the beast and the false prophet,

and Satan 'will be tormented day and night forever and ever. The beast's destruction, therefore, is not annihilation – it is eternal punishment!'

THESE FALSE TEACHERS ARE DREAMING OF A POST-REVELATION 22 SCENARIO AND THERE WILL BE PUNISHMENT FOR SUCH THINKING!

Revelation 21:3-4 says, 'there will no more death or mourning or crying or pain.' Does this imply annihilation of the righteous in the new heaven and new earth? Far from it! Four verses later, the same John describes the wicked in Hell (Rev. 21:8). The 'people stop existing in hell' false teachers must be dreaming of a scenario beyond Revelation 22, because even in Revelation 22:14, the wicked exist! Revelation 22:18 warns anyone who adds to the words of the prophecy of Revelation! They would get the plagues listed in the book of Revelation! In a way, those who teach annihilation of the wicked are going beyond Revelation 22 (because there is no support for this false teaching from Genesis 1 to Revelation 22). And they must be warned that God's judgment will come upon them for broadcasting a hell-populating false teaching that people stop existing once they land in hell!

CHAPTER 38

IS THE HELL TO HEAVEN TEACHING WHICH A CHENNAI PASTOR PREACHES, BIBLICAL?



During a seminar in Hyderabad, a Chennai based Hyper-Grace pastor used a combination of Revelation 21:25 (a verse that says heaven's doors will not be shut) and Revelation 22:17 (a verse that says, 'The Spirit and the bride say, "Come!"') to elucidate a point that there is a real possibility for those who have gone to hell ('the lake of fire') to make it to heaven. Here are the two verses in question printed in full: Revelation 21:25 – "In the daytime (for there will be no night there) its gates will never be closed"(NASB); Revelation 22:17 – 'The Spirit and the bride say, "Come." And let the one who hears say, "Come." And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who wishes take the water of life without cost'(NASB).

The question here before us is this: Can those in the lake of fire, when they positively respond to the "come" of the Spirit and the Bride (which can be taken to mean the church)(Rev. 22:17), move from hell to heaven? Is

this 'hell to heaven' teaching (that is the phrase I will use in the rest of this chapter for this teaching), straight from heaven? Is it from God? Is it Biblical?

I want to use the acronym H-E-L-L to give an answer that is not only scriptural but also, hopefully, is memorable:

H-IS TEACHING (JESUS' TEACHING) ON "HELL TO HEAVEN" TEACHING:

PREVIOUSLY, LAZARUS ATE ANYTHING THAT FELL FROM THE RICH MAN'S TABLE. BUT NOW, THE RICH MAN IS READY TO DRINK ANYTHING THAT WILL FALL FROM LAZARUS' TABLE IN HEAVEN!

I am referring to Jesus' teaching here. From Jesus' teaching, we know without a shadow of doubt that those in hell, cannot come to heaven. Once a person goes to hell, he cannot come to heaven. Jesus' understanding about this is reflected in His narration of the conversation between the Rich Man who went to Hades and a beggar named Lazarus who went to Abraham's side. 'Hades' (Luke 16;23) is just one of the many phrases Jesus used to refer to Hell and 'Abraham's side' (Luke 16:22) is one of the phrases that Jesus used for Heaven [I say this based on Revelation 20:14 which says, 'Then death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire'(another name for Hell); In John 14:2, Jesus calls heaven 'my Father's house']. The Rich Man was in torment – thanks to the flames in Hades that behaved like any flame we know would, causing intolerable heat (Luke 16:23). **He did**

not request for a fire-engine to be sent from heaven to extinguish the flames in hell. All that the rich man wanted was a few drops of water from the fingers of Lazarus who once ate what fell from the rich man's fingers when he was on earth (Compare Luke 16:21 and 24). What a reversal – previously, when they were on earth, Lazarus ate whatever fell from the Rich Man's table. Now, on the other side of eternity, with Lazarus in heaven and the Rich Man in hell, the Rich Man is willing to lap up anything that fell from Lazarus' table in heaven – including a drop of water!!!! But this 'water-drop' request was cropped by Father Abraham – cut off, refused.

'YOU ARE IN AGONY', NOT 'YOU WERE IN AGONY'!

Abraham makes a key observation in this Jesus-narrated incident. Abraham told the rich man in Hades, "You ARE in agony!" (Luke 16:25). He did not say, "You WERE in agony!" The message of this passage is clear: the punishment for those who reject Christ is an on-going process in their after-life period – it will never end!

CAN'T CROSS-OVER FROM HADES TO ABRAHAM'S SIDE

And to quench and quell the hopes, the hell-dwelling Rich Man had about crossing over from hell into heaven, Abraham told him: "And besides all this, between us and you there is a great chasm fixed, so that those who wish to come over from HERE TO YOU WILL NOT BE ABLE, AND THAT NONE MAY CROSS OVER

FROM THERE TO US."' (Luke 16:26). This Jesus-narrated event teaches us that once a person goes to eternity without repenting and trusting in Jesus, he can never enter heaven after his death. The same person cannot escape from hell and get into heaven. Jesus, at this point, could have easily chosen to mention about any such opportunity. He could have said, "The Holy Spirit in heaven, along with other believers ('Spirit and the Bride') keeps on saying, 'Come!' Do you hear their voice, rich man? Repent from your sin of loving money more than me! Confess your sin. Put your faith in me. Then you too can come to heaven, even though, at this point, you are in hell!" No, Jesus did NOT say that! Why? Jesus knew that NO CHANCES or OPPORTUNITIES would be given to anyone who dies and goes into a Christ-less eternity to come back to heaven/God's very presence, afterwards!

NOT THE ONLY TIME THAT JESUS TAUGHT IN-EFFECT, 'HELL PUNISHMENT IS FOREVER'

This is not the only time when Jesus taught that hell punishment is forever and that there is no escape from it. In Matthew 25:41, He used the phrase "eternal fire" when He talked about hell punishment for the Devil and his angels. Jesus also taught that there is no escape from this hell punishment, which is recorded in Mark's Gospel, also. In this Gospel, He taught us to be ruthless in our dealing with temptations to sin, if we want to avoid ending up in hell, "where fire never goes out" (Mark 9:43 NIV) and where "worms that eat them (the body parts of hell-dwellers) do not die" (Mark 9:47-48 NIV). "In hell, worms that eat the body never die, and the fire is never put out" (Mark 9:48, GW). In other words, Jesus was teaching that there is NO WAY anyone could worm

their way out of hell, ever!!! **Robert Peterson** after noting that Jesus used the word 'Gehenna' three times in Mark 9:43-48 summarized this passage like this: "hell is a place where fire goes on and on. So, it is worthwhile depriving yourself of a hand, a foot or an eye if by doing so you can go to heaven, because those are temporary deprivations, whereas the torment of hell is eternal."

BUT JESUS DID NOT SAY THAT!

Jesus repeatedly used one phrase to describe life in hell. This phrase: "a place of weeping and gnashing of teeth." He uses that phrase a stunning four times in Matthew's Gospel itself. Check that out in Matt. 8:12; 22:13; 24:51; 25:30. If Jesus believed in the 'hell to heaven' teaching put forth by this Chennai Hyper-Grace cult pastor, he would have slightly modified this phrase. He would have said, "Hell is a place of weeping and gnashing of teeth till you say, 'I'm coming' in response to the 'come' invitation of The Spirit and the Bride!" But He did not say that. The "ing" in the phrase that Jesus used for those who will dwell in hell – "weeping and gnashing of teeth" – implies ongoing, eternal torment. In other words, those in hell will forever regret for having rejected Jesus, when they had so many opportunities to do so, on earth. And they will express their sadness through weeping and anger through gnashing of teeth! This would be non-stop!

Let's move to the next Biblical argument to grasp why this bizarre "hell-to-heaven" teaching by this Chennai Hyper-Grace cult pastor is false. We are using the acronym, **H-E-L-L**, for this process, by the way. 'H' stands for His (Jesus') teaching on Hell. Now for the "E".

E-PISTLES TEACHING ON "HELL TO HEAVEN" TEACHING:

Not just Jesus, but the epistle-writers of the New Testament too ensure that the word "eternal" prefixes the description of the fearful fate of those who reject Jesus after their death. Apostle Paul writes that "those who do not know God and do not obey the Gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ" (2 Thess. 1:8) will pay "the penalty of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power" (2 Thess 1:9, NASB). The above-mentioned Hyper-Grace cult pastor in Chennai struts, "Paul did not ever use the word, 'Gehenna' in all his 14 epistles. If Paul can present the Gospel without using the word 'Gehenna', why can't we also do that?"

Well. Well. Well. For those of you, who do not know, 'Gehenna' is the Hebrew word Jesus used for hell. Chaim Milikowsky writes, '**In the New Testament, the word 'Gehenna' appears eleven times, seven times in Matthew, twice in Mark, and once each in Luke and James...it is a place of punishment in the last judgment'.** Gehenna was actually a real place during Jesus' time – a place outside the city of Jerusalem where the city's waste was dumped and set to fire, burning continuously in order to consume the waste.

Peter Kreeft writes, "Gehenna, the word Jesus used for hell, was the valley outside Jerusalem that the Jews used for perpetual burning of garbage because it had been desecrated by heathen tribes who used it for human sacrifice."

WHY JESUS USED 'GEHENNA' IMAGERY AND PAUL USED SOMETHING ELSE WHEN THEY SPOKE ABOUT HELL

While Paul and the other apostles obeyed Jesus' command, "teach them (those who become Jesus' disciples through their ministry) to observe everything I taught you!" (Matt. 28:19), they were under no compulsion to do so using Jesus' language or vocabulary. **Jesus used the 'Gehenna' imagery to talk about hell, because he ministered mainly to the Jews**. And Jews could immediately connect with the Gehenna imagery the way Chennai folks would have readily connected with the Kodungaiyur Dumpyard or Perungudi Dumpyard. A movie-reviewer called, Ilyaghilli, recalls a scene in the 2010 Tamil movie, Endhiran (released in several other languages), starring Rajinikanth, which featured a dumpyard in Chennai this way: "Scenes like dumping the dismantled robot in a corporation dustbin and showing that it is taken to a dumpyard of normal garbage look totally bizarre in today's era of e-waste disposal campaigns and considering the fact that a robotic scientist cannot dispose his years of work just like that. Add to it the fact that the robot can reconstruct itself even at such a crippled stage!"

Coming back from the Endhiran movie dumpyard to the dumpyard our Master talked about – Gehenna… James, the half-brother of Jesus who ministered to Jews primarily ('the twelve tribes scattered among the nations" – Jas. 1:1) used the very same word ('Gehenna') when talking about hell in his epistle (see Jas. 3:6).

But Paul's ministry was among Gentiles primarily (Acts 9:15).

Gentiles, that is, non-Jews, may not have grasped the usage of the word 'gehenna' to depict hell, the same way, even someone from Hyderabad may not grasp well the usage of the imagery of Kodungaiyur/Perungudi dumpyard to depict hell.

So, Paul was under no compulsion to use the word, "Gehenna" like Jesus did or James did!

But did he teach about eternal conscious punishment like Jesus did? Absolutely, as we just saw in 2 Thessalonians 1:9!

Peter's name for hell was 'Tartarus' (2 Peter 2:4).

While the names which different Spirit-inspired Bible authors gave for hell was different (one Bible Scholar notes that there are twenty-six total references to hell in the Bible), the reality of it and the gruesome gravity of the on-going suffering of those who go there, can never be in doubt!

Not just Apostle Paul but the other epistle writers also spoke about 'eternalness' of hell-punishment thereby totally negating the wrong teaching on 'hell to heaven', this Chennai Hyper-Grace pastor was teaching then.

EVEN THE WRITER TO THE HEBREWS TEACHES THAT HELL PUNISHMENT IS FOREVER

The epistle-writer to the Hebrews (it could have been Apollos or Barnabas or Priscilla or someone we do not know) stitches together the word "eternal" with "judgement" in Hebrews 6:2. The exact phrase used here is "eternal judgment". So, once a person is judged by God, this person goes to a place of punishment (we know that place is hell/lake of fire) and STAYS in that place "eternally"! If this was not so, judgment cannot be called, "eternal judgment"! It would be called "short-lived judgment" just as sinful pleasures in the same book are called "short-lived pleasures of sin" (see Heb. 11:25, HCSB)! It would be called "fleeting judgment" just as sinful pleasures in the same book are called "fleeting pleasures of sin" (see Heb. 11:25, ESV)! It would be called "temporary judgment" just as sinful pleasures in the same book are called "temporary pleasures of sin" (see Heb. 11:25, NASB)! It would be called "passing judgment" just as sinful pleasures in the same book are called "passing pleasures of sin" (see Heb. 11:25, NKJV)!

There can never be escape from "hades" (Luke 16:23)! There can never be an escape from the "lake of fire" (dwellers of hades are emptied into the Lake of Fire where the torment never ends – see Rev. 20:10,14)!

EVEN JUDE TEACHES THAT HELL PUNISHMENT IS FOREVER!

Not just the Hebrews-writer, the epistle-writer Jude also teaches that this 'hell-to-heaven' teaching is wrong. He talks about "eternal" punishment for the stubborn-till-death, homosexuals of Sodom and Gomorrah in his letter (verse 7).

So the hell-dwellers from Sodom won't hear a 'come' from heaven! Sodom is doomed forever! So the hell-dwellers from Gomorrah won't hear a 'come' from heaven which will make them go, "hip, hip, hurray" in anticipation of switching their dwelling-place from hell to heaven!

Moving onto the next Biblical argument against the crazy 'Hell to Heaven' hell-taking wrong teaching put forth by this particular Chennai Hyper-Grace cult pastor. We are using the acronym H-E-L-L to outline these points. H-is-teaching. E-pistles teaching. The next letter in this acronym is "L".

L-ONG LOOK AT THE BOOK OF REVELATION ON THE "HELL TO HEAVEN" FALSE TEACHING:

A long look at the Book of Revelation will reveal that this 'Hell to Heaven' teaching is wrong. If it can be

convincingly shown in the view of John, the Apostle, who wrote the Book of Revelation, that there was a route to escape from hell, then this 'hell to Heaven' teaching can be accepted. But if one were to read the book of Revelation in full-LENGTH (all the 22 chapters, and not just chapter 21 and chapter 22), he or she will **understand that there would be no escape route out of hell or a supposed invitation from heaven-dwellers to hell-dwellers to migrate their location from hell to heaven.**

THEY ARE STILL IN HELL AS ONE UNDERSTANDS FROM THE BOOK OF REVELATION

Read Revelation 14:10-11. This is the punishment for those who worship the Anti-Christ and follow him: "the smoke of their torment will rise forever and ever, and they will have no relief day or night, for they have worshipped the beast (the Anti-Christ that is) and his statue and have accepted the mark of his name!" (NLT). The smoke from hell will forever keep rising as this Scripture in Revelation teaches, because despite the fire constantly burning, the bodies of the hell-dwellers, their bodies don't get burnt as they keep writhing away in unspeakable discomfort! **John Walvoord** writes, "The ultimate convincing argument for eternal punishment is found is Revelation 20:11-15.... In this passage...the beast and the false prophet, cast into the lake of fire at the beginning of the millennium (Rev. 19:20), are still there a thousand years later and are declared to join Satan in the torment which will continue "day and night forever and ever" (Rev. 20:10). After describing that all pain would forever end when people reach heaven's shores in Revelation 21:3-4, Apostle John, writes that

the 'cowardly, the faithless, the murderers, the sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, liars,' will end in the 'lake that burns with fire and sulphur' (Rev. 21:8 ESV). Based on Revelation 20:10, where John writes that in the lake of fire there will be 'torment for day and night forever', we can confidently say that even in the lake of fire mentioned in Revelation 21:8 after folks have entered heaven, there will be continuous torment in hell for its inhabitants, after all, there is only ONE lake of fire! There will not be a way of escape from hell as this Chennai Hyper-Grace cult leader/pastor suggests at that point – after people have reached hell!

ONLY ON SINFUL EARTH YOU NEED TO LOCK YOUR DOOR!

So when there is a clear teaching by the Spirit-inspired writer of the book of Revelation that hell punishment is forever (as seen above), there is no way that he would have meant that there will be an ongoing opportunity for people to keep entering heaven all thro' eternity when he wrote, "on no day will its gates be shut, for there will be no night there" (Rev. 21:25 NIV). The key phrase in that verse is the word "for" – "for there will be no night there". The meaning can be this: 'only on earth, you lock your doors at night; this is heaven – there is no night here, so there is no need to lock doors here; evil has been once-for-all eliminated!' Also read two verses below –Revelation 21:27. It goes this way: "Nothing impure will ever enter it, nor will anyone who does what is shameful and deceitful, but only those who names are written in the Lamb's book of life." This verse is talking about the qualification to get to heaven. It is this: repentance from sin while on earth ('nothing impure will ever

enter it, nor will anyone who does what is shameful and deceitful') and placing one's faith in Jesus who died on the Cross when still on earth ('only those whose names are written in the Lamb's book of life). I included the words, 'when still on earth' for this reason – the Scripture says there, 'only those whose names ARE WRITTEN in the Lamb's book of life,' and not, 'those whose names WILL BE WRITTEN in the Lamb's book of Life!

THE 'COME' INVITATION DOES NOT COME AFTER THE RETURN OF JESUS!

Does John, the Revelation writer mean that those in heaven – the Holy Spirit and church believers ('the Spirit and the Bride') – will invite those in hell with the words, "Come!" POST the Second Coming of Jesus (Rev. 22:17)? **This is what a Chennai cult pastor, whose number one mission in life appears to be, to make Hell look harmless and decent through creative Scripture-twisting, says will happen.** No. No way! Read this verse above. Read Revelation 22:7. That verse records Jesus' statement, "Look, I am coming soon!" (also repeated in Rev. 22:12) Notice the tense here: I AM COMING SOON! The portions below Revelation 22:7 is talking about the time BEFORE the Second Coming of Jesus! Rewind back to Revelation 22:6, this already evident truth will be even more evident. That verse says, "And he said to me: "These words are trustworthy and true. And the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his servants what must soon take place." Revelation 22:16, which is just one verse before Revelation 22:17 – the verse under our exegetical microscope – is also strikingly similar. So, all the verses from Revelation 22:6 and below are taking us back to the situation

that is described in Revelation chapter 1 where John is in an island seeing visions, hearing from Angels, hearing Jesus speak about "what you have seen, what is now, and what will soon take place later" (Rev. 1:19). In other words, John is addressing the material from Revelation 22:8 and below to present-day believers – believers who are still on earth awaiting the return of Jesus Christ! So when we read, "The Spirit and the Bride say, 'Come!'" in Revelation 22:17, that is applicable to us, present-day believers living before the Second Coming. We (the Bride of Christ) are called to join the Holy Spirit in the ministry, calling people to Christ (see 2 Cor. 11:2)! Our message today, empowered by the Spirit is this: Come to the one who said, 'Come to me all you who are weary and heavy-leaden!' That is how we live out Revelation 22:17. Revelation 22:17 cannot be lived out AFTER the Second Coming, after people have gone into heaven/hell as this Chennai Hyper-Grace pastor wrongly suggests.

"FOR GOOD!"

Revelation 22:14-15 goes this way: "Blessed are those who wash their robes that they may have the right to the tree of life and may go through the gates into the city. Outside are the dogs, those who practice magic arts, the sexually immoral, the murderers, the idolaters and everyone who loves and practices falsehood"(NIV). Do these set of verses imply that the "Come" of verse 17, is for those in hell? No way! I like the way Eugene Peterson translates these verses to underline the finality of the fate of those who go to the City (heaven) and those outside it (hell). He writes, "How blessed are those who wash their robes! The Tree of Life is theirs FOR

GOOD. But outside FOR GOOD are the filthy curs; sorcerers, fornicators, murderers, idolaters – all who love and live lies" (Rev. 22:14-15). Because, those outside the city are there "for good", there is no logic in believing that the "come" of Revelation 22:17 was even directed to them as this Hyper-Grace, twisted Trinitarian Gospel preaching, taking-people-to-hell Chennai pastor suggests.

REVELATION 22:17 IS SAYING IN A DIFFERENT WAY WHAT ACTS 1:8 IS SAYING!

Revelation 22:16 goes this way: "I, Jesus, have sent my angel to give you this testimony for the churches. I am the Root and the Offspring of David, and the bright Morning Star!" This verse needs a closer look to determine the timing and direction of the "come" invitation by the Spirit and Bride in Revelation 22:17 (just one verse below). Revelation 22:16 basically says this: the supernatural revelations given to John, in the book of Revelation about the present and the future are actually a "testimony for the churches". John needs to share this with the churches or church believers. The church with the help of the Spirit's power needs to get busy broadcasting the 'come' message of the Gospel before the return of Jesus – this is the correct interpretation! **Acts 1:8 which calls us for world-wide witnessing through the Power of the Spirit and Revelation 22:17 which says that the bride of Jesus, the church, can witness (powerfully) along with the (enabling) Spirit of God, are talking about the same thing!** The next verse is also talking about the church, albeit figuratively. The word used in the next verse for the church is "Bride" (see Rev. 22:17). [Apostle Paul compared the church to a

bride in 2 Corinthians 11:2 – "For I am jealous as to you with the jealousy of God. For I have betrothed you to one husband, to present a pure virgin to Christ'(NASB)"]. Revelation 22:17 is saying what Acts 1:8 is saying, in a different way – that is all.

Here is the full verse: 'The Spirit and the bride say, "Come." And the one who hears say, "Come." And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who wishes take the water of life without cost' (Rev. 22:17 NASB). So, this is what this verse teaches: The church which is the bride of Christ, empowered by the Spirit should cry out to the lost people here and now, "Come!" That's what every reader of this book ('the one who hears' as John put it in Rev. 22:17) should also do. In fact the phrase, "he who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the church" is mentioned several times in the Book of Revelation as a phrase to label any believer from any church who will chose to listen to the message of Revelation down through history up until his death or the Return of Jesus (see Rev. 2:7; 2:11; 2:17; 2:29; 3:6; 3:13; 3:22). If that person has not yet come to Jesus, here and now, before the Second Coming or before that person's death, he or she should come to the Living Water Jesus (see John 4:14 where Jesus says that he is the Living Water) in repentance and faith.

Now, we come to final letter in the acronym chosen – H-E-L-L – to drive home the point that Revelation 22:17 is talking about the "call" to be given here to the unsaved, on this earth, and not in the next life, undergirded by the Holy Spirit. That letter is another 'L'.

L-OCKING OF ONE'S CHOICE BY GOD & "HELL TO HEAVEN" TEACHING:

Throughout the Bible, we see examples of how God would give ample choices to a person (Only God determines how many chances are enough for a person). But if that person, continues to defy God and/or reject Jesus, God would sort of "lock" that choice (to borrow a term from **Amitabh Bachchan** when he runs the popular TV quiz program, **"Kaun Banega Crorepati"**). After this 'locking' is done, there is no chance for the concerned person to be saved even on this side of eternity. There are several examples found in the Bible that underscore this understanding. Let me talk about them, one by one, starting with Pharaoh.

AFTER GIVING THEM REPEATED CHANCES, GOD FROZE THEIR FREE WILL!

Pharaoh repeatedly hardened his heart. That's when God chose to actually harden Pharaoh's heart. In other words, God 'locked' or 'froze' or 'made Pharoah's free will permanent' so that he would not be able to turn from sin and come to the Living God! Tina Miller points out that 'the first time we read that God caused Pharoah's heart to be hard was when the sixth plague hit – the boils in Exodus 9:12.' Because, God knows the end from the beginning (Isa. 46:10), he was able to know that Pharaoh will use his free-will to harden his heart (see Ex. 4:21; 7:3). But when Pharaoh repeatedly used his free will to harden his heart, God ultimately said 'amen' to his free-will enabled firm choice. God gave enough chances for Pharoah. He did not freeze his free will till

after the fifth miracle. But when Pharoah continued his stubbornness (made his heart, hard, in other words – please check out, Exodus 8:32), even after witnessing God's power live as the sixth plague got underway, God decided 'enough was enough'. But after God hardened his heart, Pharaoh could not repent. **When this is the case, what makes us think that even after a person dies and lands up in hell, that a person will still have an opportunity to hear of "come" by the Spirit and Bride, as suggested by this Chennai Pastor and cult leaders? This is not a one-off story in the Bible.**

Read the story of **King Manasseh** (2 Kings 24:4, 'the Lord would not pardon,' the stubborn Manasseh). The story of **Judas** in the New Testament [Jesus froze his free will / locked his stubborn choice to reject Jesus after giving him many changes to repent – chances he blew up – when he told him, "What you are about to do, do quickly!" (John 13:27)]. The story of the **Pharisees and Sadducees** whose stiff-necked ways, made Jesus lock their choice to reject Jesus, when he promised hell for them (Matt. 23:33). The story of the **Devil and his angels**, whose free will were also frozen by God after he gave them enough chances (Matt 25:41). The story of the Hyper-Grace teachers of Bible times who got themselves 'designated for condemnation' by God because they constantly turned God's grace 'as an excuse for sexual freedom' (Jude 4, ESV/GW). A reading of **Romans 1**, where we read, "God gave them up" thrice (Rom. 1:24,26,28) also brings forth the conclusion that God does choose to lock the freewill of those who stubbornly give up on him. The phrase in Genesis 6:3 – 'the LORD said,

"My Spirit shall not strive with man forever…' (NASB) – also teaches the very same thing if one were to check the similar context there.

These stories remind us of the many times God froze free will of stubborn folks before death, before the Second Coming of Christ, after giving them enough chances. When this is the case, why will God give those in hell another chance to repent (which is what this Chennai Pastor's strange interpretation of Revelation 22:17 entails). **Jonathan Edwards** explained why infinitely-long torment in hell is a reasonable punishment for those who will go to hell: they have sinned against an infinite God!

HYPER-LOVE CULT TEACHERS TRY TO GAG GOD!

So, if we considered the Biblical and theological arguments weaved around the H-E-L-L acronym, we will understand this 'hell to Heaven' teaching purported by this Chennai Cult Pastor is a lie, straight from hell! Yes, the hell to heaven doctrine, he teaches, is not from heaven! And as **D. A. Carson** puts it well, he (and others like him), "gag God by silencing the severity of his warnings and minimize the awfulness of the punishment that justly awaits those untouched by his redeeming grace." If they do not repent, this lot will go to hell, and take people there! This chapter and this book is an earnest attempt to somehow stem this rot!

ANOTHER WAY THIS CHENNAI CULT PASTOR TRIED TO MAKE HELL LOOK HARMLESS!

The Chennai pastor keeps looking for creative ways to make Hell look harmless by twisting Scriptures. The 'hell to heaven' false teaching which we dismantled in this chapter is just one example of this. He also tries to pick up random Old Testament references on Judgment Day to teach in-effect that hell and God's judgment is actually harmless for all stake-holders including unbelievers/stubborn-in-sin backslidden believers. Hyper-Love cult pastors like him quote from Psalm 96 to teach that when God comes to judge the earth (Psa. 96:13), it is a time to be 'glad' (Psa. 96:11), it is a time to 'rejoice' (Psa. 96:11), it is a time to 'exult' (Psa. 96:12), and it is a time to 'sing for joy' (Psa. 96:12). So, the judgment of God is not something one should be afraid of, these hyper-love false teachers, teach! **However, this is another case of wrong interpretation of Scripture to pitchfork false teaching.** If you read the rest of this Psalm, you will understand that this particular Psalm is talking about gentiles in the world who heed to the call to 'ascribe to the LORD, the glory due to his name' (Psa. 96:8). These gentiles heed to the call given to 'worship the LORD in the splendour of holiness and tremble before him' (Psa. 96:9). Using New Testament terminology, this Psalm is talking about the experience of saved people during the return of Jesus! As we see in the New Testament, when Jesus returns, it will indeed be a happy time for sanctified believers who will eagerly wait for him (see I Cor. 1:2,7). It will be a time of great 'comfort' for believers who are 'blameless in holiness' (see I Thess. 3:13) when Jesus returns (1 Thess. 4:16-18). However, it will be a terribly terrorizing time for unbelievers and those who don't abide in Christ when he

returns to judge (Rev. 1:7). Revelation 6:15-17 says that this day of wrath of the Lamb will be so terrifying that people – great and small, rich and poor – will want to run and hide from it without success. These terrified people are stubborn unbelievers who rebel against the Word of God and the Goodnews preached by those who embrace the Word of God (see Rev. 6:9,10). Even if we have red the rest of the book of Psalms, we will swiftly reject the lies of the Hyper-Love cultic pastors. Psalm 2:12 tells the full story of what will happen on the Day of Judgment: those who kiss the Son and those who take refuge in the Son will be spared from his wrath on the Final Day; the corollary is also true going by what we read in yet another Psalm: those who refuse to kiss the Son and those who refuse to take refuge in Him will be judged eternally (see Psa. 7:12-13 – "If a man does not repent, God will whet his sword; he has bent and readied his sword; he has prepared for him his deadly weapons, making his arrows fiery shafts.") Let the whole counsel of God's Word (Acts 20:27) save us from the false teachings of Hyper-Love cult pastors who are trying their best to make hell "cute" to deceive believers, and, thereby, being zealously faithful servants of their real boss, Satan!

IS HELL IN GOD, MAKING IT THEREFORE, ENJOYABLE?

The Chennai Hyper-Grace cult pastor says that hell is in God, quoting Psalm 139:8. He implies therefore that hell will be enjoyable! "It is like the irritating fire your wife feels when you try to make love to her without her permission, when she is in a bad mood; When God, in hell, tries to shower his stubborn love upon hell-

dwellers, they would feel that it is like an irritating fire! That is actually the real meaning of the word 'fire' used to describe life in hell in the Bible – it is not a fire that torments!" he says in-effect. First of all, one cannot build a doctrine on one stray verse, and that too, from the Old Testament. Second, the New Testament clearly says that hell-punishment is 'eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power' (2 Thess. 1:9). What this Chennai pastor teaches in directly against the plain teaching of the New Testament. Third, nowhere in the whole Bible, would you find a description of anyone enjoying hell-fire or even anything close to it. On the other hand, rich man who went to Hades (all Hades-occupiers will eventually go to the lake of fire, otherwise called hell – see Revelation 20:14) was in 'torment', the Bible clearly says (Luke 16:23). The rich man in Hades did not say to the Lord, "Stop loving me! It is so irritating!" The false trinity of the Devil, the beast and the false prophets, in the lake of fire (hell) will be 'tormented day and night forever and ever' (Rev. 20:10; See Rev. 14:11 too). There is no place in the whole Bible which implies that God loves Satan. Once Satan rebelled, his free-will was frozen by God. After the final day of judgment, the free-will of those in heaven and those in hell will be frozen by God. Those in hell, stay in hell. Those in heaven, stay in heaven. That is why, the words 'eternal' is pre-fixed before both heaven and hell in the Bible (Matt. 25:41,46). That is why, judgment is called 'eternal' judgment in the Bible (Heb. 6:2). That is why the punishment in after-life for false teachers (an all unbelievers, backslidden believers) merits descriptions such as this: 'reserved forever' (Jude 13).

CHAPTER 39

WHY WE MUST GIVE THE HELLISH *SHACK* MOVIE THEOLOGY, A WHACK!



Using the acronym W-H-A-C-K to give a biblical rebuttal of the 'Trinitarian Gospel' which is nothing but the 'Twisted Trinitarian Gospel' or the 'Hopeful Universalism False Gospel' or the 'Hyper-Love Another Gospel') and seeing the connection of this distortion of the Gospel with the equally dangerous Hyper-Grace cult false teaching.

Here is a summary of the movie/book *The Shack* from ChristianityToday.com, "To summarize, the shape of the novel is this: Mackenzie (Mack) Phillips' youngest daughter, Missy, is abducted and brutally murdered during a family vacation. Following Missy's death, Mack, who has always had a somewhat tenuous relationship with God, falls into what he calls "the Deep Sadness." One wintry day, Mack receives a letter from God (in his mailbox) asking him to meet God in the shack where Missy's bloody dress—the only

evidence of her murder—was recovered. The rest of the book is a conversation between Mack and the Trinity."

I want to use the acronym w-h-a-c-k to outline five main Biblical reasons to give the movie/book, *The Shack*, and the connected "Twisted" Trinitarian Gospel presented by the Canadian author of *The Shack*, a whack:

W: *The Shack* Compromises the WAY:

REPENTANCE COMPROMISED; UNIQUENESS OF JESUS COMPROMISED

In *The Shack*, Jesus declares, "I'm not a Christian," and then explains, "Those who love me come from every system that exists. They were Buddhists or Mormons, Baptists or Muslims, Democrats, Republicans and many who don't vote or are not part of any Sunday morning or religious institutions. I have followers who were murderers and many who were self-righteous. Some are bankers and bookies, Americans and Iraqis, Jews and Palestinians. I have no desire to make them Christian, but I do want to join them in their transformation into sons and daughters of my Papa, into my brothers and sisters, into my Beloved." This statement is in direct contradiction with the Biblical Jesus who claimed to be THE Way, THE Truth, and THE Life (John 14:6). This quip of Jesus in *The Shack*, is directly opposed to the Bible Truth found in Acts 4:12 – Salvation is found in no one else except in the name of Jesus. In *The Shack*, Jesus tells Mack that he is "the best way any human can relate to Papa (God the Father) or Sarayu (God the Holy Spirit)." Please notice this: Jesus is not the "only" way in *The*

Shack, but just the "best" way! What a terrible heresy!!! This declaration of Jesus in *The Shack* stands against Jesus' repeated invitation to all and sundry to "come" to him: "Come to me, all you…." (Matt. 11:28); "Anyone can come after me, but that 'anyone' should be willing to bear the Cross…." (Matt. 16:24, my translation); "Let the little children come to me…." (Matt. 19:14); It is one thing to say that Jesus "seeks" us, but totally another thing to say that Jesus wants to "join us" (which is what the *The Shack* bizarrely and wrongly proclaims). Jesus came to "seek" Zacchaeus-like sinners, the Gospel proclaims (Luke 19:5). But only after he expressed an attitude of repentance (Read Luke 19:8), did Jesus announce "salvation" in his house (Luke 19:9). Jesus calls us to take a U-turn from sin and turn towards him. Biblically, this process is called "repenting". In Luke 13:1-5, Jesus said this twice, "Unless you repent you too will perish!" "Perish"/ "die" is the biblical word that ultimately means eternal hell punishment (2 Thess 2:9,10; Rev. 21:7-8).

I TIMOTHY 4:10 DOES NOT TEACH THAT 'ALL ARE ALREADY SAVED…'

The Canadian author who of the book, upon which the movie, *The Shack* was made, quotes a verse that makes him believe that Jesus was the "best" way and not the only way. Here is that verse: "…the living God, who is the Savior of all men, and especially of those who believe" (1 Tim. 4:10, NIV). This verse does not teach that God saves from hell all people and that Jesus is the best way through which we can be saved. Absolutely not! This verse is talking about "common grace" that God extends to all people, even if they are not believers.

Matthew 5:45 talks about this – God causes his sun to rise on the evil and the good and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous. "In him (God), we live and move and have our being" – Paul mentions this truth to the unbelievers he was preaching to in Acts 17:28, quoting from a secular poet whose works they were familiar with. God gives certain graces to all folks, all over – that was Paul's point. In that sense, God is the "Savior of all men." I agree with **John Samson** who writes this about this verse: "This grace should amaze us because God is under no obligation whatsoever to give it (his common grace) to anyone. It can never be demanded. God sustains the lives of His sworn enemies, often for many decades! **However, as wonderful as it is, it is only a temporal grace because all unregenerate people eventually die and will face the judgment (Heb. 9:27).**" So, the essence of 1 Timothy 4:10 is this: God gives common grace to both believers and unbelievers. But the reception of common grace does not mean automatic escape from hell punishment. In the same sermon where he talked about common grace for all in Acts 17 (in verse 28), Apostle Paul talks about judgment for those who refuse to repent and turn to Christ (in verse 30-31). This Canadian author of the book, based on which *The Shack* movie was made, quotes from 1 Timothy to 'prove' that Christ is the 'best' way. But the Bible truth that Christ is the 'only' way comes out from the same book: there is one God and ONE MEDIATOR between God and men, the man Christ Jesus (1 Tim. 2:5). There is also the teaching that warns about a coming judgment: "the sins of some men are obvious, reaching the place of judgment ahead of them; the sins of others trail behind them" (1 Tim. 5:24). In the same book is the teaching that only the repentant,

truly humble rich people will make it to heaven (1 Tim. 6:17-20). When this is the case, there is no basis to conclude that all folks will be ultimately saved and that Jesus, at best, is only the best way, and not the only way, as the Canadian author of the book, on which *The Shack* movie was based, teaches.

In a very subtle way, *The Shack* demeans Jesus and makes the One who is THE truth, a liar! Here is how: Papa (God the Father) asserts, "regardless of what He (Jesus) felt at that moment, I never left him" when Jesus said, "My God, My God, Why have You forsaken me?" hanging on the Cross. So, according to *The Shack*, Jesus was a liar or emotionally unstable. A foundation for starting a cult is well and truly laid, when Jesus' very character is attacked and this Canadian author does that in *The Shack*!

EXALTING THE FATHER, MINIMIZING JESUS – NOT ACCEPTABLE!

James De Young, a former friend of the Canadian author of the book, on which *The Shack* movie was based, challenged the theology of *The Shack* with this title: *Burning Down the Shack: How the 'Christian' Bestseller is Deceiving Millions.* De Young brilliantly explains how subtly the theology of *The Shack* attacks the uniqueness of Jesus by magnifying one select character of the God the Father, this way: "There is a de-emphasis on the person of Jesus Christ (by the author of the book behind the movie, *The Shack)* because he is very exclusive – he's the only way to God. They don't like those statements, so there's an overemphasis on the fatherhood of God and

a lack of teaching about Jesus Christ, and yet when you look at the New Testament and the prophecies of the Old Testament, Jesus Christ is preeminent and he's the one to whom we go for everything: to understand truth, how to find comfort and encouragement in our daily lives, and so forth." What James De Young wrote about *The Shack* theology is also true about the "leading-people-to-hell" Hyper-Grace cult false teaching as well.

We are using the acronym W-H-A-C-K to literally whack the hell-populating theology of *The Shack*, which is nothing but the cultic hopeful universalism teaching. Now for the next letter in this acronym:

W-H....: *The Shack* Compromises HOLINESS:

THE WRATH OF GOD AS A HOLINESS CALL

Papa (Who is God the Father in *The Shack*) tells Mack (the main character of *The Shack*), "I don't need to punish people for sin. Sin is its own punishment, devouring from the inside. It's not my purpose to punish it; it's my joy to cure it." The message of *The Shack* is obvious: "Don't worry about sin. There is no punishment for it!" *The Shack*, thus, serves as an inspiration for unholy living. The Bible, however, calls each one of us for holy living, at times, pointing to the "coming wrath" of God. Colossians 3:5-9 was written for believers. There, Apostle Paul warns believers about the "wrath of God that is coming", if they do not turn away from sins they were so used to doing, in their former life. Read that passage yourself and you will get it: 'Put to death, therefore, whatever

belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry. Because of these, the wrath of God is coming. You used to walk in these ways, in the life you once lived. But now you must also rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips. Do not lie to each other, since you have taken off your old self with its practices.' 1 Peter 3:10-11 also says the same thing: Jesus is coming again to judge the world, so live a holy life. 1 Corinthians 10:1-11 also says the same thing: the judgment of God that came upon so many in the Old Testament can come upon careless New Testament believers; so they must be warned and live holy lives. Jude 7 also says the same thing. *The Shack* ignores such direct New Testament messages where the wrath of God is connected with a clear holiness call.

THE 'DON'T COPY JESUS' MESSAGE – SO BLATANTLY UNBIBLICAL!

There is another clear way *The Shack* implies that unholy living is okay. Jesus, in the movie *The Shack* says, "my life was not meant to be an example to copy; being my follower is not trying to be like Jesus; it means for your Independence to be killed." The basic message of this movie/book is this: "As a believer you need not copy the holy Jesus!" This is absolute rubbish! The ultimate purpose that God has for any believer is best expressed by this familiar verse: "For God knew his people in advance, and he chose them to become like his Son, so that his Son would be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters" (Rom. 8:29, NLT). If believers were not supposed

to copy Jesus, Apostle Paul would have known. Hear him please on this subject, directly. He says, "Follow my example, as I follow the example of Christ." You have to make up your mind, dear reader: to follow the heretic Canadian author of the book, upon which the movie *The Shack* was made or Apostle Paul of the Bible who taught that we must follow his example as he followed Christ's (1 Cor. 11:1)! Not just Apostle Paul. Hear the words of Apostle Peter as well on this subject: 'Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, so that you might follow in his steps' (1 Pet. 2:21, ESV). Apostle John, wrote in similar vein, this: 'whoever says he abides in him (Christ) ought to walk in the same way in which he walked' (1 John 2:6, ESV). Don't miss the word 'ought' in Apostle John's statement, I just quoted. Walking as Jesus walked is not an option for a believer – it is an obligation!

We are using the acronym W-H-A-C-K to literally whack the hell-populating theology of *The Shack*, which is nothing but the cultic hopeful universalism teaching. We shall stay longer in the "H" of this acronym.

W-H.....:*The Shack* Compromises yet another "H" – the doctrine of Hell:

A SAD CONTRACDICTION OF THE CORRECT BIBLE DOCTRINE OF HELL

The Shack refers to the "fallacy of belief in God sentencing anyone to hell." The author's viewpoint is this: God does not punish anyone. But this is directly contrary to the Scripture. God told Moses, "in the day when I punish,

I will punish them (the people of Israel) for their sin" (Ex. 32:34 NASB). Yahweh does not beat around the bush in Leviticus 26:18: "If also after these things you do not obey Me, then I will punish you seven times more for your sins." Is there no more punishment for sin post the Cross? Absolutely not! There can be punishment for the stubborn-in-sin, backslidden believer, even in the post-Cross era! The author of Hebrews writes, "How much severer punishment do you think he will deserve who has trampled under foot the Son of God, and has regarded as unclean the blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified, and has insulted the Spirit of grace?" (Heb. 10:29). Disobedience to the Gospel message (which is "repent from sin and trust in Jesus, the only Sin-Savior") will result in "everlasting punishment" – these are Apostle Paul's Spirit-inspired words post the Cross (2 Thess. 1:8-9). Post the Cross, our God continues to be a "Consuming Fire" (Heb. 12:29) as he continues to be a "Compassionate Father"!

We are using the acronym W-H-A-C-K to literally whack the hell-populating theology of *The Shack*, which is nothing but the cultic hopeful universalism teaching. Now for the "A" in this acronym:

W-H-A….: *The Shack* Compromises the A-TONEMENT:

In *The Shack*, Mack discovers, "scars in [Papa/God the Father's] wrists, like those he now assumed Jesus also had on his." Papa (God the Father) says in *The Shack*, "When we three spoke our self into human existence as

the Son of God, we became fully human. We also chose to embrace all the limitations that this entailed. Even though we have always been present in this created universe, we now became flesh and blood." No where does the Bible speak of scars in the hands of the Father God. God is spirit (John 4:24). A spirit does not have a body or body parts like the mouth with which it can eat as Jesus himself confirmed (Luke 24:39). Only Jesus (the Word) became "flesh" (John 1:1; John 1:14) - the Father and the Spirit did not become Flesh. Because Jesus had a body, he could shed His blood for us on the Cross. Both God the Father and the Holy Spirit did not choose to incarnate (that is take up a body) and therefore cannot have scars. At least eight times, the Bible talks about "the blood of Jesus/Christ" (Rom. 3:25; 1 Cor. 10:16; Eph. 2:13; Heb. 9:11; Heb. 9:14; 1 Pet. 1:2; 1 Pet. 1:19; Rev. 1:5). But the Bible never speaks about the "blood" of God the Father or the Holy Spirit!

We are using the acronym W-H-A-C-K to literally whack the hell-populating theology of *The Shack*, which is nothing but the cultic hopeful universalism teaching. Now for the "C" in this acronym:

W-H-A-C....: *The Shack* Compromises biblical truth on C-REATION-CREATOR Divide:

In *The Shack*, Jesus says this to Mack: "Papa (God, the Father in *The Shack*) is as much submitted to me as I am to him, or Sarayu (Holy Spirit in The *Shack*) to me, or Papa to her. Submission is not about authority and it is not obedience; it is all about relationships of love and respect. In fact, we are submitted to you in the same

way." Read that again! *The Shack* teaches that the Trinity is submitted to us humans, created beings!!! But if you read the Bible, the Creator-Creation divide is becomes obvious! For starters, the Bible makes it clear that while God is holy, each human is a sinner!!! Apostle Paul writes in Romans 3:4, "Let God be true and every man a liar!"

ALL PEOPLE IN THIS PLANET WILL NOT BE SAVED!

The Bible teaches that a day is coming, when unbelievers will be separated from the God-head and cast into hell. Read Matt. 13:30 – "Allow both (wheat and tares) to grow together until the harvest; and in the time of the harvest I will say to the reapers, "First gather up the tares and bind them in bundles to burn them up; but gather the wheat into my barn." Notice here that all tares do not become wheat at the end of time – Jesus himself said. If all people in the World would be saved and merged into a fellowship with the Trinity, this would have happened. But it does not happen. Jesus himself pointed this out, as we just saw! So, the truth is, some will be saved, and others will be lost. But this Canadian author, as it is made clear, by one of his books released in 2017, believes that all people in the World will be saved!!! In fact in *The Shack*, Papa (God the Father) says, "The Whole World" (not just "those who believe") will be ultimately saved."

Just like all cults start off with a wrong idea about the Doctrine of God (think of Jehovah Witnesses who say that Jesus is not God), The Canadian author of the book, upon which the movie, *The Shack* was made, through his writings, has fuelled the rise of yet another cult! Beware!!

We are using the acronym W-H-A-C-K to literally whack the hell-populating theology of *The Shack*, which is nothing but the cultic hopeful universalism teaching. Now for the "K" in this acronym:

W-H-A-C-K: *The Shack* compromises on THE K-ONFESSION TEACHING IN THE BIBLE: (Mis-spelling the word, 'Confession' here, as 'Konfession', just to keep this acronym going; this acronym, hopefully, will be a memorable biblical reminder to reject the Hyper-Love false teachings as a whole).

THEY TEACH THAT 'ALL ARE ALREADY SAVED' AND THAT IS A WRONG, HELL-POPULATING TEACHING

"Forgiveness does not establish relationship. In Jesus, I have forgiven all humans for their sins against me, but only some choose relationship." This is one of the most anti-Scriptural statements you will read/hear in *The Shack*, mouthed by the so-called God, the Father. In the movie, *The Shack*, the Lady-killer (a serial killer who killed women) who apparently raped and killed the little daughter of Mack, is forgiven by the Trinity, even if he did not ask for forgiveness. Mack's father, a stubborn, unrepentant alcoholic who never asked for his sins to be

forgiven, is shown in *The Shack*, as being in heaven. Mack is already forgiven, even before he asks for it in *The Shack*. The Canadian author of the book, based on which the movie, *The Shack* was made, writes, "So what is the Good News? What is the Gospel? The Good News is not that Jesus has opened the possibility of salvation and you have been invited to receive Jesus into your life. The Gospel is that Jesus has already included you into His life, into His relationship with God the Father, and into His anointing in the Holy Spirit (My note: Notice here, the reference to the Trinity, hence the name Trinitarian Gospel, but I would call it Twisted Trinitarian Gospel or Hopeful Universalism False Gospel). The Good News is that Jesus did this without your vote, and whether you believe it or not won't make it any less or more true....Are you suggesting that everyone is saved? That you believe in universal salvation? That is exactly what I am saying!"

This is where *The Shack* theology of this Canadian author of the book behind *The Shack* movie gives a handshake, a hug, to the Hyper-Grace theology put out by a Singapore mega-church pastor! The only difference is this: The Hyper-Grace blokes teach that believers do not need to confess their sins to be forgiven; *The Shack* teaching (called Trinitarian Gospel now) is that both believers and un-believers need not confess their sins to be forgiven!!! But this goes against the teaching of the Bible that God commands all people everywhere to "repent" (Acts 17:30-31). A realization of sin precedes repentance from sin. And repentance from sin will result in confession of sin. This is the teaching of 1 John 1:8-10. God's kindness should lead to repentance, Paul wrote (Rom. 2:4). And when we don't repent, the wrath of God is stored up against us, Paul

warned (Rom. 2:5). Paul also wrote, "Let everyone who names the name of the Lord depart from iniquity"(2 Tim. 2:19). No one can truthfully say, "I believe in Jesus," and not turn decisively from sin – that is Paul's point here. Will a believer be perfect? No. John writes, "No one born of God makes a practice of sinning, for God's seed abides in him; and he cannot keep on sinning, because he has been born of God" (1 John 3:9). When a believer does sin, he needs to repent from that sin, confess it and get back to Christ as this book teaches (1 John 1:8-10).

WHEN YOU THINK A BIBLE VERSE SUPPORTS UNIVERSALISM, KEEP READING ABOVE AND BELOW THAT VERSE AND YOU WILL SURELY REALISE THAT IT DOES NOT!

The Canadian author of the book upon which the movie, *The Shack*, was made quotes John 12:32 to teach that all will be eventually saved and that none will go to hell. Let us revisit John 12:32 again. Jesus says here, "But I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all men to myself." This Canadian author points out that "draw" in the original Greek means "to drag." So he says (in-effect), "even if you don't chose to believe in Jesus, you will be saved." This is not true. If Jesus meant to say what this cultic, hell-populating Canadian author implies, why would he say just fourteen verses later, "I have come into the world as a light, so that no one who BELIEVES IN ME should stay in darkness" (John 12:46). The corollary is true: if there are folks who refuse to believe in

Jesus, they would go to the place of "outer darkness" – hell (Matt. 22:13). John 12:32 never meant to teach that all would be saved. Similarly, when the Scripture says, "at the name of Jesus every knee should bow" in Philippians 2:10, it does not mean all people will be saved automatically in the end. Read four verses below – in Philippians 2:15, Apostle Paul talks about being "blameless and pure children of God without fault in a crooked and depraved generation (meaning, hell-heading generation)." When we bump into a Bible Verse that seems to suggest that all will be ultimately saved, we must keep reading above and below that verse. And when we do that, we will know for sure that the Bible does NOT support universalism, the cultic teaching that all will be ultimately saved.

In the same way, we could take each Scripture this cultic group spear-headed by the likes of this Canadian author of the book, upon which the movie, *The Shack,* was made, quote and do a rebuttal. But there is no space here for the same in this chapter.

The acronym W-H-A-C-K presented above will help us to whack the theology that this Canadian author of the book, upon which the movie, *The Shack* was made, and *The Shack* fans try to embrace and popularize. The Trinitarian Gospel this Canadian author popularizes, should be called, "Twisted Trinitarian Gospel" (TTG), for it twists certain elements of the Trinity to teach that all are saved even though they don't know it now.

Remember, that Apostle Peter warned us about false teachers who will "twist" Scriptures to the destruction of themselves and their followers (2 Peter 3:16).

THE CHENNAI HYPER-LOVE CULT PASTOR ALSO TEACHES THE HELL-POPULATING, HOPEFUL UNIVERSALISM FALSE DOCTRINE (MODELLED BY THE SHACK MOVIE THEOLOGY) – SO BEWARE!

That the Chennai Hyper-Grace cum Hyper-Supernaturalism cum Hyper-Love Pastor subscribes to the Hopeful Universalism hell-populating false teaching is obvious by what he said in one of his Youtube videos. He said, "We cannot say, only few are in Christ and others are not in Christ! All are in Christ (already)." If this was true, why will we have verses like these in the Bible: "If anyone is in Christ...." (2 Cor. 5:17). If all people are already in Christ and are already saved as this Chennai cult pastor teaches, such verses are meaningless. What the Bible teaches is clear: All of us are sinners who are headed to hell. When the Bible says, "All have sinned" (Rom. 3:23) and when the Bible says, "The wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6:23), it implies that everyone is hell-headed because death brings second death which is everlasting life in the lake of fire (Rev. 21:8). The only way of salvation from that hell is Jesus. That's why we read, '**In him** we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us' (Eph. 1:7-8). That is why we read, "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who **are in Christ Jesus**" (Rom. 8:1). Notice that

this verse does not say, 'those who were once upon a time' were in Christ Jesus! A living daily relationship with Jesus saves us from a living hell while we live on this earth and a literal hell after we die.

The Bible does not teach hopeful universalism. This is a wrong teaching which says: "We are hopeful that God will save everyone and not send anyone to hell!" The Bible is clear that some people will surely land in hell. Jesus confirmed this. He said, "Enter through the narrow gate; for the gate is wide and the way is broad that leads to destruction, and there are many who enter through it. For the gate is small and the way is narrow that leads to life, and there are few who find it" (Matt. 7:13-14 NASB). According to Jesus, only a small section of the world's population will come to heaven. Apostle Paul did not say that everyone was already saved as these hell-populating hyper-love false pastors believe. Instead, he called unsaved people, "children of wrath" (Eph. 2:3). If they remained that way, they were heading to hell. He confirmed this in 2 Thessalonians 1:7-10. He wrote that when Jesus returns, those who do not know God and those who do not obey the Gospel will be eternally punished! This is what he exactly said: '...when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with his mighty angels in flaming fire, inflicting vengeance on those who do not know God and on those who do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus. They will suffer the punishment of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of his might, when he comes on that day to be glorified in his saints...'

ASSURING THAT EVEN PAGANS WHO DID NOT HEAR OF JESUS ARE ALREADY SAVED – WHAT A FALSE DOCTRINE!

The Chennai pastor remarked that a person who listened to his messages were comforted because she was now sure that her unsaved parents who followed a non-Christian faith, now dead, are already saved, thanks to the hopeful universalism cultic teaching she heard from him (March 16, 2024 YouTube livestream).

The preaching of the Apostles caused riots in Ephesus! Why? Because Paul clearly preached 'that gods made by human hands are no gods at all' (Acts 19:26). And as a result, those who still wanted to worship idols felt that their idol-making business will go bankrupt and started a riot (Acts 19:27-28). The preaching of the Apostles in Corinth was also similar. Paul believed that the Corinthians, before their conversion to Christ, were 'influenced and led astray to mute idols' (1 Cor. 12:2). He further declared, 'an idol is nothing at all in the world and there is no God but one' (1 Cor. 12:2). The implication is this: everyone from every faith must hear of Jesus! Jesus indicated that the only way people can be saved is belief in His name through the message of the disciples of Jesus (see John 17:20). Paul also underlines the same thing: "And how can they believe in the one of whom they have not heard? And how can they hear without someone preaching to them?" (Rom. 10:14). So, Jesus and the apostles taught this: the Gospel must be declared and people who believe in it – only these will be saved. The pagan Gospel-ignorant who reject the General Revelation of God through creation will have 'no

excuse' on the Final Day of Judgment (Rom. 1:20). However, people like Cornelius who responded well to the General Revelation (the voice of God for all people, including those who have not yet heard about Jesus, from creation *outside* which Romans 1:19-20 talks about; the voice of God for all people, including those who have not yet heard about Jesus, from conscience *within* which Romans 2:14-15 talks about) were surely given the privilege of hearing the Gospel through Gospel-sharing missionaries (Acts 10). God always graciously rewards those who respond well to his General Revelation, with the avenues of listening to the Special Revelation of the Gospel. This, I believe.

CHAPTER 40

A BIBLICAL RESPONSE TO THE ATTEMPT BY HYPER-LOVE FALSE TEACHERS TO CRUCIFY THE MAIN REASON WHY JESUS WAS CRUCIFIED FOR US – TO TAKE AWAY OUR SIN!



There is a calculated move from those in the hyper-love/twisted trinitarian gospel camp (including a certain Chennai-based pastor) to undermine the fact that sin had anything to do with Jesus' death on the Cross, two thousand years ago, or even in the Word becoming flesh.

These folks hate any mention of "sin" and are on a clear-cut mission to delete "sin" from the vocabulary of Christian preaching/ministry, because it makes them and their hearers uncomfortable. These cultic false teachers and followers make good, the Apostle Paul's prediction: "because a time will come when some will no

longer tolerate sound teaching. Instead, they will live by their own desires; they'll scratch their itching ears by surrounding themselves with teachers who approve of their lifestyles and tell them what they want to hear" (2 Tim. 4:3, VOICE).

They effectively say, "Jesus' death was to only affirm you as His child. Sin has nothing to do with it!" The cultic theologian of *The Shack* movie fame (and a well-known proponent of this cultic camp's views) alleges that if Jesus died on the Cross for our sins, it would amount to "cosmic child abuse" there-by summarily dismissing the majority evangelical view of penal substitution as the prime reason for Jesus' death on the Cross (that is Jesus died on the Cross as a substitute to save sinners). They (hyper-grace/twisted trinitarian Gospel teachers) are liars. Liars, who are on the road to hell and taking people who believe their lie with them. These sly folks are crucifying the main reason why Jesus was crucified on the Cross: to die as a substitute for our sins!

The Scriptures repeatedly link the Cross of Jesus with sin. You will have to be stone blind or be stubbornly sold to hell-taking false doctrine not to notice that!

Here are a few references, flowing from the Spirit-propelled pen of different Bible writers:

PROPHET ISAIAH SAYS THAT JESUS DIED BECAUSE OF OUR SINS

"But HE WAS PIERCED FOR OUR TRANSGRESSIONS, HE WAS CRUSHED FOR OUR INIQUITIES…" (Isa. 53:5 NIV).

Those are the Spirit-wrought words recorded by Prophet Isaiah. Matthew 8:17 and Acts 8:26-40 present Christ as the Suffering Servant of Isaiah 53, very clearly.

APOSTLE PAUL SAYS THAT JESUS DIED BECAUSE OF OUR SINS

"For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that CHRIST DIED FOR OUR SINS in accordance with the Scriptures...." (I Cor. 15:3 ESV). Those are the Spirit-inspired words of Apostle Paul.

Paul, elsewhere wrote, "He was DELIVERED OVER TO DEATH FOR OUR SINS and was raised to life for our justification" (Rom. 4:25 NIV).

Here is **the third time**, as he writes to the church in Ephesus, Paul connects "sin" to the work of Jesus on the Cross this way: "In him we have redemption THROUGH HIS BLOOD, THE FORGIVENESS OF SINS, in accordance with the riches of God's grace" (Eph. 1:7 NIV).

The Chennai hyper-grace/twisted trinitarian Gospel preaching cult pastor I referred to at the start of this article, in a YouTube video, begins his presentation of the twisted trinitarian Gospel in a message titled, "Triune Dance" quoting from *The Message* version of Ephesians 1.

THE MESSAGE VERSION OF THE BIBLE GOT ROMANS 8:35 WRONG

Though *The Message* version of Eugene Peterson has been a blessing, it should not be used without comparison of its contemporary language and idioms filled text with essentially literal, reliable translations done by scholar teams like the ESV, the NASB, the NKJV, etc. The grave error in The Message version of the Bible is found in Romans 8 where the creator of *The Message* version, Eugene Peterson, erroneously supplies the words, "not even the worst sins listed in Scripture" (in verse 35) in the list of things Paul mentions there that cannot separate us from the love of God. Romans 8:35 in *The Message* version reads this way: 'Do you think anyone is going to be able to drive a wedge between us and Christ's love for us? There is no way! Not trouble, not hard times, not hatred, not hunger, not homelessness, not bullying threats, not backstabbing, **not even the worst sins listed in Scripture.**' None of the other major, regular translations include this false-teaching-flirting-with phrase ('not even the worst sins listed in Scripture') used by Eugene Peterson here in Romans 8:35 (Pastor Jeyakaran Immanuel of Chennai was the first to point this to me – thank you *annan!*). Romans 8:35 does NOT include sin in the list of things that can separate us from God as the ESV rendering of this verse clearly shows: "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or danger, or sword?" (ESV). Every entry in this category is in the category of suffering, not sin – did you not notice? Here is another example of a list in the Bible: Psalm 19:12-13. Psalm 19:12-13 contains a list of sin: 'own errors...hidden errors...willful sins'(NIV). Eugene Peterson, to his credit, does not insert any phrase

that is not connected with sin there. Here is his list: 'play the fool...stupid sins...grime of sin' (MSG). But in Romans 8:35, he goofs-up! Romans 8:35 has a list of different kinds of suffering (as one can see). Sin is nowhere in the picture. Eugene Peterson wrongly inserts the phrase 'not even the worst sins of Scripture' to a list that only contains elements of different types of suffering – a list that has nothing to do with sin! This entry made by Eugene Peterson in Romans 8:35 brings forth a wrong teaching that 'sin does not separate a believer from God'. However, in Isaiah 59:2 ('but your iniquities have made a separation between you and your God...'), the Bible directly teaches that sin does separate us from God [in an ultimate sense, as those believers stubborn in sin without showing fruits of repentance, are storing up God's Wrath upon themselves (see Romans 2:5) and these believes will ultimately land-up in hell, the place where there is an ultimate unleashing of God's eternal wrath].

Now, let us get back to a strange new teaching – an absolutely wrong teaching – put out by this **Chennai Pastor from Ephesians 1 that sin is not the major reason why Jesus went to the Cross.**

It is unfortunate that while the "sonship" of verse 5 of this chapter captured his attention, the "sin-reason" for Jesus' death, found just two verses below – in verse 7 – has escaped his eye. The point of Paul in his letter to Ephesus is not "sin is okay" or "sin is a minor thing" (as hyper-grace teachers often make it to be). Otherwise why would he write, "the one who steals must steal no longer..." (Eph. 4:28)? In the same book, the

book of Ephesians, Apostle Paul reminds believers of the responsibility to be sexually pure after talking about the privilege of having Christ die for us on the Cross. Here are those verses: "And walk in love, as the Messiah also loved us and gave Himself for us, a sacrificial and fragrant offering to God. But sexual immorality and any impurity or greed should not even be heard of among you, as is proper for saints" (Eph. 5:2-3 HCSB).

This Chennai Pastor quotes 2 Tim. 1:9 to teach that grace has nothing to do with sin – it was given "before the beginning of time", before man even sinned. True. However, this does not undermine the crystal-clear reason repeated in Scripture that Jesus died as a substitute for sinners. The same Apostle Paul while writing to Timothy earlier states in ultra-clear terms this: 'Here is a trustworthy saying that deserves full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the worst….'(I Tim. 1:15).

APOSTLE PETER SAYS THAT JESUS DIED BECAUSE OF OUR SINS

"HE HIMSELF BORE OUR SINS IN HIS BODY ON THE TREE, THAT WE MIGHT DIE TO sin and live to righteousness" (I Pet. 2:24 ESV). Those are the Spirit-directed words of Apostle Peter.

APOSTLE JOHN SAYS THAT JESUS DIED BECAUSE OF OUR SINS

"He is the ATONING SACRIFICE FOR OUR SINS…" (I John 2:2 NIV). Those are the Spirit-propelled words of

Apostle John. In his earlier book, John also used the imagery of the Shepherd to paint the same truth. The True Shepherd. Jesus came to lay his life down to save the wayward (sinful) sheep (John 10:11,15). Surely, John was using a familiar Old Testament imagery that explicitly said the same thing from the writings of Prophet Isaiah: "We all, like SHEEP, HAVE GONE ASTRAY, EACH OF US HAS TURNED TO OUR OWN WAY; AND THE LORD HAS LAID ON HIM THE INIQUITY OF US ALL" (Isa. 53:6 NIV).

THE WRITER TO THE HEBREWS SAYS THAT JESUS DIED BECAUSE OF OUR SINS

"...He has died as a ransom to set them free from the sins..." (Heb. 9:15 NIV). We do not know who wrote the book of Hebrews. It could have been Priscilla or Apollos or Barnabas or anyone else. But that unnamed Spirit-controlled author makes it clear: Jesus died as a substitute for sinners. He/She was using an imagery of "ransom" which Jesus already used in the Gospels (Mark 10:45) to teach this very thing that Jesus came as a sin-substitute for sinners. I would say that Jesus' words on the Cross, "Father, forgive them for they do not know what they do" (Luke 23:34) points to the prime reason why he died: so that he would be able to offer forgiveness from sin to sinners. Am I saying that Jesus never died to make us God's children? No. One of his statements from the Cross - "My God, My God why have you forsaken me?" (Math. 27:46) - indicated that Jesus voluntarily chose to be abandoned by His Father so that he would be able to adopt us into his family. Let

us embrace both the reasons as to why Jesus died: the FORGIVEN ("Sin") reason and NOT FORSAKEN ("son") reason. Let us be balanced. Let us not emphasize one truth at the cost of the other.

THEY MAKE JESUS A LIAR IN-EFFECT! HOW SAD!

Of course, many Hyper-Love cult false teachers say that the Father did NOT forsake Jesus when he hung on the Cross. This way, they make Jesus who said exactly the opposite, a liar. Calling Jesus a liar, in-effect, will bring punishment. To make their faulty hyper-love doctrine, sound good, they won't mind calling Jesus a liar (in-effect). How sad!

DESPITE ALL THIS, HYPER-LOVE CULT PREACHERS WILL STILL SAY THAT SIN WAS NOT THE MAIN REASON THAT JESUS DIED ON THE CROSS!

So, there we have it. **Every major Bible writer presents "the penal substitution" view – that Jesus died to save sinners as shown above**. You have a choice now: to believe the lies of the hyper-grace/twisted trinitarian gospel proponents view of the Cross or the truth of God's Word on the Cross.

Let us not forget that Christ came to die on the Cross as a substitute for us, sinners! To quote the words of Apostle Paul again: "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become

the righteousness of God..." (2 Cor. 5:21). Unfortunately, a Madurai based hyper-grace pastor, quotes this very verse to teach that Jesus became a sinner on the Cross. This is not Scriptural. The Bible is very clear in presenting this fact: Jesus, never ever became a sinner or sinned (I John 3:5). The false teachings associated with the Cross are many, these last days! Let us get back to the Bible! Let us hold fast to the truth!

SECTION FOUR

MICELLANEOUS FALSE TEACHINGS

CHAPTER 41

DON'T MISTAKE WOLVES FOR LABRADORS!!!



The Characteristics Of Hell-Populating False Teachers Explained

While we appreciate our true-to-the-Word-of-God teachers, we must also be wary of "false teachers". This is what the Bible says about "False Teachers": "But false prophets also arose among the people, just as there will be FALSE TEACHER among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them, bringing upon themselves swift destruction" (2 Peter 2:1, ESV). The 'man of God' you listen to Sunday after Sunday - if he teaches Hyper-Grace, immortality on earth and such salvation-affecting false teaching, is a 'false teacher'.

This verse says, false teachers are first of all 'secretive'. That means they want to show that they are part of the main-stream Christianity while they are cultic. They vehemently deny that they are cultic (but they are secretly indeed cultic, because 'popular opinion' and not the Bible is their final court of appeal; they don't mind

saying that 'The Bible is not the Word of God'). False Teachers are called 'wolves' elsewhere in the Bible (Matt. 7:15). Wolves (False Teachers) have a deceptive appearance. We can mistake them to be Labradors and pamper them (attend their church and support their ministry)!!! Beware! Don't get fooled!!!!

This verse also says that false teachers bring in 'destructive heresies'. The meaning? Unless they repent (2 Peter 3:9), these false teachers are heading towards hell and taking people who follow them blindly, also to hell.

In 2 Peter 2:4, just three verses below, Apostle Peter promises 'hell' for unrepentant false teachers. In the same chapter (2 Peter 2) – 'They have eyes full of adultery, insatiable for sin. They entice unsteady souls. They have hearts trained in greed. Accursed children!' (verse 14, ESV).

This brings to the fore front, two more characters of false teachers: they work up a theology that excuses sin, that excuses the 'eyes full of adultery' 'after all – the grace of God is ALWAYS there' (to put it in their words) (notice the word 'entice'). Yes, they use the Grace of God as a license for immoral living as Jude explains (in verse 4).

Not only that. These false teachers twist the Word of God motivated by 'greed' (a love for money) as 2 Peter 2:14 says. They preach a God of love but won't tell you about the wrath of God which the same Bible talks about, lest you get offended and won't send them an offering or stay in their church.

They will tell you about a hell, but give you hope that even from hell you can come to heaven, so that your ears are tickled and you feel good.

They tell you that Jesus will never return to earth, till a generation believes in Immortality on earth (that is not likely to happen, so Jesus won't ever come back, or come back anytime soon, and so you can live in sin in-effect, according to them).

Peter, inspired by the Holy Spirit, calls them 'accused children' (2 Pet. 2:14) [he knew they were already hell-headed, but he would not simply watch, as believers follow them, so he wrote these words primarily not to warn these false teachers but the believers who follow them without second thought.]

CHAPTER 42

SHOULD WE CELEBRATE JEWISH FEASTS MENTIONED IN THE BIBLE AND EXPECT THAT JESUS WOULD RETURN DURING ONE SUCH CELEBRATION?



We do not need to celebrate Jewish feasts as New Testament Christians. It is not compulsory! It is left to one's free will (Rom. 14:5-6). Celebrating any Jewish feasts thinking that the act will save us, is an insult to the finished Work of Jesus on the Cross (See Gal. 4:10). When we trusted Jesus as our Savior as Gentiles, we have been 'circumcised' already spiritually speaking – we don't have to undergo physical circumcision (Col. 2:11). Just as circumcision, the physical rite, involves removal of the foreskin of the male, our salvation through faith and ongoing Spirit-powered intimacy in Jesus gives us power to "remove" sinful addictions in our private lives. As New Testament believers, we can eat pork (no matter what hyper-jewish false teachers say) because Apostle Paul writes only 'hypocritical liars and hell-populating cultic false

teachers teach that we must abstain from certain foods which God created' (1 Tim. 4:2-3).

Some Hyper-Jewish groups, these days, teach, "Jesus will come around this Jewish feast," in order to coax more believers to celebrate Jewish feasts! Don't fall for their trap!

Jesus will come as a thief in the night - the Bible tells us this seven times (Matt. 24:43; Lk. 12:39; 1 Thess. 5:2; 1 Thess. 5:4; 2 Pet. 3:10; Rev. 3:3; Rev. 16:15). The Bible uses the imagery of the sudden onset of delivery pain in a pregnant woman to teach that we cannot know the exact time of Jesus' return just like we cannot know the exact time a pregnant mom will give birth (1 Thess. 5:4). And no one knows when Jesus will come, except the Father - the Bible tells us this twice (Matt. 24:36; Mark 13:32)!

Of course, having been saved by grace, we must obey the moral laws of God out of gratitude (Heb. 13:4 is basically repeating familiar moral law found in the Ten Commandments, 'Do not commit adultery'; Ephesians 4:28 is repeating another of Ten Commandments, 'Do not steal'; Colossians 3:9 is repeating another of the Ten Commandment, 'Do not bear false witness/lie"). Following the moral laws of the Old Testament will not save us! But if we are truly saved, we will follow the moral laws of the Old Testament empowered by the grace of God and the Spirit of God (Rev. 22:13-14, Jesus is the 'alpha' and the 'omega' of our salvation, but we need to wear what he gives us freely in order to enter heaven; wearing what Jesus gives us freely is an analogy for using His power and strength to live holy).

CHAPTER 43

TAKE THE VACCINE, AND YOU TAKE THE BEAST'S (ANTI-CHRIST'S) MARK?



Three Scriptures connect receiving the mark of the Beast, which the book of Revelation talks about, with receiving something you receive on your forehead and hands (Rev. 14:9; Rev. 13:11,16,17; Rev. 20:4). Since, the corona vaccine is sent into one's hands, the speculation has been rife that receiving the vaccine shot, equals to receiving the mark of the beast/the antichrist. These well-meaning folks passionately argue this way: 'If C equals 3, being the third letter in the English alphabet, O equals to 15, R equals to 18, O equals to 15, N equals to 14, and A equals to 1, the total comes to 66. And there are 6 letters in the English word, Corona. So, there you have it – Corona has something to do with 666, the mark of the Antichrist!' Does this interpretation of Revelation hold water? Let's see.

The SETTING to the Book of Revelation

There is a background, a setting, a context to every New Testament letter. For example, we know that Apostle Paul wrote to the believers at the church in Corinth to instruct them on how to handle a believer who was sleeping with own mother (1 Cor. 5). This was one of the different reasons. In the same way, Apostle John wrote the Book of Revelation to seven specific church believers in Asia Minor who faced the specific problem of being sucked into and swept away by what was called the 'imperial cult'. The Book of Revelation mentions that John wrote to an actual bunch of Asian churches, very clearly (see Rev. 1:4,11). So, as we see the book of Corinthians in its context, we must see the book of Revelation in its context.

WHEN 'SHAH RUKH KHAN' IS MENTIONED...

If someone says, **'Shah Rukh Khan'**, we instinctively ask, 'Shah Rukh Khan, the IPL Team Owner and Bollywood Star or Shah Rukh Khan, the Big Hitting IPL Player from Tamil Nadu?', don't we? Context-seeking questions come naturally to us, don't they? In the same way, we must look at everything mentioned in the Bible keeping in mind the context. Or else, the meaning of that text will get assassinated!

When the book of Revelation was being written, the believers were faced with the temptation of joining what was called the Roman Imperial Cult. The Caesars of those days wanted the people to worship them or

face trouble for not doing so. Bible Scholars of repute assert that the book of Revelation was written during the rule of one these two emperors – Nero and Domitian. One killed his own mother and the Christians. The other praised a palace steward, showered on him courtesies before killing him, the next day. Because of this kind of erratic, eccentric, emotional behavior, these emperors were popularly called 'beasts' (of course in whispers).

So, when Apostle John wrote about the beast and his mark, the early church believers instantly knew who he was talking about. They knew that he was talking about the 'beast' who was also the Caesar of the land, the emperor of the land, the same way, a cricket fan instantly knows that **Rahul Dravid** is being talked about when someone mentions 'The Wall' or an action movie addict knows that **Jean-Claude Van Damme** is being spoken of when someone quips, 'Muscles from Brussels'!

So, when the book of Revelation talks about the mark of the beast being received in the hand, it cannot be talking about the Corona Vaccine, I believe! When you keep the context of the book in mind, you simply cannot come to that conclusion!

The SYMBOLISM of the Beast's Number (666)

Both the Hebrew people and the Greek people assigned numerics to their language's alphabets. If one spelt "Nero Caesar" in Hebrew letters (like assigning A equals to 1... Z equals 26 in English alphabets), the total came

to 666 (you just have to Google this and you will know).

So, the number 666 mentioned in the book of Revelation was speaking about Nero Caesar using a code language which was familiar to the original readers of the book of Revelation. The book of Revelation was clearly understood by its original readers as Romans and Corinthians was by its original readers! The writer of Revelation did not want the church believers he wrote to, to get into trouble for possessing a letter with direct references to an evil emperor like Nero Caesar who was out to capture them and throw them to the lions. So, he used **a code language like '666', 'the beast',** etc. to refer to the evil rulers of their time who persecuted them for their faith in Christ and their rejection of him, as their Lord!

The SHOPPING-SELLING ban which Revelation talks about

'DON'T WORSHIP THE EMPRORER' COMMAND, PUT IN CODE LANGAUGE IN THE BOOK OF REVELATION

Revelation 13:17 which reads this way, has intrigued a lot of people: 'so that could not buy or sell unless they had the mark, which is the name of the beast or the number of its name' (NIV). What was this shopping-selling ban on those who refuse the beast's mark all about? The Caesars of those days had their images conformed to the images of the popular deities in the coins, people used for daily business transactions, day-to-day shopping and selling in the markets. In the public square, a gigantic image of the Caesar was placed so that people would

worship him as god. The very helpful *NIV Cultural Backgrounds Study Bible* observes this: 'In AD 89/90, maybe five or six years before the book of Revelation arrived in the churches of Asia, Ephesus issued a coin that conformed Domitian to the image of the chief deity, Zeus. Domitian also dedicated an imperial statue of nearly 25 feet (eight meters) high in the imperial temple in Ephesus. Individuals faced social pressure to participate in public cults, but unless they were accused of disloyalty, no one would hunt down nonparticipants to ensure their participation' (page 2247). If you did not worship Caesar, you would not be easily granted access to the market he controlled, symbolized by the coins that bore his god-like image. You would be accused of sedition. You would be accused of hating your land. So, the book of Revelation was calling the believers to 'endure' and not participate in the emperor cult. Revelation 2:10 called for endurance *directly*: 'Do not fear any of those things which you are about to suffer. Indeed, the devil is about to throw *some* of you into prison, that you may be tested, and you will have tribulation ten days. Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life' (NKJV). And passages like Revelation 14:9-10 (burning sulphur for recipients of beast's mark) called for the very same thing *indirectly*: using the 'mark of the beast'/666 imagery! So, the writer of the book of Revelation was not talking about receiving a literal mark on the forehead or hands, but warning his congregation against possible Caesar-worship – thanks to social pressure! 'Be ready to lose your business, or a prominent spot for your shop in the Caesar-controlled market because you will rub Caesar the wrong way by not worshipping him. But if you do, and do so stubbornly, you will lose a lot more. You will land up in ever-burning hell!' – that was

the message of the writer of the book of Revelation. There is nothing in the book of Revelation that is not clearly taught in the first 65 books of the Bible – this I believe. In the letter to the Hebrews, the writer challenges the readers to even accept prison terms and property confiscation by the State, joyfully, for refusing to compromise their faith amidst of a similar-to-the-Book-of-Revelation situation of political persecution because of their faith in Jesus who alone was the Lord (Heb. 10:34).

The SEALING of the Saved, which the book of Revelation Speaks About

THE MEANING OF NUMBERS IN THE BOOK OF REVELATION

The book of Revelation talks about 144,000 from the 12 tribes of Israel who were 'sealed on the forehead' by the living God (Rev. 7:2-8). Just like the beast imagery, the 666 imagery, the numbers in the book of Revelation, I believe, have a symbolic meaning. What Revelation 5:9 ('persons from every tribe and language and people and nation' will be saved by the blood of Jesus) teaches directly, Revelation 7:2-8 teaches indirectly, using symbols! 12 x 12 x 1000 (a large number) is one way we can write 144,000. So, the message of Revelation 7:2-8 is this: "people from the Old Testament (symbolized by the first 12) and people from the New Testament (symbolized by second 12) will be saved in large numbers (symbolized by the 1000) on the final day by the blood of Jesus! They will be saved if they have a mark of the blood of Jesus! Since Revelation 5:9 and

Revelation 7:2-8 seems to be talking about the same thing (how the blood of Jesus 'seals' believers from various backgrounds across the globe, across various time periods), the sealing of Revelation 7:2-8 can be seen as symbolic. So, the sealing of the mark of the beast mentioned elsewhere in Revelation (Rev. 13:11,16,17; 14:9; 20:4) can also be logically seen as symbolic. Through symbols these passages teach this: "If you allow the evil anti-Biblical, anti-Jesus policies of your political ruler or even your work-place boss to impact your head, you are receiving the mark of the beast on your *head*. If you allow the evil anti-Biblical policies of your political ruler or work-place boss to impact your actions, you are receiving the mark of the beast on your *hands*!"

'MARK ON THE FOREHEAD' – THE MEANING

Elsewhere in Ezekiel 9, the word 'mark on the foreheads' seems to have been used symbolically as well. A man clothed in linen was assigned by the Lord to go throughout the city of Jerusalem putting a mark on those in the city of Jerusalem, who mourn and grieve over the detestable things done there (Ezek. 9:3-4). Such people so marked were spared from the judgement of God, apparently (see Ezek. 9:10-11). So, the message is simple: those who turn from the popular-among-people sinful ways of the city they live in – be it porn-watching, be it pride, be it foul-language use, etc., enabled by the Grace of God, cleansed by the Blood of Jesus – they are 'marked on the foreheads' (spiritually speaking) and they will be saved from the soon-coming wrath of God and hell-punishment!

So, when there are clear indications that the 'mark' in Revelation 7 and Ezekiel 9 are symbolic, the mark of the beast can also be a symbolic thing. The message woven around this symbolism is what the rest of the Bible has underlined all through: "Even if it costs your life, do not compromise your faith in Christ, despite mounting political pressure or unbearable peer pressure!" (Hebrew 12:4; Acts 20:24; Acts 21:13). The mark of the beast has nothing to do with an **injection**, I believe! It has got everything to do with the **rejection** of the spirit of compromise with sin promoted by celebs, false teachers and the politically powerful, prevalent in our time and age (my opinion)!

So, in CONCLUSION, I would like to say this: if you are standing in a vaccination queue and the nurse says, "You will agree to worship the Prime Minister/President/Chancellor/Chief Minister/the Mayor when you receive this vaccine and if you don't agree to these terms and conditions, then we can't vaccinate you', then you DON'T have to get vaccinated. But to the best of my knowledge, that is not what is being done now, anywhere in the world! So, we all get vaccinated against the corona pandemic! Let not a bizarre way of interpreting Revelation, violating self-evident sound Bible interpretation principles, prevent us from taking the Corona vaccination!

CHAPTER 44

SHOULD WE EQUATE APOCRYPHA TO THE WORD OF GOD AS ROMAN CATHOLICS DO?



If apocrypha (which is man-added, uninspired by the Holy Spirit books inserted into the Roman Catholic Bible), is also the Word of God like all the 66 books, found in the Protestant Bible, then we also could believe even in the unbiblical teachings which hyper-grace/hyper-supernatural/hyper-love preachers bring by adding to the Bible and deleting inconvenient truth found in the Bible! That's why the question which this chapter title is asking must be answered!

The Apocrypha has the following books which are not there in the original Bible (which has 66 books). This is the list:

1. The Wisdom of Solomon,
2. Ecclesiasticus

3. Tobit

4. Judith

5. 1 Esdras

6. 1 Maccabees

7. 2 Maccabees

8. Baruch

9. Letter of Jeremiah

10. 2 Esdras

11. Additions to Esther

12. Prayer of Azariah

13. Susanna

14. Bel and the Dragon

15. Prayer of Manasseh. The Douay version of the Bible which Roman Catholics use does not have the last book named above (Prayer of Manasseh).

Why should we not equate Apocrypha to the Word of God! Here is why:

VEHEMENT JEWISH OPPOSITION: Norman Geisler and Ron Brooks mention that Athanasius and Jerome, two respected Jewish scholars, never included the apocryphal books in the Bible of their time. They write, 'Jerome, a Hebrew scholar, made the official Latin Vulgate without the added apocryphal books' (*When Skeptics Ask*, page 156).

VERY LATE INCLUSION: The occasion – The Council of Trent. The year - 1546. The deed - the adding of the apocryphal books to the Roman Catholic Bible! My comment - "That's too late!"

REACTION TO MARTIN LUTHER'S QUESTION: Martin Luther was emphatic that practices common in the church of his time such as 'prayer for the dead' did not have the support of the Bible. So, he asked why the church of his time followed these practices without biblical warrant. He also stated that the Bible does not support salvation by works. Some 29 years after he raised these very valid questions, the apocrypha was included in the Roman Catholic Bible Canon as a reaction. Here's why: there is support for these practices in the Apocrypha (you may checkout 2 Maccabees 12:45-46; Tobit 12:9). The canon was expanded by the Roman Catholics so that they would be able to claim support for extra-biblical practices such as prayer for the dead. And that is not right. Also doing such a thing makes one recall the command not to add or subtract from God's Word found throughout Scripture: Revelation 22:18,19/Proverbs 30:6/Deuteronomy 4:2; 12:32. The Scripture

warns those guilty of adding or removing from Scripture, will face severe punishment – definitely on the other side of eternity and at times, even on this side of eternity ('God will add to him all the plagues described in this book' – Rev. 22:18; 'God will take away from him his share in the tree of life and in the holy city which are described in this book' – Rev. 22:19).

IN-TEXT 'NOT INSPIRED' DECLARATION: There are verses in the apocryphal text (like the one in I Maccabees 9:27) which clearly states that no prophets operated during the time these books were written – inter-testamental time. If there are no prophets, there is no question of divine inspiration of that book. So, even within the text of the apocrypha, there is a declaration that these books are not inspired!

PAGAN LITERATURE QUOTATION: Those who argue that apocrypha should be included in Scripture say this: "Even passages like Hebrews 11:35 are alluded to in Apocryphal books." We read in Hebrews 11:35 this: 'Women received back their dead, raised to life again. Others were tortured and refuse to be released, so that they might gain a better resurrection!' *The Spirit of Reformation Study Bible* says: "This is an apparent reference to the events during Maccabean revolt (c. 167-157 B.C.), which occurred after the close of the Old Testament but are recorded in the Apocrypha (2 Meccabees 6-7). Jude, verse 14 includes a quote from I Enoch (another apocryphal book). This statement can be said in response to these allegations from the Catholic side: "If we claim that we must say that certain apocryphal books are God-inspired because a couple of New Testament

quotes are from them, our line of argument becomes problematic. Here is how: Apostle Paul even quotes from Pagan prophets in His Gospel messages (Acts 17:28); does that mean that even pagan prophets write under the inspiration of the Bible? Of course not!"

For these and many reasons, we can safely say that apocrypha was never ever part of the original Bible! **Let us fix our focus on the Sixty Six (the Bible with Sixty Six books)** and keep it steady, for the moment we step out of the Sixty Six, we are stepping out of God's Word! And that's dangerous! God's Word is the final court of appeal for all matters of belief and behavior (Rom. 4:3;
2 Tim. 3:16-17) and so it really matters when books which are not part of the original canon, get into the canon!

The main points mentioned in this chapter has been taken from the book, ***When Skeptics Ask: A Handbook on Christian Evidences****, by Norman Geisler and Ron Brooks.*

SECTION FIVE

LONG-TERM ANTI-DOTE

AGAINST MODERN FALSE TEACHING

CHAPTER 45

THE BIBLICAL ANTIDOTE AGAINST ANY FALSE TEACHING



New Testament Scholar Phillip J. Long writes, 'Paul stays in Ephesus for three years (Acts 20:31). This is Paul's longest period of settled ministry and perhaps the most fruitful time in his entire career'. Paul said that after his departure 'savage wolves' will come among the Ephesians 'not sparing the flock' (Acts 20:29). We know that 'savage wolves' is a riveting word picture, Paul used to describe hell-populating false teachers. Jesus called false prophets as wolves in sheep's clothing, remember (Matt. 7:15)? We know that 'flock' is another word picture he uses to describe church believers. Also notice that Paul did not say 'savage wolves may come' but rather 'salvage wolves will come' (Acts 20:29). We can be certain that false teachers will be around, all through church history till the return of Jesus. There will be many of them before his return, Jesus predicted (Matt. 24:24). We can see the damaging influence of the cultic hyper-grace, hyper-

supernatural and hyper-love false teachers/false pastors among the present-day church. What is the anti-dote against their damaging influence?

There is only one anti-dote! It is the Word of God. That's why Paul says this to the Ephesian elders: 'And now I commend you to God and the Word of His Grace, which is able to build you upon and give you the inheritance among all those who are sanctified' (Acts 20:32, NASB). What is the connection between the Word of God and False Teaching? A real-life incident from the life of Jim Bakker illustrates this, memorably.

JIM BAKKER'S HONEST CONFESSION INSPIRES US FOR RIGOROUS BIBLE MEDITATION

Jim Bakker was the founder of a big ministry (named Praise The Lord ministries, PTL) in America. He was convicted of fraud in 1989. He ended up in prison for misusing millions of dollars, he received in donations. He spent five years in jail. In jail, he started reading the Bible. He talks about it in his book, *I Was Wrong*:

'After the time of my parole hearing, I completed my study of all the words of Jesus in the New Testament. To my surprise, after months of studying Jesus, I concluded that He did not have one good thing to say about money. Most of Jesus' statements about riches, wealth, and material gain were in a negative context.

'I was wrong. I was wrong! I was wrong in my understanding of the Bible's true message. Not only was I wrong, but I was teaching the opposite of what Jesus had said.

'For years I had embraced and espoused a gospel that some skeptics had branded as a 'prosperity gospel'.

'I even got to the point where I was teaching people at PTL, "Don't pray, 'God, your will be done,' when you are praying for health or wealth."

'Such arrogance! Such foolishness! Such sin! The Bible says we are not to presume upon God, but we should say, "If the Lord wills, we shall live and do this or that" (James 4:15).

'I may not always have been so blatant about it, but I often preached a prosperity message at Heritage USA and on our PTL television programs. BUT WHEN I BEGAN TO STUDY THE SCRIPTURES IN DEPTH WHILE IN PRISON, SOMETHING I AM EMBARASSED AND ASHAMED TO ADMIT THAT I RARELY TOOK TIME TO DO DURING THE HECTIC YEARS OF CONSTANT BUILDING AND MINISTERING IN PTL, I WAS VERY DISTRESSED AT WHAT I DISCOVERED.

'I realised that for years I helped propagate an imposter, not a true gospel – a gospel that stated, 'God wants you to be rich'!

'THE MORE I STUDIED THE BIBLE, HOWEVER, I HAD TO ADMIT THAT THE PROSPERITY MESSAGE DID NOT LINE UP WITH THE TENOR OF SCRIPTURE!

'IN PRISON, I DECIDED TO DIG DEEP INTO THE SCRIPTURE FURTHER....'

(Selections from, Jim Bakker's Book, *I Was Wrong*, chapter 48 which is also titled, *I Was Wrong*).

I want to salute the honesty of Jim Bakker here. It is very rare to find such honesty. What he is underscoring is this: a deep study of Scripture and escape from false teaching go together; the ones who do not take time to study the Scriptures are the one who will slip into false teaching!

The Economic Times reported, 'The easiest way to check for a fake currency note is to compare it with a genuine note of the same denomination'. And the surest way to detect and escape false teaching is to know the 'genuine note' - in our case, it is the Holy Bible. And we must take time to read all the Bible with reflection and understanding.

CHAPTER 46

READY TO SHUN AND SHAKE OFF BIBLICAL ILLITERACY SO THAT FALSE TEACHING WILL BE HELD AT BAY?



The translation of Bible into English by the likes of John Wycliffe (1328-1384) and William Tyndale (1494-1536) in the 14th century and 15th century paved way for even shopkeepers in England to become 95% literate. Bob Creson writes, "Literacy in England is directly attributable to the Bible" (*The Washington Post*, December 11, 2014). This phenomenon was repeated in India. Here is a report: 'Teaching people to read was one of the responsibilities the evangelists undertook so that by the time they left a village, there were Christians who could read. Conversion and literacy were adopted together. Among the Khasis in Northeast, India missionaries taught that "You cannot be a Christian without reading the Bible!" So, people were taught to read in Schools.' (Darrell L. Whiteman's essay in the Philip C. Stine-edited book, *Bible Translation*

and the Spread of the Church: The Last 200 Years, page 138).

Unfortunately, Christians who brought in literacy initiatives so that people could read the Bible, are fast becoming Bible illiterates. 'Sodom and Gomorrah? Are they sisters?' – this Biblically illiterate generation asks! False teachers have a field day, because today's Christians are mostly biblical illiterates!

Let me use the word 'THEOLOGY' as an outline to underline the need for Biblical Literacy among God's people.

T-Titus Being Called To Pick Bible-Strong Elders!

Paul fondly called Titus his 'son' (Titus 1:4). He told Titus about what kind of elders he had to appoint for providing Christian Leadership in every town: "He must hold firm to the trustworthy Word as taught, so that he may be able to give instruction in sound doctrine and also to rebuke those who contradict it" (*Titus* 1:9, ESV).

H-Head-nodders, the Bereans Weren't!

The people of Berea were not head-nodders. They were more noble than those in Thessalonica because they not only "received the Word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see", if the things Paul and Silas taught were in line with the Scriptures.

E-phesian Elders Called To Commit Themselves To The Word of Grace!

Paul never stayed continuously in one place to minister as much as he did in Ephesus. And when he wanted to move, he made a gripping farewell speech to this church's elders. What did he say? He said after he left, 'fierce wolves will come in, not sparing the flock' (Acts 20:29). What was the antidote for this wolf-attack? A commitment to the 'Word of His Grace!' (Acts 20:32).

O-One Hundred Twenty Thousand People, That God Talked About!

God's last question to Jonah still rings in my ears: "Then shouldn't I show concern for the great city of Nineveh, which has more than one hundred twenty thousand people who do not know right from wrong, and many animals too?" (Jonah 4:11, NCV). The big number of people in Nineveh were morally confused as they had no knowledge of Yahweh's life-giving, ethics-shaping laws! A knowledge of Yahweh's Written Laws would have told them the difference between "left" and "right", the difference between what is right and what is wrong! From that big number, comes a missionary call to us that we must carry the message of the Bible to all who still have no access to it! India's population is approximately 10,000 times more than Nineveh! That means we have a bigger motivation than Jonah had to grasp the Word of God ourselves and share it with the ignorant millions around us!

L-Lack of Knowledge Which Hosea Writes About!

One of the most painful cries from God in the whole Bible is recorded in the book of Hosea. God says, "My people are destroyed from lack of knowledge. Because you have rejected knowledge, I also will reject you as my priests; because you have ignored the law of your God, I also will ignore your children!" (Hosea 4:6 NIV).

O-Online Millions and the Opportunity For Evangelism They Present!

Sandhya Keelery wrote on July 7, 2020 that there are 550 million internet users in India (Statista.com). This huge number beckons Bible Teachers to dedicate their lives to teach people by modern media such as Zoom. And there are fully online Bible Training programs by reputed Bible Colleges like South Asian Institute of Advanced Christian Studies (SAIACS), Southern Asia Bible College (SABC), etc., which trains those who feel called to be Word preachers.

G-Going On Circle!

Apostle Paul talked about an ever-increasing circle of Bible Teachers when he wrote to Timothy: "And the things that you have heard me say among many witnesses, entrust these to faithful

men who will be qualified to teach others as well..." (2 Tim. 2:2).

Y-ahweh's Prediction!

Yahweh's prediction about a famine of hearing God's Word is mentioned in the book of Amos (8:12). So, in the short time available now, let us become Bible Literates! Let us learn to handle the Word of Truth and teach it to our generation!

You may be a lay-person. But you can equip yourself by a self-study of the Word of God. Pick up a good Systematic Theology book. Wayne Grudem, Millard J. Erickson and others have written excellent systematic theology textbooks. I picked up my first theology book, not after I landed in Bible College, but long before that. As a student of Technology (B. Tech) in Allahabad, I was studying volume 1 of *Renewal Theology* by Rodman Williams! And I led Bible Studies on the Doctrine of God for a small group in the men's hostel! That was the training ground for a nation-wide Bible Teaching ministry for me! God has grand and glorious plans for you! And as you shun and shake-off biblical illiteracy and take time to study His Word systematically, you will become a blessing!

CHAPTER 47

WISHING YOU SMASHING YEAR(S) OF NON-STOP DEEP SCRIPTURE STUDY (SHOULD THE COMING OF JESUS, TARRY) – A HABIT THAT WILL HELP YOU STEER CLEAR OF HELL-POPULATING FALSE TEACHING!



I am sure that you hope that each new year of your life will be a "prosperous New Year". You are dreaming that this particular year you exist in, would be a "successful New Year", correct? Ask Joshua. He would tell you that it is imperative to meditate on the "book of the Law", the Bible, if we put that in our context, day and night, to become "prosperous" and "successful" – in God's eyes (Josh 1:8).

One of the wisest things we can do in the upcoming year (and for the rest of our lives, year after year), is to read the entire Bible within current year. In what is known as the greatest poem devoted to the Bible and

its greatness, Psalm 119, we read, "Your commandment makes me wiser than my enemies, for it is ever with me" (Psa. 119:98). Yes, it is true - when God's Commandments (read, "The Bible") is ever with us (shall we make sure that "is read everyday of the fresh year" to begin with), we would be wiser than our enemies. Not just our enemies, we would become even wiser than our teachers - the very next verse tells us (Psa. 119:99)! That apart, we will also find "light to our path" throughout the year - won't we? (Psa. 119:105).

Three basic questions are commonly asked when the topic of daily Bible reading comes up. They are:

1. Does the Bible teach us that we should read it daily?
2. Does the Bible teach that we should read all of it (i.e. all the 66 books of the Bible)?
3. What version of the Bible can I choose to read?

Let me answer the first question: **Does the Bible teach us to read it daily?** Of course, it does!

LEADERS TO BE READERS!

The command for the Kings of Israel was that he should keep for himself a copy of the Law of Moses and read it "daily" (Deut. 17:18-20). In other words, God wanted the leaders of His people to be regular readers of His Word which was their leadership manual! You may say, "I am not a king of Israel!" But do you know that if you are a believer, God, the King of kings sees you as a king? Has what Peter written in his epistle, that we are "a

royal priesthood" slipped from your mind? (1 Pet. 2:9). I hope not. If we are kings in God's eyes, and He wants to use us in leadership positions. in His Kingdom, we must fulfill what He expects from His little kings all the days of their life - read his written Word, the Bible!

SEVEN TIMES A DAY!

The Law-of-God lover of Psalm 119 says that he would praise God for His righteous Laws seven times a day (Psa 119:164). To be able to do that, don't you think he would have read a section of his Bible (which was just the Law books of the Old Testament), at least once a day?

TOOTH-DECAY VS TRUTH-DECAY!

The example of the Berean believers challenges us to read our Bibles daily. After Paul preached to them, they went back home and "daily" examined the Scriptures to check if what they heard from Paul was supported by the Scriptures (Acts 17:11). By doing this, the Bible says that they became "nobler" than the believers in Thessalonica. They received an appreciation for the hunger they showed for the truth. Do you want to earn the "noble" tag from the Bible? The further you keep yourself from the Bible, the further you will be away from the truth. Forgetting to brush your teeth everyday may cause tooth-decay. But you know what is worse? Forgetting

to study your Bible - the source of all truth worth knowing on this planet. It will cause truth-decay in your life! Then, we must read our Bibles daily like the Bereans did!

NO BIBLE - NO BREAKFAST!

In the Bible, we read about a man who could testify, 'I have not departed from the commands of His (God's) lips; I have treasured the words of His mouth more than my daily bread' (Job 23:12 NIV). Yes, I am referring to the ancient patriarch, Job. The Bible was more important to Him than "daily bread"! In other words, the Bible was more important to him than breakfast, lunch and dinner! Shall we resolve, being challenged by Job's example, that even if we have to miss our breakfast or lunch or dinner, we will not miss our Bible meditation, each day? Such a rigorous and regular habit of devouring God's Word on a daily basis certainly helped Job. This steady diet of the Scriptures increased his appetite to be holy and made him holy, so much so that he could say, 'I made a solemn pact with myself never to undress a girl with my eyes' (Job 31:1 MSG).

NOT A JOB, BUT HIS JOY!

Read Job 23:12 again! This verse says that Job "treasured" the words of God, did you notice? For Job, Bible meditation was not a job - it was a joy! It was not a chore - it was an encore! Won't you learn from his example?!

Would you "run" to your Bible to meditate on it, with enthusiasm each day, instead of dragging your feet in disinterest? Will you jump up from your bed, each day, to land in your Bible so that you can swim deep in it, every morning?!

These four passages - one from Deuteronomy, one from Acts, one from Psalms and one from Job - teach us that it is imperative that we read the Bible, each waking day of our lives!

Now, for the second question...

Now we will answer the second question, **"Does the Bible teach us that we must read all of it?"** Yes - of course!

READ ALL OF IT!

Hear is what Paul penned in 2 Timothy 3:16: 'All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness.' Notice that Paul uses the word "all" here. Yes, "all" of Scripture is God-breathed and so we must read all of it! Yes, we must read each of the 66 books of the Bible! Paul must have read every part of the Bible he had, the Old Testament. How can I say that? I can say that after reading Romans 10:18-20. He quotes from three different Bible books from three different sections of the Bible (the Law section, the Poetic Section, the Prophetic section) in a span of just three verses!

EVERY WORD, READ!

With all of Israel standing to hear him, Joshua, read both the blessings as well as the curses found in the book of the Law (Josh. 8:33, 34). We further read, 'There was not a word of all that Moses commanded that Joshua did not read before all the assembly of Israel, and the women, and the little ones, and the sojourners who lived among them' (Josh. 8:35). The lesson here is loud and clear: If every single word of God-dictated Laws of Moses had to be read, we too, must read every single word of every single Bible book!

LET NOT YOUR EYE MISS EVEN A SINGLE "I" ...

Jesus preached that while it was possible for heaven and earth to disappear, it was not possible even for a "dot" or an "iota" (ESV) or "the smallest detail" (NLT) or "the smallest letter" or "one little hook" (Amplified) or "the smallest stroke"(NASB) or "a period or a comma" (CEV), "one jot or one title" (KJ21) or the "smallest part of a letter" (NCV), even one "i" (Wycliffe NT) to disappear from the Law (read "the Bible") until "all" of it was "accomplished" (Math 5:18). So, isn't that a motivation for us to read the entire Bible without even missing an "i"?! It is - for me! So I resolved my eye would not even miss even a single "i" of the Bible text while I read it!

JOHN'S WARNING!

All-alone in the Isle of Patmos, John possibly had just the Word of God and the manifest presence of God, for company. He signs off from the book he wrote in that circumstance, the book of Revelation, saying, "If anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away his share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are described in this book!" (Rev 22:19). What was John trying to convey here? Was he trying to imply that a page from the Bible must never be torn? Billy Graham, in his autobiography, *Just As I Am*, talks about how, he, at times, would take a Bible, scissor some passages from it and paste it onto his sermon file, carry it to the pulpit and preach from it directly during meetings that lasted for many days. Was Billy Graham wrong when he did that – according to John, in Revelation 22:19? I do not believe so. What John was implying here, I believe, is this: we must never stubbornly leave out sections from the Bible or leave out sections even from difficult-to-grasp books like the book of Revelation, when we sit to read it during the course of our lifetime! That would be equivalent to "taking away words from the book of this prophecy!" This is how one preacher helped me see that passage!

READING EVERY BIT OF THE HOLY WRIT!

Paul, Joshua, Jesus and John as we have just seen, motivate us to read every part, every book, every verse,

every word, every letter, and every part of the letter of the Bible! There could be portions of the Bible, you have never touched. There could be sections of the Holy Writ that you haven't read one bit! In the upcoming year, you can change that!

THE SIX-LAYERED SANDWICH METHOD OF DAILY BIBLE READING!

It has been my practice, to read one chapter each from each section of the Bible for many years now. And, trust me; I have thoroughly enjoyed reading the Bible this way. My Bible-reading becomes as enjoyably lip-smacking as biting into a six-layered butter-jam-mayonnaise-cheese-meat stuffed sandwich. The six sections of the Bible are as follows: The books Genesis to Esther make up the Old Testament History books section; the books Job to Song of Songs make up the Old Testament Poetic Section; the books Isaiah to Malachi make up the Old Testament Prophetic Section. Cross over to the New Testament and you will find two more sections: the New Testament History Section (Mathew to Acts) and the New Testament Letters Section (Romans to Revelation). Read one chapter each day from each section. This way, you will get to read six different chapters of the Bible, every day.

Did you know that this way you, would have read the whole Bible once and the New Testament twice in the whole year?! "WOW!" You could read three chapters in the morning after you get up and three before you

go to sleep. The variety in the material you read will spice up your interest to read and keep at it. Highlight at least one verse from each chapter you read that spoke to you the loudest. That way, it is easy to keep track where you stopped in each Scripture section. Use a color that you have not used so far on your Bible to avoid confusion with previously colored verses. In case you fall behind on your Bible reading, you can catch up during your weekend.

The third question:

Now let us head for the third and final question: **What version of the Bible can I use to read the Bible?**

ESV, VOICE, NLT - MY PICK!

The answer to this depends on you and what you like. If you want to read the Bible in a very literal word-for-word translation, go for the English Standard Version (ESV) - the latest and perhaps the best addition to the short list of Bible versions produced with this kept in mind. If you want to read the Bible in the language we use today, go for the VOICE version of the Bible. While the popular Message version of the Bible is done by one person (Eugene Peterson), this version published by the respected Thomas Nelson publishers is done by a team of scholars, and hence, safer. If you want a balance between both, go for the New Living Translation

(NLT) of the Bible. Reading the Bible in a version that you have not read before, makes your Bible-reading more interesting than you can ever imagine! But there are many more good translations of the Bible out there in the crowded world of English Bible Versions. Go to www.BibleGateway.com and on this very resourceful site, you will find that it is possible to read the Bible in all the major English versions! Among the many online Bible websites out there, the site, www.esv.org is perhaps the best one. The ESV Bible is also a smartphone app, worth downloading. You can search Bible verses and phrases and get them listed before your eyes, book by book, at amazing speed. The New American Standard Bible (NASB) is also a respected Bible translation known for the word-for-word accuracy. I once heard that the 1977 edition of this Bible is among the most-accurate essentially literate versions of the Bible we have in print on our planet! The India Bible Literature (IBL) store in Kellys, Chennai, is perhaps the best place to buy Bibles in India. You get maximum value for your money, there!

With these basic questions answered, are you now, getting ready for smashing years of non-stop Scripture Study?! When you do that, escaping and steering-clear from hell-populating false-teaching will become second nature to you!

IF YOU LOVE THE BIBLE, YOU WILL NATURALLY HATE FALSE TEACHING!

The main purpose of this book, is of course, to show you that false teaching is dangerous. But the ultimate main

purpose of this book is this: to invite you to fall in love with God's Word. When you love God's Word, you will automatically hate false teaching!

Psalm 119 is the longest poem on the Greatest Book ever, the Bible. And in this poem we read that the Psalmist declares his love for the Bible, directly, a whopping 11 times!

LOVE THE WORD, ABHOR FALSE TEACHINGS!

#1 Psalm 119:47 – for I find my delight in your commands which I love.

#2 Psalm 119:48 – I will lift up my hands towards your commands, which I love.

#3 Psalm 119:68 – My soul keeps your testimonies, I love them exceedingly.

#4 Psalm 119: 97 – Oh how I love your law. It my meditation all day.

#5 Psalm 119: 113 – I hate the double-minded but I love your Law.

#6 Psalm 119: 119 – All the wicked of the earth you discard like dross, therefore I love your testimonies.

#7 Psalm 119: 127 – Therefore I love Your Commandments above gold, above fine Gold! (can we say in the same vein, 'Therefore I love Your Commandments above my phone, even my iPhone'?)

#8 Psalm 119:140 – Your Promise is well-tried and your servant loves it.

#9 Psalm 119:159 – Consider how I love your precepts; Give me life according to your steadfast love.

#10 Psalm 119:163 – I hate and abhor falsehood but I love your Law (can we say, 'My love for the Word has led me to ABHOR false teachings like Hyper-Grace, Hyper-Supernaturalism, Hyper-Love?')

#11 Psalm 119: 165 – Great peace have those who love Your Law; nothing can make them stumble! (this verse, is one verse I often read with the person next to me in my flight journeys as I witness for Christ, using the ESV Bible app on my smartphone).

THE AUTHOR'S BLOG, SOCIAL MEDIA HANDLES & CONTACT INFO



You may choose to check out the author's latest writings at

www.dukejeyaraj.com

His social media handles will show up when you google his name.

The author welcomes criticism, corrections and comments about this book via his email ID, which is,

emailduke@gmail.com.

Thank You!

THE AUTHOR'S BLOG, SOCIAL MEDIA HANDLES & CONTACT INFO



You may choose to check out the author's latest writings at

www.dukejeyaraj.com

His social media handles will show up when you google his name.

The author welcomes criticism, corrections and comments about this book via his email ID, which is,

emailduke@gmail.com.

Thank You!